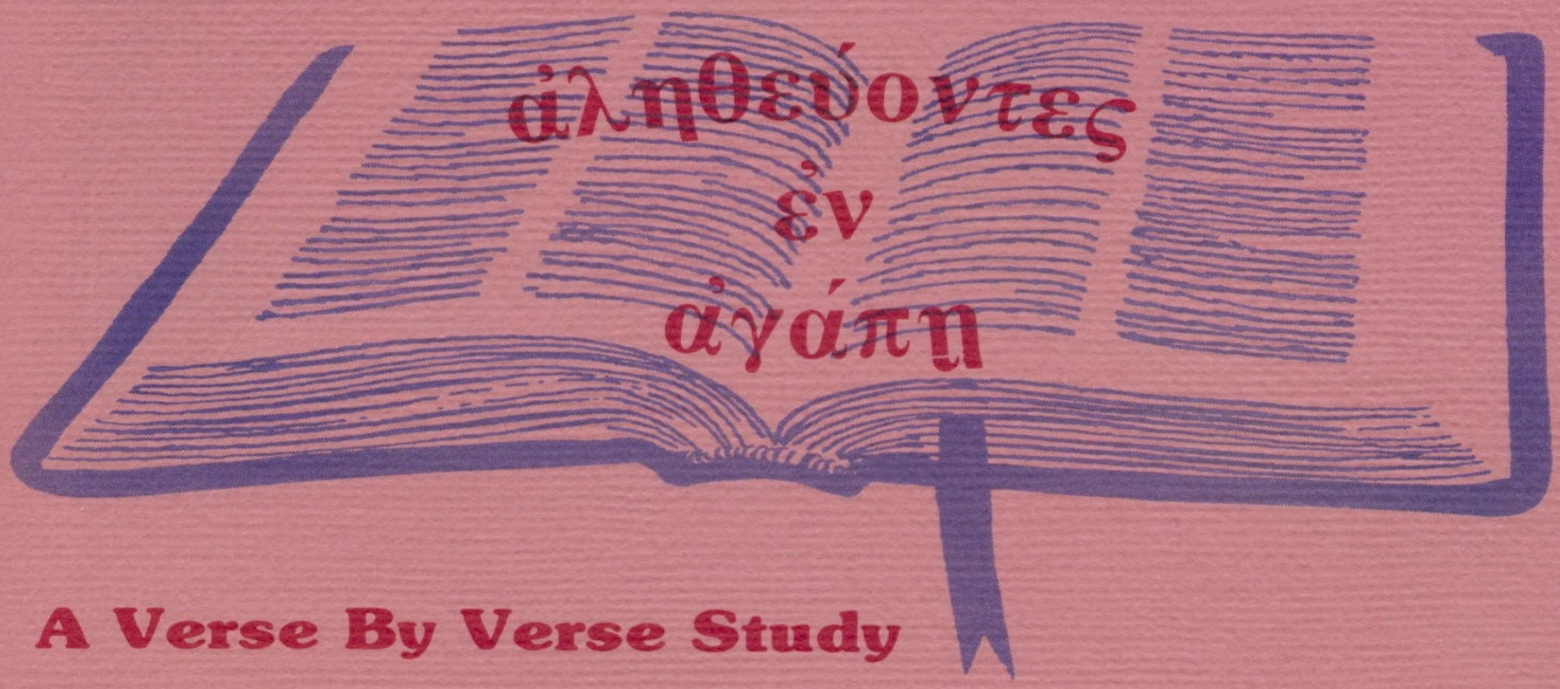
A Commentary Of

EPHESIANS

BASED UPON THE
GREEK NEW TESTAMENT



A Verse By Verse Study

By
Ernest R. Campbell

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EPHESIANS

Based on the Greek New Testament

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Unlocking Truth from the Greek New Testament

A Commentary of **EPHESIANS**

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ernest R. Campbell was born at Michigan, North Dakota in 1915. His farm environment instilled in him the importance of hard work, gave a breadth of experience, and encouraged independent thinking and initiative. He moved to Oregon in 1933. For four years he worked in the electrical and radio broadcasting fields.

He received his B. A. degree from the University of Oregon. His major was in English literature, which has strengthened his ability in Biblical interpretation. His B. A. also included a major (hours beyond B. A.) in psychology and two years of classical Greek. He earned his B. D. and Th. D. degrees from Northern Baptist Theological Seminary. His major in Greek New Testament was under the renowned Greek scholar, Dr. Julius R. Mantey.

He has taught New Testament Greek at North Park College. He was College Dean of faculty at the Detroit Bible Institute where he taught beginner through advanced New Testament Greek. He has been the pastor of the Salem Bible Church for thirty-five years during which time his ministry has been based entirely on the Greek New Testament. Simultaneous with this he had taught private Greek classes prior to the beginning of Canyonview Bible College, which is now Canyonview Bible Seminary.

The author was one of the founders of an evening school in 1973, which became the forerunner of Canyonview Bible Seminary. At this time he introduced a new natural method of teaching New Testament Greek, which is now enabling Canyonview students to teach directly from their Greek New Testaments.

As the president of Canyonview Bible Seminary the author's *supreme burden* is to equip students to *literally teach the books of the Bible in a verse by verse manner.* He is convinced that the ability to teach from the Greek New Testament is the *most important single factor* in accomplishing this end in an interesting and authoritative manner.

The author realistically recognizes that it is not possible for all Bible teachers to acquire competency in New Testament Greek. This is why he has written this commentary, the sixth in a series on the epistles written to the New Testament churches, that the English reader *may more fully share in* the treasures of the Greek text.

PREFACE

The prefaces in each of our commentaries set forth important hermeneutical principles designed to help the reader become a more accurate Bible interpreter. Correct Biblical hermeneutics is the basis for a correct understanding of the Scriptures. These hermeneutical principles serve as guideposts to hold us to the literal-intended-meaning of each portion of the Bible.

In this preface we will discuss the GRAMMATICAL-HISTORICAL approach to the Scriptures. As this compound definition implies, this approach to the Bible consists of two distinct thoughts, which in application are interlaced. The word *grammatical* means that the respective languages in which the Bible was written must be accurately adhered to. The word *historical* means that the language used must be understood in the light of the historical circumstances surrounding the writer. Generally speaking, that which was written in the Scriptures was colored by the historical cradle in which it was written.

First, in dealing with the grammatical approach to the Bible, let us examine some pertinent aspects of it. It should be acknowledged, without controversy, that this approach *must be based upon the original language* in which the Bible was written. This means that competent teaching of the Old Testament involves the ability to either exegete the meaning directly from the Hebrew in which it was written, or to accurately deduce its meaning through the use of commentaries based on the Hebrew text. The same holds true of the New Testament, competent teachers should be able to either bring out the meaning from the Greek text or use commentaries based upon it.

In speaking of the grammatical approach, we want to limit our discourse primarily to the Greek New Testament. This is logical, since the truth for the Body of Christ, the Church, is revealed in the New Testament, not in the Old (Eph. 3:5). We need to recognize that there are many significant shades of meaning which cannot be conveyed from the Greek into English in even an excellent translation. So-called expanded translations have tried to capture the fuller in-depth nuances of the Greek, but in doing so they have deviated from the Greek by additions and duplicating words. Furthermore, beyond the accuracy gained by going back to the Greek text, there is an added

benefit, a subjective inner conviction that *God is directly speaking to us through the original Greek, giving us a sense of spiritual warmth mainly lost in translations* (Luke 24:32).

Having explained some of the reasons why the grammatical approach must be based on the original language, now let us consider some features of the Greek language which convey very significant shades of thought, which are incapable of being transferred into English in a word-for-word translation. The English reader would not be aware of these underlying meanings, they would be hidden from him, unless he had direct or indirect knowledge of the Greek language.

As an Indo-European language Greek has three voices. These express the *relation* of the action of the verb to the subject. The active voice depicts the *subject doing the acting*. The middle voice depicts the *subject acting upon itself*. The passive voice depicts the *subject being acted upon.* Due to the difference between the Greek and English languages it is impossible to transfer the voice meanings into English apart from a commentary-type translation. On the other hand, failure to distinguish between the translation of an active and a passive voice can lead to serious error, i.e., exalt man and mitigate God's sovereignty.

There are four different modes (moods) in the Greek. These are distinct forms a verb may take and they show the *attitude* of the speaker with regard to the action. The indicative mode is used in the *statement of a fact*. The subjunctive mode is used to denote *future contingency.* The optative mode is used to express *a wish or desire*. The imperative mode is used regarding *commands*. In reading a translation, it is often difficult to detect the modes used in the original text. The writer's attitude regarding the action may be very ambiguous; not obvious whether it is a fact, or that which is probable, possible, or a command.

There are six different tenses in the Greek. These tenses designate the *time* the verbal action takes place. The present tense may depict both *current* and *continuous* action. The future tense points to action which *will come to pass*. The imperfect tense refers to *continuous action in past time.* The aorist tense looks back to action *finished in*

the past. The perfect tense points back to action which *has been completed and the results continue* in full effect. The pluperfect is a past perfect, goes a step further back than the perfect, and is seldom used in the New Testament. Translations should convey the meaning of the present, future, and aorist tenses over into English; however, usually they fail to accurately transfer the full meaning of the imperfect, perfect, and pluperfect tenses. This is why we must go back to the Greek text for highest grammatical accuracy.

The meaning of participles (verbal adjectives) is usually inadequately transferred into English. The present participle depicts action *simultaneous* with the leading verb. For example, Matthew 10:7 says, "*While going* preach . . . " The going and preaching take place at the same time. On the other hand, the aorist participle refers to action *prior* to that of the leading verb. a good example is Matthew 28:19, where Jesus says, "Therefore, having gone disciple all the nations. . ." (cf. Mark 16:15). The emphasis is on *what they are to do after they have gone.* The use of the passive voice indicates that God is the one who effects the prior going. Having placed them in the midst of the Gentile nations, God commands them to disciple.

The meaning of infinitives (verbs which are not limited as to person or number) should readily transfer from the Greek to the English. It is important that translations conform to the tense of the infinitive.

Second, let us observe some of the things involved in a historical approach to the Bible. a good communicator should have one thing in mind, the transferal of his thoughts in such a manner that they stimulate identical thoughts in the minds of his readers. As new truth strikes our minds, it is understood in the light of what has already been fed into them. The intelligent comprehension of new truth takes place when it is *meaningfully related* to the existing mind-set of the reader. This means that the individuals through whom God the Holy Spirit wrote the Bible adjusted their grammar and vocabulary to the minds of those to whom they were writing. In view of this principle, it is logical to expect the grammar of a given writer to vary as he accommodates the mental status of his readers.

If we are going to accurately understand a New Testament epistle we must know *to whom* it was written. Was it written primarily to Jewish

believers, Gentile believers, or to both as the Church of God (1 Cor. 10:32)? If the purpose is to relate the truth to Jews, it is tied into that which had a significant part in forming their mind-set, the Old Testament (cf. Hebrews). If the purpose is to convey the Gospel to the Gentiles, there must be a bridge which will relate it to their heathen mentality (Acts 14:15-17; 17:22-27). If an epistle (letter) is written to an individual, such as Timothy, the more we know about him the better we will understand what was written to him.

Every New Testament epistle was written for a purpose: (1) to solve problems, and (2) to instruct and edify believers. First Corinthians is a good example of a problem-solving epistle. In it Paul sets forth solutions to specific problems which confronted them. What Paul says in this epistle must be understood in the light of the geographical location and historical circumstances of this affluent, licentious, and immoral city.

The two primary sources of historical data which give us insight into the times when most of the New Testament was written are the Four Gospels and the Book of Acts. There are many allusions in Paul's epistles to historical facts recorded in the Four Gospels (Rom. 1:3; 1 Cor. 15:3-4; 1 Tim. 3:16; 2 Tim. 2:8). The historical information in the Book of Acts affords us valuable background for better understanding the Book of Romans, First and Second Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, and First and Second Thessalonians. The Book of Acts also gives us a valuable clue as to how most of the churches in Asia were started (Acts 19:10). Finally, it explains how Paul was in prison in Rome, the base from which he wrote Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon.

In addition to the above, there is a great deal of *internal historical data* in the New Testament epistles. This evidence is abundant in Galatians, First Corinthians, Philippians, Colossians, First and Second Thessalonians, First and Second Timothy, and Titus. When the historical information contained in all the New Testament epistles is combined, and when we add to this the historical data of the Four Gospels and the Book of Acts, we have an adequate pool of information to assure a balanced grammatical historical approach to the New Testament epistles.

INTRODUCTION

In this brief introduction we want to consider the *main purpose* for which this book was written, and we will point out some of the most *significant truths* which are taught in this epistle. Pertinent information pertaining to the most probable date it was written will be examined.

PURPOSE

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER ONE was to show: first, that God's sovereign actions are unto the *praise of His Grace* (3-6); second, that God's summing up all things in Christ is unto the *praise of His glory* (7-14); third, that believers might *know* the *hope of His calling,* the *riches of His inheritance*, and the *greatness of His power* (15-22).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER TWO was: first, to inform believers that they were *totally depraved*, and that *God is the one* who gave them spiritual life, resurrection, and placement with Christ in the heavenlies demonstrating the exceeding *riches of His grace* toward us in Christ, so that there is no room for works (1-10); second, to remind the Gentile believers that once they were without hope and God in the world, but now they have been brought near God by the Blood of Christ (11-13); third, to explain to them how Jesus Christ, by the cross, *destroyed the enmity* between Jews and Gentiles, and that they are jointly being built into a holy temple, the Church (14-22).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER THREE was, first, to inform Gentile believers that according to Mystery truth revealed to him they now have the privilege of being *fellow heirs, fellow body members,* and *fellow partakers of the promise* (Holy Spirit) through his Gospel. Paul affirms that he was made a minister of this Gospel, according to grace, to preach the unsearchable truth of the Mystery to the Gentiles (1-13; cf. Rom. 16:25). Second, Paul lets them know that he is praying that they might be *able to comprehend* through the spirit what is the breadth, length, height, and depth of the Mystery, and to know the love of Christ, unto the end to be filled with all the fulness of God (14-19).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER FOUR was, first, to plead with them to *walk worthily* of their calling, particularly, to maintain the *unity of the Spirit* (1-6). Second, Paul gives them the *necessary knowledge of the gifts* which is essential for unity among believers, emphasizing the *mutual responsibility* they have for building up the Body of Christ (7-16). Third, he exhorts them to put away the lifestyle of the old man and *to put on the new man* characterized by righteousness (17-24). Fourth, he urges them to put away lying, wrath, stealing, filthy talking, and blaspheming, and *to put on the opposite* of each of these, and not to grieve the Holy Spirit (25-32).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER FIVE was, first, to admonish believers to *walk in love*, and to have no part in fornication, uncleanness, and shameful speech (1-5). Second, he instructs them as children of light *to have the fruit of light* and to be separated from the unfruitful works of darkness (6-14). Third, he tells them to look at their lifestyle, to be wise, to know the Lord's will, *to be filled with the Spirit,* and he gives a pattern for local assembly meetings (15-21). Fourth, with a twofold purpose in mind, Paul explains *what the relationship is* between Christ and His Church, and then he uses it as an example of the ideal husband/wife relationship (22-33).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER SIX was, first, to set forth the *proper relationship* between children and parents and fathers and children (1-4). Second, it was to *instruct slaves* to obey their masters, and the latter are not to threaten their slaves (5-9). Third, he gives them insight into the *real nature of their enemy*, describes the armor that is necessary if they are going to stand and prevail, and affirms their need to persevere in prayer for all believers and for him that he might boldly make known the Mystery of the Gospel (10-20). Fourth, he explains his purpose for sending Tychicus to them (21-22).

SIGNIFICANT TRUTHS

Believers, according to God's good purpose and will, were chosen and foreordained to a position of sons before the creation of the world (1:4-5, 11).

Believers have redemption through the Blood of Jesus Christ (1:7; 2:13).

Believers are sealed by the Holy Spirit, who Himself is a guarantee that we will receive our glorified bodies (1:13-14; 4:30).

Paul's prayer is that believers might have a perfect knowledge of Christ (1:17).

Christ is the sole Head over the Church, which is designated as His Body, the fulness of God (1:22-23; 5:23).

All men are dead in trespasses and sins, children of wrath, and totally depraved (2:1-4; 4:17-18).

God, because of His love and mercy, takes the initiative in making sinners alive in Christ (2:4-5).

All that is involved in salvation is of Grace, that which is freely given by God, including the faith by which one believes (2:5, 8-9).

Those who have been created in Christ are to produce good works previously prepared by God (2:10).

Through Christ both Jews and Gentiles have access by one Spirit to God the Father (2:18).

Paul had a special dispensation of the grace of God given to him for the Gentiles (3:2).

Paul had a distinct body of truth revealed to him which he calls both the Mystery and the Mystery of Christ (3:3-8).

Paul was dominated by one supreme purpose - to make all men see the nature of the dispensation of the Mystery (3:9-11).

In emphasizing the need to keep the unity of the Spirit Paul declares that there is only one baptism (4:5; cf. 1 Cor. 12:13).

From His heavenly position Christ gave men as gifts to his Church (4:10-11).

These men, particularly the teachers, have the responsibility of perfecting all the believers, that they in turn might do the work of the ministry unto building up the Body of Christ (4:12-16).

Paul emphasizes that believers should work with their hands to support themselves and others in need (4:28).

Believers are commanded not to grieve the Holy Spirit (4:30).

We are to forgive others even as God in Christ has forgiven us (4:32).

Believers are commanded to continuously live Spirit-filled lives (5:18).

This epistle suggests that there was a multiple ministry in the local assemblies, not a one-man ministry (5:19-21).

The substitutionary death of Christ on behalf of the Church is clearly taught (5:25).

The truth of the Mystery revealed through Paul focuses on Christ and His relation to the Church (5:32).

Paul affirms that preaching the Mystery of the Gospel was what brought about his imprisonment (6:19-20).

As we reflect back on the contents of this epistle it is unique in that it lacks specific personal references. Since Paul ministered in the city of Ephesus longer than in any other city, we would expect more personal references and greetings instead of none. In view of the very apparent impersonal nature of this epistle, when we would expect just the opposite in an epistle written to the Ephesian church, we legitimately raise the question, was it originally written to the Ephesian believers?

Furthermore, there are some statements in this epistle which are difficult to understand in the light of the close relationship that existed between Paul and these believers. For example, in 1:15, Paul says, "Because of this I also, having heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus and the love unto all the saints." Even though Paul had not been at Ephesus for a few years, we would expect him to be basing such a

statement on *what he knew first-hand* about them instead of on what he had heard. This statement is synonymous with Colossians 1:4, where all that Paul knew about them was what he had heard, for he had not been there before writing to them. The implication is that this may be a *general epistle* which would be read by some churches and believers who had no personal contact with Paul.

Also, let us look at the forepart of the third chapter, where Paul isn't sure that they know about the dispensation of the grace of God, something which should be common knowledge among the Ephesians. Paul says, "If you have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God that was given to me for you." If there was any New Testament church that should have known about the special dispensation of Grace committed unto the Apostle Paul, it should have been the Ephesian church, since he had taught them nearly three years. This verse seems to support the idea that this epistle may be read by some who know nothing about the special dispensation of Grace given to Paul. This lack of knowledge on Paul's part, as to how much his readers may or may not know, is a strong argument favoring the view that this was originally a *general epistle* which was to be circulated among all the churches (cf. 4:21).

If the internal evidence implies that this epistle was not specifically written to the church at Ephesus, which we believe it does, then how did the words "in Ephesus" (εν Εφεσω) find their way into a great number of the manuscripts? The bulk of the manuscripts available today, with a few exceptions, have the words "in Ephesus" in them. There are, however, two very important manuscripts, Aleph and B, and an early papyri, p^{46}, which do not have these words. In evaluating the above we must keep in mind that the *quality* of manuscripts is more important than the bulk of them. The patristic writings suggest that the words "in Ephesus" were not in the early texts.

On the basis of internal evidence we are quite confident that the Apostle Paul wrote this letter as *a general encyclical epistle to all the churches,* particularly, to the Asian churches. In view of Ephesians 6:21-23, Tychicus apparently delivered this epistle to the church at Ephesus at the same time he delivered the epistle to the Colossians and the letter to Philemon. After having read this epistle, the church at Ephesus had the responsibility of distributing it to the other

churches, or at least, seeing to it that all the Asian churches had a chance to read it. Paul may have made the Ephesian church, not only the distributor, but also the custodian of this epistle. This would mean that after it had been distributed to others to read, it was to be returned to Ephesus (cf. 2 Cor. 1:1; Col. 4:16). Granting this thesis, and the need for a mark of identification on it, the words "in Ephesus" would be most logical.

In most of Paul's epistles, to a greater or less extent, he deals with specific problems pertinent to either given churches or to individuals. As we come to the Book of Ephesians, a general encyclical epistle addressed to the common needs of all believers, Paul is free in the Spirit to write about those truths which he considers *most essential* for believers. As Paul approached the writing of this epistle, he certainly realized how important it would be in formulating the thinking of believers in all the churches, and for this reason must have *very carefully considered* what he would include in it. In fact, he had good reason to believe that this might be the only epistle some of the churches would read; therefore, it was imperative that he deal with those specific subjects which would be most helpful in establishing them in their Christian thinking and living.

On the basis of the contents of this general encyclical epistle we get a panoramic view of the *knowledge which is necessary* for the spiritual development of believers. The highlights of this knowledge entail: 1) the reason for what God sovereignly does is *in Himself* 2) what God does during the Church age is *totally determined by Him* and is not contingent on what man does; 3) what God does on behalf of men is done *through the Person of Jesus Christ;* 4) new truth revealed to Paul, the Mystery, puts *Jewish and Gentile believers on a par* in the Body of Christ; 5) the Mystery includes *all truth necessary* for the establishment and operation of the Church; 6) God has provided both *unity and the means* by which it can be maintained; 7) both negative and positive information on *how believers should live;* 8) insight into the relation that exists between Christ and the members of His Body; 9) an explanation of the *kind of armor* believers need in their stand against the devil and his cohorts.

DATE WRITTEN

This epistle was apparently written about the same time Colossians and Philemon were written, for Tychicus delivered these three epistles to Asia at the same time. In view of the internal and externα1 information, we would date it A.D. 60.

Chapter 1

1. ***"Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God, to the saints being in Ephesus and the faithful in Christ Jesus."***

The writer calls himself *Paul*. The first time we were introduced to him, at the stoning of Stephen, he is referred to as a "young man called Saul" (Acts 7:58). He was known by this name through Acts 13:9, at which time he was designated as Paul, his permanent name for the rest of his life. It is interesting that up to this time, on the first missionary journey, Barnabas seemed to be the leader (Acts 13:2, 7), but in verse 9 *Saul took the initiative*, his name was changed to Paul, and he performed his first miracle which was instrumental in the conversion of the proconsul (Acts 13:12). From this time on Luke refers to this missionary team as Paul and Barnabas (Acts 13:43, 46, 50). It is possible that this change in leadership may have been a factor in John Mark returning to Jerusalem (Acts 13:13).

Paul refers to himself in this verse as "an apostle of Christ Jesus." The Greek word translated "apostle" (αποστολος) is derived from "απο" and "στελλω" and means to *place, set,* or *send from*, hence, to send away or dispatch is to *send forth*. The word *apostle* is the noun form and speaks of a *sent forth person* or *one dispatched*. In defending his apostleship before the Corinthians Paul calls to their attention the fact that he has seen the Lord Jesus (1 Cor. 9:1-2), and that he performed the *signs of an apostle* among them, namely signs, wonders, and miracles (2 Cor. 12:12). As an apostle, Paul is not to be confused with the Twelve Apostles, but was chosen to be *the distinct Church Apostle* (3:1-12; Titus 1:1-3).

It is important to observe that Paul was an apostle of a very special Person, Christ Jesus, the son of God. The use of the genitive case indicates that as an apostle he was *owned, possessed,* and *belonged to* Christ. He recognized that he had been crucified together with Christ, that there was no room for living his own old life, but as one for whom Christ had died, he was now *owned by Him*, and logic demanded that Christ had the right to live in him (Gal. 2:19-20; cf. 1 Cor. 6:19-20). The Twelve Apostles were appointed by Jesus Christ to promulgate and execute His Messianic Kingdom reign - still to be

completed. The Apostle Paul was appointed and owned by Jesus Christ to promulgate, establish, and reveal the Truth for the Church (Rom. 2:16; 16:25; 1 Cor. 2:6-10; 12:13).

Observe that Paul refers to the one of whom he is an apostle as "Christ Jesus" (Χριστου Ιησου). The name Jesus relates to His physical body which was offered as a sacrifice for our sin (Matt. 1:21). The name Christ originally identified Him with the Messiah, the anointed one, and the Christ promised in the Old Testament (John 1:41; 4:25; 7:31; Acts 17:3). As Paul uses the name Christ he uses it with a meaning beyond that of the Old Testament - He is the *Head* of the Body, the Church (1:22-23). In his earlier epistles Paul frequently uses the name order *Jesus Christ*, but with the passing of time he increasingly uses the name *Christ Jesus*. In First and Second Timothy he always uses the order, Christ Jesus. Often, just the name *Christ* is used. This suggests that there was a decreasing emphasis on His humanity and an increasing emphasis on His office as head of the Church (2 Cor. 5:16). However, when the word *Lord* precedes Christ's name, Paul consistently speaks of Him with his earlier word order; namely, as the *Lord Jesus Christ*.

Now we come to the question, what led Saul of Tarsus to become the Apostle Paul? On the basis of the Book of Acts and the Pauline Epistles the answer is - *nothing*. The furthest thing from his mind was to become an apostle of Christ (Acts 22:3; 26:4-5, 9-11; Phil. 3:7). Instead, he was doing everything possible to squelch and bring to naught those who believed that Jesus was the Christ (Acts 9:1-2; 22:4-6; 1 Tim. 1:13). There was absolutely *nothing in the mind-set and will of Saul of Tarsus* that transformed him from a hater of Christ into a lover of Christ, and hence into an apostle! Apart from God's Divine intervention, there is no reason to think that Saul of Tarsus wouldn't have carried out his ferocious purpose against the believers in Damascus.

The New Testament historical record makes it abundantly clear that Paul was an apostle of Christ Jesus "through the will of God." The Greek preposition translated "through" (δια), used together with the genitive case, conveys the idea of *through the agency of* the will of God. In other words, the will of God was the *active agent* which transferred Saul from being a zealous Law-keeper into the category

of the Apostle Paul, one who was owned by and at the disposal of Christ Jesus. God's sovereign will irresistibly and effectually energized in Saul, apart from consultation with his depraved will, to bring him into alignment with His specific purpose for him in conjunction with the Church (Gal. 1:15; Eph. 3:2-3, 8).

In four other epistles Paul also affirms that he is an apostle of Christ through the agency of the will of God (1 Cor. 1:1; 2 Cor. 1:1; Col. 1:1; 2 Tim. 1:1). He frankly tells the Galatians that *no human being* had anything to do with his being an apostle, but that it was through the agency of God the Father and Son. Note Galatians 1:1, he says, "Paul an apostle, not from men neither through a man, but through Jesus Christ and God the Father who raised him from the dead."

Now let us consider those to whom Paul was writing. Since we discussed the words "those being in Ephesus" in our preface, which it is imperative that you read for fuller understanding of this epistle, we will not duplicate the same here. Thus, abbreviating the last clause in this verse, Paul is writing "to the saints and the faithful in Christ Jesus" (cf. Col. 1:2). The Greek word translated "saints" (αγιοις), as used here, speaks of those who are *separated from that which is common unto God, those who are sanctified and cleansed in Christ,* or *those who are holy.* Saints are the sovereign product of God. Their holiness is the resultant of identification with Christ.

The Greek conjunction rendered "and" (και), between the words *saints* and *faithful*, also has the meaning of even; i.e., "the saints even the faithful in Christ Jesus." Those who are truly holy in Christ will be *faithful to Christ*. The Greek word for "faithful" (πιστοις) describes those who *fulfill their obligations, obey the Word*, and are *trustworthy*. Observe, Paul is addressing a specific group here - those who are *in Christ, in the sphere of Christ,* and *in His Body*. Apart from Christ men are in their sin, totally depraved, and void of all true holiness and faithfulness. Those who are truly in Christ are holy and faithful ones in their relation to Him and their fellow men.

2. ***"Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ."***

In eight other epistles Paul uses the same greeting with the exception of a slight alteration in Titus (Rom. 1:7; 1 Cor. 1:3; 2 Cor. 1:2; Gal. 1:3; Phil. 1:2; 2 Thess. 1:2; Titus 1:4; Philem. 3). In two epistles the ends are shortened following the words "Grace and peace to you" (Col. 1:2; 1 Thess. 1:1). In First and Second Timothy they are the same as in our text with the exception that the word *mercy* is added to grace and peace. In the last chapter of the Book of Hebrews the writer (Paul) desires that God may give his readers grace and peace (Heb. 13:20, 25). In view of the fact that the words grace and peace were selected by Paul and other New Testament writers to be a commonly used greeting, we want to give adequate consideration to their meaning.

The Greek word translated "grace" (χαρις) has in its etymological background the idea of *joy*; hence, to extend grace is to provide the *basis for spiritual joy and pleasure*. As used by the Apostle Paul, this word has the idea of *giving to those who do not deserve what is given.* It is showing favor to those who do not merit it. It is freely giving to others, that they may have salvation and joy, even though at the time one may be despised for it (Matt. 27:39-44; Luke 23:34). The reason and cause for extending grace is *intrinsic in the giver*, his *nature, love,* and *mercy* (John 3:16; Rom. 9:15-16; Eph. 2:4-5). Truly, grace is unmerited favor toward deliberate, hell-bound sinners, *giving them eternal life* instead of eternal punishment (Rom. 6:23; 2 Cor. 8:9). We must keep in mind that God's grace is essential for our *salvation* (Eph. 2:8), *standing* (Rom. 5:2), and *living* (Rom. 6:14).

The other ingredient Paul desires God to give believers is peace. The Greek word rendered "peace" (ειπηνη), as used here, means *no inner fighting, spiritual and psychological harmony, concord, and tranquillity*. If Paul was writing to sinners, the prime requisite would be for peace between God and them. However, here he is writing to saints, those for whom God has provided *peace with Himself* (Rom. 5:1) and *peace between Jews and Gentiles* (2:14-18). God has once for all established the basis for vertical and horizontal peace by providing His Son as our substitute on Calvary (2 Cor. 5:21; Eph. 2:13). On the one hand, God has made *perfect provision* for believers to be at peace with both Him and their fellow men. On the other hand, there is the constant need for believers to *appropriate and actualize* this provision in their daily living. As God's spokesman, Paul's desire

is that all believers may mature and grow in their realization of God's peace in all its ramifications (Rom. 14:19; Eph. 4:3; Col. 3:15; 2 Tim. 2:22).

The grace and peace of which Paul is speaking is "from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ." The Greek preposition translated "from" (απο) means *from the side of, from the edge of,* or *to come out from.* As "απο" is used here, it seems to border on the meaning of "εκ" which emphasizes *out of* in the sense of source. Prior to the creation of the universe the Triune God predetermined to give grace and peace unto Divinely selected men. This decision was motivated by the *love and mercy of God* (2:4-5), it was *effected through the Blood of Jesus Christ* (Col. 1:20), and it is being applied through the Holy Spirit (Titus 3:5). God the Father gives grace and peace, Jesus Christ on Calvary is the *embodiment of grace that results in peace,* and the Holy Spirit *effectually implants* both in the lives of believers (Rom. 5:5-6; 2 Cor. 3:3).

3. ***"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenlies in Christ,"***

The Greek word for "blessed" (ευλογητος) is derived from "ευ" and "λεγω" and literally means *to speak well of*, hence, to exalt one *worthy of blessing and praise.* Paul directs this blessing toward God the Father, for He is the One who has blessed us. We see God the Father as the *Prime Mover* here, for it is because He has first blessed believers that Paul blesses Him. In other words, Paul's blessing is a response to God's blessing. The aorist participle translated "who has blessed" (ο ευλογησας) us refers to *that which took place prior* to the action of the leading verb. In fact, if God had not first blessed Paul there would not have been any incentive nor ability for him to bless God. Now can a sinner, strangled to death by sin, come to God or bless Him? Impossible - apart from God taking the initiative!

Flowing with the context, Paul declares that God is to be blest because He has blessed all those who have believed "with every spiritual blessing in the heavenlies in Christ." This may also be translated "in every spiritual blessing," i.e., *in the sphere of* every

spiritual blessing. The Greek word used here is *singular*, and means that God has blest believers with every *individual blessing*. The Greek word for "blessing" (ευλογια), as used in this phrase, speaks of every *favor, gift,* and *benefit*. God has literally spoken forth, as a gift, that which is good, benevolent, and needed to bring sinners into a living relationship with Himself.

In contrast to the emphasis on physical blessings in the Old Testament, Paul is emphasizing the fact that we have been blest with every *spiritual blessing*. The Greek word translated "spiritual" (πνευματκη|) refers to that which is *the opposite of physical* (1 Cor. 15:44), *that which is invisible* like the wind (John 3:8), and *that which is on the same plateau with God* (John 4:24). The spiritual blessings Paul is talking about here are those which God extended to certain sinners to enable them to come into relation with Himself. a few of these blessings are: He chose us before the creation of the world to be saints (v. 4); He *foreordained* us to a position of sons (v. 5); He made us *heirs* with the believing Jews (v. 11); and He sealed us with the Spirit until the redemption of the Body (v. 13-14). In Romans 8:28-30 we have a resume of these blessings.

It is important to note that these spiritual blessings are "in the heavenlies in Christ." The Greek word for "heavenlies" (επουρανιοις) is derived from "επι" and "ουρανος" and etymology-wise means *upon or in heaven*. In contrast to an earthly location it speaks of a *heavenly location* (1 Cor. 15:40). It is used to describe *Christ's heavenly position* at the right hand of God (v. 20) and the position we believers occupy with Him (2:6). Every single one of these spiritual blessings is in Christ, in the sphere of Him, dependent upon *who He is and His substitutionary death for us.* This heavenly position in Christ is inseparable from our relation to Him in His Church.

4. ***"Even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, to be holy and blameless before him,"***

The words "even as" (καθως), which are derived from "κατα" and "ως," may also be translated *according as*. This Greek word indicates that Paul is about to delineate some of the spiritual blessings he mentioned in the previous verse. He says that God *chose* us in Christ

before the foundation of the world. The Greek word translated "chose" (εξελεξατο) comes from "εκ" and "λεγω" and basically means *to speak out,* hence*, to pick out* or *select*. The use of the aorist tense indicates that at a *given point in past time* God chose those who will exercise faith in Jesus Christ (2 Tim. 2:10). The use of the middle voice suggests that God sovereignly selected us believers *to fulfill a purpose involving the fulfillment of Himself.* The following context, which will be considered in the order in which it is written, substantiates this view. In addition, we observe that God chose us in Christ *that He might have fellowship with us* (1 Cor. 1:9; 1 John 1:3). We should unceasingly thank and praise Him, that as a result of His establishing fellowship with us, we have the *unspeakable privilege of having fellowship with Him*, our Great Creator and Redeemer!

Having observed that God chose "us" (ημας), individual members of the Body of Christ who confirm our election, now let us consider *when* He did this (1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23; 2 Peter 1:20). Paul says that this selecting of individuals took place "before the foundation of the world." The Greek word translated "foundation" (καταβολης) is derived from "κατα" and "βαλλω" and literally means *to cast down*, hence, *to lay a foundation* or *to create*. Prior to the time God laid the foundation, laid the basis, and created the "world" (κοσμου), He chose us in Christ. Speaking of the Blood of Christ, which was essential for carrying out this choice, Peter says, "He was indeed foreknown before the foundation of the world, and was manifested in the last times because of you" (1 Peter 1:20). Thus we see that God's choosing in Christ and provision for redemption in Christ both took place before the creation of the world.

The *reason* God chose us in Christ before the foundation of the world was for "us to be holy and blameless before Him." Note very carefully our literal translation, for "us to be" (ειναι ημας) holy and blameless. It is *not* that we *might* be, but the resultant of His choice is that we *are* holy. God's sovereign act of choosing us and of providing redemption for us in Christ makes us *absolutely holy and blameless* before Him. Paul is talking here about what God, even before the creation of the cosmos, *determined to do* on behalf of His elect. This is a perfect, once for all transaction, whereby God *forensically confirms* His elect in the holiness in which He originally created man (1 Cor. 1:2; cf. Col.

3:10 -practical sanctification). We must not confuse what God has done, that which we have here, with *what He desires the elect to become* through the power of the Holy Spirit (4:22-24).

Now let us consider the *standing* which God freely gives to His elect in Christ. First, they are declared to be "holy" (αγιους), those who are *separated* from that which is common and unclean, those who are *saints*, and those who have this characteristic in common with God (1 Peter 1:15). Without holiness it is impossible to see God or to stand in His presence (Heb. 12:14). Second, they are declared to be "blameless" (αμωμους). This Greek word is derived from "α" and "μωμος" and literally means *without blemish*, without stain, and void of fault. Peter uses this word in describing Jesus Christ as "a lamb without blemish and without spot" (1 Peter 1:19). Paul uses this same word in 5:27, similar to his use in this verse that Christ gave Himself to make the Church *holy* and *blameless*.

It is significant that we note *before whom* the elect are declared to be holy and blameless. Paul says that God selected us believers "to be holy and blameless *before him*." The Greek word rendered "before" (κατενωπιον) comes from "κατα" and "ενωπιον" and conveys the idea of *in front of, in the presence of,* and *in the sight of*. In writing to the Colossians, Paul uses this word in exactly the same way to point out that on the basis of the death of Christ they are holy and blameless *in His sight* (Col. 1:22). This statement involves more than what meets the eye at first glance. The fact that we are made holy and blameless in His sight certainly implies that this holiness and blamelessness are *according to the Divine standard*; but more than this, it sets the stage for mutual fellowship between God and His elect. The only way for God to have fellowship with men is for Him to make them like He is. This is exactly what He does for those whom He has chosen in Christ, for Christ has been made for them *wisdom, righteousness, sanctification,* and *redemption* (1 Cor. 1:30). Thus, we see that apart from God sovereignly making those whom He has chosen *like He is*, there would be no basis for fellowship between God and men, and apart from this fellowship there would be no basis for moral living. God makes us holy, enables us to have fellowship with Himself, and as a result we are to live holy lives (Col. 3:12-14).

5. ***"In love having foreordained us unto a son position through Jesus Christ unto himself, according to the good pleasure of his will,"***

It is our conviction that this verse should begin with the phrase "in love" (εν αγαπη). The punctuation is not a part of the original inspired text, and this division accords better with the flow and meaning of the context. Paul is affirming here that *love is what motivated God* to foreordain believers to a son-position. In writing this encyclical epistle, Paul says that all men were totally depraved and by nature the children of wrath, but God, "on account of His great love with which He *loved us*, even while we were dead in trespasses made us alive together with Christ" (Eph. 2:4-5).

Observe, Paul refers here to God's love directed toward believers, toward "us" (ημας), *toward those who had exercised faith in Christ* when he was writing, and thereby manifested the fact that they were chosen before the creation of the world. Thus we see, that even as love motivated God to foreordain believers unto a son-position; likewise, in the process of history, it motivated Him to triply identify the elect with the *life, resurrection*, and *heavenly seatment* of Christ. This adds up to the fact of *salvation by grace, faith being an inextricable part* of this free gift (2:8).

Now let us look at the key verb in this verse which we have translated "foreordained" (προορισας). This verb comes from a combining of "προ" and "οριζω" which respectively mean *beforehand* or *prior*, and *to set bounds, limits, and restrictions*. Its etymological meaning dominates the manner in which it is used to convey the idea of to *limit, restrict,* and *mark out beforehand*, to *in prior time design and determine*, or to *ordain beforehand* and to *predestinate*. Since this verb is in the form of an aorist participle, it implies that this foreordaining took place prior to, or at least simultaneous with, the Divine choosing mentioned in the preceding verse. Interpreting this grammatical principle in the light of the context, we understand Paul to be saying that at a given point in time, prior to the creating of the world, God both chose and foreordained individuals to be holy and blameless, and as such, to occupy a son-position.

Having examined the meaning of the Greek word translated "foreordained" (προορισας), let us consider further the conjunctive significance of the phrase "in love" (εν αγαπη) preceding it. It is imperative that we clearly understand that the rebellion of Adam and Eve dragged the entire human race into the pit of *total depravity*. There was *no way* that Adam and Eve could undo what they had done, i.e., restore themselves to their original relation to God. Furthermore, it is just as impossible for their descendants to regain this relation, for those who are spiritually dead are unable to make any advances toward God (Rom. 5:12).

Also, when infants become capable of expressing themselves, they *confirm* the fact that innately they are sinners, depraved, and cut off from God (4:17-19; Col. 3:5-7). If Adam and Eve, having an unconfirmed free will, rebelled against God, *it is naive to think* that sinners, with depraved human wills, even if they could, would be interested in turning to Him, their very opposite (John 3:19-20; Rom. 1:19-21). The dilemma of the human race is that it consists of self-confirmed sinners in Adam, who left to themselves, are both *unwilling and unable* to bring themselves into a true relation to the One Living God.

The Scriptures make it clear that no person will or can come into a vital relationship with God the Son unless *God the Father takes the initiative* (John 6:44; Acts 16:14). Apparently God's original purpose was that all the descendants of Adam and Eve should live in a voluntary relation to Himself. Instead of Adam and Eve *positively confirming* their relationship with God through strict obedience to His Word, they succumbed to the lies and enticements of Satan (Gen. 3:4-5), and lost this universal relationship for both themselves and their descendants.

God's original purpose in Adam and Eve harmonizes with what Paul says in First Timothy, that He "desires, wishes, and wants all men to be saved and to come unto a perfect knowledge of the truth" (1 Tim. 2:4). God did not make Adam and Eve robots, but free moral agents, and as such, His wish and desire for them was that they might confirm themselves in a perfect knowledge of the truth which he had given to them. God's purpose in Adam, to have a voluntary universal relationship with all men, having been thwarted by Adam and Eve

and all men, left God no alternative but to put into effect His eternal purpose in Christ (Titus 1:1-3).

Now let us observe some Scriptural facts regarding God's eternal purpose. First, it is a purpose which is *based upon the love and mercy of God.* Perfectly knowing that the human race in Adam would disobey His Word and become rebels against Him, God, *motivated by love*, promulgated a plan and purpose by which He would bring men into a relationship with Himself according to mercy (Rom. 9:15-18; Eph. 2:4). Please keep in mind, apart from the love of God foreordaining individuals unto a son-position in the Body of Christ, *not a single person would be saved.* We who are believers, who have been chosen and predestined to a sonship relation with God, should unceasingly thank Him for His boundless love and mercy extended toward us.

Second, in contrast to God's universal purpose to bear a relation with *all men* in Adam, God's present purpose is limited to *certain individuals* whom He wills to bring into a relationship with Himself (v. 11). Third, whereas God's purpose with Adam and Eve was *conditional*, depending upon their obedience, His purpose today is *unconditional*, totally dependent upon the perfect, finished work of Jesus Christ on Calvary (Col. 1:22; Heb. 9:14). Fourth, God's purpose with Adam and Eve was *resistible*, since God was confirming them in holiness by testing their obedience to His Word, which they could and did resist, but His purpose today is *irresistible* in that it rests upon His *unchanging will* and the *completed redemptive work* of Christ.

The object or end unto which God foreordained us was to place us in a "son-position" (υιοθεσιαν). The Greek word used here is derived from "υιος" and "τιθημι" and literally means to *place* or *put in the position of a son,* hence, *to adopt a son*, or to give one the *status of a son.* In Galatians 4:5, Paul implies that the basis for this adoption is the redemptive work of Christ. In verse 6 he refers to those who have been adopted *as sons*, who, having received the Spirit, recognize that God is their Father. Thus we see that before the foundation of the world, we were foreordained, predestined, and marked out to be *placed in the position of a son*, and in the process of history, when God calls us through the Holy Spirit, we clearly recognize Him as our

Father. God is dead to the non-elect, who are void of a relation to Him, but to us who are believers, He is not only alive but our Father (Rom. 8:15).

Next in this verse we see that this son-position is "through Jesus Christ" (δια Ιησου Χριστου). The Greek preposition rendered "through" (δια), as used here with the genitive case, clearly states that Jesus Christ is the *Divine Agent* through whom the foreordination has been effected. Apart from the fact that the sacrificial death of Jesus Christ *was foreordained*, the prerequisite for the redemption of sinners, God could not have foreordained individuals and still be just (Acts 2:23; I Peter 1:19-20; Rom. 3:24-26).

There are four very important thoughts in the first half of the verse before us. First, we believers have been foreordained. Second, this has been unto the end of placing us in a son-position. Third, this has been accomplished through Christ's foreknown death. Fourth, the ultimate end unto which God foreordained was to place believers in a sonship relation "unto Himself" (v. 5). According to election we are *His sons* and He is *our Father*. What a wonderful *privilege* it is to be a part of God's chosen family (Heb. 2:10).

The last clause in this verse sets forth the basis God used in foreordaining us. It was "according to the good pleasure of his will." The preposition translated "according to" (κατα), as used here, has the idea of *in keeping with, conforming to,* and *in alignment with* the good pleasure of His will. The Greek word for "good pleasure" (ευδοκιαυ) is derived from the words "ευ" and "δοκεω" and means that God foreordained in conformity with what He *thought best, deemed good,* and *that pleased Him.* In interpreting these definitions we must keep in mind that God is omniscient and all-knowing; therefore, in the light of all the facts of eternity, what He thought best, deemed good, and pleased Him was the *highest possible intelligent decision.* These eternal facts, plus God's perfect judgment, enabled Him to sovereignly, according to His purpose for the ages, foreordain us unto the praise of His grace and glory (vv. 6, 12).

6. ***"unto the praise of his glorious grace which he freely gave us in the beloved,"***

God's purpose in foreordination has as its final object "the praise of his glorious grace." The Greek preposition translated "unto" (εις), as used here with the accusative case, consistently conveys the meaning of *unto the end of, unto the accomplishment of*, or *unto the result of* the praise of His glorious grace. God has doubly manifested His grace in foreordination. First, His purpose to foreordain was motivated by love, bathed in mercy, and an act of grace. Second, the requisite for foreordination, the necessary basis for its enactment, is the outpouring of *God's grace in Jesus Christ on Calvary* (2 Cor. 9:15; 2 Tim. 1:9). In summary, foreordination is not a cold, hard, and callous doctrine as some perceive it to be, but in essence it is *love*, *mercy*, and *grace*. It is the channel through which God pours out His grace upon men, and apart from it *no one* would be saved nor come into a relation with God the Father (Rom. 9:16).

Having observed that foreordination is unto the end of, has as its object, "the praise of his glorious grace," let us consider the fuller meaning of the Greek word translated "praise" (επαιυου). This word is derived from "επι," which basically means *upon*, and "αινος" which has the common meaning of *praise*. Of the eleven times "επαινος" is used in the New Testament, Paul uses it nine and Peter two times. The significance of a prefixed preposition is seen in that it either *alters* or *intensifies* the meaning of the word to which it is prefixed. In this case the prefixed preposition "επι" may well add the idea of *praise on the basis of*, i.e., God's glorious grace, *on the basis of what it has accomplished*, is to be praised. This appears to be the most feasible alteration of the underlying meaning of the word for "praise" (αινος). Summarizing, on the basis of the fact that God's grace has made our foreordination possible, it is to be *praised, commended*, and *applauded*.

Now let us consider the meaning of the phrase translated "his glorious grace" (δοξης της χαριτος αυτου). This may equally well be rendered "unto the praise of the glory of his grace." The thought is that our having been foreordained is unto the end of the praise of the glory that *belongs to His grace* (possessive genitive). The Greek word for "glorious" (δοξης), as used in the context, speaks of His *honorable, splendid*, and *exalted* grace. The word for "grace"

(χαριτος), as we observed in verse 2, depicts that which is *given free, without obligation*, and *on a non-meritorious basis*. In this verse it refers to God's gracious act of foreordaining us based upon God the Son's gracious act of dying for us (Rom. 3:24; Acts 13:48). When we consider that apart from the manifestation of God's grace in predestination and at Calvary, none of us would be saved, not even the Apostle Paul (1 Tim. 1:14-16), it should cause us to praise, commend, and applaud the glorious, splendid, and exalted grace of God!

The phrase "which he freely gave us in the beloved" may also be rendered "which he graced to us in the beloved." The translation "freely gave" is from "εχαριτωσεν," the verb form of the noun *grace* (χαρις); therefore, in being consistently literal, we prefer to use the lesser known verb *graced*. This verb is quite commonly used by Paul, and apart from when it is used with the idea of forgive, it denotes that which *God graces or gives* to us (Rom. 8:32; 1 Cor. 2:12; Phil. 1:29).

Paul goes on to say that God graced His glorious grace unto us *in the Beloved One* (εν τω ηγαπημενω). This is a participle which is in the perfect tense and passive voice. In the light of all that Paul has to say about Jesus Christ (Col. 1:15-17; Heb. 1:2-3), and the significance of the tense and voice of this participle, the implication is that from eternities past *He has and continues to be* the Beloved One of the Father. This is the only time this particular form (ηγαπημενω) is used in the New Testament with respect to Jesus Christ. It is used three times by Paul regarding believers (Col. 3:12; 1 Thess. 1:4; 2 Thess. 2:13). We ceaselessly praise God for His glorious grace which He has graced to us in His Beloved Son, which in turn, has made it possible *for us* to also be called beloved ones.

7. ***"in whom we have the redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of the trespasses according to the riches of his grace,"***

When Paul expresses his praise for the sovereign grace of God extended to us in Jesus Christ, what particular aspect of His Person or ministry does he have in mind? Is he praising God's grace which produced the miraculous and unique birth of Jesus? Is he praising

God's grace for the loving, merciful, compassionate, and hope-bringing ministry and message it enabled Jesus to have? Is he praising God's grace for the perfect, holy, and sinless life it enabled Jesus to live? Yes, all of these are marvelous expressions of God's grace in the incarnate life of His Son, and each is very significant when considered in context, but they are not ^hat Paul has in mind when he talks about the glorious grace of God which was given to us in His Beloved Son.

As the Apostle of the Church, Paul never emphasizes the historical aspects of the earthly life and even the death of Jesus (2 Cor. 5:16). He does, however, go back to the Cross, to *the fact of Jesus' crucifixion and death upon it*, not in the sense of explaining the physical details, but to point out the tremendous *spiritual significance of the Blood of Jesus Christ shed there.* When Paul talks about God's glorious grace in Jesus Christ, he has in mind the *substitutionary death* of Jesus Christ.

There is no doubt about it, God's grace in Jesus Christ focuses on the Cross, where God the Son paid the penalty for man's sin. Speaking of Him, Paul says, "in whom we have the redemption." First, let us consider the meaning of the noun translated "redemption" (απολυτρωσιν). It comes from "απο" and "λυτρος" and literally means to *loose, liberate,* and *ransom from*. As used in this context it conveys the idea that we are *ransomed, delivered,* and *liberated from sin* through the Blood of Jesus Christ. The use of the present tense "we have" (εχομεν) indicates that this redemption is *a present continuous possession.* The phrase translated "in whom" (εν ω) is in the locative case, and clearly states that this redemption is *in the sphere of Jesus Christ.* There have been many who have claimed to be redeemers, but Paul's statement here very specifically narrows the True Redeemer down to the God-man, Jesus of Nazareth, the Christ of the Old Testament (1 Tim. 2:5; Rom. 3:24; 1 Cor. 1:30).

Now let us observe what is required of a redeemer who is able to deliver men from their sins. First, he must be one who is *sinless* before God. Jesus Christ is *the only one* who has ever met this requirement. John the Baptist, with the blemishless sacrificial lamb of the Old Testament in mind, referred to Jesus as "the lamb of God the one taking the sin of the world" (John 1:29). He was able to challenge

his would-be adversaries with the question, "Who of you convicts me concerning sin," only to get a response of silence (John 8:46). As the virgin-born Son of God He was *sinless* in both His nature and life (Heb. 4:15; 2 Cor. 5:21). Second, he must be one who is the *embodiment of righteousness*. In Romans 3:21-22, Paul says that apart from the Law, a righteousness of God has been manifested through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ. As one who was perfectly faithful, He was perfectly righteous (Phil. 3:9). In His very essence, He was and is the righteousness of God (1 Cor. 1:30).

As one who was both sinless and righteous, Jesus Christ met the requirements for an *adequate redeemer*. On the one hand, He was identified with the human race, yet apart from sin (Heb. 4:15), and on the other hand, He was identified with God in Divine righteousness (2 Cor. 5:21). We have redemption *through the agency* of the Blood of Jesus Christ because of Who He was in His sinless human nature and in His *confirmed righteous life*. His Blood had *redemptive value* because it was from the veins of the sinless, blameless Son of God (1 Peter 1:19).

It appears that faithfulness and the Blood of Christ are inseparably *linked together* in Romans 3:25, where Paul says of Him, "whom God set forth a propitiation through faithfulness in his blood." Amplifying the translation - "whom God set forth a propitiation *through the agency of the faithfulness (of Christ) in the sphere of His Blood."* The faithfulness of Christ is what gives worth, value, and makes precious His Blood. He alone has the credentials of sinlessness, righteousness, and faithfulness necessary for the *Adequate Redeemer* (Col. 1:14).

Having declared that we have redemption through the Blood of Christ Paul adds, "the forgiveness of the trespasses according to the riches of his grace." The Greek word translated "forgiveness" (αφεσιν) comes from "απο" and "ιημι" and literally means the act of *sending away, dismissing,* and *pardoning* the trespasses. The Greek word rendered "trespasses" (παραπτωματων) is a combination of "παρα" and "πιπτω" and literally means *to fall by the side of, to fall away,* hence, *to defect.* Thus we see that God has sent away, dismissed,

and pardoned our (the) falling on our face, falling away, and many failures (2 Cor. 5:19; Col. 2:13).

In case anyone might wonder how completely God has forgiven our trespasses, the answer is, "according to the riches of his grace." The Greek word for "according" (κατα), used with the accusative case, means *in keeping with, in proportion to,* or *to the extent of* the riches of His grace. Since the only thing that would limit God in forgiving trespasses is the *extent of the riches of His grace*, we need to carefully consider the meaning of this phrase. The Greek word for "riches" (πλουτος), as used here, means the *wealth, copiousness, abundance,* and *plentifulness* of God's grace. As we have previously noted, "grace" (χαρις) is giving that which is *unmerited, undeserved,* and *unearned.* The word *grace* in itself implies *no limitations* on that which is given. The qualifying word *riches*, preceding the word *grace*, suggests that God's *unlimited wealth of grace* is His ad infinitum ability to forgive all trespasses. This verse leaves no room for unpardonable sins and trespasses in this Church age (Rom. 3:24; 5:17; 1 Tim. 1:14; cf. Eph. 2:7).

8. ***"which he abounded unto us in all wisdom and intelligence,"***

The pronoun "which" (ης) refers back to God's grace. Regarding this grace, Paul says, "He abounded [it] unto us." The Greek word translated "abounded" (επερισσευσεν), as used in this context in the aorist tense, means that God gave His grace *over and above, He lavishly furnished it,* and *caused it to be plentiful* unto us. In bringing out the meaning in this context we are forced to add the English verbs *caused* or *made* to abound. Paul expresses the same thought in Romans 5:15, where he says, "much more the grace of God and the gift of grace of the one man Christ Jesus *abounded* unto the many" (cf. 2 Cor. 9:8). The emphasis of this verse is not on the universal extension of grace, but that it has been abundantly given to "us" (ημας) believers.

Now let us observe that the sphere in which this grace has abounded unto us is "in all wisdom and intelligence." The aorist participle, preceding the contents of the next two verses, makes it clear that the

nouns *wisdom* and *intelligence* comprise the concept of the *Mystery*. First, let us consider the meaning of the word "wisdom" (σοφια) as used in this context. This word is used 27 times by Paul; 16 times it appears to have reference to the truth for the Church, the Mystery Gospel. An example of this is in First Corinthians 2:7, where Paul says, "we speak a wisdom of God in a mystery." The point Paul is making here is that the abounding grace of *God has provided the wisdom contained in the Mystery* and all that it entails for us believers.

Second, the word we have translated "intelligence" (φρονησει), as used here, means that God caused His grace to abound in *giving understanding and intellectual insight* into the truth of the Mystery, the truth pertaining to the dispensation of the grace of God (3:2). The emphasis here is on God's grace giving believers an intelligent and intelligible revelation of Truth for their obedience as members in the Body of Christ.

9. ***"having made known to us the mystery of his will, according to his good pleasure which he purposed in him"***

The Greek word translated "having made known" (γνωρισας) is an aorist participle which indicates that in past time God *gave knowledge, cognition,* and *understanding* of the mystery of His will. Paul affirms that God revealed this secret knowledge of His will to us. The plural pronoun "us" (ημιν) may be interpreted as an *editorial we*, or it may be interpreted to include Paul and those associated with him. In view of what Paul says in chapter 3:2-9, the most feasible interpretation is that the pronoun *us* is used with a singular editorial meaning (cf. Rom. 2:16; 16:25; 2 Tim. 2:8). The emphasis here is on truth which God had made known to the Apostle Paul (1 Cor. 2:10; Gal. 1:12), which he in turn shared with other apostles, prophets, teachers, and elders (Acts 20:24; Phil. 4:9; Col. 1:25-28; 2 Tim. 2:2).

Now let us look at that which God made known to Paul, namely, the "mystery of his will" (μυστηριον του θεληματος). The Greek word rendered "mystery" (μυστηριον,) as used in this context, speaks of that which had been *hidden, concealed*, and *kept secret*. The word translated "will" (θεληματος) is a noun and it conveys the idea of that

which God has willed, hence, His *design, plan*, and *purpose*. The phrase, the mystery of His will, implies that prior to being revealed to Paul, God's design for this Church age was hidden, His plan was concealed, and His purpose was kept a secret. The consistent message of the Pauline Epistles is that *God made known His will to Paul* for the Church, truth which had previously been *hidden from all men* (Rom. 16:25; 1 Cor. 2:7-9; Eph. 3:5, 8; Col. 1:26).

Having declared that God made known to him the mystery of His will, Paul adds, "according to his good pleasure" (κατα την ευδοκιαν αυτου). The Greek preposition translated "according to" (κατα), as used here in the accusative case, indicates that God revealed His will *in accordance with, in keeping with,* or *in conformity* to His good pleasure. In other words, the truth which constitutes the mystery of His will, the truth which was made known to Paul for the Church, is exactly that which God was pleased to reveal. The Greek noun translated "good pleasure" (ευδοκιαν) is derived from the two words "ευ" and "δοκεω" and means that God, who is omniscient, made the specific truth for the Church known in accordance with what He *thought, considered,* and *approved as good*. The mystery of God's will, revealed in Paul's epistles, is the masterpiece of God's thinking for this Church age.

Now let us observe that the mystery of God's will, the plan which He was pleased to design for this present dispensation of grace, was "purposed" (προεθετο) in Christ. The use of the feminine relative pronoun "which" (ην) definitely makes the phrase *His good pleasure* the antecedent of what was purposed in Christ. This means that the truth which God was pleased to reveal for the Church, that which constitutes the mystery of His will made known to the Apostle Paul, was "purposed" (προεθετο), *set forth, determined,* and *designed beforehand to be effected in Christ.* The total gamut of truth for the Church, from the beginning unto the end, orbits around the Person of Jesus Christ. The individual members of the Church were chosen in Him (v. 4), they were foreordained to a position as sons through Him (v. 5), they received the epitome of God's grace in Him (v. 6) and redemption from sin through His Blood (v. 7).

10. ***"unto a dispensation of the fulness of the times, to sum up all things in Christ, things upon (in) the heavens and things upon the earth, in him, "***

As we approach this verse we need to carefully observe the preposition translated "unto" (εις). Used with the accusative case it expresses the idea of *movement toward* a given object, and we most commonly render it *unto the end of*, i.e., unto the end of a dispensation beyond that of the Church. The Greek word translated "dispensation" (οικονομιαν) is a combination of the words "κοικος" and "νεμω" and this feminine noun form, as used by Paul, always refers to an *arrangement, administration,* or *economy* which covers a given period of time. This is the only time Paul speaks of a "dispensation of the fulness of the times." On the basis of the possessive genitive, we may render this, "unto a dispensation which belongs to the fulness of the times." Note that the phrase "the times" (των καιρων) is in the plural, which we would identify with the dispensational epochs. The word "fulness" (πληρωματος) indicates that Paul is referring to the *last dispensational period of time.*

In this grand finale dispensation, which is the ultimate consummation of God's revealed purpose, all things will be summed up in Christ. The Greek word translated "to sum up" (ανακεφαλαιωσασθαι) is derived from " ανα " and "κεφαλαιον" and literally means *to head up,* hence, *to bring together, to assemble,* and *reduce* all things under the headship of Christ. We recognize that in this present dispensation of grace Christ is the sole Head of the Church, i.e., everything which relates to the Church, His Body, is directly under His headship. In Ephesians 1:22 Paul says that God the Father gave Christ the position of "head over all things to the church" (cf. 4:15; 5:23; Col. 1:18). However, at the present time, things beyond the scope of the Church are not subject to Him. Writing from the vantage point of the present Church age, Paul says in Hebrews 2:8, "but now we do not yet see all things as having been subjected to him." An even more literal meaning of the perfect passive participle used here is that "we do not yet see all things having been arranged under him." Thus we see that what is said in this verse is not being fulfilled in this present dispensation, but it awaits fulfillment in a future and final dispensation.

Paul precludes possible misunderstanding of his statement "to sum up all things in Christ" by adding "things upon the heavens and things upon the earth." Since the preposition translated "upon" (επι) is used with both the words for heavens and earth, and does have the basic meaning of *upon*, we have so rendered it. Paul's point of view is that even as things upon the earth are to be arranged under Christ, likewise things upon the heavens (plural). In First Corinthians 15:20-28, Paul gives a resume of the order in which future events will take place: first, the resurrection of Christ (v. 23); second, the resurrection of those who belong to Christ at His coming (v. 23); third, His Kingdom reign during which He will put all the enemies under His feet (rulers, authorities, and powers, vv. 24-25; cf. Phil. 2:9-11).

11. ***"in whom we were made heirs having been foreordained according to the purpose of the one working all things according to the determination of his will,"***

This verse declares that God sovereignly brought a given people unto Himself. Paul uses the first person plural verb ending we to designate them. In the 13th verse he used the second person plural pronoun you to depict another group. It is obvious that both of these groups are believers. In view of the context it is apparent that the we group consisted of *saved Jews* and the *you group* consisted of *saved Gentiles.* Paul makes this distinction here in the light of the prevailing mind-set of his day, particularly pointing out that God the Holy Spirit had also sealed the Gentile believers in the Body of Christ.

Speaking with reference to Christ, Paul says to the Jewish believers among those to whom he was writing, "in whom also we were made heirs." The Greek verb translated "we were made heirs" (εκληρωθημεν) is in the aorist tense and passive voice and means that God gave them a *lot, portion,* and *share* in Christ. The passive voice denotes that this was the *work of God* and the aorist tense indicates that it was *completed* when they exercised faith in Jesus Christ. Paul wanted the Jews to recognize that they are not heirs in this Church age because they are Abraham's seed or because they try to keep the Law (Rom. 4:13; Gal. 3:22), but because God has given them an inheritance in Christ (Titus 3:6-7).

The fact that individual Jews were made heirs had not been left to chance, but they had been "foreordained according to the purpose of the one working all things." The Greek word translated "having been foreordained" (προορισθεντες) comes from "προ" and "κοριζω" and literally means to *mark or stake out beforehand*, hence, to *predestine* or *predetermine*. The aorist participle form clearly indicates that these Jewish believers were foreordained *prior* to the time they were made heirs, which was actually before they were chosen in Christ before the creation of the world (1:4-5). In sovereignly bringing them to Himself God first foreordained them according to His elective purpose, and second He made them heirs when they came on the scene in the process of history.

What guidelines has God used in foreordaining individuals to become heirs in Christ? Paul gives us the answer to this question in the verse - God has foreordained *in accordance with His purpose* as determined by His will. We as believers need to understand that God did not choose us on a haphazard, random, or mere preferential basis, but that His choice of us involved the effecting of His purpose. The Greek noun translated "purpose" (προθεσιν) is derived from "προ" and "κτιθημι" and literally means *to set or place beforehand*, hence, *a prior design, a prefixed mind-set*, or a *predetermined plan.* It stretches our imagination in grasping the fact that God has taken us, the elect, into union with Himself in the working out of His eternal purpose. We cannot begin to comprehend *how valuable* every foreordained heir is in the fulfillment of His present purpose through the Church.

There are those who feebly acknowledge that God originally created all things, but then they say that since that time He has assumed a passive role. Contrariwise, Paul teaches the opposite in this verse, for the God who has foreordained us according to His purpose is “the one working all things according to the determination of his will.” The phrase translated “the one working” (του ενεργουντος) consists of a definite article preceding a present participle. This phrase emphasizes the fact that God is *continuously working* and energizing in conjunction with His purpose. The use of the genitive of possession makes it clear that the above sovereign purpose *belongs*

to a God who is ceaselessly moving toward the accomplishment of His purpose for the ages (cf. 3:11).

The fact that God had *foreordained* the believing Jews and made them *heirs in Christ* in conjunction with His purpose was according to the determination of His will. The Greek word translated "determination" (βουλην) may also be rendered *counsel, deliberation, design,* and *decree* of His will; i.e., that belongs to God's will. The basic premise is the will of God, when exercised it deliberates, designs, makes decisions, and determines God's plan and purpose. Summarizing, we begin with *God's will* making *determinations*, which are formulated into His *purpose*, which in turn results in the *foreordination* of given individuals before the creation of the world, which in the process of history makes their *heirs* in Christ.

12. ***"unto the end for us to be unto the praise of his glory, those who had before hoped in the Christ."***

It is difficult to accurately translate the meaning of this verse into clear English. Another very literal translation of the first part would be, "unto the end we to be unto the praise of his glory." The previous verse emphasized what God had done for the believing Jews, how He had brought them to Himself through foreordination making them heirs in Christ. This verse affirms that this was unto the end of the praise of His glory. The believing Jews, as trophies of God's sovereign purpose, were in essence new creations in Christ, totally the work of God, and as such unto the praise of His glory. As we observe God sovereignly transform a sinner into a saint, take a Saul of Tarsus and make him into the Apostle Paul, we are viewing that which is unto the praise of His glory. This entire context is dealing with what *God has done* unto the praise of His glorious grace (v. 6) and unto the praise of His glory (vv. 12, 14).

Having observed in this context that God is the sole Actor, and that what He has done is unto the praise of His grace and glory, let us briefly consider the other side, that He also seeks to be glorified through those He has chosen. In First Corinthians 10:31 we are told to do all things unto the glory of God. According to Philippians 1:11 believers are to be filled with the fruit of righteousness through Christ unto the glory and praise of God. If God is to be praised and glorified

He must directly do it Himself or He must indirectly do it by the Holy Spirit through His people.

As we approached verses 11-12 we pointed out that they were dealing with believing Jews. Paul's statement in the latter part of verse 12 confirms this, for he refers to them as "those who had before hoped in Christ." For centuries the Jews looked forward to the coming of the Messiah, the Anointed One. When He actually came the nation rejected Him, but elect, individual Jews accepted Him as their Head over the Church (Rom. 9:11, 16; 11:5, 7, 28).

13. ***"in whom also you having heard the word of the truth, the gospel of your salvation, in whom also having believed you were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit"***

In this verse Paul used the pronoun "you" (υμεις) to direct what he is saying to the believing Gentiles. Even as his emphasis in verse 11 was on what the Jews have in Christ; likewise his emphasis here is on what the Gentiles have in Him. His main thrust is to remind the Gentiles that they have been Divinely sealed in Christ by the Holy Spirit. He gives a brief historical sketch of the steps involved in the Gentiles coming into Christ. First, they heard the word of the truth; second, this was the gospel which contained their salvation; third, having believed this gospel they were saved; and fourth, the evidence of their salvation was the sealing of the Holy Spirit. We will consider some of the pertinent details related to each of these steps.

First, we need to consider the meaning of the phrase "the word of the truth" (τον λογον της αληθειας) which the Gentiles had heard. This exact phrase is used three times by the Apostle Paul (Col. 1:5; 2 Tim. 2:15). In each case Paul used the definite *Greek article before the noun, truth,* which is accurately translated "the truth" (της αληθειας). In each of these instances Paul is speaking about a specific body of truth, the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24), the unsearchable riches of Christ (Eph. 3:8), and the Mystery of Christ (Col. 4:3). In other words, Paul is talking about the fact that the Gentiles had heard the word of the truth, the revealed Mystery, the good news that they also had the *privilege of becoming members of the Body of Christ,* the Church. Apart from God's sovereign purpose to make the Gentiles fellow-heirs with the Jews in the Body of Christ, which

purpose was revealed to Paul for the Church, no Gentile would have been interested in nor able to become a member of the Church (3:4-6).

On the first missionary journey, which came under the leadership of the Apostle Paul (Acts 13:9, 13), we observe that at Antioch "the Gentiles hearing were rejoicing and glorifying the word of the Lord, and as many believed as had been arranged unto eternal life" (Acts 13:48). In Thessalonica a multitude of Greeks, i.e., Gentiles, believed the Gospel proclaimed by Paul (Acts 17:4). In Corinth, when the Jews resisted his message, he turned to the Gentiles who were willing to listen (Acts 18:6, 10). Observe other earlier examples of how the Lord was incipiently instilling interest in the minds of the Gentiles (Acts 10:3-6; 11:1, 18).

Second, as Paul looks back 12 years to the time when he began preaching to the Gentiles he uses the *same terminology* to describe his message then as when he was writing. Much had happened during the intervening time covered by the Book of Acts. Paul had confirmed to Israel that Jesus was the Messiah, with accompanying sign gifts, which became extant when Israel refused to listen and was laid aside. With the temporary laying aside of Israel much of the Jewish paraphernalia sloughed off from the early churches. The one thing which remained unchanged and unaltered was the distinct revelation of truth given to the Apostle Paul (Gal. 1:12; cf. 8-9).

He speaks of "the word of the truth" which the Gentiles had heard as also "the gospel of your salvation." Observe the phrase "the word of the truth" is broad enough to comprehend all the truth of the Mystery Gospel. On the one hand, as it related to the ongoing Church, it kept expanding until Paul finished his last epistle. On the other hand, as it related to the gospel of salvation, the fact that justification is by grace through faith apart from works, it was *unalterable* (Gal. 1:8-9). Paul preached the *same* gospel of salvation to the last Gentile as to the first.

Third, having heard the word of the truth, the gospel of their salvation, Paul says to them, "in whom also having believed you were sealed." Behind the scene there is the implication that they believed the message of salvation first, the word of the truth which Paul taught

them, and as a result they believed in the Person of Jesus Christ as their Saviour. We know that *God gives* to His chosen and elect the necessary faith to believe in Jesus Christ. It is a part of the salvation which He has freely provided for them (Eph. 2:8). God has not seen fit to reveal exactly how He implants this faith in the minds of those who are to believe, but Romans 10:17 may have significant bearing on the subject. One thing we do know: if these Gentiles *in themselves conjured up the faith to believe*, then they were saved by works and not by grace. Everything that is generated and produced by a depraved human mind falls into the category of the works of the flesh (Rom. 8:5-8).

Fourth, Paul says that the Gentiles who believed in Christ "were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit." The Greek grammar used here would also permit the translation "were sealed by means of the promised Holy Spirit." The first translation looks at the *Holy Spirit Himself as the seal,* while the second focuses our attention on the *Holy Spirit as the sealer.* We definitely prefer the first translation for it smoothly flows along with the thought of the following verse. The Greek verb translated "you were sealed" (εσφραγισθητε) is in the aorist tense and passive voice and may mean *a mark of acceptance, a mark of ownership,* or *a seal of security.* It appears to me that the sealing with the Holy Spirit may have this triple significance.

There was never any question about the right of the Jews to become members of the Body of Christ. From the time when God graciously selected Abraham, their father out of Ur of the Chaldees, they had an inside relation with Him. On the other hand, the situation of the Gentiles was very different. Paul describes them as being "alienated from the commonwealth of Israel and strangers of the covenants of the promise, not having hope and without God in the world" (Eph. 2:12). They had no reason to think that they would be accepted into the Church as first class citizens (Phil. 3:20). It is very possible that Paul's statement, "You were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit," may have reference to the precursory sealing mark of the Spirit at Caesarea (Acts 10:44-47; cf. 19:1-7).

Having suggested that this seal may have been a preliminary outward mark of Gentile acceptance, don't for one moment think that this exhausts its significance. In a much deeper theological sense, it

applies to both Jews and Gentiles being sealed and secured in the Body of Christ as God's very own (2 Cor. 1:21-22). God the Holy Spirit is the Active Agent who calls (Rom. 8:30), re-creates (2 Cor. 5:17), baptizes (1 Cor. 12:13), and seals believers in the Body of Christ. The Holy Spirit seals and *secures* that which God began doing before the foundation of the world.

14. ***"who is an earnest of our inheritance, unto the redemption of the purchased one, unto the praise of his glory."***

In the previous verse Paul reinforced the truth to the Gentiles that they have been sealed with the promised Holy Spirit. In this verse he continues to enlarge on the Holy Spirit's ministry to both Jews and Gentiles. The Spirit plays a very important role in assuring that God's future purpose for each believer will be meticulously fulfilled. The Holy Spirit Himself acts as surety guaranteeing that every elect person will receive his glorified body (2 Cor. 5:1-5; Phil. 3:20-21).

Now let us carefully exegete the clause, "Who is an earnest of our inheritance." The relative pronoun translated "who" (ος) is in the masculine gender in the most valid manuscripts. Even if it was in the neuter gender it still should be translated "who" because it refers to a person. Slavish adherence to genders, without recognizing that they are not always used in the same manner in different languages, often results in an inaccurate conveyance of thought from one language to another. For example, the word for child (τεκνον) in Greek is in the neuter case. We recognize this as a language idiosyncrasy, and like the neuter word "Spirit" (πνευμα) adjust it to the proper English gender. The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Godhead and should always be referred to as he, him, who, and whom in translating from the Greek.

Paul used the present tense to affirm that the Holy Spirit *is now, currently,* and *at the present time* "an earnest of our inheritance." The Greek noun translated "earnest" (αρραβων) also conveys the thought of *pledge* or *guarantee*. In view of the evidence we feel that the word earnest most accurately expresses Paul's intended meaning. The Holy Spirit, with whom all believers are sealed in the Body of Christ, is like an initial *earnest* payment, a pledge that full payment will be

made when due, which in this case is the receiving of our inheritance. This noun translated "inheritance" (κληρονομιας), as used in the New Testament, speaks of that which is *handed down, passed on*, or given as a *gift* or *reward*. Even though Paul uses this word seven other times in the New Testament, none of the contexts aid in defining its meaning as used here. Three passages mention a future inheritance, but they are not definitive, too general to throw any light on the verse before us (Acts 20:32; Col. 3:24; Heb. 9:15).

On the other hand, this 14th verse contains a built-in definition of our inheritance. The Holy Spirit is the earnest of our inheritance unto the end of "the redemption of the purchased one." The Greek word rendered "redemption" (απολυτρωσιν) conveys the thought of *deliverance, liberation,* and *emancipation*. The phrase translated "the purchased one" (της περιποιησεως) has the meaning of one who has been *obtained, acquired*, hence, a possession. Summarizing, Paul is affirming that the Holy Spirit is an earnest/pledge unto the end of the redemption, deliverance, liberation, and emancipation of the one who has been purchased, obtained, and acquired through the Blood of Jesus Christ (Acts 20:28; cf. 1 Thess. 5:9; 2 Thess. 2:14 for the meaning of *obtain*).

This use of the Greek word for "redemption" (απολυτρωσιν) is found in other passages. In Romans 8:23 Paul says that we believers are anticipating "the redemption of our body." In Ephesians 4:30 Paul exhorts believers not to "grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with whom you have been sealed unto the day of redemption." These verses give us a clear precedent for applying the Greek word for redemption to a future time when believers will be liberated from corruptible into incorruptible bodies.

The general truth in this verse is also corroborated by other passages. In Second Corinthians 1:21-22 Paul declares that God has sealed us "and given the earnest of the Spirit in our hearts." In the fifth chapter of this same epistle Paul expresses a longing for his heavenly body, saying, "God has wrought us for this end, who has given to us the earnest of the Spirit" (2 Cor. 5:5; cf. 1 Cor. 15:52-53; Phil. 3:20-21).

Finally, as Paul comes to the end of the first section in this epistle, he says, "unto the praise of his glory." Thus far Paul has been sharing with his readers what *God has done, is doing*, and *will do* on their behalf. God is the Sole Actor in these first 14 verses. What He has done and why He has done it has its object reason, and purpose *in Himself.* The summation of this portion is - "unto the praise of His glorious grace" (v. 6) and "unto the praise of His glory" (vv. 12, 14).

15. ***"Because of this I also, having heard of the in-you faith in the Lord Jesus and the love unto all the saints,:"***

In this section Paul's desire is that they might have spiritual wisdom in perfectly knowing Christ. However, before he tells them that he is praying unto this end, he lets them know that he is unceasingly thanking God for the spiritual progress which they have already made. a brief of this verse, based on the flow of thought, would be, "because of this I also . . . do not cease giving thanks on behalf of you." Interjected in the middle of this brief Paul gives his *reason* for giving thanks. Having observed why Paul opens this verse as he does and the logic of it in the flow of the context, let us concentrate on his two reasons for giving thanks for them.

Paul's use of the aorist participle, translated "having heard" (ακουσας), implies that there was a relatively good flow of news from these churches to him in Rome (Col. 1:7; 4:12-13). He had undoubtedly heard many things about these believers, but according to the *value standard for the Church*, two things stood head and shoulders above everything else; namely, their *faith in the Lord Jesus Christ* and their *love unto all the saints.*

First, the Greek word rendered "faith" (πιστιν) has the thought of *belief* and *trust.* It is to have *complete confidence* in God's total revelation concerning His Son and to *unreservedly rely* upon His Blood for forgiveness of sin and a righteousness acceptable to God (1:7; 2 Cor. 5:21; Gal. 2:16). Faith in Christ is the initial step. It identifies the sinner with the Saviour.

Second, the Greek word for "love" (αγαπην) is best defined in First Corinthians 13:4-7. It is the first listed fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22). Believers have the mutual responsibility to love one another (Rom.

13:8). We are to hold up one another in love (Eph. 4:2). This love is not to be confined, but is to *encompass all the saints*, all members of Christ's Church.

16. ***"I do not cease giving thanks for you, making mention in my prayers,"***

In view of their faith in Jesus Christ, which was being manifested in love toward all the saints, Paul is unceasingly giving thanks for them. a fuller rendering of his thought is that *faith in Christ* produces *faithfulness to Christ* which is manifested in *obedience to His Word* and results in *love toward all* the saints. It is important we note that their love was "unto all the saints" (εις παντας τους αγιους). Statements such as this leave no room for sectarian exclusiveness, but suggest that we should love and be concerned for all members of the Body of Christ.

The phrase translated "I do not cease" (ου παυομαι) means that Paul did not *stop, desist,* or *discontinue* giving thanks for them. Our English word *pause* is a transliteration of this Greek word, i.e., Paul did not pause in giving thanks to God. The present participle translated "giving thanks" (ευχαριστων) is derived from " ευ" and "χαρις" and means that he was continuously expressing *gratefulness, gratitude,* and *thankfulness* for those to whom he was writing. The phrase translated "for you" (υπερ υμων) conveys the idea of *on behalf of* or *for the sake of* you. Summarizing, Paul was unceasingly expressing this thankfulness to God the Father on behalf of those to whom this epistle was directed.

In the first part of this verse Paul gives thanks to God for what He is doing in the lives of these believers, while in the last part he is making mention of them in his prayers. The Greek phrase translated "making mention" (μνειαν ποιουμενος) has in the background the thought of *remembrance*, i.e., *what is remembered* is the basis for making mention and referring to them in his prayers. Paul uses the same general grammatical construction in writing to the Romans, for he says that God is my witness, "how unceasingly I make mention of you" (Rom. 1:9). In First Thessalonians 1:2, after having expressed thanksgiving to God, Paul makes an identical statement, "making

mention in (our) prayers" (cf. Philemon 4). Paul's consistent prayer formula is to first *thank God* for what He has done and is doing, and, second, *to mention* or pray for further spiritual maturity in the lives of believers (cf. Phil. 1:3-11).

Having observed that the phrase *making mention* portrays Paul reaching out in his prayers to the end that believers might grow, now let us briefly consider the significance of the statement, "in my prayers" (επι των προσευχων). First, the preposition "επι", which has the basic meaning of upon, and indicates that Paul's petitioning was on the basis of his prayers, may be well translated *in* as used in this context. He uses the common Greek word for "prayers" (προσευχων) in the plural, with the article preceding it, which implies that time after time he prayed.

He speaks of the time he spent in prayer as "my prayers" (προσευχων μου), prayers which belonged to him. He uses this same plural phrase *the prayers*, together with the possessive pronoun "my" (μου), in both Romans and Philemon (Rom. 1:10; Phile. 4; cf. 1 Thess. 1:2). In view of these facts we conclude that Paul spent *definite times* in prayer each day as well as constantly *living in a prayer relation* to God (6:18; Col. 1:3, 9; 1 Thess. 5:17). He obviously believed that prayer was a potent factor in the glorification of God (1 Cor. 10:31; Eph. 3:21; Phil. 1:9-11).

17. ***"that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give to you a spirit of wisdom and revelation in a perfect knowledge of him,"***

As we come to this verse we begin to see some of the *specific* things which Paul was making mention of in his prayers. The English word "that" is a translation of the Greek conjunction "ινα" and used with the subjunctive mode denotes the *purpose* of Paul's prayers. A fuller translation of this "ινα" clause is *in order that God may give to you* spiritual insight. Paul was very purposefully praying that God would meet specific needs in their lives.

Now observe the One to whom Paul addressed his prayers, namely, "the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory." The genitive

of possession, as used in the statement "the God of our Lord Jesus Christ," makes it clear that the God to whom Paul prayed was the One who *belonged* to Jesus Christ. The use of the pronoun "our"(ημων) indicates that they mutually acknowledged Jesus Christ as their Lord. They knew the fact that He had been incarnated in the flesh (John 1:14), that He had personally manifested Himself to Paul (Acts 9:3-6), and that He was a Real Person. Since they knew Jesus Christ, Paul was able to define the God to whom he prayed as *His God,* moving from the known to the unknown.

Paul also describes the God to whom he prayed as "the Father of glory." The noun "Father" (πατηρ) in this case primarily refers to the God to whom he prayed as also the *Father of Jesus Christ* (cf. 2 Cor. 1:3; 11:31; Eph. 1:3). He, of course, is also commonly referred to as our Father (Rom. 1:7; 1 Cor. 1:3). This is the only time Paul uses the phrase, "the Father of glory," however, he often associates the Father with glory (Rom. 6:4; Phil. 4:20; Gal. 1:4-5). Since the ultimate end of God the Father's sovereign purpose is His glory (1:11-12), and that He will consummate us with Christ in glory (Rom. 8:30), it is logical that Paul commonly refers to Him as the God and Father of glory (Phil. 2:11; 4:20), and the God of glory (Rom. 3:23; 5:2 15:7). Thus we conclude that all prayer is to be addressed to *God the Father* (3:14).

Now that we have considered the One to whom Paul prayed, let us examine the *purpose* of his prayers. He was asking God to specifically give to them "α spirit of wisdom and revelation in a perfect knowledge of him." In view of the fact that there is no article before the word for "spirit" (πνευμα) and in the light of the context, it should be translated *a spirit*. If Paul's reference here was to the Holy Spirit, he would be implying that these believers had not yet received Him, an implication utterly foreign to the truth in his epistles (Rom. 8:2, 9-16).

We need to consider some of the different ways the word "spirit" (πνευμα) may be used. It may be translated *wind* (John 3:8) *breath* (2 Thess. 2:8), a given *essence* (John 3:6), *mind* (Acts 19:21; Rom. 1:9; Eph. 3:23), and as a *mind with various qualities* such as a mind of *slumber* (Rom. 11:8), a mind of *faith* (2 Cor. 4:13), and a mind of

power, love, and sound thinking (2 Tim. 1:7). Thus we see, Paul is praying that God will give them via their spirit a mind of wisdom and revelation enabling them to perfectly know Jesus Christ.

Paul's prayers are unto the end that God would give them a via-spirit-mind imbued with wisdom and enlightenment essential for perfectly knowing Himself. The Greek verb translated "give" (δωη) is an aorist subjunctive with the meaning of *bestow, grant,* or *supply*. Paul is praying that God will objectively supply to their minds wisdom and insight. God's customary method used to reveal new truth and to impart knowledge of truth already given is through the agency of the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 2:10, 12). This fact forces us to recognize that the word "spirit" (πνευμα), as used in this verse, has both a human spirit and mind connotation. There is an indivisible juncture between the spirit and mind of believers. God the Holy Spirit, through the medium of the human spirit, imparts to the minds of believers divine wisdom and enlightenment. As we endeavor to harmonize biblical terminology with modern terminology an acceptable amplified translation would be, that He "may give to you a *spirit-mind* of wisdom and revelation in a perfect knowledge of him."

Having observed that it is possible to move God through prayer to give believers a spirit-mind of wisdom and revelation, now let us examine the meaning of the Greek word translated "wisdom" (σοφιας). This word depicts that which is the *sum total of all knowledge* (Acts 6:3; 7:22). It is the ability to think and act correctly (Acts 7:10). It is a word commonly used to describe the Truth for the Church in this age of Grace (Rom. 11:33; 1 Cor. 2:7; Eph. 3:10; Col. 1:9, 28). As the Head over the Church Christ is referred to as *the embodiment of wisdom* (1 Cor. 1:24; Col. 2:3). In view of the above usages, and the fact that Paul *most commonly* uses it with reference to the Truth for the Church, the Mystery, we conclude that Paul is praying for God to give them a *full understanding of the Mystery,* particularly, as it relates to His calling, inheritance, and power unto believers.

Now let us consider Paul's prayer for God to give them a spirit-mind of revelation. The Greek word for "revelation" (ιαποκαλυφεως) comes from "απο" and "καλυπτω" and literally means to *uncover*, hence, *the*

disclosing and opening up of Mystery Truth pertaining to the Body of Christ, the Church. Paul's use of the noun revelation in conjunction with the Mystery, the Truth for the Church, confirms the fact that his main burden is for them to have insight and enlightenment into God's present church purpose in Christ (Rom. 16:25; Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:3; cf. 1 Cor. 2:10; Eph. 3:5). Summarizing, Paul is praying that God through the Holy Spirit will, via their human spirits, give them wise and enlightened minds in the Truth encompassing Christ and His Church.

As Paul prays that they may have a spiritual mind of wisdom and insight, he adds the phrase, "in a perfect knowledge of him." The context makes it clear that the antecedent of the pronoun "him" (αυτου) is God. The Greek noun translated "α perfect knowledge" (επιλνωσει) is derived from "επι" and "γινωσκω" and literally means knowledge based upon something such as Divinely revealed truth. Apart from Peter this noun form is exclusively used by Paul, particularly in his latter epistles, with the idea of a *perfect, full,* and *complete knowledge* (cf. Rom. 3:20; 10:2). Bath Paul and Peter use it with reference to a perfect knowledge of Christ (4:13; 2 Peter 1:18; 2:20) and a perfect knowledge of God (Col. 1:10; 2 Peter 1:2, 3). It is most frequently used by Paul with reference to a perfect knowledge of the Truth (1 Tim. 2:4; 2 Tim. 2:25; 3:7; Titus 1:1; Heb. 10:26). It is also used by him regarding a perfect knowledge of the Mystery (Col. 2:2). In conclusion, Paul is praying that they may have wise and enlightened minds *in the sphere of a perfect knowledge* of God's provision. This enlightenment involves the Truth, the Mystery, of which Christ is the very center.

18. ***"having enlightened the eyes of your heart, unto the end that you may know what is the hope of his calling, what is the richness of the glory of his inheritance in the saints,"***

The Greek word translated "having enlightened" (πεφωτισμενους) is a participle in the perfect tense and passive voice. It may be more fully rendered *having had enlightened, having had light thrown upon,* or *having had illuminated the eyes of your heart*. The use of the perfect participle suggests that *prior* to giving to them a spirit of wisdom and revelation, they had the eyes of their heart enlightened. This could be interpreted to include their initial salvation when the Lord transferred them from darkness to light (5:8). Furthermore, this tense implies that

the results of this enlightening *continued*, and in this case, as a result of prayer, they had the potential to be solidly established in the wisdom of the Mystery.

The use of the passive voice indicates that *one other than themselves*, namely, God the Holy Spirit, had enlightened them. There is no way for those who are in the sphere of darkness (σκοτος) to be launched into the sphere of light (φως) apart from God Himself doing the launching. The eyes of the depraved heart are blind, totally incapable of leading the sinner to the Light (1 John 1:5), except God preveniently gives them spiritual vision (Rom. 1:21; Eph. 4:18). In summary, God the Holy Spirit, according to sovereign election, had and continued to enlighten their hearts.

Paul says that the object of this enlightenment is "unto the end that you may know" (εις το ειδεναι υμας) three key things. We need to recognize that God's sovereign enlightening of them, transferring them out of darkness into light, was not an end in itself, but was unto the end that they might be *knowledgeable* regarding their spiritual eyes with which to see. They have the responsibility to use these eyes that they may *know* the great truths of the Mystery. Paul's prayer in the previous verses posits the fact that they have spiritual eyes, and it is his desire, that through the use of these eyes, God will give them via the Spirit *minds of wisdom and insight* into the Truth for the Church.

The first specific aspect of the Mystery which Paul wants them to know is "what is the hope of his calling." The Greek word for "hope" (ελπις) means *expectation, anticipation*, and *that which is looked forward to.* The word translated "calling" (κλησεως), as used here, means *a summons, an irresistible invitation*, and *a non-disobeyable order to come.* Putting this in the form of an amplified translation, God has given to believers spiritual enlightenment to know the hope, expectation, and anticipation that belongs to His sovereign calling, summons, and irresistible invitation.

This calling is a part of God's sovereign purpose of making men alive in Christ and members of His Body, the Church. In chapter four Paul reaffirms the fact that this calling has *one hope* (4:4). The ultimate

end of this calling, its one hope, is that believers will be *glorified* together with Christ (Rom. 8:30). The same calling is referred to as "the high calling" (ανω κλησεως) in Philippians 3:14. In Hebrews 3:1, it is spoken of as a "heavenly calling." Summarizing, we believers have one supreme hope, the fashioning of "our lowly body to conform to the body of His glory" (Phil. 3:21).

The second specific aspect of mystery Truth which Paul desires them to know is "what is the richness of the glory of his inheritance in the saints." Since the word for "richness" (πλουτος) is in the *singular*, speaking of only *one thing* that belongs to the glory of His inheritance, we have refrained using the plural English word *riches*. The thing that Paul wants all believers to know is how *rich*, *opulent*, and *profuse* the glory is which belongs to God's inheritance. This word defines the *quality* of the "glory" (δοξης), which in turn, describes God's inheritance.

Now let us look at the statement, "his inheritance in the saints." The possessive pronoun "his" (αυτου) clearly indicates that this inheritance *belongs to God.* It is an inheritance which God has in the sphere of the saints, locative case, i.e., *the saints themselves are the inheritance.* Rich, opulent, and profuse glory surrounds and circumscribes God's inheritance, the saints. Apart from what God has done for us saints, "having blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenlies in Christ, ... having foreordained us unto a position of sons . . . and having made us heirs" with Christ, we would not be a rich and glorious inheritance (vv. 3, 5, 11). In summary, Paul wants all the saints *to know* that God has sovereignly made them a rich-in-glory "inheritance" (κληρονομιας) or possession for Himself.

19. ***"and what is the exceeding greatness of his power unto us, those believing, according to the working of the strength of his might,"***

The third specific aspect of the Mystery which Paul wants them to know is "what is the exceeding greatness of his power unto us, those believing." The key word in this verse is "power" (δυναμεως), which may also be translated *force, might,* and *ability*. Paul commonly uses this word with reference to the *power of God* (Rom. 1:16; 1 Cor. 2:5;

2 Cor. 4:7) and the *power of Christ* (1 Cor. 5:4; 2 Cor. 12:9). He also uses it to describe God's power in conjunction with believers (2 Cor. 13:4; Eph. 3:7, 20; 2 Tim. 1:7).

In this verse Paul wants believers to know the "exceeding greatness" (υπερβαλλον μεγεθος), *the surpassing vastness* of God's power unto them. It is important to observe that this power is exercised only toward "those believing" (τους πιστευοντας), which may be more literally translated, only to *the believing ones*. The extent to which this power has been used for us is "according to the working of the strength of his might." The word translated "working" (ενεργειαν) basically means *energy*, i.e., this power has been utilized on behalf of believers according to the energy contained in the strength of His might. The meanings of the Greek words translated "strength" (κρατους) and "might" (ισχυος) seem to be almost interchangeable. One thing is certain, however, their combined use emphasizes the great reservoir of strength and might behind God's working and energizing. Summarizing, Paul wants believers to know the surpassing greatness of God's power unto them, which energizes in accordance with his reservoir of strength and might.

20. ***"which he energized in Christ having raised him out from the dead, and having seated him at his right hand in the heavenlies,"***

The antecedent of the pronoun "which" (ην) may, grammatically speaking, be either God's power (δυναμεως) or His *might* (ισχυος). Regardless of our interpretation, the main point is that God's comprehensive power and might "energized" (ενηργησεν), *worked*, and *were effectual* in Christ during and subsequent to His resurrection. Generally speaking, the aorist participle, "εγειρας" having raised in this verse refers to an action prior to that of the leading verb, "ενηργησεν" in this case. Applying this principle to this verse the emphasis is not on God's power energizing in the resurrection and ascension of Christ, but on the working of His power *subsequent* to these two events.

Examining this verse more closely we observe that God energized, effected, and wrought His power "in Christ" (εν τω Χριστω), which is a locative case, and means *in the sphere of Christ*. The statement

"having raised him out from the dead" (εγειρας αυτον εκ νεκρων) conveys the idea of *after* or *subsequent* to His being raised. The implication here is that God the Father was the active agent who effected the resurrection of Jesus Christ (cf. Rom. 10:9; 1 Cor. 6:14; 15:15).

Now observe the category from which Jesus was raised. The Greek phrase translated "out from the dead" (εκ νεκρων) consists of the preposition "εκ" and the word for dead ones (νεκρων) in the *plural*. The word " εκ," always used with the ablative case, has the basic meaning of *separation*, hence, we prefer to render it *out from, out of,* or *from*. The resurrection of Jesus involved His being raised both *out of* and *from* the category of dead persons (Gal. 1:1; Col. 2:12). Even as Jesus Christ's resurrection was *out from among dead men*, likewise, believers will be raised and *separated from dead men* (1 Cor. 15:23).

The last thing God the Father did before setting in motion the effectual working of His power in Christ was to seat Him at His own right hand in the heavenlies. Translating the Greek literally, Paul says, "having seated him at his right hand." As we have already intimated the word translated "having seated" (καθισας) is an aorist participle which portrays Christ as having been seated, sitting, and positioned at God's right hand *before* the energizing of God's power in Him. Certainly God's power was involved in both the resurrection and ascension of Jesus Christ, but the emphasis here is on what God's power wrought in Him *after He returned* to the "heavenlies" (εεπουρανιοις). Since this word is derived from " επι" and "ουρανος" and literally means *upon the heavens*, we would suggest that "upon earth" (επιγειος) existence had as its counterpart "upon heaven" (επουρανιος) existence.

21. ***"far above all rule and authority and power and dominion and even name being named not only in this age but also in that which is to come"***

In this verse we have a fuller explanation of Jesus Christ's status at the right hand of God. Having been seated in the heavenlies He occupied a position *far above* every possible present and future

potentate. The Greek adverb translated "far above" (υπερανω) is derived from "υπερ" and "ανω" and basically means that Christ was put in a peerless category *over the top of, out beyond,* and *far superior* to all authorities.

First, He was placed far above "all rule" (πασης αρχης). This noun translated rule (αρχης) is sometimes used by Paul with the meaning of *beginning* or *first* (Phil. 4:15; 2 Thess. 2:13). It is most frequently used by him to depict *those who are rulers* (3:10; 6:12; Rom. 8:38; Titus 3:1). The Greek word for *all* (πασης), since it is singular, may be well translated every. Summarizing, Paul is affirming that Jesus Christ as *first*, the ruler, was placed far above *every ruler* (Col. 1:10).

Second, He was positioned far above all "authority" (εξουσιας). The word all (πασης), even though not repeated before the words authority, power, and dominion, obviously applies to all of them. Paul uses this word to denote one's *authority* or *right* to do something (Rom. 9:21; 1 Cот. 7:37; 9:6). He commonly uses it to refer to those who are exercising their authority and rights, hence, *authorities* (Rom. 13:1; Eph. 3:10; 6:12; Col. 2:10, 15; Titus 3:1). In conclusion, Jesus Christ was given a position far above *every authority* (cf. Col. 2:10).

Third, He was elevated far above all "power" (δυναμεως). This word is often used by Paul to depict *power, stored energy*, or *its manifestation in miracles* (Rom. 1:16; Col. 1:11; Gal. 3:5). It is used by him with reference to the power of God (1 Cor. 1:18), the power of Christ (2 Cor. 12:9) and of the Holy Spirit (Rom. 15:13). As used in this verse it speaks of those who wield and exercise power, i.e., those who are *powerful ones* or *powers*. Thus we see, having been elevated into the heavenly realm, Christ was far above *every power*.

Fourth, He was exalted far above all "dominion" (κυριοτητος). The ending of this Greek word clearly expresses the idea of *one who lords over, has dominion,* and exercises lordship. In Colossians 1:16, Paul uses it in association with those who are kings (thrones) and rulers. Peter uses it in speaking of those who despise the *one who has dominion* (2 Peter 2:1; cf. Jude 8). The evidence is clear, in His exalted position at the right hand of God, Jesus Christ is far above *every dominion* (cf. 1 Tim. 6:15).

In reinforcing the fact that Jesus Christ is far above every ruler, authority, power, and dominion, Paul adds the statement, "and every name being named not only in this age but in that which is to come." The present passive participle translated "being named" (ονομαζομενου) is *broad enough* to continuously cover any other categories of rulers and potentates who might come on the scene (cf. Phil. 2:9-11). Paul uses language that makes it very clear that there are *no exceptions* to what he has said. Jesus Christ *is now, continues to be,* and *will always be* far above every one exercising power over others. He occupies this prestigious position because of *Who He Is,* God the Son, and not because the Father has specially energized in Him (cf. v. 20).

Having observed the superior position Jesus Christ has in the universe, according to this verse, now let us briefly consider the ramifications of the statement, "not only in this age but also in that which is to come." The Greek word translated "age" (αιωνι) refers to *a period of time, a given duration, an era,* or *an epoch*. The demonstrative pronoun "this" (τουτω) particularizes the age in which Paul was writing as *distinct* from other ages. The phrase, "in that which is to come," clearly implies that a different future age is coming. In this context it is not Paul's purpose to list all the ages in which God has dealt with His people in different manners, but he does call our attention to *this age, now age* (3:5; Col. 1:26), or *Church age*. The burden of Paul's epistle is to make known Truth specifically revealed to him for this Church age (Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9). The coming age Paul refers to is apparently the *Kingdom era* when Christ will reign as King.

22. ***"and he arranged all things under his feet, and gave him to be head over all things to the church,"***

In this verse we see the *reason* the power of God energized in Christ, as stated in verse 20: it involved making Him the Head of the Body, the Church. The Greek verb translated "he arranged" (υπεταξεν) is derived from "υπο" and "τασσω" and basically means *to arrange or place under,* hence*, to subordinate* or *subject under.* The aorist tense

indicates that God the Father did this at a *given point in time*, namely, after He had raised and seated Jesus Christ at His right hand.

The place where God arranged all things was "under his feet" (υπο τους ποδας αυτου). Paul uses like or similar terminology seven times in his epistles with the thought of *placing under the authority of power of a person,* and at times, seemingly, it particularly applies to those who have been defeated and subjugated (Rom. 16:20; 1 Cor. 15:25; Heb. 10:13). This statement probably reverts back to Psalm 8:6; however, Paul only uses the *principle* here, in a limited manner, as he introduces Christ's relation to the Church.

The key truth in this verse is the fact that God the Father gave Christ the Son "to be head over all things to the Church." The verb translated "gave" (εδωκεν) is in the aorist tense; it means that God *bestowed, committed,* and *assigned* the position of Head of the Church to Christ. We see the granting of this great authority to Christ as the ultimate fulfillment of God's power energizing in Christ, according to verse 20. The Triune God sovereignly planned the Church and its membership before the creation of the world (v. 4), but the headship of Christ over it wasn't actualized until after his resurrection and ascension.

Let us examine the meaning of the word translated "head" (κεφαλην) as used in this context. As the Head of the Church, Christ occupies the *top position* over it (cf. 1 Cor. 11:3; Col. 1:18). He administers the Divine principles by which it is governed, He is in charge of all its operations, and He is responsive to the prayers of the saints to the Father (vv. 16-17). He personally nurtures and cherishes it (5:29), and above all, He did love it unto death (5:25), and *continues* to love each member of it (Rom. 8:35-39).

The statement, He gave him to be "head over all things to the church," needs to be interpreted so as to *align* with what Paul says in all his epistles. We must recognize that the phrase "over all things" (υπερ παντα) is *limited* by the phrase "to the church" (τη εκκλησια). This latter phrase may be considered in the locative case, hence, *all things are in the sphere of the Church,* or it may be considered in the dative case, i.e., *all things have reference to the Church.* It is

imperative that we understand that Paul is not saying that God the Father gave Christ headship over all things in general, but that He made Him Head over *all things which pertain* to the Church.

A cursory glance at conditions in the world today readily suggests that αl1 things are not under the headship of Christ. Paul affirms that this is so, for he says in Hebrews 2:8, "But now we do not yet see all things as having been arranged under him." Speaking with reference to the present time, Paul says in Second Corinthians 4:4, that Satan is "the god of this age" (cf. Luke 4:5-7). Also, according to Romans 8:20, "Creation has been subjected to vanity." These passages should make it clear that during this age of Grace *only the Church*, and that which directly pertains to it, is arranged under Christ as Head.

Finally, we need to consider the meaning of the phrase "the church" (τη εκκλησια) and the connotation Paul gives to it. First, the word translated "church" (εκκλησια) is derived from " εκ " and "εκαλεω" and literally means *called out ones* or a group *called out of* and *separated from* the hoi polloi. Those who have been called out constitute, in themselves, an *assembly, a congregation*, and that which is commonly called *a church*. As these designations are commonly used, the emphasis is not on the derivation of the group, that from which it is called out of, but on the mere fact that it is a group which has *come together, assembled,* and *congregated* in a given location.

The Greek word "εκκλησια" in itself, does not infer anything about the nature of an assembly. It is used in the Septuagint regarding the Children of Israel in the wilderness (Deut. 4:10; 23:1-2; cf. Acts 7:38). It is used of the congregation of Israel in the land (1 Kings 8:14, 22). In Matthew 16:18, in the middle of a Kingdom-truth context, Jesus uses the word "εκκλησιαν" in speaking of an assembly which He is going to build (cf. Matt. 18:17). In the Book of Acts, prior to the conversion of the Apostle Paul, it was used to describe assemblies which accepted Jesus as the prophesied Messiah of the Old Testament (Acts 5:11; 8:1, 3). The word "εκκλησια" is used of a confused, riotous, secular assembly in Ephesus (Acts 19:32, 39, 41). It is used the vast majority of the time in the New Testament to refer

to "the church" (η εκκλησια), a particular church, truth of which was revealed to the Apostle Paul. In conclusion, the word "church" (εκλησια), apart from the context in which it is used, may refer to a variety of different kinds of assemblies. The fact that the word church has a given meaning in one passage cannot be used to prove that it means the same in another passage.

23. ***"which is his body, the fulness of the one filling all things in all."***

The relative pronoun "which" (ητις), of course, has as its antecedent the word "church" (εκκλησια). This relative pronoun is derived from "η" and "τις" and implies that the church, in its very nature, is the body of Christ. The reflexive pronoun translated "his" (αυτου), used in the genitive case has a *possessive meaning*, indicating that the church is a body which *belongs to Christ.* In order to understand what Paul is talking about here we need to consider the general meaning of the word "body" (σωμα) and the specific meaning which Paul gives to it.

The Greek word translated "body" (σωμα) is used to depict the *body of a person, animal* or *a corpse.* It is used of the flesh and blood body of Jesus (John 2:21; Heb. 10:10) and of the bread, a token, which typifies it (Luke 22:19; 1 Cor. 11:24). It is used o£ Christ's glorious resurrection body (Phil. 3:21). It is used of both heavenly and spiritual bodies (1 Cor. 15:40, 44). In the previous verse it is used synonymously with the word for "church" (εκκλησια; cf. Col. 1:18, 24).

As we understand Paul's concept of the Body and how it functions we will gain insight into the nature of the Church. First, in this dispensation of Grace God is *calling* believers to have peace in one Body (Col. 3:15). He Himself places each believer in the Body by means of the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 12:13, 18). This means, God both selects and adds individuals to the Body.

Second, Paul emphasizes that believers are members of one Body. He says in Romans 12:5, "we the many are one body in Christ" (cf. 11:17). In First Corinthians 12:12, he declares, "and all the members

of the body being many are one body" (cf. v. 20; Eph. 4:4). Regardless of race and location, all believers constitute *one single Body.*

Third, what is the relation of this Body to Christ? In Romans 12:5, Paul says that we are one body "in Christ" (εν Χριστω). The locative case implies that the one Body is *in the sphere of Christ*, *located in Christ*. On the other hand, in First Corinthians 12:27, the genitive case indicates that the Body *belongs to Christ*, for he says, "And you are the body of Christ and members in part." Generally speaking, Paul refers to the Body as that which *belongs to Christ*, as *His possession* (cf. 4:12; 5:30). We members have been bought with the price of His own Blood (Rom. 5:8; 1 Cor. 6:20; 2 Cor. 5:21).

Paul further defines the Church as "the fulness of the one filling all things in all." The subject of this statement is God the Father, He is in sole charge of continuously filling all things in the sphere of all. This statement is broad enough to include God creating/sustaining and formulating/effecting His plan for the ages.

Against the background of the great things which God has and is doing, Paul says that the Church is "the fulness" (το πλητωμα), *the completeness, the ultimate,* and *the epitome* of God's revealed purpose. Paul desires that all believers may be filled unto all the fulness of God that is embodied in the Church. This can be attained by *knowing* the Truth of the Mystery, conjoined with Christ's love, according to chapter 3:18-19. To be filled with the fulness of God in the Church is to become *lost in the fulness of Christ* its Head (cf. 4:13; Col. 1:19; 2:9).

Chapter 2

1. ***"And you being dead in your trespasses and sins."***

This is a literal translation of this verse. There is no justification for adding anything to it. Paul's purpose in verses 1-3 is to set forth the fact that both Jews and Gentiles were spiritually bankrupt, dominated by Satan, and sinners by nature before God expressed his mercy toward them. These verses give us a brief glimpse into the dilemma of the human race, man's total depravity, and his *inability to be other than what he is* apart from God's grace.

The phrase, "and you being dead," implies three things. First, the pronoun "you" (υμας) indicates that Paul is *writing to believers* who were once dead. Second, the present participle translated "being" (οντας) means that they were previously existing and *continuing* in a state of spiritual death. Third, the Greek noun for "dead" (νεκρους), as used here, refers to those who are *morally and spiritually dead* (Col. 2:13), to those who are alienated from the life of God (4:18).

Now let us consider the reason all men are dead prior to the bestowal of God's mercy upon them. Speaking to them, Paul says, you were "dead in your trespasses and sins." We may interpret this to mean that they were dead *in* their trespasses and sins (locative case), or that they were dead *by means of* their trespasses and sins (instrumental case). The locative case looks at them as being dead *in the sphere of* or *in the midst of* their sins. The instrumental case looks at them as being *put to death by means of their sins*, i.e., *their sins were what killed them* spiritually. Regardless of which interpretation we may prefer, one thing is certain, their trespasses and sins resulted in their spiritual death.

Paul's emphasis here is not that they died as a result of Adam's sin, as it is in Romans 5:12, but that they died *because of their own* trespasses and sins. As descendants of Adam, sin was engrained in their nature, and they volitionally expressed it in their thoughts and deeds, confirming the fact that *they themselves were sinners*. Paul tells them that "your" (υμων) trespasses and sins, the trespasses and

sins which belong to you, have brought death upon you. In other words, God holds them directly *responsible* for their spiritual demise.

The Greek word translated "trespasses" (παραπτωμασιν) is derived from "παρα" and "πιπτω" and basically means to *fall beside*, hence, the noun form means *stumblings* and *fallings*. The word rendered "sins" (αμαρτιαις) basically means *to miss a mark*, hence, *errors* and *mistakes*. Summarizing, the persistent *stumblings* and *errors* of the human race, contrary to the will of God, leave all men in a state of spiritual death.

2. ***"in which you once walked according to the age of this world, according to the ruler of the authority of the air, the spirit now working in the sons of disobedience "***

The phrase "in which" (εν αις) is in the locative case and indicates that "once" (ποτε), at a *time in the past*, and *formerly* they walked *in the sphere of* or *in the midst of* the foregoing trespasses and sins. The verb translated "walked" (περιεπατησατε) comes from "περι" and επατεω" and basically means to *walk around* or *walk about*, hence, it speaks of how they *lived*, *moved*, and *conducted* themselves in the midst of their trespasses and sins. Paul also uses this same word to describe how the Colossians formerly lived in various sins (Col. 3:7; cf. Eph. 4:17).

Paul goes on to say that they lived in their trespasses and sins "according to the age of this word." The Greek preposition translated "according to" (κατα), as used here, means *in keeping with, conforming to,* and *as dictated by* the age of this world. The Greek noun rendered "age" (αιωνα) basically refers to *a period of time* such as *a given age, era,* or *epoch*. With changing times and centuries the outward expressions of sin may vary. For example, the murderous sin of abortion is rampant in the age in which we live, whereas different sins were popular in the first century. Before these people were saved, while they were still dead in their trespasses and sins, they were deeply involved in the heathenish practices of their age or time (4:17-19; Col. 3:5-6). Sin is missing the Divine standard, disobedience to God, but some of the outward forms it takes during different periods which are a part of this evil world system

(τον αιωνα του κοσμου τουτου), may vary greatly (cf. v. 12; Col. 2:8, 20; 1 John 2:16).

Furthermore, Paul says that in their sins they conducted themselves "according to the ruler of the authority of the air." Again we observe that the preposition "κατα" indicates that their thinking and acting was *dictated* by the ruler of the authority of the air. The Greek word translated "ruler" (αρχοντα) conveys the basic idea of the *first* or *beginning one*, hence, one who is *chief*, *ruler*, or *prince*. We feel that the English equivalent "ruler" most accurately designates the intended meaning in this context. Note that this ruler is *of the authority* of the air. The genitive case indicates that he *belongs to* and is *owned by* the authority of the air. He is subject to the authority of the air, an emissary of the same.

To whom does the phrase "the authority of the air" refer? The Greek word translated "authority" (εξουσιας) has the basic meaning of *power, ability, weight*, and *right*, hence, one who has the necessary prerogatives to exercise authority. According to Luke 4:5-6, this word is used to describe the authority which has been given to the devil (cf. Luke 22:53; Acts 26:18; Col. 1:13). The grammatical construction, an article preceding a singular noun, rendered "the authority" (της εξουσιας), plus the manner in which this word is used in the New Testament, clearly identify "the authority" as *Satan*, the devil. The fact that he is the authority "of the air" (του αερος) implies that this sphere also comes under his authority (cf. 3:10; 6:12).

We see an *attributive relation* between the phrase "the ruler of the authority of the air" and "the spirit now working in the sons of disobedience." The Greek grammar appears to favor the thought that "the authority of the air" is "the spirit" (του πνευματος) working in the disobedient, i.e., Satan as a spirit (cf. Matt. 16:23; Luke 22:3: like God is; John 4:24). On the other hand, it may be that "the ruler" (τον αρχοντα), who is an emissary of Satan, is to be identified as "the spirit." Regardless of interpretation, we see *Satan as a spirit working directly or his emissary-ruler as a spirit working indirectly* in the sons of disobedience. The phrase, "the sons of disobedience," as used in this context, refers to the unsaved world.

3. ***"among whom we all also once lived in the lusts of our flesh, doing the will of the flesh and of the thoughts, and we were by nature children of wrath even as also the rest."***

In the two foregoing verses Paul uses the plural pronoun "you" (υμας) in addressing those to whom he is writing. He says that you were "dead in your trespasses and sins, in which *you* once walked." This second person plural pronoun is used with reference to the Gentile believers among those to whom Paul is writing (cf. v. 13). In this verse he uses the first person plural pronoun "we" (ημεις) to include himself and all Jewish believers in the same lustful lifestyle (cf. v. 11; Rom. 3:9).

The phrase "among whom" (εν οις) is a translation of the preposition "εν" with the relative pronoun "οις" in the locative case. It implies that the unsaved Jews were living *among, in the midst of,* and *in the same location* as the unsaved Gentiles - all were dead in trespasses and sins and dominated by Satan.

Now let us examine more fully the statement, "among whom we all also once lived." First, Paul uses the word "all" (παντες) to make it clear that *every* unsaved Jew was living according to the lusts of his flesh. The verb rendered "lived" is derived from the Greek words "ανα" and "στρεφω" and basically means to *turn up*. It is used five times by Paul in his epistles with the meaning of *how one turns up, around,* and *moves,* hence, to describe his *walk, conduct*, and *behavior* (cf. the noun form, 4:22). The temporal particle rendered "once" (ποτε), used with the aorist tense and passive voice, indicates that *at one time* or *formerly* Satan caused them to live in the desires of their flesh.

In speaking of the Gentile believers, before they were saved, Paul says that they walked in their trespasses and sins (vv. 1-2). Referring to Jewish believers, before they were converted, he says that they lived in the lusts of their flesh. The Greek word translated "lusts" (επιθυμιαις) comes from "επι" and "θυμος" and basically means *to set the rush and passion of the mind upon*, hence, it may be rendered *desires, longings,* and *cravings.* The phrase "of our flesh"

(της σαρκος ημωϖ) indicates that their lifestyle was shaped according to what their flesh lusted after and desired.

Paul goes on to explain that prior to being saved all Jews were "doing the will of the flesh and of the thoughts." The use of the present participle implies that they were *continuously* pursuing this course. First, observe as above, they were involved in doing the "will" (διανοιων), *wishes, wants,* and *inclinations* which belong to the flesh. Their lives were being controlled by flesh-wants. Also, Paul says that they were doing the will of "the thoughts" (των διανοιων). This word is derived from "δια" and "νοεω" which speak of the *mind in operation,* hence, they were doing the will of their *thinking, reasoning*, and *cogitations*. Note that the depraved mind, which is estranged from God, is identified with the flesh in the sphere of evil and is incapable of producing moral thinking and living (cf. 4:18; Col. 1:21).

Having said that the Jewish believers, before they came to know Christ, were living in the lusts of their flesh and doing the will of their flesh and minds, Paul now adds, "And we were by nature children of wrath even as also the rest." The Greek word translated "nature" (φυσει) means that *in essence, in basic character*, and *in natural disposition* the Jews were children of wrath. The Greek word for "wrath" (οπγης) may also be translated *anger* or *indignation*. This noun is in the genitive case and may be interpreted as children *who belong to wrath,* i.e., the wrath of God (John 3:36; Rom. 1:18), or children *who are possessed by wrath*, i.e., who have a disposition of wrath (Rom. 9:22; Eph. 4:31; Col. 3:8). We see these two possible interpretations as double aspects of this wrath - their wrathful nature brings upon them the wrath of God.

As Paul indicates that he, together with all unsaved Jews, were formerly children by nature of wrath, he adds, "even as also the rest." The phrase "the rest" (οι λοιποι), as used in this context, refers *to the remaining ones, those left,* namely, *the Gentiles* (Rom. 1:13; Phil. 1:13; 1 Thess. 4:13). There was no question about the Gentiles being utterly depraved and corrupt (Rom. 1:18-32; Gal. 1:15). Everything Paul said about them in verses 1-2, plus what he says about the Jews in this verse, applies to them. The phrase, "even as the rest,"

lumps the Jews together with the Gentiles as *totally depraved sinners in their very nature* (cf. Rom. 3:9-19, 23).

4. ***"But God, being rich in mercy, because of his great love with which he loved us,"***

We have been looking at individuals who were spiritually *dead*, energized by Satan, controlled by the lusts of their flesh, and depraved sinners in their nature. On the other hand, Paul is addressing this epistle to these same people, but something had happened to them, for they are now *alive in Christ*. Now could those who were spiritually dead and depraved in nature initiate and effect such a change? The answer is obvious: they in themselves could do *nothing*, for dead individuals are impotent. Biblical hamartiology leaves *no room* for self-deliverance. If a person is going to be rescued from his dead-sinner-by-nature status, *God has to sovereignly do it.*

Against a background of the sinner's debauched condition, Paul says, "But God . . . " (ο δε θεος). If these sinners had been left to themselves not one of them would have obtained life in Christ, *but* that which was impossible was made possible by God entering the arena. His entry changed a world of hopelessness, under Satan's control, into a world in which there is hope.

God came on the scene with *mercy*. Paul briefly describes this entrance as God "being rich in mercy" (πλουσιος ων εν ελεει). The Greek word for "mercy" (ελεει) speaks of God's *compassion, pity*, and *clemency* toward sinners. The word translated "rich" (πλουσιος) emphasizes the fact that God is *loaded with, wealthy,* and *affluent* in mercy and compassion (cf. Titus 3:5; Heb. 4:16; 1 Peter 1:3). Paul makes it very clear that God's elective purpose is based upon His mercy (Rom. 9:10-18, 23).

The clause, "because of his great love with which he loved us," makes it clear that God's love was what *caused Him to express His mercy* toward sinners. The preposition "δια" used with the accusative case "την πολλην αγαπην" may also be translated *on account of His much, multitudinous,* and *the magnitude* of His love "with which He

loved us" (ην ηλαπησεν ημας). We interpret this phrase as referring to the love which God poured out toward us in Christ on Calvary when He died for our sin (Rom. 5:8; 2 Cor. 5:21).

5. ***"even while we were dead in the trespasses he made us alive together with Christ - by grace you have been saved - "***

The previous verse revealed the magnitude of the love with which God loved "us" (ημας), the elect, which in turn caused Him to be rich in mercy toward us, and to graciously provide a Saviour to deliver us from our sin (cf. 1 John 4:9-10). This verse affirms that God's love was extended toward us "even while we were dead in the trespasses." The present participle translated "while" (οντας) means that *during the time* or *simultaneous with being dead* God loved us (Rom. 5:5-10). The phrase, "dead in the trespasses," reverts back to verse 1, where Paul says, "and you being dead in your trespasses and sins." The thought here is that we were *spiritually dead* in the sphere of "the trespasses" (τοις παραπτωμασιν), i.e., in and by means of the trespasses which we, the elect, previously committed.

As God, prompted by His love, affluent in compassion came on the scene, "he made us alive together with Christ." The Greek verb translated "he made (us) alive with" (συνεζωοποιησεν) is derived from "συν" and "ζωος" and "ποιεω" and in the third person singular basically means *he made alive* or *living with*. In order to more fully bring out the unmistakable thought of the Greek, we prefer to translate it, *He made us alive together with Christ*. The aorist tense makes it clear that in a once-for-all transaction *God joined us to the living Christ for eternity.* This was totally the work of God, a perfect sovereign work, which our immutable God effected. We must keep in mind that Divine life is transmitted from God the Father through Christ the Son to believers (John 6:57).

The statement, "by grace you have been saved," is set off by dashes in the Greek text. It is an abrupt break in thought, a brief description of what being made alive together with Christ is, namely salvation by grace. The Greek word translated "grace" (χαριτι) speaks of a *gift, benefit,* or *favor* bestowed by God. Paul uses this word here to emphasize that deliverance from spiritual death to life in Christ is

exclusively the work of God, it is that which God has wrought Himself, and it is *totally a gift* from Him. God is the sole Actor in this verse, *He alone* made us alive in Christ, and He did it apart from human effort on our behalf. Over and over again Paul makes it clear in his epistles that salvation is a *free gift* from God (vv. 8-9; Rom. 3:24; 11:5-6; 1 Tim. 1:14; 2 Tim. 1:9; Titus 2:11, 14; 3:4-6).

Now let us consider the meaning of the Greek words rendered "you have been saved" (εστε σεσωσμενοι). Instead of labeling this a periphrastic grammatical construction, with little or no significance, I want to examine its possible literal meaning. The verb "εστε" is in the present tense and means *you are*. The participle "σεσωσμενοι" is in the perfect tense and passive voice and means *have been saved ones.* Combining these thoughts in an amplified translation, Paul is affirming, "by grace you are have been-saved ones" or "by grace you are those who have been saved." The perfect tense indicates that they were saved at a given time in the past and that they *continue in this saved state.* The passive voice points to God as the one who had saved them, i.e., He is the one who *produced* their salvation (v. 8; 1 Thess. 2:16).

6. ***"and raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenlies in Christ Jesus,"***

As already observed, the first thing God's mercy did was to make us alive in a together-with-Christ relationship. Second, having made us alive in Christ, He raised us up out from among those who were dead in trespasses and sins. This refers to a spiritual resurrection out from the midst of those who were spiritually dead. The Greek word translated "raised us up with him" (συνηγειρεν) is derived from "συν" and "εγειρω" and the three times it is used in the New Testament (Col. 2:12; 3:1) it refers to the spiritual resurrection of believers with Christ. Even as we were once dead in trespasses and sins, and in the salvation process were identified with the death of Jesus Christ, likewise, we are identified with His resurrection and life (Rom. 6:3-11; Col. 2:12). The premise upon which all true spirituality rests is the fact that we have died to sin with Christ, we have been identified with Him in His death, and we have been raised to live a new spiritual life

together with Him in the power of the Holy Spirit (Rom. 6:10-14; 8:11).

The third thing God did, after He had made us alive and raised us with Christ, was *to seat us with Him in the heavenlies*. The Greek word which we have translated "seated us with him" (εσυνεκαθισεν) comes from "συν" and "καθιζω" and, used in a transitive sense, means that God the Father *seated us with Christ or caused us to sit together with Christ.* It is very important to observe that *God is the subject,* the Actor, the One who personally seats the elect with Christ in the heavenlies. The use of the aorist tense indicates that this seatment took place at a given *point in past time*, it was the work of God, and as such is *unalterable*. Those whom God sovereignly seats in Christ, who is at His right, are seated with Him for eternity.

The place where we have been seated with Christ "in the heavenlies" is derived from "επι" and "ουρανος" and if we grant that the basic meaning of the preposition "επι" is *upon*; then it follows that the basic meaning of "επουρανιοις" is *upon the heavens*. Since this preposition prefixed to the Greek word for earth (γη) means *on* or *upon the earth*, why shouldn't it mean *on* or *upon the heavens* when prefixed to the word for heavens (ουρονος)? It appears to me that Paul's perspective of the heavens was a place *on* or *upon* which believers existed together with Christ. The preposition "in" (εν) is in the locative case and suggests that we believers are spiritually with Christ upon the heavens *in the heavenly sphere* in contrast to the earthly sphere. Even as our present flesh and blood bodies are designed for existence upon the earth, likewise, our future resurrection bodies will be spiritual, designed for our environment upon the heavens (1 Cor. 15:40, 44). These bodies will conform to Christ's glorious body, the one together with whom we now live in an out-of-the-body manner (Phil. 3:21; 2 Cor. 5:4). This change into a body designed for our eternal existence on the heavens will take place the next time Christ returns to earth (1 Cor. 15:52; 1 Thess. 4:15-17).

7. ***"that he might show in the coming ages the exceeding riches of this grace in kindness upon us in Christ Jesus."***

The order of the words in our translation conforms to the order in the Greek text. To get into the flow of the context we need to go back to verse 5, where Paul begins telling us what God did for us while we were still in our trespasses, namely He made us alive together with Christ, raised us up with Him, and seated us with Him upon the heavens in the heavenly sphere. The question is, *why* was God motivated by His love to express His mercy toward us, even while we were yet sinners (cf. Rom. 5:8)? The answer is clearly set forth in this verse, "that he might show in the coming ages the exceeding riches of his grace." The phrase translated "that he might show" consists of the conjunction "ινα" with the verb "ενδειξηται" in the subjunctive mode. This phrase states that God's *purpose* and *reason* for doing what He did was that He might "show" (εϖδειξηται), *point out, manifest,* and *display* the affluence of His Grace toward rebelling sinners even while they were sinning.

The time when God is going to show the exceeding riches of His grace is "in the coming ages" (εν τοις αιωσιν τοις επερχομενοις). The Greek noun for "ages" (αυωσιν) is in the plural and speaks of *periods of time, eons,* and *epochs*. Paul defines these ages as being in the *future*, i.e., they are the "coming" (επερχομεϖοις) time periods. This Greek word is derived from "επι" and "ερχομαι" and basically means *coming upon, overtaking,* and *future eons of time.* We are now living in a given age, which Paul speaks of as "this age" (εαιωνι τουτω; Rom. 12:2), "the present evil age" (του αιωνος του ενεστωτος ; Gal. 1:4), and "the now age" (τω νυν αιωνι; Titus 2:12), and which we commonly refer to as *the Church age*. According to the verse before us, out beyond this present age, *in the future ages,* God is going to display the exceeding riches of His Grace extended upon us in Christ Jesus.

There is room for two interpretations regarding Paul's emphasis in this verse. The question is *to whom* is God going to show the exceeding riches of His grace in the coming ages. Is the emphasis on the fact that in the coming ages God will show *to those living at that time* the riches of His grace given to us in this present age in Christ? Or, is the emphasis on us and the fact that God is going to *continue to display His grace toward us* in the sphere of the coming ages. I prefer to think that what God's grace has already done and will

continue to do in the coming ages will be both objectively applied to us as well as displayed before those present.

The statement, "the exceeding riches of his grace," (το υπερβαλλον πλουτος της χαριτος αυτου) speaks of the *casting-out-beyond, surpassing,* and *extraordinary* riches (πλουτος) or *wealth* of His grace. Paul does not look at God's grace, which has taken sinners out of death, made them alive, and seated them with Christ in the heavenlies, as something which is common and ordinary. In fact, He uses the strongest possible language to emphasize how exceedingly, surpassingly, and extraordinarily rich and affluent this grace really is (cf. 2 Cor. 9:14). The word translated "grace" (χαριτος), as used in this context, refers to God's sovereign purpose and work of rescuing those spiritually dead, making them alive with Christ, and giving them a position with Him in the heavens.

Paul affirms that this rich grace was shown "in kindness upon us in Christ Jesus." The Greek word rendered "kindness" (χρηστοτητι) means that God's grace was extended toward us *in the sphere of kindness, goodness,* and *usefulness* to meet our need, i.e., God's grace embodied these characteristics. Note, this kindness was bestowed "upon us" (εφ ημας), upon us who have been saved, including both Jews and Gentiles in *Christ Jesus*. The center, the heart, and the essence of God's grace is Jesus Christ. In His death upon the Cross and His subsequent resurrection we have the culminating and epitome expression of Divine grace (Rom. 3:24; 5:15; 2 Cor. 8:9; 1 Tim. 1:14-15). Apart from the grace of God, funneled down to us through the Person of Jesus Christ, we would have no substitute to bear the penalty of our sin, hence, we would still be in our sin (2 Cor. 5:21).

8. ***"For by the grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not out of you, it is the gift of God"***

The statement, "For by the grace you have been saved," differs slightly from the earlier like statement in verse 5, "By grace you have been saved," in that it has added the conjunction "for" (γαρ) and the article "the" (τη) before the word "grace" (χαριτι). The conjunction for only aids the flow of thought; however, the article may be interpreted

to emphasize that *the grace of God,* the *particular grace of God*, is that which has saved us. Apart from emphasis, the message of these two statements is identical, God's method of saving sinners is by grace.

The Greek word for "grace" (χαριτι) is in the instrumental case, and the thought is that the *means God used* to save us was His grace, in other words, we have been saved *by means of grace*. The two Greek words "εστε" and "σεσωσμενοι," used in conjunction with each other, may be looked at as constituting a periphrastic phrase, where the meanings of both sort of amalgamate into a common meaning, namely, *you have been saved.* As we already indicated in our comments on verse 5, we believe that we come closer to the intended meaning by translating the Greek verb "εστε" and the participle "σεσωσμενοι" in keeping with their individual meanings. According to this literal approach, we translate the forepart of this verse, "For by the grace *you are have been saved ones*" or "*you are those who have been saved.*" The present tense verb "εστε" states the fact that they are *currently* saved, and the perfect participle implies that the salvation God gave to them is their *continuous possession* (cf. v. 5).

The perfect passive participle "εσεσωσμενοι" translated *have been saved* or *have been saved ones*, gives the outside agent, God, the total credit for doing their saving. The question is, *what* is it that caused God to save us? Paul's answer is that we have been saved "through faith" (δια πιστεως). The Greek preposition "δια," as used with the genitive case here, means that faith is the *agent, medium*, or *catalyst* through which God saves. Faith may be likened to a crane, the *Divine agent*, which lifted us out of the realm of sin and seated us with Christ in the heavens.

It is imperative that we accurately understand the meaning of the Greek word for "faith" (πιστεως) as it is used in this context. Other possible English translations are *trust, belief,* and *confident reliance.* In this verse Paul says nothing about the one in whom the faith is placed, for his emphasis is on the principle of faith rather than its object. He wants to make it crystal clear that God gives salvation to sinners *totally through the agency of faith* and not through human

effort, such as, the will and the works of those spiritually dead in trespasses and sins (cf. Rom. 9:11-16).

With reference to the statement, "For by grace you have been saved through faith," Paul says, "And this is not out of you." Both of the Greek words rendered "grace" (δχαριτι) and "faith" (πιστεως) are in the feminine gender, but the Greek pronoun translated "this" (τουτο) is in the neuter gender. If this pronoun refers back to the words "grace" and "faith," as we have suggested, why isn't it in the feminine gender? The answer is in the latter part of this verse, where Paul considers both the grace and faith as a "gift" (δωρον), a Greek noun which is in the neuter gender, and as such, is the antecedent of the pronoun "this" (τουτο). In other words, looking at the two essential ingredients involved in God's saving of sinners, Paul refers to the same as a gift which is "not out of you" (ουκ εξ υμων). This verse clearly teaches that neither the grace nor the faith are of human origin, they are *not out of nor from* those being saved (cf. v. 5; 2 Tim. 1:9; Titus 3:5), but are from an outside Divine source.

Having denied that the gift (grace and faith) is out of those who had believed, those to whom he is writing, Paul affirms that it is "the gift of God" (θεου το δωρον). The Greek word rendered "gift" (δωρον) means that which is *freely given, granted,* or *donated*, hence, *a gift* or *present*. The Greek article would tend to emphasize the fact that it is *the gift*, not just another gift, but a very *special gift* of God. The use of the genitive case indicates that this gift is *owned* and *possessed* by God, i.e., it is that which exclusively belongs to God, which He sovereignly presents to whom He wills (Rom. 3:24; 5:17; Eph. 1:5, 11). No other person in the universe is able to give this gift, the essence of which is Jesus Christ (Acts 4:11-12; Rom. 5:15; 2 Cor. 9:15).

9. ***"not out of works, that no one might boast."***

In this verse Paul makes it very clear *why* God has totally eliminated man from the salvation transaction. In the preceding verse he said that it is "not out of you," and in this verse he says that it is "not out of works" (ουκ εξ εργων). The Greek adverb translated "not" (ουκ) is a definite negative that leaves no room for works in God's enacting of

salvation. The preposition "εξ," used with the ablative case, affirms that the essentials for salvation (grace and faith) are *not to be found, derived, nor acquired* from works. The Greek noun rendered "works" (εργων), as used in this context, refers to any *mental or physical exertion or action,* hence, *deeds, laboring* or *toiling*. The inception of all work is in the mind, and whether or not mental exertion manifests itself in overt physical action is insignificant in defining works. The person who professes to have the ability in his own human mind, which is dead and depraved in its perception of spiritual things, to conjure up saving faith needs to carefully consider what Paul is saying here. Faith which has its origin and source in the dead sinners mind, apart from being a gift of God, is designated as "works" (εργων) by the Apostle Paul (Gal. 2:16; Col. 1:21-22; Titus 3:5).

Recognizing the literal truth of what Paul is saying about God's redemptive purpose in this chapter (vv. 4-9), and from this vantage point considering what is going on in so-called Christendom, one cannot help but feel that it is primarily a scene of *professed humanly generated faith.* Instead of being struck with a sense of *unworthiness* (John 1:27), an attitude which should characterize every person who has been made a recipient of the gift of salvation (1 Tim. 1:12-16), sectarianism, confusion, and pride ride high in the saddle. In fact, the attitudes in so-called Christendom are often boastful and egotistic, parallel to those in this Satan-dominated world (age, 2 Cor. 4:4). On the other hand, in the midst of all this confusion *God has His elect* (Col. 2:12), those chosen in Christ before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4), and those truly saved through exercising the faith He gave to them (Acts 13:48). These genuine believers are concerned about manifesting the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22-23), and they "continue in the faith as *having been foundationed* and *firm* and *not being moved* from the hope of the gospel" (Col. 1:23).

Now let us consider why God excluded works from the act of salvation. Paul says that the reason is, "that none might boast" (ινα μη τος καυχησηται). The Greek conjunction "ινα" which may well be translated "in order that," when used with the subjunctive mode, expresses *purpose*. The reason, God's purpose for excluding works, according to a literal rendering of the original, is "in order that not anyone might boast." The Greek word for "boasting" implies that

there is no room for even a word of boasting, *bragging, glorying*, and *lauding of self.* Salvation is totally and exclusively the work of God!

10. ***"For we are his doing, having been created in Christ Jesus on the basis of good works, which God previously prepared, that we should walk in them."***

Following exactly the same train of thought as in the preceding verses, Paul says, "For we are his doing." The Greek word translated "doing" (ποιημα) is a substantive form of the verb "ποιεω," commonly translated I *do* or *make*. This same form is used in Romans 1:20, with reference to what God has *made*. It is frequently used in the Septuagint with the meaning of *doings* or *things done* (1 Sam. 8:8; 19:4; Neh. 6:14; Ps. 64:9). This same use is corroborated by its use in the Greek papyri. The possessive pronoun "His" (αυτου), in the genitive case, indicates that we who have believed are the *doing*, *making*, and *product* of God. When we were *dead* in our trespasses and sins (vv. 1, 5), incapable of even the slightest movement toward God, He sovereignly energized and worked in us to make us *His own doing, work,* or *creation* (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15).

As believers who are exclusively the product of God's doing, Paul says they are "having been created in Christ Jesus on the basis of good works." The Greek word translated "having been created" (κτιοθεντες), as used in the New Testament, *always refers to that which God created* (for example, Matt. 19:4; Col. 1:16; 1 Tim. 4:3). The internal meaning of this verb excludes the thought that believers may have had something to do with effecting their own salvation. Furthermore, since this verb is in the aorist tense and passive voice, and since the subject is God, it is obvious that *God is the one who acted upon us at a given point in time* to make us creatures who belong to Him. Paul affirms this same truth in First Corinthians 1:30 where he says, "And out of him [as the source] you are in Christ Jesus."

Now note that this Divine creative act took place "in Christ Jesus" (εν Χριστω Ιησου). This phrase is preferably interpreted as in the locative case, which means that God the Father created us *in the sphere of* Jesus Christ the Son, which involves the fact that we were

sovereignly identified with His substitutionary death and subsequent resurrection (Rom. 4:25; 6:4-8). Furthermore, in the preceding context, it entails our being made spiritually alive, resurrected, and seated with Christ "in the heavens in Christ Jesus" (vv. 5-6). We need to acknowledge that God's sovereign soteriological purpose, from beginning to end, is effected in Jesus Christ (vv. 4, 6-7, 9-11). Second Corinthians 5:17, affirms the same truth as this verse, namely that God's creative act is wrought in Christ, for it reads, "If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation."

As those who are God's doing, we were created in Christ Jesus "on the basis of good works." Since we emphasize the need to stay as close as possible to the basic meaning of prepositions, the context permitting, we have translated the preposition "επι" with the idea of *upon*, i.e., *on the basis of.* The reason God created us in Christ was not an end in itself, but this is to serve as the *basis, foundation*, and *support* for good works. There was no way for those dead in trespasses and sins to have a base from which to produce good works. In view of this, God sovereignly made them new creations in Christ, providing them with a base of righteousness from which to bring forth good works (2 Cor. 5:21; Phil. 3:9).

Now let us consider a qualifying statement regarding these good works, that they are those "which God previously prepared." The Greek word translated "previously prepared" (προητοιμασεν) is derived from "προ" and "ετιυμαξω" and literally means that which God *in prior time* or *beforehand made ready*, *made provision for,* hence, *prepared*. God has predetermined and provided the good works which He wills to accomplish in and through the members of the Body of Christ. These are most clearly listed in the Pauline Epistles. In order to avoid fruitlessly beating the air, we need to know the specific Truth which Jesus Christ has revealed for us through His key Church apostle (Gal. 1:12; 2 Cor. 2:6-10).

The reason for God making us new creatures in Christ is good works, which He himself previously prepared, "that we should walk in them." The conjunction "ινα" used with the subjunctive mode clearly indicates that the ultimate end of God's sovereign purpose, as expressed in the preceding context, is *in order that we might walk in*

conformity to the good works set forth by God. The Greek word for "walk" (περιπατησωμεν) comes from "περι" and "πατεω" and literally means to *walk around*, hence, the way one *lives, conducts himself*, or his *lifestyle*. The locative case phrase "in them" (εν αυτοις) suggests that we are to live in the sphere of these God-ordained works, they are to encompass our lives, and constitute our lifestyle.

Finally, as we conclude this section, and deal with the capstone of it, good works, let us take a brief glimpse at what Paul says about them in his other epistles. In Philippians 1:5-6, Paul refers to *furthering the Gospel* as a good work. Believers are to be *bearing fruit* in every good work (Col. 1:10), *established* in good works (2 Thess. 2:17), *rich* in good works (1 Tim. 6:18), *prepared and equipped* unto every good work (2 Tim. 2:21; Titus 3:1; 2 Tim. 3:17), and are to *maintain* good works (Titus 3:8, 14). Paul makes it very clear, we who have been created in Christ for good works, have the *responsibility* of allowing God the Holy Spirit to produce these works through us (Gal. 5:22-23; Phil. 2:13).

11. ***"Wherefore remember that once you Gentiles in the flesh, those called Uncircumcision by the-called-Circumcision, handmade in the flesh,"***

There is a similarity between the contents of verses 1-2 and the contents of the following verse. Both are addressed to converted Gentiles, and refer back to their past bankrupt spiritual condition. In the earliest verses Paul *states the fact* that they were dead in trespasses and sins, while in verses 11-12, he *tells them to remember* their hopeless plight. The Greek verb translated "remember" (μνημονευετε) is a present imperative, which means that they are *commanded* to *continuously call to mind, recollect*, and *reflect back upon* what they were prior to knowing Christ. It is essential that we maintain the proper balance between the backward and forward look (Phil. 3:13-14).

The statement, "once you Gentiles in the flesh," reverts back to a *former* and *past time* when they were in an unsaved condition. Prior to being saved all those who were not Jews were categorized as *Gentiles*. (Sometimes the word Greeks was used interchangeably.) This is brought out clearly in First Corinthians 10:32, where Paul

says, "Do not be offensive to Jews and Greeks and the Church of God." Before being saved they were Gentiles in the sphere of the flesh, but after being saved they were amalgamated with the saved Jews in one Body, designated *The Church*, a spiritual organism (vv. 15-16).

Having observed that those to whom Paul is writing were called "Gentiles in the flesh," he adds, "those called Uncircumcision by the the-called-Circumcision." The thought here is that they were not only specified as Gentiles (εθνη), *nations*, but also as the "uncircumcised" (ακροβυστια), those who still had their *prepuce* or *foreskin*. This name was given to them by the Jews, who were called the "Circumcision" (περιτομης), because they had their prepuce or foreskin cut off. Paul is speaking here of a "handmade" (χειροποιητου), *hand-produced* cutting off of the flesh foreskin in contrast to spiritual circumcision (Rom. 2:29; Phil. 3:3; Col. 2:11).

12. ***"that you were at that time without Christ, having been alienated from the commonwealth of Israel, and strangers from the covenants of the promise, having no hope and without God in the world."***

Referring back to the time when they were uncircumcised Gentiles in the flesh, Paul says, "You were at that time without Christ." First, the Greek adverb translated "without" (χωρις) means *apart from* and *separated from* Christ. The name "Christ" (Χριστου) is used in this context with a twofold significance: (1) these Gentiles were without the benefit of Christ's redeeming Blood, and (2) they were without the privilege of being members of His Body. The terrible plight of the Christless Gentiles is lucidly described in Romans 1:18-31.

Second, prior to being saved these Gentiles had been "alienated from the commonwealth of Israel." The Greek participle translated "having been alienated" (απηλλοτριωμενοι) is in the perfect tense and passive voice. This means that from a given point of time on God had *alienated, estranged,* and *shut them out* of the commonwealth of Israel. The Greek noun rendered "commonwealth" (πολιτειας) means that they were alienated *from being a citizen, the right to be a citizen,* or *from citizenship* in Israel. God sovereignly chose Abraham as the

progenitor of Israel, His special people, and in so doing left the Gentiles outside as aliens (Gen. 12:1-3).

Third, before these Gentiles came to know Christ they were "strangers from the covenants of the promise." The Greek noun for "strangers" speaks of *those who are not acquainted with* the covenants. The Greek word for "covenants" (διαθηκων) is in the plural, which implies that God made *several* covenants, *arrangements, dispositions,* and *wills* with Israel (Gen. 15:18; Ex. 19:5; Num. 25:13). Paul says that they were strangers of the covenants "of the promise." As already noted, the noun translated "covenants" is in the plural, but the word rendered "promise" (επαγγελιας) is in the *singular*, the genitive case, and has the article preceding it, and refers to a *specific single promise* which God made to Israel. This promise probably refers to the fact that God was going to *send a Saviour* to redeem the fallen Adamic race (Gen. 3:15; Isa. 53:2-6). The covenants made with Israel were sub-parts involved in the fulfillment of this promise. Since God sovereignly chose Israel as the people to whom He gave covenants in conjunction with the fulfillment of His redemptive promise, the Gentiles were strangers and unfamiliar with the covenants related to the promise (Rom. 9:4; 11:26-27; Heb. 9:15-16).

Fourth, we note that before these Gentiles became believers their condition was that of "having no hope." The Greek word for "hope" (ελπιδα) means that they had *nothing to look forward to, nothing to anticipate and expect in the future* but death and subsequent judgment (Heb. 9:27; 10:26-27). The Greek participle rendered "having" is in the present tense and active voice which means that they were a people *continuously void of hope*. In First Thessalonians 4:13, Paul speaks of those who have died in the Lord, who await resurrection, in contrast to the grief suffered by "the rest who have no hope."

Fifth, Paul affirms that in past time these Gentiles were "without God in the world." The Greek word translated "without God" (αθεοι) is derived from "α" and "θεος" and literally means that they were a *no-God, void-of-God people*. This word, transliterated into English, depicts them as *atheists*. Observe, the sphere in which they are a no-

God people is "in the world" (εν τω κοσμω). This is the sphere in which Adam and Eve rebelled against God, this is the sphere in which Satan has been given considerable authority (Luke 4:5-6; 2 Cor. 4:4; 1 John 5:19), and this is the sphere *out of which* God has chosen His elect (Acts 15:14; John 15:19; I Cor. 1:27-28). Other spheres which all atheists will occupy are a *place of wrath* (Rom. 2:5; Eph. 5:16) and the lake of fire (Rev. 20:10, 14).

13. ***"but now in Christ Jesus you, those once being far off, have been made near by the blood of Christ."***

Paul frequently uses the adverb "now" (νυνι) to express contrast between the way it was and *the way it now is*. Formerly, the Gentiles were far off from the blessings God had extended to His covenant people Israel, but now that they are believers they occupy a *near position.* The big thing that altered their position was their *relation to Christ.* Previously they were "without Christ" (χωρις Χριστου), but now they are "in Christ Jesus" (εν Χριστω Ιησου). The phrase "in Christ Jesus" is in the locative case in the Greek, which means that their spiritual position was now in the *sphere, location,* and *centered in* Christ. Paul uses this phrase to express an indissoluble identity with Christ and His blessings (1 Cor. 1:2; 2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 3:28; Col. 1:4).

In the previous verse Paul used five different phrases to describe how the Gentiles were deprived of the blessings which had been given to Israel. In this verse he adds a sixth description, a summary of the above, namely, that their condition was "once being far off." The present participle translated "being" (οντες) means that at one time their *state of existence* was "far off" (μακραν), far *away, distant,* and *remote* from both God and His covenant people Israel. In verse 17, Paul also uses this same word, as he refers to the gap between the Gentiles and God (cf. Acts 17:27).

Reminding them of their past estranged and far off position, Paul says, "You . . . have been made near by the blood of Christ." The Greek verb rendered "have been made" (εγενηθητε) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, and means that at a *given point in past time* they had been wrought upon by a person outside of themselves,

namely, God the Holy Spirit, to *make, place,* and *put* them in a near position. The word translated "near" (εγγυς) means a *close* and *adjacent* relation to God. This verse certainly emphasizes the fact that God the Holy Spirit was the *Prime Mover* in closing the gap between the Gentiles and God.

That which had separated the Gentiles from God was their sin (vv. 1-3). God being just and righteous could not maintain His justice and simultaneously justify sinners apart from the sin being paid for (Rom. 3:23-26). This is the consistent message of the sacrificial system of the Old Testament - without the shedding of blood there is no remission of sin (Heb. 9:22). As a result of the substitutionary death of Christ, God was able to bring the Gentiles near.

14. ***"For he himself is our peace, who has made both one, having also destroyed the middle wall of the partition,"***

As we approach this verse we must keep clearly in mind that what Paul is saying is based upon the *Blood of Christ* (v. 13). The emphasis here is on the fact that Jesus Christ "Himself" (αυτος) is our peace. As one who died as our sin-substitute, as one who was made sin for us, He is in the *essence of His Person* the Lamb of God (Matt. 26:28; John 1:29; 2 Cor. 5:21). The emphasis in this verse is on WHO HE IS, which determines the *value* of His Blood to effect peace.

In the three previous verses Paul was speaking about the Gentiles, however, what he says in this verse applies to both Jews and Gentiles. He says that Jesus Christ is "our" (ημων) peace. This plural possessive pronoun, as used in this context, clearly indicates that both believing Jews and Gentiles own and possess Christ as their peace. The Greek word for "peace" (ειρηνη) means that in Christ we have *concord, harmony,* and *serenity*. In Colossians 3:15, Paul instructs believers "to let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts."

Speaking of Christ who is our peace, Paul says, "Who has made both one." The Greek phrase translated "who has made" (ο ποιησας) consists of an article and aorist participle in the nominative case, and may also be rendered, *the one who has made.* The aorist participle denotes action prior to that of the leading verb, which means that

Christ *having made* the Jews and Gentiles one, i.e., *after He had made them one*, He Himself is designated as their peace. Furthermore, this aorist participle indicates that at a given point in past time *Christ was the one* who "made" (ποιησας), *produced, constituted,* and *created* "both" (τα αμφοτερα) unto the end that they might be "one" (εν). It is important to observe that this Jew-Gentile oneness is totally *the work of Christ* based upon His substitutionary death. According to Colossians 3:11, where the new man has been put on, "one is not a Greek and a Jew, circumcision and uncircumcision," but Christ is everything.

Before both Jews and Gentiles could be made one "the middle wall of the partition" had to be destroyed. The aorist participle translated "having destroyed" (λυσας) refers back to a time *prior* to when Christ became their peace and also prior to their being made one. There was no possibility of oneness, which is the basis for peace, until something had been done about "the middle wall" (το μεσοτοιχον), *the wall which stood in the midst, the midwall,* or *the center wall*. The article "το" used before the Greek noun for "middle wall" suggests that Paul had a *definite* and *specific* metaphorical wall in mind.

Paul describes this middle wall as "of the partition" (του φραγμου). This Greek word speaks of *that which obstructs, serves as a barrier,* hence, a fence or hedge. Again, we observe that the use of the article before the word for partition, together with the fact that both are in the genitive case, gives us a picture of a specific wall *which belonged to* a specific metaphorical partition, i.e., the wall was *a part* of the larger partition. Since this is the only time the Greek word translated "middle wall" (μεσοτοιχομ) is used in the New Testament or the Septuagint, we have to depend on the two words from which it is derived for its meaning, which clearly point to a center wall that divided the Jews and Gentiles. The Greek word for "partition" (φραγμου) is used three times in the Synoptic Gospels (Matt. 21:33; Mark 12:1; Luke 14:23), twice with the meaning of a wall around a vineyard and once pertaining to hedges or barriers along public paths.

15. ***"the enmity, in his flesh, having abolished the Law of commandments in decrees, that he might create in himself the two info one new man, making peace,"***

In the United Bible Societies Greek text the words "the enmity, in his flesh" are a part of verse 14. We have divided these verses according to the Majority Text since it is the generally accepted line demarcation. The phrase, "the enmity" (ετην εχθραν), is in apposition with the preceding phrase, "the middle wall of the partition." The Greek word rendered "enmity" (εχθραν) conveys the idea of *hatred, hostility,* or *that which is odious.* The "middle wall of the partition" metaphorically refers to "the enmity," or, to reverse it, "the enmity" is the "middle wall of the partition" (Rom. 8:7).

We saw in verse 14 that Jesus Christ had *destroyed* the wall and the partition, which included the enmity. It is important to note that the sphere in which this destruction took place was "in his flesh" (εν τη σαρκι αυτου). We have translated this phrase as in the locative case, which we prefer, but it could also be looked at as in the instrumental case, and translated *by means of his flesh*. Regardless of which case we may prefer, the enmity and hatred between the Jews and Gentiles was destroyed *in the sphere of* the sacrifice of Jesus Christ's flesh-body or *by means of* His sacrificial death on Calvary. Paul reinforces this same thought in Colossians 1:22, where he says, "But now you have been reconciled in the body of his flesh through death." (cf. Heb. 10:19-20)

Having declared that Christ destroyed the wall and partition, even the enmity that separated the Jews and Gentiles, Paul now adds that He also "abolished the law of commandments in decrees." The phrase, "the law of commandments" (ετον νοηον των εντολων), refers to the Mosaic Law and the commandments which belonged to it. The Greek noun for law is in the *singular* and the noun for commandments is in the *plural*. There was one law given to Moses which consisted of many commandments, for example the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:1-17). Paul says that this Law of commandments was "in decrees" (εν δογμασιν). The Greek word translated *decrees* is most commonly used with this meaning in the New Testament (Luke 2:1; Acts 17:7). Other possible renderings are *statutes or ordinances*.

Paul is affirming here that Jesus Christ "abolished" (κατατγηδσς), *annulled, nullified,* and *abrogated* the Law consisting of

commandments which were fulfilled through various ordinances or decrees. The main point here is that the *total Law of Moses*, with all its commandments and ordinances, *has been abolished*. The aorist participle makes it clear that the Law *had to be annulled before* the Jews and Gentiles could be united in a peaceful relation of oneness.

The reason the Law of Moses, with its commandments and ordinances was abolished, was in order "that he [Jesus Christ] might create in himself the two into one new man." As we have already affirmed, the middle wall of the partition had to be destroyed, and the Law had to be abolished, that *something new* might be brought into existence. The *subject*, the actor, of this clause is Jesus Christ. He is the one who takes the Jews, for whom the Law is now irrelevant, together with the Gentiles, and creates both in the sphere of Himself into a single new man.

The Greek verb translated "create" (κειση), as used in the New Testament, always refers to the *work of God* (Matt. 19:4; Eph. 3:9; 1 Tim. 4:3); therefore, since it is used with reference to Jesus Christ here, the implication is that *He is God* (cf. Col. 1:16). Note, this creative act by God the Son takes place "in himself" (εν αυτω). This phrase, in the locative case, indicates that Jesus did this creating *in the sphere, location,* and *area of His own Person*. The emphasis in this verse is that two groups of people, Jews and Gentiles, are spiritually created *by Christ* as well as *in Christ* unto the end that they might be a *single unit*. The concept of creation taking place *in Christ* is expressed in verse 10, where Paul says that we were created "in Christ Jesus on the basis of good works." Also, in Second Corinthians 5:17, the *place* a person is a new creation *is in Christ.* Thus we observe, Christ is the One who *effects* this creation of Jews and Gentiles into one, and this is accomplished *within the sphere of Himself.*

Now let us take a careful look at the purpose of Christ's amalgamating Jews and Gentiles together, namely, "into one new man." The "ινα" clause in the Greek, which is most fully translated *in order that,* together with the aorist participle translated "having abolished" (καταργησας), make it obvious that the abolishment of the

Law was a prerequisite to the fulfillment of His purpose relating to the Jews and Gentiles. Paul is talking about the fact that God's dealing with the Jews, as a group, through the Law, had to be annulled before Christ could make them one with another group, the Gentiles. When these two groups were separate, prior to Christ's creative work on them, Paul speaks of them in *plural terminology* (vv. 13-19). After they had been created by and in Christ the resultant is *singular*, "one new man." The thought here is *not* that it was Christ's purpose to make those in these groups into new creations (plural; cf. 2 Cor. 5:17), but to join them together in a *single new creation*.

We have translated Christ's creative purpose as being "into one new man." An even more literal translation would be "unto the end of one new man." The preposition "εις," used with the accusative case, focuses attention on the *end* or *object* of this creative act. The Greek adjective translated "new" (καινον) means that which was *previously unheard of* that *exists for the first time*, or that was *recently made*. We interpret the Greek word for "man" (ανθρωπον), as used in this context with the word new preceding it, as having a metaphorical meaning, namely, THE BODY OF CHRIST, THE CHURCH. This is in keeping with the fact that the Church was something new, *never heard of before,* that which *cannot be searched out* in the Old Testament, and that had been hidden (Eph. 3:8-9). Also, associated with this "new man" is the phrase, "making peace," that which takes place in the Body of Christ according to Colossians 3:15, hence, identifying the "new man" with the "Body of Christ."

The Greek phrase rendered "making peace" consists of the present participle "ποιων," which may also be translated *producing, establishing,* and *executing* peace, and the noun "ειρηνην" which depicts a state of *tranquillity, harmony,* and *peace*. This phrase clearly indicates that *Christ is the one* who produces and establishes Jews, Gentiles, and all men in a peaceful and harmonious relationship with one another *in His Body*, the Church. We reaffirm, the Law had to be abolished before Jesus Christ could establish this peace within Himself, His Body, the Church. This peace is limited to those who are in the sphere of the Body of Christ, to those who exercise their God-given faith, to those who are the elect and who

were chosen before the creation of the world (Acts 13:48; Eph. 1:4; Col. 3:12).

16. ***"and that he might reconcile both in one body to God through the cross, having slain the enmity by it."***

The key verb in the previous verse was that "he might create," whereas the key verb in this verse is that "he might reconcile." The Greek verb translated "reconcile" is derived from the words "απο" and "κατα" and "αλλασσω" and basically means to *change-down-from, to change or transfer from one state to another or to alter one from a status of enmity to harmony.* The context makes it clear that Jesus Christ is the subject of this verb, i.e., He is the one doing the reconciling. This same word is used in Colossians 1:20, where we see God the Father reconciling all things unto Himself through Jesus Christ. The only other time it is used is in Colossians 1:22, where Paul says, "But now you have been reconciled by the body of his flesh through death." These passages all affirm that God the Father and Son are the *Effecters* of our reconciliation.

Now let us look at the Greek word translated "both" (αμφοτερους) in this verse. It is always used in the *plural* in the New Testament. The three times Paul uses it are in this paragraph. It means the *both of two* or *both one and another*. In verse 14, Paul says that Christ "has made the both one," i.e., Jews and Gentiles. In this verse, as a part of Christ's purpose, Paul says, "that he might reconcile both." In verse 18, Paul affirms, that "we both have access . . . to the Father." In every instance it is used with the article preceding, pointing to a *specific both*, namely the Jews and Gentiles.

Having stated that it is Christ's purpose to reconcile both Jews and Gentiles, Paul explains *how*, i.e., "in one body" (εν ενι σωματι). We interpret this phrase as being in the *locative case*, and as such, properly rendered *in the sphere, location,* and *confine of one body.* If the article, instead of the Greek word for "one" (ενι), preceded the word "body" (σωματι), we would interpret this as referring to the physical body of Jesus Christ in accordance with Colossians 1:22. However, since we have already observed that the phrase "one new man" is to be identified with the *one body of Christ*, and the emphasis

is on oneness in this body, we positively affirm that the reconciliation of Jews and Gentiles takes place *in the Body of Christ*, the Church.

Having observed that the reconciliation of both the Jews and the Gentiles to God is *in the location of the Body of Christ,* let us consider Paul's statement, that this was accomplished "through the cross" (δια του σταυρου). The Greek preposition " δια," used with the genitive case, clearly affirms that *the Cross is the agent through* which reconciliation is effected. The Greek word for "cross" (σταυρου) speaks of a physical instrument on which the Roman government put criminals to death (Luke 23:26). Paul consistently uses this word with *a metaphorical meaning*: it depicts the death of Jesus Christ on the cross (Phil. 2:8) and the *Blood* which He shed there (Col. 1:20). The substitutionary death and shed Blood of Jesus Christ is the agent through which both Jews and Gentiles are reconciled to God (cf. 1 Cor. 1:18; Col. 2:14). If one was to interpret the reconciliation as "by one body" and "through the cross" there would be *redundance*; however, when one recognizes that the reconciliation takes place *in the sphere of the Body of Christ through the agency of the Cross* there is a logical flow of thought.

Speaking of the enmity which existed between the Jews and the Gentiles and Christ's redemptive work on the Cross, Paul says, "having slain the enmity by it." The word translated "enmity" (εχθραν) refers to the *hatred, animosity*, and *hostility* that existed between these two groups. The Greek word which describes what Christ did to this enmity, namely, "slain" (αποκτεινας), means that He *put it to death, killed,* and *destroyed* it. The phrase "by it" (εν αυτω) points to the Cross as *the means* by which Christ slayed the enmity between the Jews and the Gentiles. The fact that Jews and Gentiles are created into one new man, the Body of Christ where there is perfect oneness, is inseparable from the fact that they are individually made new creations in Christ on the basis of His substitutionary death (2 Cor. 5:14-17). Apart from the obliterating of sin there can be no reconciliation to God nor killing of the enmity between Jews and Gentiles, for *sin is a barrier which separates*. The only way a Just God can remove this sin and still be Just is through the agency of a sin-substitute (Rom. 3:24-26). Jesus Christ, The Lamb of God, was made our substitute on the Cross (2 Cor. 5:21).

17. ***"And having come he preached peace to you, those far off, and peace to those near"***

In this verse Paul continues to describe what Jesus Christ did on behalf of both the Jews and the Gentiles. He uses the aorist participle, which we translated "having come" (ελθων), to point out that *after He had come* "he preached peace" (ευηγγελισατο ειρηνην). The verb *preached* literally means that He *spoke* or *announced a good message or tidings.* The central theme of this message was "peace" (ειρηνην), *tranquillity, calm*, and *harmony*. This refers to Christ's message to and through the Apostle Paul (Gal. 1:12), and not to what He preached while here on earth, for that message was not spoken to the far-off Gentiles but to the near Jews (Matt. 10:5-6; Rom. 15:8). Furthermore, what Paul is saying here *posits the historical fact of the Cross,* which during His Synoptic Gospel ministry was still in the future.

In this epistle Paul is writing Truth given for this church age to individual churches. The fact that Jesus Christ, from His heavenly vantage point, was preaching a message of peace to those far off, the Gentiles, identifies what is being said here as a part of the Mystery (Eph. 3:2-7) revealed to and through Paul (1 Cor. 2:7-10). Prior to the revelation of the Truth for the Church, which Paul commonly calls the Mystery, the Gentiles had *very limited privileges as proselytes,* but here they have *unlimited and equal privileges* with the Jews, God's Covenant People. In fact, in this verse, Paul mentions *first the Gentiles* had peace preached to them and then the Jews - a word order that gives no priority to the Jews. Historically speaking, the Gospel of God's Grace did go to the Jews first, but in a very practical sense, their rejecting of it worked hand-in-glove to fulfill God's sovereign purpose for the Gentiles (Rom. 11:25-32).

18. ***"because through him we both have the access in one Spirit to the Father."***

Paul opens this verse with the conjunction "οτι," which we commonly translate "because of" or "on account of." The thought is that *because of* or *on account of* the fact that both Jews and Gentiles have access

to the Father through Christ, therefore Jesus Christ through Paul preached peace to both those far off and near. The phrase, "through him we both have the access," deals with the issue of *how* Jews and Gentiles can come into the presence of God. The Greek preposition "δια," used with the genitive case, makes it clear that this *access is through the agency of Jesus Christ* (cf. John 14:6). The use of the plural verb "we have" (εχομεν), together with the plural phrase "the both" (οι αμφοτεροι), certainly emphasizes that *all believing* Jews and Gentiles have access to the Father. The Greek word rendered "access" (προσαγωγην) is derived from "προς" and "αγω" and basically means *to lead to*, *conduct unto,* hence, *to bring into the presence of, to have entry,* and *admission*. In conclusion, both Jews and Gentiles continuously have access, entry, and admission into the presence of God through the Divine Agent, Jesus Christ (cf. Romans 5:2; Eph. 3:12).

Now that we have considered the Agent through whom we have the *right* to enter into the presence of God the Father, let us reflect on the Divine person who actually *effects* this entry. Since all men are *dead* in their trespasses and sins, *totally depraved* in their very nature, and incapable of appreciating and appropriating what God in Christ has provided for them, the Holy Spirit must act as the *Prime-Mover*. The price Christ paid for our admission into the presence of the Father (1 Cor. 6:19-20) *would go begging for takers* if the acceptance of it depended upon depraved men left to themselves (John 6:44, 65; 1 Cor. 1:30). Men who are dead physically cannot do anything in the physical sphere; likewise, men who are dead spiritually cannot do anything in the spiritual sphere they have *no ability* to run, walk, or even crawl toward Jesus Christ (Rom. 9:16).

As we have suggested above, if sinful, depraved, and spiritually dead men are going to appreciate the value of Christ's substitutionary death on their behalf the Holy Spirit will have to *come along aside, be called to their side by God* (παρακλητος), to *infuse Divine faith in them* with which to believe on Jesus Christ as their Saviour. Paul's statement that we have access to the Father "in one Spirit" (locative case) may also be translated "by one Spirit", (instrumental case). Regardless of translation, the important thing is that the Holy Spirit

must draw men to Christ, the Redeemer, and through Him into the presence of God the Father (John 6:44).

19. ***"then therefore you are no longer strangers and sojourners, but you are fellow-citizens with the saints and family of God,"***

This verse opens with two Greek particles, which we have translated "then" (αρα) and "therefore" (ουν), which indicate that what Paul is now saying is the *consequence* of what he has said in verse 14-18. Granting the veracity of what Paul has said, then it follows, "you [Gentiles] are no longer strangers and sojourners." The Greek adverb translated "no longer" (ουκετι) is derived from "ουκ" and "ετι" and basically means that the Gentiles are *not still, not yet,* and *not now* strangers and sojourners. In other words, this adverb emphasizes that with the passing of time there has been a *change in the status* of the Gentiles.

Back in verse 12, Paul says that previously the Gentiles were "strangers of the covenants of the promise." In this verse he affirms that they are no longer "strangers" (ξενοι), *foreigners, aliens,* or *those who occupy an outside position* (cf. Matt. 25:35, 43; 27:7; Heb. 11:13). Also, the Gentiles are no longer "sojourners" (παροικοι). This Greek noun is derived from "παρα" and "οικος" and basically means one who houses beside, i.e., beside or *outside of his own country*, hence, *a sojourner, a temporary resident,* or *a non-citizen.* It is used to describe Abraham's seed dwelling in a strange land (Acts 7:6), and the *status of Moses* in the land of Midian (Acts 7:29). What a tremendous *declaration of privilege* this statement is for every Gentile. We are no longer strangers, sojourners, and outsiders in our relation to God!

Paul begins the second half of this verse with the Greek conjunction "αλλα," which is the strongest word in the Greek language to emphasize *contrast*, and which we would translate into English with the word *but* underlined or capitalized. In contrast to formerly being strangers and sojourners, Paul says, BUT now "you are fellow-citizens with the saints and family of God." The verb "to be," rendered you are (εστε), denotes that their *fellow-citizen* and *family of God*

status is *their present* and *continuous possession*. They enjoy this new position and relationship *totally* on the basis of what God has sovereignly wrought through Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit (vv. 16-18).

The Greek word translated "fellow-citizens" (συμπολιται) comes from a combining of the two words "συν" and "πολιτης" and basically means *citizens with, joint-citizens,* or *citizens together* in the same commonwealth (Phil. 3:20). Even though this is the only time this word is used in the New Testament, its meaning can be clearly established on the basis of etymology. Paul modifies the noun *fellow-citizens* by adding the phrase "with the saints" (των αγιων). His point is that the Gentile believers are fellow-citizens with a particular group of people, "with the saints." a more meticulous translation of this phrase would be "of the saints," for the genitive case is used, and as such indicates that the fellow-citizens *belong to the saints*, i.e., they are equally a *part of the saints.*

As we closely follow Paul's line of thinking in this verse, that he is talking about Gentile believers as being a part of the saints, we readily concede that Jewish believers would constitute a large part of the saints, but we would not concede that they are *all the saints* Paul mentions here. Paul's use of the phrase, "the saints" (των αγιων), as used here, may well be broad enough to include all the Lord's people in all ages. The important point is that the Gentiles, in this present Church age, *have the privilege of belonging to the saints* (cf. 1:15, 18; 3:8, 18; 6:18).

The believing Gentiles are not only fellow-citizens with the saints, but they are also "family of God" (οικειοι του Θεου). The Greek word which we have translated "family" (οικειοι) stems from the word for "house" (οικος). It is used only two other times in the New Testament. In both instances it seems like its meaning is most accurately brought out by translating it *family*. In Galatians 6:10, Paul says that "we are to work that which is good to all, and especially to the *family* of the faith." In First Timothy 5:8, Paul declares, "And if anyone does not provide for his own, and especially his *family*, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever." The noun *household* is a good translation, however, its meaning is tending to be more commonly

expressed by the noun "family" in current English. As the Greek word "οικειος" is used in the *Septuagint*, it is very smoothly translated by the English word "family." In conclusion, the Grace of God in Christ has lifted believing Gentiles out of their hopeless, far-off, stranger, and sojourner condition, and it has made them citizens with the saints and members of the family of God.

20. ***"having been built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the chief cornerstone,"***

Paul apparently has all the saints, particularly of the Body of Christ, and αI1 the family of God in mind, when he says, "having been built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets." The verb translated "having been built upon" (εποικοδομηθεωτες) comes from combining the three Greek words, "επι" and "οικος" and "δομεω," and basically means *to build a house upon*, i.e., upon or above a foundation (cf. 1 Cor. 3:10). Paul uses this verb six times, and in every instance he gives it a *metaphorical meaning.* In First Corinthians 3:10-14, he speaks about individual believers exercising their responsibility to build upon a foundation which has been laid. In Colossians 2:7, he exhorts believers to live as those who have been in the sphere of Christ, i.e., upon Him.

Since the exact meaning of the Greek noun translated "foundation" (θεμελιω) is very vital to understanding this verse, let us examine both its *basic meaning* and *how* it is used in the New Testament. It basically means a *foundation, that which undergirds*, or *supports* a structure. It is used of a rock foundation (Luke 6:48), of a foundation for a tower (Luke 14:28-29), and of the foundation of a prison (Acts 16:26). When used metaphorically, by the Apostle Paul, it refers to the foundation or underpinning which supports the *total Truth for the Church,* the Body of Christ, with possibly two exceptions (Heb. 6:1; 11:10).

Now let us endeavor to ascertain the *nature* of this foundation. In First Corinthians 3:11, Paul affirms that no one is able to lay a foundation beyond that which has been laid, "which is Jesus Christ." In Romans 15:19-20, Paul implies that preaching the gospel lays the foundation, Jesus Christ. In First Timothy 6:17-19, we suggest that Paul wants

visible evidence confirming that the rich are resting upon the foundation, Jesus Christ, in whom they have true life. In Second Timothy 2:19, Paul speaks of the solid foundation of God, which has the seal, the Lord knows those who belong to Him, who are resting upon Jesus Christ.

Having observed Paul's declaration that Jesus Christ is the *exclusive foundation* of the Truth for the Church (1 Cor. 3:11), and having found that his general use of the Greek noun translated "foundation" (θεμελιος) fits this pattern, let us continue to examine the meaning of this verse. If Jesus Christ Himself is the foundation, what does Paul mean by the statement, "having been built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets"? First, we need to recognize that what Paul is saying here is consistent with what he said earlier in First Corinthians 3:11; however, he does slightly alter the figure of speech so as to make Jesus Christ *the chief cornerstone representing the entire foundation.* Second, in First Corinthians 3:11, Paul says "no one" (ουδεις) is able to lay a foundation other than what has been laid, namely, *by himself* (1 Cor. 2:1-2; 3:6-8). Even though Jesus Christ is the foundation, *someone* had to lay Him as such, and in the case of the Corinthians it was Paul (Acts 18:1-11). Likewise, in churches where Paul had not personally laid the foundation of Jesus Christ, it was laid by New Testament apostles and prophets (cf. Rom. 16:25).

As we elaborate on this verse we must not lose sight of the fact that Paul has been primarily dealing with believing Gentiles in the foregoing context. In verse 19, as a result of all that God has sovereignly done on their behalf, Paul says that they are *part of the saints and of the family of God.* Speaking with reference to the Gentiles and Jews, who constitute those being made "the saints" in this Church age, Paul says that they have been built upon the foundation "of the apostles and prophets" (των αποστολων και προφητων). The genitive case indicates that this foundation *belonged to* the apostles and prophets, i.e., it was the foundation which *they laid* through the preaching of Jesus Christ. They possessed this foundation because they had produced it, but *they themselves were not the foundation.*

Now we raise the question: Who were these apostles and prophets? Paul uses the Greek word for "apostles" (αποστολων) thirty-five times in his epistles. He uses the Greek word for "prophets" (προφητων) only seven times in his epistles. He uses both of these words together only three times, all in Ephesians. The Twelve Apostles are never associated with prophets in the synoptic Gospels, hence to apply what Paul says in this verse to them has no precedent. Also, in writing to the Corinthians, Paul designates Jesus' disciples as "the twelve" (τοις δωδεκα; 1 Cor. 15:5).

If these apostles and prophets were not the Twelve (including Matthias), who were they? The best way to answer this question is by considering the *qualification required* of them. First, they had to be those who knew that the Mosaic Law, with its commandments and ordinances, *had been annulled* (v. 15; contrast Acts 21:20-21). Second, they had to be those who knew that Jesus Christ was creating Jews and Gentiles into *one new man, the one body of Christ* (vv. 15-16; contrast Acts 21:24-25, 28-29). Fourth, they needed to be those who were preaching *the foundation of Jesus Christ to the particular churches* within the orbit of this encyclical epistle (See comments on 1:1; contrast Gal. 2:7-9; James 1:1; 1 Peter 1:1).

As we consider the noun "apostle" (αποστολος), as used in the New Testament, it appears that it is used to designate two distinct groups. First, it is used with reference to those associated with Jesus Christ and His earthly *Kingdom ministry* (Matt. 10:2-Acts 16:4). Second, it is used with reference to those associated with Jesus Christ in His heavenly *church ministry* (Rom. 1:1-Heb. 3:1). We recognize that there may be some *overlapping* between the former and the latter groups (Peter, Acts 15:7-11; 1 Pet. 1:1; Barnabas, Acts 4:36; 12:25; 13:2; Silas, Acts 15:22, 40). Paul often uses the *plural* number in referring to apostles related to the Church (Rom. 16:7; 1 Cor. 12:28; 2 Cor. 8:23; Eph. 3:5; 4:11). Twice he speaks of apostles as gifts given to the church (1 Cor. 12:28; Eph. 4:11). Paul directly or by association calls ten different persons apostles: himself (Gal. 1:1), Barnabas (Acts 14:14), Titus (2 Cor. 8:23), Andronicus and Junia (Rom. 16:7), Sosthenes (1 Cor. 1:1; 4:9), Apollos (1 Cor. 4:6, 9), Epaphroditus (Phil. 2:25), Silas and Timothy (1 Thess. 1:1; 2:7).

Negatively speaking, we cannot identify the Twelve Apostles with the apostles in verse 20, for they did not have the required qualifications. Positively speaking, these apostles are to be identified *with the apostles given to the church, with the plurality of apostles Paul mentions,* or they *may have included some, all, or more than the above ten.*

The foundation of Jesus Christ which these apostles laid was *based upon the Gospel of the Grace of God* revealed to Paul (Acts 20:24; Gal. 1:12). Their job was to proclaim and confirm, through the Holy Spirit, the Truth which had been made known to Paul (3:5). We have an example of how this occurred in Acts 19:9-10, where for two years Paul taught the Truth for the Church in the school of Tyrannus at Ephesus, which resulted in all those in Asia hearing the word of the Lord. It appears that those who sat under Paul's ministry at Ephesus went forth, as apostles and prophets, and laid the foundation which they had been taught throughout Asia (cf. Col. 1:7). Since most of those receiving this encyclical epistle had probably heard the gospel through these apostles, it is logical for Paul to point out the importance of their ministry in building the Church.

The phrase "the apostles and prophets," on the mere basis of conjunction "και," could conceivably be translated "the apostles even prophets." This rendering would put the noun prophets in *apposition* with the noun apostles, implying that the same persons held both offices. In view of Paul's general use of these two nouns (cf. 4:11; 1 Cor. 12:28-29; 14:29, 32, 37), we are opposed to bending the Greek grammar to accommodate the concept that these two offices were held by the same persons. It seems that the apostles had more of a *church-planting ministry* and the prophets an *edifying ministry in the local assemblies* (Acts 13:1-2). The method used by both was *teaching* the specific truth given to the church, the Gospel of the Mystery (6:19).

We interpret the phrase "Christ Jesus himself being the chief cornerstone" as being in *apposition* with the phrase "the foundation of the apostles and prophets." The meaning of the word for "chief cornerstone" (ακρογωνιαιου) is ambiguous. It may well be translated as the *stone in the corner of a foundation*. It is a key stone which

represents the entire foundation (Isa. 28:16; 1 Pet. 2:6). Jesus Christ is the cornerstone of the foundation laid by the apostles.

21. ***"in whom all the building being fitted together grows into a holy temple in the Lord,"***

The relative pronoun "whom" (ω) refers back to Christ Jesus, i.e., He is the one *in whom* this fitting together is taking place. In the previous verse the emphasis was on the fact that the Gentiles, fellow citizens of the saints, were built *upon the foundation* laid by the apostles and prophets, namely Jesus Christ. In this verse the emphasis is on the *structure* being built upon the foundation, which is in the sphere of Jesus Christ, and which has Him as its periphery. All that is mentioned in this verse is encircled and encompassed by Jesus Christ.

The phrase "all the building" (πασα οικοδομη) is in the singular and may also be translated *each* or *every building.* This rendering, in the light of the immediate context, could be interpreted as applying to *every believer* being fitted together into a holy temple. Apart from grasping Paul's exact emphasis here, both of these interpretations lead to the same conclusion: all are made members of a holy temple. The singular may also be interpreted to mean *all of a given building*, the parts of which are being fitted together, unto the end of forming a holy temple. Regardless of which interpretation we may prefer, the ramifications of all are true: individually and collectively all Jewish and Gentile believers are fitted together in a holy temple.

The Greek word which we have translated "being fitted together" (συναρμολγουμενη) is derived from "συν" and "αρμος" and "λογος." The meaning of these words as used in this context, in inverted order, would be *collect-joint-with*, hence, *to collect that joined together, to join* or *to fit together.* This participle is in the present tense and passive voice, and the full meaning is that Jesus Christ is the one continuously assembling and joining together all believers. What Paul is talking about here is a *continuous work* which *God the Son performs.* The language used excludes the thought that man fits himself into the holy temple mentioned here. The only other time this compound verb is used in the New Testament is in the fourth chapter

(v. 16), where the present tense and passive voice also affirm that *Jesus Christ is the one* who continuously joins members to His Body.

The Greek verb rendered "grows" (αυξει) is in the present tense, and may also be translated *increases, enlarges,* and *matures*. Paul is declaring that all the building which is in the process of being fitted together *is continuously growing*, enlarging, and maturing. He is not talking about something that is static, *but dynamic*, an organism that as a result of Christ's fitting and joining together is *increasing in size*. The emphasis here is on quantity and size rather than quality. In *quality*, the temple Paul speaks of is *holy*; in quantity, it is growing as additional members are being added.

Now let us look at the phrase "into a holy temple in the Lord." The Greek preposition "εις" may be translated either *into* or *unto*. The basic meaning is that the *end* or *result* of the growing is the holy temple. Looked at from the viewpoint of God's sovereign purpose, the size of this temple was established before the creation of the world (1:4-5). Looked at from the vantage point of history, this temple is being enlarged as God's sovereign purpose is being effected (Acts 13:48).

As we began this verse we observed that the truth stated in it takes place in the sphere of Christ. As we approach the end we note that the holy temple is *located in* the Lord. The preceding context, the unique terminology used, and the development of thought all lead to the conclusion - this temple is the *Body of Christ*. What Paul says in chapter four (vv. 15-16), certainly confirms this identification. Also, in First and Second Corinthians he refers to believers, using the plural, as collectively being a temple of God (1 Cor. 3:16-17; 2 Cor. 6:16). The adjective "holy" (αγιον) describes this temple, the Body of Christ, as that which is *separated* unto Deity, in this case, God the Son. In the Body of Christ our life is hid with Christ in God (Col. 3:3).

22. ***"in whom also you are being built together into a dwelling-place of God in the Spirit."***

The relative pronoun translated "in whom" (εν ω) may also be rendered *in which* in this context. If we interpret that the antecedent of

this pronoun is Jesus Christ, then the translation "in whom" is correct, but if we interpret the antecedent as being the holy temple, then the translation *in which* would be proper. The grammar permits either translation. Since the temple is the Body of Christ, and all that is mentioned here takes place within the sphere of Christ, both translations end up with believers being a temple, a dwelling-place of God.

As we have mentioned before, we continue to emphasize, the main point of this paragraph (vv. 14-22) is that the Gentiles are on *equal footing* with the Jews in the Body of Christ. In verses 20-21, Paul seems to be dealing with esoteric truth applicable to both Jews and Gentiles in their being amalgamated, assimilated, and united into one growing organism, the Body of Christ. In this verse he again uses the personal pronoun "you" (υμεις) to direct what he is saying to the Gentiles. The Jews knew that they had a position in the Body of Christ, that they were part of the holy temple in the Lord, and here Paul informs the Gentiles that they are *being built together with the Jews in this privileged Body-temple relationship.*

The Greek participle translated "are being built together" (συνοικοδομεισθε) is derived from "συν" and "οικος" and "δομεω." In as much as this word is in the present tense and passive voice it literally means you (Gentiles) *are being built - a house - with*, hence, the Gentiles are being built together with the Jews into a house (holy temple) which is to serve as a dwelling-place of God. This is the only time this compound Greek word is used in the New Testament. It describes a *new relationship* between Jews and Gentiles in a *new organism,* the Body of Christ, the Church (3:8-9; Col. 1:26).

The ultimate end of Christ joining together Gentiles and Jews into a single holy temple, the Body of Christ, is that *they might constitute a dwelling place of God*, i.e., that belongs to God (genitive of possession). It is important to note that God occupies this "dwelling place" (κατοικητηριον) or *habitation* in the form of the Spirit (cf. John 4:24). Believers collectively, both Jews and Gentiles, are an invisible temple and Body in which God the Holy Spirit dwells (1 Cor. 3:16-17; 6:19; Rom. 8:9).

Chapter 3

1. ***"For this cause I, Paul, the prisoner of Christ Jesus on behalf of you Gentiles - "***

In the previous chapter, verses 14-22, Paul has clearly stated that the Gentiles have *equal privileges* with the Jews in the Body of Christ. This was certainly good news for the Gentiles who had been a far-off and estranged people from God. On the other hand, wouldn't such a statement excite jealousy among some of the Jews who had been God's Covenant people for over 1800 years? (cf. Acts 10:15, 28, 34-36; 11:1-3) Even as Peter had to give evidence for preaching to the Gentiles in Caesarea (Acts 11:4-17), likewise Paul recognizes that he needs to support what he has said with evidence. As chapter three opens this main burden is to explain *where he got this truth*. In a nutshell - it was *given* to him (v. 2) and *revealed* to him (v. 3).

The Greek phrase translated "For this cause" (τουτου χαριν) may also be rendered *for this reason* or *on account of this*. It appears that Paul's thought-flow was that *because of what he had said he is now going to add something*. What he had said is the cause or reason for what he is about to say. The fact that he speaks of himself as "I, Paul" (εγω Παυλος) certainly emphasizes the *importance of his person* as the one to whom the Mystery was revealed. In verses 2-13, four times he mentions the distinct Truth which had been *given to him* (to me; vv. 2, 3, 7, 8,), *his understanding* (my: v. 4), the fact that he had been *made a minister* (v. 7), and *his afflictions* for the Gentiles (v. 13). As Paul, one distinct from others, he had the distinct Truth of the Mystery given to him, which contained the fact that the Gentiles are *on a par* with the Jews in the Body of Christ (cf. Gal. 3:28).

Having made it clear that he, Paul, is the one who has declared and affirms the equality of the Gentiles with the Jews, he adds the phrase, "the prisoner of Christ Jesus on behalf of you Gentiles." He uses this same word twice to describe his state when writing this encyclical epistle (4:1), twice in writing to Philemon (vv. 1, 9) and once in writing to Timothy (2 Tim. 1:8). He refers to himself as being a prisoner *of Christ Jesus.* The genitive case is used here to denote *possession*,

i.e., Paul is a prisoner who is possessed by and *belongs to Jesus Christ.*

As a prisoner of Christ, Paul's imprisonment was "on behalf of" (υπερ), *for the sake of,* or *for the benefit of* the Gentiles. This is the only time Paul specifically says that he was in prison on behalf of the Gentiles. Three times he says that he was in prison on account of the distinct Gospel which he preached, namely the *Mystery Gospel* (Eph. 6:19-20; Col. 4:3) and his *My Gospel* (2 Tim. 2:8-9; cf. Rom. 2:16; 16:25). We need to keep in mind that the Mystery Gospel and My Gospel are merely different designations for the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24). We recognize that as Paul proclaimed this Gospel, and the fact that it gave Jews and Gentiles equal privileges in this Church age, his imprisonment for the sake of the Gospel is inseparable from his imprisonment on behalf of the Gentiles. Paul's fidelity to the Mystery Gospel, which made believing Gentiles and Jews one in Christ, and his rejection of the Mosaic Law which divided them, was the cause of his Caesarean and Roman imprisonments (cf. Acts 21:20-21, 27-28; Gal. 5:11; 6:12).

2. ***"if you have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God that was given to me for you,"***

This verse offers a strong argument in favor of the position that this is an encyclical epistle. If it was written to only the Ephesians, we would expect Paul to know whether or not they had this information, but if it was written to several churches he probably did not know the extent of their information. It appears that what Paul says in verse two is primarily for those who knew nothing about the revelation of Truth he had received from the Lord. We would suggest that if Paul was confident that all his readers knew that the dispensation of the grace of God had been given to him, he would have maintained a smooth flow of thought from verse one to verse three. From this point of view verse two is a parenthesis for the uninformed.

The question Paul raises is this: Have you heard *of* or *about* the dispensation of the grace of God that was given to me? It is very important for us to accurately understand the meaning of the Greek noun translated "dispensation" (οικονομιαν). This is a compound word which is derived from combining "οικος," meaning a *house,*

family, or *people,* and "νεμω," meaning *to dispense, manage,* or *administer.* This word is used in Greek literature to depict the management of a family or household, the public economy of states, and the administration of government. It is also used in the Septuagint, Isaiah 22:19-22, pertaining to an important government office.

This word rendered "dispensation" (οικονομιαν) is used nine times in the New Testament: three times by Jesus and six times by Paul. Jesus used it to describe the *office* which involved managing a rich man's possessions, i.e., managing things according to given arrangements and regulations so as to enhance the rich man's estate (Luke 16:1-4).

Five out of the six times Paul uses the word "dispensation" (οικονομιαν), he speaks of it as that which had been *given to him* (1 Cor. 9:17; Eph. 1:10; 3:2, 9; Col. 1:25). This is a very special word in Paul's vocabulary - it has a *unique meaning* - which is not found in any other New Testament writers. It is also closely associated with the Truth of the Mystery and the Grace of God in his epistles. In the light of the above observations, particularly the manner in which Paul uses the word "dispensation" (οικονομιαν), we want to give two possible definitions of it: 1) it is an arrangement based on grace whereby God relates to His people through Christ and His Church; 2) it is a grace economy in which God is governing His people through Christ and His Church.

The phrase, "the dispensation of the grace of God," indicates that it is a dispensation which *belongs* to God's grace, a dispensation which is *based upon* God's grace, and a dispensation which *functions* according to the principle of God's grace. It is a dispensation in which God's grace toward believers causes them to be gracious to one another (Col. 3:13).

Finally, Paul says that this dispensation "was given to me for you." The aorist tense and passive voice indicate that God the Holy Spirit gave it to him at a *given time* in the past (1 Cor. 2:10). We have already observed that five times he affirms that this special

dispensation was given to him. It was given to him "for" (εις), *unto the end* to give it to the Gentiles.

3. ***"that according to revelation the mystery was made known to me as I previously wrote briefly,"***

In this verse Paul explains *how* the Truth of the Mystery was made known to him. Some might feel that he is diverging from his main subject when he does this, but not at all, for the fact that the Gentiles are made one with the Jews in the Body of Christ is an important *part of Mystery Truth*. If the Mystery was Divinely revealed to him, which he affirms that it was, then what he says about the dispensation of the grace of God being given to him, which included the Gentiles in the Church, is truth *backed by Divine authority*. In other words, to validate the Mystery is to validate the right the Gentiles have to membership in the Body of Christ, the Church.

Now let us look at the statement, "that according to revelation the mystery was made known to me." The Greek conjunction translated "that" (οτι) may also be rendered *for, for that,* or *because* in this context. The phrase "according to revelation" (κατα αποκαλυψιν) means that *conforming to* or *by way of revelation* the Mystery was made known to Paul. The Greek word for "revelation" is derived from "απο" and "καλυπτω" and literally means *to take the cover from*, hence it speaks of an *uncovering, revealing,* and *disclosing* of the Mystery.

The Greek verb rendered "made known" (εγνωρισθη) is in the aorist tense and passive voice and indicates that Jesus Christ through the Holy Spirit *imparted knowledge, implanted understanding*, and *gave insight* to Paul pertaining to the Mystery (cf. 1 Cor. 2:10; Gal. 1:12). The implications of the grammatical construction of the forepart of this verse are: 1) that the Mystery was made known to Paul by an *outside source,* it had its origin in God (1 Cor. 2:1, 7; 4:1; Col. 2:2); 2) that it was made known in *past time* in various stages as the ingressive aorist suggests (1:9); and 3) that the manner in which it was made known was *by direct Divine revelation* (v. 8; 1 Cor. 2:10; Gal. 1:12).

It is very important that we understand what Paul means by the phrase "the mystery" (το μυστηριον). The use of the article makes it clear that he is speaking about a specific mystery, THE MYSTERY, a phrase which he uses to designate the Truth given to him for the Church. The English word *mystery* is a transliteration of the Greek word " μυστηριον." Paul uses this Greek word regarding truth which had previously been kept silent, hidden, and concealed, *but which now has been revealed* (Rom. 11:25; 16:25-26; 1 Cor. 2:7, 10; Eph. 3:5; Col. 1:26). In other words, this noun is used by Paul to denote truth *which had been unknown*, but which was made known to him, hence, it refers to *a body of known Truth*.

We have a problem of communication when we designate *Truth which is known* by an English word which means just the opposite. The generally accepted meaning of the English word *mystery* is that it is *something which is not known, understood* or *comprehended*. If our concern is to accurately convey *the thought* in the Greek language into the English language, then it appears that we need to look for a word or phrase other than the transliteration, namely mystery. Since Paul specifically uses the word "μυστηριον" with reference to *formerly-secret truth*, which is now known truth, and since out of 21 times he uses it 18 times regarding Truth for the Church, in these instances we may well translate it CHURCH TRUTH, i.e., as used by Paul the transliterated word Mystery generally may be replaced by the phrase *Church Truth*. Applying this principle to the verse before us, we would render it, "that according to revelation Church Truth was made known to me as I previously wrote briefly." One aspect of this Truth is the fact that the Gentiles have been given co-membership in the Body of Christ.

Observe that Paul makes the claim that this Church Truth was *made known unto him,* i.e., unto "me" (μοι). He is the only New Testament writer who asserts that he has the prerogative of dispensing the Truth for the Body of Christ, the Church (cf. 1 Thess. 2:13; 2 Tim. 3:16). To affirm, however, on the basis of this limited statement that no other New Testament writer had Church Truth revealed to him would be an unjustified argument based on silence. Nevertheless, even though there is a high alignment between the Truth in John's and Peter's

epistles and those of Paul, it is interesting that Paul is the *only one* who lays claim to having Church Truth specifically revealed unto him.

With respect to the Mystery, the Church Truth made known to him, Paul says, "As I previously wrote briefly." We raise the question - what does he refer to when he says "I previously wrote"? Our first choice is that he is referring to the Church Truth which he mentions in the forepart of this epistle (cf. 1:9-14, 18-19; etc.). Keep in mind that this is a very carefully written treatise which Paul may have written over a period of weeks or months. As he writes the third chapter it would be logical for him to refer to what he had written earlier as what "I previously wrote." Our second choice is that he had written a short letter on this subject, of which we have no record, which may have been addressed to some or all of these churches (cf. 1 Cor. 5:9). The language used makes it clear that he is referring to something he wrote *prior to what he is now writing* (προεγραψα) and that it was short, little, and brief.

4. ***"which considering you are able while reading to perceive my understanding in the mystery of Christ,"***

This verse begins with the Greek preposition "προς" which we have translated *considering*. As used in this context the thought seems to be that *paying attention* to what Paul had previously written, while reading it, they will be able to perceive his understanding in the Mystery, Church Truth. The Greek verb translated "you are able" (δυνασθε) means that as they read what has been written they will have the *ability, capacity*, and *acumen-strength* to perceive how well Paul understands the Truth for the Church.

The present active Greek participle rendered "while reading" (αναγινωσκοντες) is derived from "ανα" and "γινωσκω" and literally means *to know up*, hence, *to gather exact knowledge* or *to read*. The action of this present participle is *simultaneous* with the action of the leading verb, which means that *while they are reading they are able to perceive* Paul's insight into the Mystery. We must keep in mind that Paul is obviously referring to the public reading of his epistle in the local assembly. His epistles were usually written to local assemblies

or churches and were expected to be read to the whole assembly (cf. Col. 4:16; 1 Thess. 5:27).

This verse has some very significant implications, particularly the present participle, for it gives us insight into the *method* used to dispense Church Truth in New Testament times. While or during the time an epistle was being publicly read to a church, the congregation consequently was *able to perceive* the truth in the epistle. When Paul speaks about reading here he is speaking about *reading coupled with perceiving* what is read. The job of a teacher in a local assembly was to read what Paul had written in a manner that *enabled the hearer to intellectually grasp the concepts and thoughts* of what was presented. It is one thing to go through the ritual of reading the Scriptures without producing any perception on the part of the hearers; but this is the very opposite of what Paul has in mind in this verse.

As we exegete this verse we need to keep clearly in mind that *the reading is not the object in itself*, but it is only the means by which the object is accomplished, the *accurate perception of the truth* read. As we think in terms of the historical setting of Paul's day, and the spiritual ignorance which prevailed, it is obvious that simply reading through an epistle would not have accomplished the object he had in mind, *comprehension of the Truth* for the Church. Furthermore, as we apply the principle of reading to the present time, with its humanistic ally oriented spiritual ignorance, we recognize that just reading the Pauline Epistles, even from the original language, is utterly inadequate for accomplishing the above object - an accurate understanding of the Mystery. This forces us to recognize that when Paul uses the Greek participle translated "while reading" *he has more in mind* than simple reading.

We have already observed the derivation of this participle, and that its basic meaning is *knowing - to know exactly* or *to bring knowledge up* as from the printed page. Recognizing that the basic meaning of this word is *accurate knowing*, and that the object of its use in this verse is a *clear perception* of Church Truth, it appears that Paul is using it here to mean *reading involving expounding the exact knowledge* of an epistle. In other words, it is to slowly and progressively *read and expose* as accurately as possible what Paul has written in his epistles (2 Tim. 2:15). It is a *reading-expositional method*, progressing verse

by verse, involving three facets - *reading, explaining,* and *perceiving* the greatness of the Mystery, the Truth for the Church, made known to the Apostle Paul (cf. 1 Tim. 4:13, 15-16; 2 Tim. 3:16).

The Greek infinitive translated "to perceive" (νοησαι) conveys the idea of *mentally grasping, apprehending*, and *laying hold of* knowledge, which in this case was the fact that Paul possessed a comprehensive understanding of the Mystery, Church Truth. The Greek noun rendered "understanding" (συνεσιν) comes from "συν" and "ιημι" and literally means to *send together*, hence, *understanding, comprehension,* and *insight*. As the leaders in the local assemblies read-expositionally, the congregations were able to mentally grasp Paul's vast understanding of Church Truth.

Finally, the phrase "the mystery of Christ," refers to Church Truth which *belongs* to Christ, of which He is the center, as the Head over the Church. The *foundation* on which the Church was established is Jesus Christ's substitutionary death on Calvary, in *essence* the Church is a living organism nurtured by its Head, Christ, and the *hope* of the Church is future glorification together with Christ. Since the Mystery is Truth concerning and for the Church, and since the Church is totally dependent upon Him for its beginning, continuance, and future, it is logical to refer to the Mystery as belonging to Christ.

5. ***"which in other generations was not made known to the sons of men, as it now has been revealed to his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit,"***

This verse begins with the relative pronoun "which" (ο), the antecedent of which is the noun *Mystery* in the preceding verse. Here Paul affirms that the Mystery was not made known in "other generations" (ετεραις γενεαις). This is the only time he uses this phrase in his epistles. The Greek word translated "other" (ετεραις) may also be rendered *another, second,* or *different*. The Greek noun for "generations" (γενεαις) conveys the same meaning as the English noun. Here Paul is confirming the fact that the making known of the Mystery to him *was a first* (v. 3); it had never previously been made known in another or different generation than his own (cf. Rom. 16:25; Col. 1:26).

Having said that the Mystery was not made known in the time-sphere of other generations, Paul adds, "to the sons of men." Since the Greek word translated "sons" (υιος) is often used with a generic meaning, including both men and women, it may also be translated "to the children of men." This is the only time Paul uses this phrase in his epistles. Its meaning in this verse is clear - he is declaring that the Mystery *had never before been made known to members of the human race* as it now has been revealed to the apostles and prophets.

Note that Paul presents a *contrast* here between two groups - the Mystery was not previously made known to the sons of men - now it has been revealed to the holy apostles and prophets. These two groups are in the *plural*, they are both a part of the same human race; one belongs to *other generations* and one to *the now generation*. In both the Old and New Testaments, when God wanted to reveal new truth to His people, it appears that He always did it through *a given person*, singular. The examples of Abraham, Moses, the Old Testament prophets, John the Baptist, Jesus (the God-man), and the Apostle Paul verify this principle. The Revelators of New Truth *must be distinguished* from those who reveal, make known, and spread it abroad to the people. We understand that the apostles and prophets in this verse are in the same general category as the sons of men - those to whom the Revelator dispensed the truth.

As we exegete the Truth in the Pauline epistles, which represent the inspired Word of God given to the Church, we recognize that their contents are not contradictory but *consistent*. Since Paul makes it clear that the Mystery, the Truth for the Church, was made known and revealed unto him, and gives no inkling that even those closest to him had the same revelation, we have no choice but to interpret his epistles in the light of this principle. Consider the following evidence confirming that the *Mystery, Church Truth*, was revealed to Paul (Rom. 16:25; 1 Cor. 2:7, 10; 4:1; 15:51; Eph. 1:9; 3:3-4; 3:7-9; Col. 1:25-26; 4:3-4), and that he had a *distinct Gospel* which he refers to as *my gospel* (Rom. 2:16; 16:25; 2 Tim. 2:8), *our gospel* (2 Cor. 4:3; 1 Thess. 1:5; 2 Thess. 2:14), and *the preached-by-me-gospel* (1 Cor. 15:1; Gal. 1:11; 2:2). Furthermore, the *contents* of Paul's Mystery-Gospel are *distinct*.

Granting that Paul is the only one who claims to have had the Mystery, Church Truth, revealed to him, and that he is the only one who has a distinct "dispensation of the grace of God" message, we acknowledge that the apostles and prophets mentioned in this verse were *dispensers of the Truth revealed to the Apostle Paul*. Having discussed the identity of these apostles and prophets in the previous chapter (2:20), we will limit our remarks here to the role they play in this context.

It was one thing for the Apostle Paul to have his Gospel revealed to him by Jesus Christ (Gal. 1:12) by the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 2:10), and it is another thing for this Spirit-given Truth to make sense to its emissaries (cf. 1 Cor. 2:14-15). To those coming out of Judaic and heathenistic backgrounds, the Mystery, the Truth about the Church, would certainly make no sense (1 Cor. 1:23). If these Church apostles were going to disseminate this Truth, they first needed the Holy Spirit to reveal the truthfulness of the Mystery Truth to them. If these New Testament Church prophets were to adequately do their job in the local assemblies they too needed the convincing work of the Holy Spirit on their minds and enlightenment to perform their ministries in accordance with the Mystery, the Truth for the Church (cf. John 16:8; 1 Cor. 14:30). Summarizing, the only way for the apostles and prophets, associated with the early Church, to know and understand the Mystery made known through Paul was *by means of the Holy Spirit.* Through revelation the Holy Spirit gave them insight into the nature and functioning of the Body of Christ (cf. Phil. 3:15; 1 Cor. 14:26; Eph. 1:17).

6. ***"to be, the Gentiles fellow-heirs and fellow-body members and fellow-partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel,"***

We have translated the first word in this verse "to be" (ειναι); it is a present infinitive and this is an accurate rendering of it. The thought is that according to the revealed Mystery the Gentiles *are* now fellow-heirs, fellow-body members, and fellow-partakers of the promise. As we pointed out earlier, the main reason Paul introduces the subject of the Mystery at the beginning of this chapter is to establish an authoritative basis for what he said in the latter part of chapter two.

His authority for declaring that the Gentiles are co-equal with the Jews in the Body of Christ is *based on the Mystery* which was made known to him. It is interesting that Paul does not go back to Peter and Cornelius at Caesarea for authority to proclaim that the Gentiles are equal with the Jews in the Body, the Church (Acts 10:44-48). There was a good reason why he did not go back to Caesarea, for at this point in time Peter knew nothing about the organism, the Body of Christ, and joint heirship of Jews and Gentiles in it. The Mystery is the *sole source of authority* that we Gentiles have for claiming equal status with the Jews in the Body of Christ, the Church (cf. Gal. 3:26-28).

Paul does not set forth a great deal of new truth in this verse, but primarily uses different words to reaffirm what he said in the preceding chapter. First he says that the Gentiles are "fellow-heirs" (συγκληρονομα) with the Jews. This Greek noun is derived from "συν" which means *with* or *together*, and "κλμρος" which means a lot or portion, and "νεμω" which may mean to *assign* or *occupy*. This basically means that the Gentiles have been *assigned a portion together with the Jews* or *that they occupy a portion with the Jews* in the Body of Christ. In other words, The Mystery, Church Truth given to Paul, affirms that the Gentiles are *co-heirs* with the Jews in the Church. This same Greek word is used to describe our co-heir relation with Jesus Christ (Rom. 8:17).

Second, Paul says that the Gentiles are "fellow-body members" (συσσωμα) with the Jews. This is the only time this noun is used in the New Testament. In view of its absence from the Septuagint and extra-biblical Greek, it was apparently coined by the Apostle Paul. Since the concept of the Body of Christ, the Church, was entirely new, it is most logical that he would have to develop *new terminology* to describe relations to it. This noun is derived from "συν" and "σωμα" which respectively mean *with* or *together* and *body*. It literally means *with-body-ones, together-body-ones*, or *those who are together in the Body,* hence, the translation *fellow-body-members*. This word gives us a picture of Jews and Gentiles equally participating in membership in the Body of Christ - members of one another (Rom. 12:5).

Third, Paul declares that the Gentiles are "fellow-partakers [συμμετοχα] of the promise in Christ." This noun is derived from a combining of "συν" and "μετα" and "εχω." It literally means to *have-together-with* or to *hold-together-with,* hence, *those who share together with* or who are *joint-partakers*. The only other time this word is used in the New Testament is in the fifth chapter (v. 7), where Paul says that they are not to be fellow-partakers with the sons of disobedience. Thus we observe, according to Mystery Truth the Gentiles equally share and participate with the Jews in the promise in Christ.

What is this promise of which the Jews and Gentiles are fellow-partakers? First, in answering this question it is very important that it is *not just a promise*, but it is *THE promise* (της επαγγελιας), *a specific promise* as implied by the article preceding the noun promise. Jesus promised His disciples that He would send *the promise* of the Father upon them (Luke 24:49). In Acts 1:4, Jesus charged His disciples not to depart from Jerusalem, but to wait for *the promise* of the Father. In Acts 2:33, Peter says that Jesus Christ having been exalted to the right-hand of God, "*the promise* of the Holy Spirit having received from the Father, he poured out this which you both see and hear." The above citations should be sufficient evidence for identifying *the promise with the Holy Spirit's coming and presence*. We recognize that the above passages primarily apply to the Spirit's relation to the earthly Kingdom; however, it having been rejected and temporarily replaced by the Church dispensation (v. 2) in which the Holy Spirit plays a key role, the concept of *the promise* also secondarily applies today. The thought is that both Jews and Gentiles equally share and participate in the Holy Spirit.

The sphere in which this participation in the Spirit takes place is "in Christ Jesus" (εν Χριστω Ιησου). In the light of what Paul has said in the last part of the previous chapter, we prefer to interpret this phrase as meaning *in the Body of Christ* (cf. 1 Cor. 12:12-13). It is logical to think that this applies to the *total work of the Spirit* on behalf of believers in conjunction with the Body of Christ. The phrase "through the gospel" (δια του ευαγγελιου) indicates that the Gentiles being made fellow-heirs, fellow-body-members, and fellow-partakers of the Holy Spirit - this takes *place through the agency of the Gospel*. The

Truth that produces the above results is the Gospel of the Grace of God vitalized by the Holy Spirit!

7. ***"of which I was made a minister according to the gift of the grace of God that was given to me according to the energizing of his power."***

The phrase "of which" is a translation of the relative pronoun "ου," which is in the genitive case, and its antecedent is the noun Gospel. Paul closes the previous verse with the phrase "the gospel" (του ευαγγελιου), and in this verse he goes on to explain *his relation* to this Gospel. The use of the article prior to the noun "Gospel" is significant in this context. He is referring to the fact that the Gentiles were made fellow-heirs, fellow-body members, and fellow-partakers of the promise through the agency of *the Gospel a specific Gospel*. The relative pronoun rendered "of which" *ties* the Apostle Paul to this specific and distinct Gospel.

Speaking with reference to this Gospel, Paul says, "of which I was made a minister." The Greek verb translated "I was made" (εγενηθην) is in the aorist tense and passive voice and conveys the idea that at a given point in past time Paul was *made, constituted*, and *appointed* a minister by God. Jesus Christ was the *Active Agent* who did this; Paul was passive (Acts 9:3-8; 1 Tim. 1:12-14). It is impossible, on the basis of human psychology, to explain the complete reversal that took place in the life of Saul of Tarsus - a blasphemer instantaneously re-created into a minister, one ready to die for Christ (Acts 9:15-16; 20:24). If Paul's conversion, and the cataclysmic effect it had on his lifestyle was not the sovereign work of God, we have an inexplicable phenomenon which defies human comprehension.

The Greek noun translated "minister" (διακονος) designates Paul's - *position* in relation to this specific Gospel. Some of this word's basic meanings are *one who serves, attends to a given work,* or *who administers.* This word is transliterated into English in the form of the noun *deacon*. Since this word has tended to take on a limited connotation, as a proper name for certain church officers, we need to examine how Paul uses it in the New Testament. In Romans 13:4, he uses it of *God*, and in 15:8, of *Christ*. He uses it respecting himself

some *six* times. He uses it regarding Tychicus two times and Timothy *once*. It is a noun which has grown out of the Greek verb " διακονεω," and as such, it depicts one who is *actively* serving, waiting on others, and ministering, which in Paul's case was *focused on the Gospel* which brought good news to the Gentiles.

Paul says that he was made a minister of the Gospel "according to the gift of the grace of God that was given to me." The Greek word translated "gift" (δωρεαν) is used as an adverb and may also be rendered according to the *free giving, gratuitous giving,* and *undeserved giving* of the grace of God that was given to Paul. The grace of God, *freely extended* to Paul, was what made him a minister of the Gospel. We have already pointed out, on the basis of the passive voice used in this verse, that the Lord was the one who made Paul a minister. This phrase explains *how* the Lord did it, namely *freely, gratuitously,* and *apart from any merit* on Paul's part, He sovereignly made, constituted, and appointed him a minister of the Gospel.

Having observed that it was God's grace which *gave* (δοθεισης), as a free gift, the ministry of the Gospel to Paul, now we have the added statement, "according to the energizing of his power." Even as the free gift grows out of the grace of God, likewise, the energizing grows out of the power of God. The Greek word translated "energizing" (ενεργειαν) is derived from the preposition "εν" and "εργον" and literally means *work-in* or *working in*, hence, *energy, working*, and *activity*. Our English word *energy* is a transliteration of this Greek word. This word is always used in the New Testament in conjunction with *superhuman* energy, either of God or Satan.

Also involved in making Paul a minister of the Gospel was God's power energizing and working on his behalf. The Greek word translated "power" (δυναμεως) speaks of God's *ability, strength*, and *might*, the reservoir which supplied the necessary effectual energy to make him a minister of the Gospel. According to Colossians 1:29, we need to acknowledge that this Divine energizing was a *continuous part and requisite* in the fulfillment of his daily ministry of the Gospel. Furthermore, where we see the power of God released and

energizing in the lives of believers, we can posit the fact that this is being done *through God the Holy Spirit* (1 Cor. 2:4; cf. Acts 1:8).

8. ***"To me the lesser of all the saints this grace was given, to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ,"***

In translating, when we can bring out the meaning of the Greek clearly, and still adhere to its *word order*, we prefer to do so, as in this verse. This helps the English reader get a better feel of what is going on behind the translation. As Paul opens this verse he still has in mind the grace of God which has been given *to him*, in the first person singular, "to me" (εμοι). As he thinks of his terrible past, and how finite he is, and reflects on the greatness of His sovereign God, he is amazed that God chose him to be the minister of the Gospel to the Gentiles. He uses the Greek word translated "lesser" (ελαχιστοτερω), a comparative form added to the superlative form, to say that he is *the lesser of the least* of all the saints. This is the only time this dual form is used in the New Testament. I interpret this statement to mean that *when God extended His grace to Saul of Tarsus* he was *less than the least* of all the saints from whom God might have chosen at that time. He gives himself this deplorable comparative rating because he was a blasphemer, persecutor, insulter, and the chief of sinners (1 Tim. 1:12-16).

In the previous verse the aorist passive participle is used to indicate that *the Lord gave this grace*; likewise, in this verse the aorist passive verb (εδοθη) is used to reinforce the same truth - Paul's salvation and placement in the ministry were *totally the resultant of the grace of God.* We already suggested that *special grace* was given unto Paul for a distinct ministry. In this verse he refers to the grace given unto him as "this grace" (χαρις αυτη), using the demonstrative Greek pronoun to set it apart as a *specific grace* for a *specific ministry*, namely, "to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ."

First, let us consider the fact that he was given a special *Gentile ministry.* The fact that he should go to the Gentiles was incorporated in his original commission (Acts 9:15). This was reaffirmed by the Lord a second time when he was in the temple at Jerusalem (Acts 22:17-21). In writing to the Galatians he reiterates God's purpose

given to him, to preach to the Gentiles (Gal. 1:16). James, Peter, and John recognize his Gentile ministry (Gal. 2:9).

Second, now that we have considered the fact that Paul was to go to the Gentiles (cf. also Rom. 1:5; 11:13; 15:16), let us turn our attention to the *message* which he was to proclaim to them. The message which had been committed unto him was "to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ." The Greek word, an aorist infinitive, translated "to preach" (ευαγγελισασθαι) comes from the word "ευ " and "αγγελος" and means a *good message, good news,* or *good tidings.* As an infinitive it means to *proclaim, announce,* or *bring good news,* which is the essence and substance of the Gospel. Where this word is used in conjunction with another nounal phrase, such as in this case the *unsearchable riches*, it commonly replaces the inherent meaning of good news or gospel. On the other hand, this could be *more fully translated*, "to preach the gospel, the unsearchable riches of Christ, to the Gentiles," or "to preach the good news, the unsearchable riches of Christ, to the Gentiles." In the latter translations "the unsearchable riches of Christ" would be in *apposition* with the "gospel" and "good news," i.e., the Gospel and good news would be the *truth contained in the unsearchable riches of Christ.*

What are the unsearchable riches of Christ which Paul is to preach to the Gentiles? Fortunately, the answer to this question is inherent in the etymological meaning of the Greek word translated "unsearchable" (ανεξιχνιαστον). This word is derived from "α" which *negates* what follows it, and "εξ" which means out, and "ιχνος" which means a *track* or *footprint*. Combining and inverting these meanings we have *track-out-unable*, hence, *unable-to-track-out* riches of Christ, *untrackable* riches of Christ, or *untraceable* riches of Christ. This is the only time Paul uses the phrase, *the riches of Christ*, in his epistles. We identify it with the phrase, the mystery of Christ (v. 4; Col. 4:3), for it is intertwined in a context which is dealing with the mystery. Also, the only other time Paul uses the word *untrackable* is together with the word riches, and in a mystery context (Rom. 11:25), suggesting that the words *untrackable riches* and *mystery* refer to the same truth.

Why does Paul call the riches of Christ, to which he refers in this verse, as being unsearchable, untrackable, and that which cannot be traced out? Does he mean that the truth he is talking about had never been revealed to anyone before him and it is not to be found in any literature, not even the Old Testament? If the Greek language is an adequate vehicle for conveying accurate thoughts, which it is universally recognized to be, then the conclusion is inescapable: Paul is saying that *what he means by the riches of Christ and the mystery of Christ cannot be tracked out in any literature, particularly in the Old Testament.* The evidence he brings to bear on this point should be sufficient to convince even the skeptic who is vainly trying to find Body truth in the Old Testament.

Now let us look at some of the evidence pertaining to the absence of the riches of Christ and the mystery in the Old Testament, hence, the impossibility of tracking it out there. In Romans 16:25, Paul says that his gospel is "the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery *having been kept silent in times eternal*." In First Corinthians 2:7-8, Paul says, "We speak the wisdom of God in a mystery, *that which has been hidden away*, which no one of the rulers of this age knew. " In this same chapter, verse 5, Paul says that the mystery "*was not made known to the sons of men in other generations* as it has now been revealed." Also, in verse nine, he says, "the dispensation of the mystery *which had been hidden from the ages* in God." In Colossians 1:26, Paul speaks of "the mystery which *had been hidden from the ages and from the generations*, but now has been manifested to his saints." These citations should make it clear, the message Paul was preaching could not be searched or tracked out in the Old Testament, but it represented a *new revelation of truth for the Church.*

9. ***"and to enlighten all men regarding the dispensation of the mystery that has been hidden from the ages in God who has created all things,"***

Previously we observed that as a minister of the Gospel Paul's task was to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ, and now elaborating on this, he says, "and to enlighten all men regarding the dispensation of the mystery." The previous statement may have led us to think that he had a ministry limited to the Gentiles, but the

latter statement clarifies this, *his ministry was to all men*, to both Jews and Gentiles (Rom. 1:14-16; 9:3-4; 1 Cor. 9:12-22). What Paul says here certainly emphasizes the need to *universally proclaim* the Gospel of God's Grace to all men (Acts 20:20-24).

Paul's main thrust in this verse is to enlighten all men *regarding* the dispensation of the mystery. The meaning of this verse is clear in the Greek; however, it is difficult to bring this meaning over into an English translation without either adding or altering words. We have chosen to do the latter in our translation, replacing the more common translation *what* with the word *regarding*. If we had been disposed to adding words, we would have translated it, "to enlighten all men *as to what is* the dispensation of the mystery." The thought that Paul wants to get across to all men is "what" (τις) the dispensation of the mystery really is, i.e., *its nature, mode of operation,* and *its message*. Summarizing, Paul wants to focus the spotlight on the nature of the dispensation of the mystery *so that all men can clearly see its truth.*

Even though we quite thoroughly discussed the meaning of the Greek word translated "dispensation" (οικονομιαν) in verse two, where it was associated with the grace of God, it is still important that we deal with it here in conjunction with the word mystery. This word does not have inherent in it the concept of time, but *its meaning is enacted in time.* It basically means *a house-law*, hence, *the management, administration, arrangement,* and *economy* of a house. In actual usage the idea of house has tended to drop off in favor of the meaning *administration, dispensation, arrangement,* and *economy*.

The Truth which God has given for this present Church age is the mystery. This Truth covers the span of time from the beginning to the closing of the Church age. It determines *how* God *manages*, *administers*, and *governs* the affairs of His Church. The Truth of the mystery, which is the Truth for the Church, *controls* the present Church economy and gives a *pattern* for operation.

Having observed that the word "dispensation" (οικονομια) speaks of the *Divine arrangement, administration,* and *economy* by which God manages His Church today, and that *the Truth of the Mystery is the constitution which determines the nature of the Church economy,* an administration which operates on the basis of grace (v. 2), let us

consider the fact that this Mystery Church Truth was hidden prior to the time of the Apostle Paul. We already briefly dealt with this subject in verse eight, as it related to the untrackable riches of Christ, and in this verse we will examine it in the light of the immediate context.

Paul affirms that this Mystery "had been hidden from the ages in God." Since we have deduced that the phrase *Church Truth* is equivalent to the meaning of the word *Mystery* as generally used by Paul (v. 8), this means that the Truth regarding the Body of Christ had been hidden from all previous ages. The Greek participle translated "has been hidden" (αποκεκσυμμενου) is in the perfect tense and passive voice. It is derived from the words "απο" and "κσυπτω" which inverted mean to *hide from*, hence, *to hide away* or *conceal from sight.* The perfect tense denotes that at a given point of time in the past, when God sovereignly formulated His plan pertaining to the Church, He *began and continued* to keep the Truth regarding this plan hidden from all men in all the ages. The passive voice indicates that *God Himself* was the one who hid this Church Truth from former ages. To have revealed it to an earlier age, which was functioning under a different economy, such as the Law of Moses, would have produced intolerable confusion in the finite, imperfect minds of His people.

The separate use of the Greek preposition "απο" emphasizes that the Mystery was hidden *from, away from*, the ages. The Greek phrase translated "the ages" (των αιωνων) is in the plural and designates *a significant period of time, an era, a span of time when God deals with men in a specific manner,* or *unlimited time such as eternity.* In order to better understand the meaning of the word *ages* as used in this verse, let us consider some examples of its use in Paul's epistles. First, in the singular it is commonly referred to as *this age* (Rom. 12:2; 1 Cor. 1:20; 2:6, 8; 3:18; 2 Cor. 4:4). Second, in Galatians 1:4, it is spoken of as the *present evil age.* Third, it is called the *now age* three times (1 Tim. 6:17; 2 Tim. 4:10; Titus 2:12). Fourth, in Ephesians 1:21, it is used with reference to *this* and *the coming age* (cf. 2:7). Fifth, the Mystery was foreordained *before the ages, prior to the beginning of the ages*, to our glory (1 Cor. 2:7). Sixth, in verse 11, Paul speaks of the *purpose of the ages*. In summary, we see *the ages* in this verse referring to the distinct ages from the creation of

Adam and Eve up to the present Church age. During these periods, when God related to men in differing arrangements, *He never mentioned the Mystery Truth* for the Church.

The companion passage in Colossians 1:26, tends to substantiate the fact that these ages were different eras when men lived on the earth. In this verse Paul speaks of the Word of God as "the mystery that has been hidden from the ages and from the generations." The use of the word *generations* with the word *ages* argues in favor of interpreting the ages as *definite periods of time* when God related differently to men.

Having observed that the Mystery had been formulated (1 Cor. 2:7), and that it had been hidden, we logically raise the question, Where? Paul's answer is "in God who has created all things." An expanded translation of this phrase would be: "in the God, the particular God who has created all things." In view of the polytheism of his day, Paul wants it clearly understood that he is talking about the one and only God, the God of creation, when he says that the Mystery was hidden in Him. This is obviously a locative case which means that the Truth regarding the Church was *hid in the sphere of God*, in His mind, not to be divulged before His time (cf. Gal. 1:15-16; 4:4).

10. ***"that it might be made known now to the rulers and to the authorities in the heavenlies through the church the manifold wisdom of God."***

This verse begins with the Greek "ινα" clause which is commonly used to express *purpose*. A full rendering of it would be: "in order that it might be made known." What Paul has said in the preceding verses has been leading up to the fulfillment of this purpose. That which Paul wants to "make known" (ιγνωρισθη), *to give knowledge of,* and *to disclose* is "the manifold wisdom of God." The Greek word translated "manifold" (πολυποικιλος) comes from "πολυς" and "ποικιλος" which respectively mean *much* or *many and various colors, variegated,* and *diverse.* Combining these dual meanings we have the thought of *the many colored, much variegated,* and *highly diversified* wisdom of God. The Greek word rendered "wisdom" (σοφια) is used 27 times by Paul, and some 16 times it pertains to Truth for the Church. In this

verse it obviously refers to the Mystery, Truth which is made known through the Church in the heavenlies and is *broad in spectrum, consists of great variety,* and is *highly diversified.*

Now let us consider to whom this Truth is to be made known - "to the rulers and to the authorities in the heavenlies." Who are these rulers and authorities in the heavenly sphere? They are apparently the evil forces associated with Satan (cf. 2:2; 6:12; Col. 2:15). With a very definite purpose in mind, which is unexpressed, God wants to make known His manifold wisdom to the rulers and the authorities in the heavenlies. Since the purpose for His doing this is not stated, we suggest that it is *to show His superior wisdom to His enemies* who thought they had foiled His plan by enticing Israel to reject the Messianic Kingdom. After the King had been crucified and His Kingdom rejected, God raises Him from the dead, and *reveals the broad spectrum of His wisdom in the Mystery,* Christ's headship over both Jews and Gentiles in the Church.

It is interesting to note that the *agent through whom* this manifold wisdom is made known to the rulers and the authorities in the heavenlies is the Church. The use of the Greek preposition "δια" with the genitive case indicates that this knowledge is disseminated exclusively through the Church. We have no reason to think that the Truth of the Mystery, the manifold wisdom of God, was revealed to anyone else apart from the apostles and prophets through the Apostle Paul (cf. v. 5; Col. 1:26). This means that the broad spectrum of Mystery Truth regarding the Church, made known to men on earth, is the same Truth that is to penetrate into the heavenly sphere.

11. ***"according to the purpose of the ages which he made in Christ Jesus our Lord,"***

The truth in this verse revolves around the word "purpose" (προθεσιν). This noun is derived from the preposition "προ" and the verb "τιθημι" and literally means *to place beforehand* or *to set forth prior,* hence, as it projects out into the future time it conveys the idea of *purpose, plan,* and *scheme.* The use of the preposition "κατα" suggests that the making known of the manifold wisdom of God is *according to* the purpose, plan, and design of the ages. In other

words, the revealing of the variegated Truth of the Mystery was not a spur-of-the-moment decision on the part of God, but it was in conformity with His purpose and plan for all the ages. We need to keep in mind that this purpose *belonged to the ages*, as indicated by the genitive of possession, i.e., it was a comprehensive plan of which the programs in the separate ages were a part. God's purpose and plan for this particular age is the Mystery, the Church.

Paul has a great deal to say about God's purpose (προθεσιν). In Romans 8:28, he speaks of those who are being *called* according to God's sovereign purpose. This includes the whole gamut from being foreknown to ultimate glorification with Christ. In Romans 9:11, Paul informs us that the purpose of God is accomplished according to *Divine election*. God gives His elect faith by which they become identified with Jesus Christ as Saviour. In the epistle before us, Ephesians 1:11, we are told that we have been *foreordained* according to the purpose of God who does all things according to His will. In Second Timothy 1:9, Paul says that God has *called and saved us* according to His own purpose and grace. The above passages give us some insight into how God is sovereignly effecting His purpose of Grace today. God's purpose in this Church age operates totally according to *the principles of Grace*.

We are told that God's purpose of the ages, as it relates to this present age, has been accomplished "in Christ Jesus our Lord." As we look at God's purpose involving the Church we are forced to recognize that its existence *totally depends upon Christ*. Those who are its members were chosen in Christ before the world was created (1:4). We were foreordained to the *position of sons* through Christ (1:5). God's glorious *grace was extended to us* in Christ (1:6). We have been made *heirs* in Christ (1:11). We have been sealed by the Holy Spirit in Christ (1:13). God placed Christ in the position as *Head over the Church* (1:22). We have been *made alive, raised,* and *seated* with Christ in the heavenlies (2:5-6). We have been *created in Christ* for good works (2:10). The *Gentiles have been brought near* by the blood of Christ (2:13). Through Christ's substitutionary death the Gentiles have been made *fellow-citizens and members of God's family* with the Jews (2:16-19). The above are only a few examples of the fact that God's Church purpose is wrought in Christ.

12. ***"in whom we have the boldness and access in confidence through his faithfulness."***

In this verse Paul is dealing with *how* we become a part of God's purpose of the ages, the Church. In the previous verse we looked at some of the things God did in effecting His purpose in Christ. In this verse Paul adds that in Christ "we have the boldness and access in confidence." As one considers the Truth of the Mystery, and the *glorious Church it portrays*, in which one occupies an *in-Christ relationship*, he might well consider himself utterly unworthy of becoming a member of it. In view of this Paul declares, I can understand your sense of unworthiness, but keep in mind, it is *in Christ* that we have the boldness to come. The Greek word translated "boldness" (παρρμσιαν) conveys the idea of *liberty in speaking, plain speaking,* and *bold speaking.*

Paul knew what the Grace of God *had provided* for him in Christ, he knew that he was one who *had been chosen* before the foundation of the world in Christ, he knew that he *had been redeemed* through the blood of Christ and *forgiven* according to the riches of God's grace. With such knowledge, for Paul to have approached the Body of Christ, the Church, with apprehension would have been a denial of the Grace of God, it would have been diffidence where there should have been boldness to appropriate what God had given to him in Christ. We who take literally what the Scriptures say about the sovereignty of God in salvation gratefully, but boldly, occupy our Grace-given position in the Body of Christ.

Not only do we have boldness in Christ to approach our position in the Church, but we also have "access in confidence." The Greek word translated "access" (προσαγωγην) is derived from the words "προς" and "αγω" and basically means to *lead to, conduct to,* and *bring to.* This word is used three times in the New Testament, all by the Apostle Paul, and it appears to me that in each case it conveys the idea of entrance into the presence of, hence, the translation of entry. In Romans 5:2, Paul says of Christ, "through whom we have the access [entry] in one Spirit to the Father." Through the sovereign Grace of God we are *brought into the Body, have entry* into the Church, which is God's purpose for today. Furthermore, we

have this entry "in confidence" (πεποιθησει). This word carries the idea of being *fully persuaded*, hence, it speaks of an *entrance with assurance, confidence,* and *trust* based on the perfect sacrificial work of Jesus Christ.

Having observed that a *knowledge* of God's sovereign working in salvation is the prerequisite for boldness and confident entry into the Body of Christ, we need to recognize that the epitome of God's purpose is based upon the *faithfulness of Jesus Christ*. The Greek phrase which we have translated "through his faithfulness" (δια της πιστεως συτου) cannot justifiably be rendered otherwise in this context. The first reason many have mistranslated this phrase is because they fail to understand the *breadth* of the meaning of the word "πτστεως." True, as this word is used in the New Testament, its most common meaning is accurately expressed by the English word faith. On the other hand, it is frequently used with a meaning which is equivalent to the English word *faithfulness* (cf. Matt. 23:23; Rom. 3:3, 22, 26; Gal. 2:16; 3:22; 5:22; Eph. 3:12; Col. 2:12; 1 Tim. 4:12; 6:11; 2 Tim. 2:22; Titus 2:10; Phile. 1:5). This is not intended to be a complete list of references where the Greek word "πιοτις" means faithfulness. Also, there are many *betwixt* passages where it is not easy to ascertain which English word most accurately conveys the intended Greek thought.

The second reason many have mistranslated this and other verses in which "πιστις" is used is because they often tend to be addicted to following prior translations more than the original Greek text. The *number* of versions which mistranslate this word in this and other passages is *inconsequential*, for as followers they may be merely handing down the thought of one person. We cannot determine the correct translation of a verse by counting how the majority of versions translate it; nor can we determine the value and accuracy of manuscripts by counting and weighing them.

Third, the King James version and Young's Literal Translation of the Bible both endeavor to follow what the Greek grammar says in this twelfth verse. They translate this Greek phrase "by the faith of him" whereas we have translated it "through his faithfulness." They substitute the preposition *by* for the preposition *through* (δια),

which does not greatly alter the meaning, and they use the word *faith* instead of the word *faithfulness* which may have tended to verge on the meaning of the latter at that time in the history of the English language.

The literal meaning of this verse is that we have boldness and confident entry into God's purpose for today, the Church, *through the agency of the faithfulness of Him,* or as we have translated it above, *through His faithfulness*. As we have said before, the preposition "δια" with the genitive case focuses our attention on the *agent through which something is accomplished*, and is generally translated with the English word "through." The reflexive pronoun "αυτου" in the genitive case has as its antecedent Jesus Christ (v. 11) which may be translated either *his* or *of him*. Summarizing, sticking with the most literal English equivalents and the grammatical construction we have no choice but to translate this phrase *through his faithfulness*. On the basis of the perfectly faithful life of Jesus, which *culminated in His sacrificial death*, we have boldness in Him and confident access into our Grace-given position in the Body, the Church.

13. ***"Wherefore I ask that you not become weary in my tribulations on your behalf, which are your glory."***

The Greek word translated "wherefore" (διο) comes from the preposition "δια" and the relative pronoun "ο." These combined literally mean *on account of which, because of;* or *therefore*. The implication is that Paul was undergoing affliction, which he was, for he was in prison in Rome, but he does not want them to become discouraged on account of this.

Not wanting them to empathetically suffer any emotional trauma because of his imprisonment, Paul says, on account of this "I ask that you not become weary in my tribulations." The verb rendered "I ask" (αιτουμαι) is in the present tense and suggests that Paul continued *requesting, petitioning,* and *soliciting*. Since this verb is commonly used to express requests to God (v. 20; Col. 1;9), our primary interpretation is that he was *asking God* not to let them become weary, and secondarily, he was also asking them not to become

weary. We see here a *joining* of the energizing of God and the cooperation of the believer, synchronizing together in the accomplishment of the will of God.

The Greek word translated "weary" (εγκακειν) is derived from " εν" and "κακεω," and literally means a *bad inner condition*, hence, *to faint, lose heart,* and *become unstrung.* Paul uses this word twice with reference to himself; he did not lose heart and become weary in his ministry (2 Cor. 4:1), and even though this outer man was wasting away, *he did not faint*, for his inner man was being renewed daily (2 Cor. 4:16). In writing to the Galatians and Thessalonians, he uses this verb to encourage them *not to* become weary in doing that which is good (Gal. 6:9; 2 Thess. 3:13).

Paul's concern is that these believers not lose heart in his tribulations, which in the first person singular is "in my tribulations" (εν ταις θλιψεσιν μου). This may be more fully translated "in the tribulations of mine." The article tends to emphasize that Paul had *many separate* "tribulations" (θλιψεσιν), *pressures* resting on him, *distressing situations,* and *afflictions* hurled at him. If we interpret the case used here as locative, then Paul is saying, I do not want you to lose heart *in the sphere* of my many afflictions, or, if we interpret the case as instrumental, Paul is saying, I do not want you to lose heart *by means of* my afflictions. In either case that which would cause them to lose heart would be *identification* with his afflictions or as a *result* of his afflictions.

Many people undoubtedly were willing to identify with the Apostle Paul when things were going good, when numbers were being converted through his ministry, but as he was increasingly afflicted and thrown into prison, their allegiance to him waned (2 Tim. 1:15). On the other hand, the fact that Paul was afflicted, engulfed in tribulations, and imprisoned would cause some superficial believers to look at him as an evil doer and to desert him (2 Tim. 4:16.)

Paul reminds those to whom he is writing why he is suffering when he says, "my tribulations on your behalf." He made it crystal clear in His epistles that the reason he is in prison is due to his faithful proclamation of the Mystery, the special Truth revealed to him for

the Church (Eph. 6:19-20; Col. 4:3; 2 Tim. 2:9). Most of those to whom this encyclical epistle was written were apparently gentiles converts, those who had the privilege of being members of Christ *on the basis of the Truth of the Mystery* (vv.4-6)

With regard to his tribulations, which he suffered on behalf of thorn he is writing, Paul says, "which is your glory." In Colossians 1:27, Paul says that the rich glory of the Mystery among "is Christ in you, the hope of glory." All that we know about the present and future glory which belongs to members of the Body of Christ has been revealed to us as a part of the Mystery Truth for the Church. The ultimate end of God's revealed purpose for beliers is *mutual glorification with Christ* (Rom. 8:28-30; Phil. 3:20-21). Finally, in Colossians 3:4, Paul says "whenever may be manifested, your life, then also you with him shall be manifested in glory."

14. ***"For this cause I bow my knees toward the Father,"***

The Greek phrase translated "for this cause" (τουτου χαριν) consists of the demonstrative pronoun "τουτου" in the genitive case and "χαριν." In actual usage it conveys the meaning of *for this reason* or *on account of this.* It refers back to the all-important Truth of the Mystery, the manifold wisdom of God, which in this present Church age is being effected in Jesus Christ. What Paul has just got through saying is the *cause* or *reason* why he is about to pray.

Now let us consider the meaning of the phrase, "I bow my knees." Paul uses the Greek verb translated "bow" (καμπτω) three other times in his epistles. Twice it is used in quotations from The Old Testament where it has the significance of *submission to authority* (Rom. 11:4; 14:11). In Philippians 2:10-11, its primary meaning is submission to authority, and its secondary meaning is confessing to the lordship of Jesus Christ (cf. last part of Rom. 14:11). The context surrounding its use in this verse makes it evident that Paul's bowing his knees is both *submission to the Father's authority* and *praying* for those to whom he is writing (cf. Acts 20:36.)

It is very important to observe that Paul addressed his prayers “toward the Father." The Greek preposition translated "toward" (προς), when used with the accusative case as here, has the basic dea of *motion toward*, but as one comes toward he occupies a position *in the presence of, in the sight of,* and *before*. Al of these could be acceptable translations. There are no in-between mediators, such as angels or Mary, but as believers we have the *privilege of being in the very presence of God the Father* as we talk w ith Him in prayer.

There is no biblical justification for praying to anyone except *God the Father.* Paul consistently addressed all prayer to God the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ (1 Cor. 1:4; 11:13; Col. 1:3; 3:17; 4:3; Phil. 1:3). Prayer is to be *in the Holy Spirit* (Rom. 8:26-27; Eph. 6:18). Prayer should be *through* (δια) Jesus Christ (Rom. 1:8; 7:25; Col. 3:17). Some manuscripts add the words "of our Lord Jesus Christ" to this verse, which do not change the basic meaning.

15. ***"out of whom every family in the heavens and upon the earth is named,"***

The contents of this verse are in apposition with the noun "Father" (πατερα) in the preceding verse. The Father to whom Paul prayed is the *origin* of every living being both in the heavens and upon the earth. The Greek phrase translated "out of whom" (εξ ου) is in the ablative case, and means that God the Father is the source *out of which* and *from which* every family has originated. Paul leaves absolutely *no room* for any group of living creatures to have their origin in anything or anyone else than God. The thought of Darwin's evolutionary theory would have been *utterly asinine* to him. He operated according to *observable facts* and not fiction (Rom. 1:19-20).

Now let us look more closely at the Greek word translated "family" (πατρια). This is the only time Paul uses this word in his epistles. It is used, however, in Luke 2:4, where Joseph is described as being of the *family* (πατριας) of David, and it is used in Acts 3:25, in an Old Testament quotation, to describe how all the *families* (πατριαι) of the earth will be blessed in Abraham's wed, Christ (Gen. 12:1-3).

This word is frequently used in the Septuagint, where it has the same meaning. We interpret Paul's use of the word family in this verse to be broad enough to include the angelic beings, rulers, and authorities in the heavenlies (3:10; 6:12), and all the different races of mankind upon the earth (Acts 17:26). We would also suggest that it may be Paul's intent to include all the species of living beings in the universe in the word "family" (πατρια).

The Greek verb translated "is named" (ονομαζεται) may be rendered is *called, described,* or *designated*. We interpret that Paul's use of this verb is broad enough to comprehend the concept of *creation*. The main emphasis of the verse is on the fact that God is *the source* of every family, not merely the one who named them. In fact, according to the Genesis record the creating was the work of God and the naming the responsibility of man (Gen. 2:19).

16. ***"that he might give you according to the riches of his glory, to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in the inner man,"***

Here Paul uses the Greek conjunction "ινα" with the subjunctive mode to clearly set forth the *purpose* of his prayer. He is praying in order that the Father might "give" (δω), *grant, supply*, and *bestow* upon them increased power. His prayer is that God might do this "according to the riches of his glory." The Greek preposition rendered "according to" (κατα) means *in keeping with, conforming to,* and *in proportion to* the riches of His glory. For Paul to ask God to give them power according to the riches of His glory appears to be tantamount to praying that He would make available to them His *boundless power*. In Romans 9:23-24, we see God making known the riches of His glory on His previously chosen elect, both Jews and Gentiles. In Philippians 4:19, Paul tells those who have faithfully supported the gospel that "my God shall supply your every need according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus."

The crux of Paul's prayer is that they might be "strengthened with power through his Spirit." The Greek word translated "to be strengthened" (κραταιωθηναι) is an aorist passive infinitive. The aorist tense indicates that he was praying that God would strengthen

them at *that point in time*, and the passive voice makes it obvious that *God is the one who bestows this strength*. That with which they need to be strengthened is *power* (δυναμει). This word has the basic idea of *ability*, the quality of *being able*, and is transliterated into English as *dynamite*. As Paul combines the meaning of the above infinitive with this noun, he is praying that God will *strengthen them with greater ability and empower them so they will be more able* in the inner man. This is the only time Paul combines these two words which have similar meanings.

We observe that God strengthens the ability of His people in the inner man through the Holy Spirit. The Greek preposition "δια" used with the genitive case, as here, clearly points to the Spirit as the *agent* through whom God the Father increases and strengthens the believer's inner-man ability. In this present Church age God energizes His power in believers through the Holy Spirit as is evident in Paul's Epistles (Rom. 15:13, 19; 1 Cor. 2:4; 1 Thess. 1:5; 2 Tim. 1:7, 14). During this signless dispensation of grace, the Holy Spirit quietly but powerfully works in believers to produce the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22-23).

Paul's prayer is that God through the Spirit might strengthen their ability and capacity "in the inner man." The Greek word for "inner" (εσω) speaks of the *inside, internal*, and *interior* man. In Rom. 7:22, Paul uses this adverb when he says, "For I delight in the law of God according to the inner [εσω] man." Here its meaning seems to be nearly synonymous with the English word *mind*. In second Corinthians 4:16, Paul says, "our inner man [εσω] is being renewed day by day." In light of the immediate context this refers to both Paul's *mental and emotional state*. It appears to me that the inner man is probably best defined as the believer's *internal spirit, the spirit of man,* the inclusive residence of the Holy Spirit, the total person (1 Cor. 2:11, 15).

17. ***"that Christ may dwell through faith in your hearts, in love having been rooted and having been grounded,"***

In picking up the flow from verse 16, Paul's prayer is that through the Spirit they might have spiritual ability in the inner man *to the end* that

Christ may dwell in their hearts. Paul is setting forth here a series of steps which they need to climb, energized by the Holy Spirit, as they move toward the spiritual goal God has for then. To be strengthened with power in the inner man is the first steλ toward Christ dwelling in them. The Greek infinitive translatei "dwell" (κατοικησαι) is derived from "κατα" and "οικεω" and literally means *to live down*, hence, *to inhabit, occupy, and live in* their hearts.

What does Paul mean by the statement, "that Christ may dwell through faith in your hearts"? The context apparently makes the phrase "in the inner man" equivalent with the phrase "in your hearts." Through the Holy Spirit Christ *lives in their human spirits*, occupying their mental and emotion-beings. This is apparently comparable with what Paul says in Colossians 3:16, "Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly." The Word is to *live in the mind.*

Having observed that Paul is praying that Christ may live in the sphere of their hearts and minds, he now turns his attention to *how* this takes place. He says, "that Christ may dwell through faith in your hearts." In the Greek the preposition "δια" with the genitive case gives us a clear answer as to how this is effected, namely, *through the agency of faith.* There are two possible interpretations of the noun "faith" (πιστεως) as used here. First, it is knowing that something exists even though it is not seen. It is an unseen reality based upon the projected truth of the Word of God. In Hebrews 11:1, we read, "Faith gives *substance* to things being hoped for, of things not being seen it is the *evidence*." According to this interpretation faith *makes real* the fact that Christ inhabits our hearts through the Holy Spirit.

Second, the noun "faith" (πιστεως) may be interpreted as *a body of truth,* the truth revealed for the Church. The fact that the Greek article precedes the word "faith" (της πιστεως) tends to add credibility to this interpretation. Following this interpretation, Paul is saying, "that Christ may dwell through the truth in your hearts," i.e., through a knowledge and perception of the truth His indwelling may be realized. In view of the following emphasis on intellectual comprehension, this interpretation becomes more feasible, but our preference favors the first one. We must keep in mind that the first interpretation, if it is

going to have a knowledgeable basis, must rest upon the truth pertaining to the fact that Christ does indwell believers, otherwise it would be unwarranted faith.

As Paul continues to pray, he desires that those "in love having-been-rooted and having-been-grounded" ones, may have insight into the four dimensional love of Christ. The Greek phrase rendered "in love" (εν αγαπη) is in the locative case, and indicates what these believers have been rooted and grounded in, namely *the sphere of love* (Rom. 12:10; 1 Cor. 13:13). The perfect passive participle translated "having been rooted" (ερριζωμενοι) means that at a given point of time in the past *they were rooted* and that these roots *continued solid* in Divine soil. The passive voice indicates that they were *rooted by one other than themselves*, by God.

Paul also refers to these believers as those "in love ... having been grounded." This too is a perfect passive participle (τεθεμελιωμενοι), and it literally means that they were *laid like a foundation,* hence, *foundationed, established,* and *made firm* in the sphere of love. As indicated by the passive voice, God is the one ιiho had sovereignly foundationed them in the location characterized by love, the Body of Christ (1 Cor. 12:25-26; Eph. 4:15-16). We see this as having taken place when God chose all believers in Christ hefore the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4), and consummated it in the process of history when the Holy Spirit called those chosen to their position in the Body of Christ, the Church (Rom. 8:30).

18. ***"that you may be fully able to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth,"***

As back in verse 16, again we have the Greek conjunction "ινα" used with the subjunctive mode to express *purpose*. Mainning the flow of the context, Paul is saying, that Christ may live in your hearts through faith as those who have been rooted and grounded in love ones, "that you may be fully able to comprehend with all the saints" how comprehensive love is. The Greek verb translated "fully able" (εξισχυσητε) is derived from "εξ" and "ισχυω" and

means that you may be *very strong, highly capable,* and *abundantly able* to comprehend all the ramifications of what Paul is speaking about in the next verse.

The Greek infinitive translated "comprehend" (κατακαβεσθαι) is a compound word from "κατα" and "λαμβανω" and literally means *to take or hold down,* hence, Paul is praying that they may be highly capable of *intellectually grasping, of mentally laying hold of,* and *understanding* with all the saints the fourfold aspects of the love of Christ. He describes love as a *vast quadrangle* with breadth, length, height, and depth. The statement, "that you may be fully able to comprehend with all the saints" leaves no room for spiritual infants in the Body of Christ. Those to whom Paul was writing in this encyclical epistle together with all other saints are to abundantly be able to comprehend the limitless love of Christ.

19. ***"to know the love of Christ surpassing knowledge, that you may be filled unto all the fulness of God."***

Having carefully examined the grammatical construction of both verses 18 and 19, it is our conviction that verse 19 bears an *appositive relation* to verse 18. The first part of it is *explaining* what the breadth, length, height, and depth is, and it is not adding an additional thought. Following the Greek infinitive translated "to know" (γνωναι) we have the Greek particle "τε," which some have translated by the English word *and*. Paul uses this particle the vast majority of the time with the idea of *both*. Sometimes he uses it with the Greek conjunction translated for (γαρ), and in such cases its significance is obscure. A few times it is used in contexts where it seemingly could be translated as a weak English *and* or not even translated. In this verse we have preferred to leave it untranslated; however, underneath it could insignificantly convey the thought of both the first and last parts of this verse or of a slight *and*.

The Greek infinitive used in this verse, which is translated "to know" (γνωναι), may also be rendered *to perceive, ascertain,* or *be cognizant*. It is broad enough to include knowledge which is gained through both intellectual and experiential pursuits (Phil. 3:10). Knowledge which God has revealed in His Word for the Church is

the *premise* upon which our concept of the Church is built. We cannot overemphasize the importance of accurately comprehending this knowledge, but at the same time we must cooperate with the Holy Spirit who *fuses it into our daily experiences* (Phil. 2:12-13).

That which Paul wants them to know, both on the basis of revelation and experience, is "the love of Christ surpassing knowledge." This may also be rendered "the *surpassing--knowledge* love of Christ." The phrase surpassing-knowledge is adjectival; it defines and describes the love of Christ. It is a love which "surpasses" (υπερβαλλουσαν), that *casts out beyond*, that *overshoots*, and *transcends* knowledge. Revealed knowledge gives us insight into this love, but the love itself projects out beyond the insight.

Paul is speaking about a *particular love* in this verse, a surpassing-knowledge love, but even more significant, it is "the love of Christ," i.e., the love which *belongs to Christ, the love which He owns and possesses.* Paul commonly refers to the love of Christ in his epistles. In Romans 8:35, he raises the question, "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?" In the 39th verse, he refers to this love as "the love of God in Christ Jesus." In Second Corinthians 5:14, Paul writes, "The love of Christ constrains us." Paul knew what the Spirit had revealed unto him regarding the love of Christ, but beyond this, he knew the constraining, motivating power of this love which propelled him to tirelessly make the Gospel of the Grace of God known (Acts 20:18-20, 24; Rom. 1:14-16).

The ultimate purpose of Paul's prayer was that those to whom he was writing "may be filled unto all the fulness of God." At this point let us review the series of steps which have led up to this final purpose. First, Paul prayed that they might be *strengthened with power* through the Spirit in the inner man. Second, following the former, Paul's prayer was for the indwelling presence of Christ, through faith, in their hearts. Third, he prays that they may be super-able to comprehend the four dimensional love of Christ. Fourth, as an outgrowth of the above, and in apposition with it, he ηrays that they may know the surpassing-knowledge love of

Christ. Fifth, the ultimate end or purpose of this prayer is that they "may be filled unto all the fulness of God."

The Greek noun translated "fulness" (πληρωμα) may convey v he idea of *that which fills up, full development,* or *completeness*. It appears to us that Paul has given this word a *proper meaning* in several contexts in his Prison Epistles. After we have observed how it is used in these contexts, we will on the basis thereof, endeavor to draw some conclusions. In the first chapter, verse 23, speaking of the headship of Christ over the Church, Paul says, "which is his body, the fulness [πληρωμα] of the one filling all things in all." Here we observe that *the Church is the fulness of God* per se. In the verse before us (19), Paul prays that they "may be filled unto all the fulness of God." The use of the preposition "εις" with the accusative case suggests that this filling is *unto the end* of all the fulness of God. This speaks of believers being *perfectly identified with* the fulness of God, which is Christ's Body, the Church.

In speaking of the gifts given for the building up of the Body of Christ, Paul says in 4:13, "until we all attain unto the unity of the faith and the perfect knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto a measure of the stature of the fulness [πληρωματος] of Christ." It appears that the fulness of Christ pertains to His Body in this context, and as such, it would be equivalent to the fulness of God in 1:23. Paul's goal for believers is *consummate identification* with the fulness of Christ.

In Colossians 1:19, speaking of Christ, Paul says, "Because in him he [God] was pleased all the fulness [πληρωμα] to dwell." We have already observed that the Church is God's fulness (1:23), which is the Body of Christ, and here we note that *Christ Himself is indwelt with God's fulness.* At times, the relation between Christ and His Body seems to almost defy distinction, but we must not forget His position as Head (Col. 1:18) and corner-foundation stone (2:20).

Finally, in Colossians 2:9, Paul says that in Christ "dwells all the fulness of the Godhead bodily." The use of the present tense indicates that this is Christ's present status at the right hand of

God. As the Son of God, in resurrection body form, the fulness (πληρωμα) of God the Father and God the Holy Spirit dwell or exist in Him. God is *one in essence*, joined in fulness, and distinguishable in persons. This fulness characterizes each person of the Godhead individually and jointly in Christ.

Summarizing, we observe that the fulness (πληρωμα) of Deity *dwells in Christ and His Church* in this present dispensation of grace. God's total purpose, since the Mosaic Law was fulfilled at Calvary and the Messianic Kingdom was rejected (Acts 7:58-59), is *centered in Christ and His Church*. The person who looks for the fulness of God in the Old Testament Law during this Church age, *will find only emptiness*. The person who expects to find the fulness of God by endeavoring to keep the legalistic precepts of the Messianic Kingdom, during this Church age, *will find only frustration and emptiness.* There is only one place to find the fulness of God today and that is *in the Body of Christ, the Church*. Paul's prayer is that we as believers may be filled unto the end of having all the fulness of God. The use of the passive voice makes it clear that God is *the one who fills us* with this fulness which resides *in Christ and His Church*.

20. ***"And to the one able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think according to the power energizing in us,"***

As Paul moves toward the end of his prayer on behalf of those to whom he is writing, he addresses God the Father as the one who is able to do exceeding abundantly above all which we ask or think. The Greek phrase translated "to the one able" (τω δυναμενω) may also be rendered *to the one with power* or *to the one with ability.* In his address Paul acknowledges God's unlimited power and ability to answer prayers. The Greek word for *now* (νυν) is not in the Greek text; therefore, it is not in our translation.

In contrast to the powerless idols of his day, Paul is praying to ¯he God of Abraham and his seed, who had revealed his power on behalf of Israel for some 1800 years. Paul knew through the ¯

istorical record of the Old Testament, through Divine revelation, and through experience that his God was able "to do" (ποιησαι), *to make, accomplish,* and *effect* that which was far beyond the con::ptive range of the human mind.

The language Paul uses here emphasizes God's ability to *superabundantly* (υπερεκπερισσου) *go out beyond* (υπερ) all things hich we believers *ask, request,* and *desire* (αιτουμεθα) or even *think* and *conceive* (νοουμεν) in our minds. Boiling this down, Paul is saying, My God has *unlimited power*. Having said this, he adds the qualifying statement, "according to his power energizing in " This means that God's activity on our behalf is *in keeping with* and *conforms to* (κατα) the particular power *energizing and workin*g in us (ενεργουμενην). Nothing is said as to whether God Himself or believers qualify the extent to which the Holy Spirit seizes His power in us. It may be according to *His sovereign will*, or according to our *cooperation with the Spirit.*

21. ***"to whom be the glory in the church and in Christ Jesus unto all the generations forever and ever."***

We need to keep in mind that this is the closing part of a prayer which Paul began back in verse 14. In verse 20, he shared with us some information regarding the greatness of the God to whom he is praying, that He is one who is "able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think." Out of a heart full of gratitude to his mighty God, Paul says, "To whom be the glory in the church and in Christ Jesus." The Greek noun translated "glory" (δοξα) seems to express the idea of *the highest imaginable virtue and excellence*. It is to ascribe to God *praise, honor, dignity*, and the *acme of respect.* Paul frequently uses this word in this same manner in his epistles (Rom. 11:36; 16:27; 2 Tim 4:18).

Now let us consider that this expression of glory to God is "in the church and in Christ Jesus." The use of the locative case here indicates that this glory is *in the sphere of the Church*, it centers in the Church through which God is dealing with His people in this present age of grace. Also, this glory is in the sphere of Christ Jesus. It is impossible to have this glory in the Church without also

being in Christ, for the Church is His Body, over which He is the Head. Paul speaks of the Body of Christ as being a glorious church (5:27; cf. 1 Thess. 2:12). God has soveтeignly placed the elect in the Church, that as those who constitute the Church, we may be to the "praise of his glory" (1:12, 14). As those who are members of the Body of Christ, the Church, we are to do "all things unto the glory of God" (1 Cor. 10:31; cf. Phil. 1:11).

As Paul looks out into the future, it is his prayer that glory may be to God "unto all the generations forever and ever." The phrase "unto all the generations" (εις πασας τας γενεας) is in the plural, and literally means generation after generation without end. The Greek phrase translated "forever and ever" (του αιωνος των αιωνων) may be literally rendered "of the age of the ages." The thought is that Paul wants God to have the glory extending unto all the generations which belong to the age of the ages, or more briefly stated, *unto all generations of eternity*.

Chapter 4

1. ***"I therefore, the prisoner in the Lord, exhort you to walk worthily of the calling with which you were called,"***

The Greek particle translated "therefore" (ουν) suggests that as a consequence of what Paul has said in the previous chapters they are to walk worthily of their calling. Thus far in this epistle Paul's main burden has been to explain to them how God has sovereignly ;aved them by grace, how He has made Christ the Head of the Church, how the Gentiles have also been made members of the Body of Christ, and how this truth was revealed unto him through the Mystery. This is foundational knowledge, basic doctrinal truth, which is essential for living pleasing to God in this Church age.

As the one who is writing to them, Paul describes himself as the prisoner in the Lord." The Greek word for "prisoner" (δεσμιος) basically means one who is *bound, tied* with a chain, or *confined*. Four times chains are mentioned in connection with Paul's being bound and imprisoned (Acts 21:33; 28:20; Eph. 6:20; 2 Tim. 1:16). The evidence indicates that he was in prison in *Rome* at this time (Phil. 1:13). In this verse he refers to himself as being a prisoner "in the Lord" (εν κυριω), which means *in the sphere of* the Lord or as a result of his activity which *centered in the Lord*. This is the only time he speaks of himself as being a prisoner *in the Lord*. Generally, he calls himself a prisoner "of Christ Jesus" (3:1; Phile. 1, 9; cf. 2 Tim. 1:8). The underlying reason he was a prisoner as *the message which he preached*, the Mystery, the Truth for the hurch (6:19-20; Col. 4:3-4; 2 Tim. 2:9).

The Truth which Paul has written in the first three chapters of this epistle, the Mystery, is a message which the devil and all those involved in legalism hate. Why such hatred of this Mystery Truth? - the answer is very clear - it is a special revelation of Truth exaining *how God is relating to His people in this age of grace* through the Church over which Christ is Head. This special revelation of Truth given through the Apostle Paul is God's right-on-target message for the present dispensation of the grace of God (Eph. 3:2). Even though the enemies of the Gospel of the Grace of God tried to stop

Paul's mouth from proclaiming this new revelation of Church Truth by bringing about his imprisonment, they utterly failed, for in these first three chapters *he boldly makes it known in permanent written form* (Acts 21:27-31; 23:12-13; 25:2-3).

Having laid a solid doctrinal basis, the premise on which the Truth for the Church rests, Paul has put these believers in a position *to know the mind and will of God* for this present Church age. Because they know what God has done for them, because they know that they have been blessed with all spiritual blessings in the heavenlies in Christ (1:3), and because they have been given the privilege of being members of Christ's Body, now they are "to walk worthily of the calling with which" they were called.

What does Paul mean by the phrase, "the calling with which you were called"? He uses this noun some ten times (κλησεως); nine times it refers to a *divine call* and once to an occupational call (1 Cor. 7:20). It speaks of God's sovereign call, at the apropos time in history, *when He leads those* whom He has chosen in Christ before the creation of the world to a position of justification and ultimate glory (1:4; Rom. 8:30). This call is refered to as a *high calling* (Phil. 3:14), *holy calling* (2 Tim. 1:9), and a *heavenly calling* (Heb. 3:1).

Paul's joint use of the verb form of this noun aids in substantiating its correct meaning. The passive voice indicates that they were *called by God* (Rom. 8:30; 9:24) and the aorist tense signifies that this took place at a *given point in time in the past* (Col. 3:15; 1 Tim. 6:12). The Holy Spirit is the one who *effects this call* at the appropriate time (1 Cor. 12:3).

As he writes to these elect, called members of the Body of Christ, Paul encourages them to "walk worthily" (αξιως περιπατησαι), i.e., *to live in keeping with, in a manner becoming*, and *in a manner which corresponds to* their holy calling. In Philippians 1:27, Paul exhorts believers to conduct themselves *worthily of the Gospel of Christ*. In Colossians 1:10, Paul is praying that they may walk *worthily of the Lord* pleasing Him in everything.

2. ***"with all humility and meekness, with longsuffering, upholding one another in love,"***

To live worthily of our high calling involves doing those "good works which God has previously prepared" for the purpose that we might live in the sphere of them (2:10). Paul begins setting forth some of these good works in this verse, which involve both *subjective attitudes* and *objective doing*. The fact that Paul mentions three different mental attitudes as prerequisites to their mutually aiding one another gives us insight into what he considered priorities. Our thinking and attitudes must be in alignment with the Word of God for the Church before our doing and works will be acceptable to God.

First, Paul exhorts them to be believers who are "with all humility" upholding each other in love. The Greek word translated "humility" (ταπεινοφροσυνης) comes from a combining of "ταπεινος" and "φρην" and literally means a *low, poor, humble*, and *modest mind-set, mind,* or *frame of thought.* In actual usage it may well be rendered *humble-minded* or *modest-minded*. In Acts 20:19, Paul uses this word in speaking to the Ephesian elders when he says that while he was with them he was "serving the Lord with all humble-mindedness and tears." In Philippians 2:3, we have a context which helps pinpoint the meaning of this word where Paul says, "in humble-mindedness counting each other above yourselves." In Colossians 3:12, Paul instructs believers to put on "humble-mindedness, meekness, longsuffering," the same three characteristics we have in this second verse. It is interesting that Paul uses this word six out of the seven times it is used in the New Testament. This emphasizes his antipathy to pride and haughtiness.

Second, Paul exhorts them to have "meekness" in their spholding of one another. The Greek word rendered "meekness" (πραυτητος) may also be translated *mildness, gentleness*, and possibly *kindness*. Out of the eleven times it appears in the New Testament it is used eight times by Paul, twice by James, and once by Peter, emphasizing the importance of this attitude to him. We will cite several passages in which it is used to more accurately observe its meaning. In Second Corinthians 10:1, Paul says, "I encourage you

through the meekness and gentleness of Christ." This erse indicates that this is one of the characteristics of Christ. According to Galatians 5:23, this is one of the fruits the Spirit. In Galatians 6:1, Paul advises that disciplining be done in a spirit of meekness (cf. 2 Tim. 2:25). Paul tells Titus to "show all meekness toward all men" (Tit. 3:2). In the classical Greek this word may also have the idea *softness*, a soft touch, and in the Septuagint it has the opposite meaning of "χαλεπος", which means hard, rugged, or furious, hence, *soft, mild,* and *lenient*.

Third, Paul exhorts them to possess "longsuffering" in their upholding of each other in love. The Greek word translated "longsuffering" (μακροθυμιας) is derived from "μακρος" and "θυμος" and basically means *a long time in becoming angry* or *slow to become angry*, hence, *patient endurance, patience,* and *forbearance.* Out of the fourteen times this word appears in the New Testament it is used eleven times by Paul, once by James, and twice by Peter. Again we observe, Paul did not want believers losing their cool nor easily angered. According to Galatians 5:22, this is one of the fruits of the Spirit. In Colossians 1:11, Paul prays that they may be empowered "unto all endurance and longsuffering." In First Timothy 1:16, this word is used to describe Christ's longsuffering toward sinners.

Thus we observe, with an attitude of humility, meekness, and longsuffering they are to be "upholding one another in love." The Greek word for "upholding" (ανεχομενοι) consists of the preposition "ανα" prefixed to the verb "εχω," which literally means *to have or hold up, to sustain,* or *to support*. Since the nominative present participle is used here, Paul is really saying, *you are to be ones who are continuously holding up one another in love.* The Greek phrase rendered "in love" (εν αγαπη) means that this mutual holding up of one another is to be *in the sphere of love*, it is to be *encircled with love*, and *love is to motivate* this reciprocal sustaining of each other. In Colossians 3:13, we have a parallel passage with the identical participle. Paul says, "upholding one another and forgiving yourselves." Allowing the basic meaning of this participle to come through, these verses offer believers a tremendous, positive challenge to support one another in love!

3. ***"being diligent to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace"***

The thought of "upholding one another in love" is inseparable from "being diligent to keep the unity of the spirit." The present participle translated "being diligent" (ασπουδαζοντες) may be rendered *continuously endeavoring, striving,* and *being eager* to keep the unity of the Spirit. The present infinitive translated "to keep" (τηρειν) may mean *to protectively watch, to guard, to preserve,* and *to maintain* the unity of the Spirit. The Greek word for "unity" (ενοτητα) basically means *oneness*. The same word is used in Galatians 3:28, where Paul says that all believers "are one in Christ Jesus."

The central concept in this verse is "the unity of the Spirit," which we have observed may also be translated "the oneness of the Spirit." The key point is that the phrase rendered "the Spirit" is in the genitive case and, as such, speaks of that which *belongs to, is owned by*, and *which is the possession of the Spirit*. Paul is *not* telling us to produce unity, but to keep, preserve, and maintain an already produced unity, that which the Holy Spirit has produced. This identical word for "unity" (ενοτητα) is used only one other time in the New Testament, which is in verse 13 of this chapter. In this verse Paul is emphasizing the "edification of the Body of Christ, until we all attain unto the *unity of the faith* and the perfect knowledge of the Son of God." Unity and oneness in "the faith" (της πιστεως), *that which is believed, the truth for the Church*, is basic and imperative for keeping the unity of the Spirit. An accurate, literal understanding of *the Truth given to the Church*, the Body of Christ, in the New Testament is mandatory for maintaining the oneness of the Spirit. Unity is based upon correct biblical knowledge, and this is gained through *a correct, literal approach* to the Word of God - obeying its exact, literal intended-meaning.

We note that this unity of the Spirit is to be kept "in the bond of peace." The Greek noun rendered "bond" (συνδεσμω) is derived from the preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "δεω" and literally

means *to bind with* or *to bind together*, hence, the nounal thought is *that which binds together*. The three times Paul uses this word it is directly or indirectly associated with the Body of Christ. We are *bound together* in the peace which exists in the Body.

The Spirit places believers into the Body of Christ where all distinctions are lost (Gal. 3:28), where all are one in Christ (Eph. 2:15), hence, where there is peace (1 Cor. 12:13). We believers have the responsibility, intertwined with the Holy Spirit, to preserve this unity through *knowing and obeying* God's Word given to us, members of the Body of Christ.

4. ***"There is one body and one Spirit, even as also you were called in one hope of your calling,"***

The words "there is" are not in the Greek text, but are added to give smoother thought flow. It appears to us that the continuity between verses 3 and 4, may be better served by prefixing "in" to the latter, in which case these verses would read: "being diligent to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace in one body and one Spirit." We must keep in mind that the punctuation in the Greek text is not a part of the original autographs, is open to question at times, and this may be the case in the division between these two verses. Regardless of which approach we may take to this verse, to give a smooth flow of thought in the English, the intended meaning of the context remains the same, *the bond of peace is in the Body of Christ.*

As Paul emphasizes the unity and oneness of the Spirit and the need for believers to keep it, he presents a brief statement including seven essential fundamentals of the faith. Some feel that the seven things Paul mentions constitute a minimal doctrinal statement, the bare essentials for keeping the unity of the Spirit. In view of the fact that they did not have the New Testament canon of Scripture at that time, and probably few or none of Paul's other epistles, this is a very feasible interpretation of verses 4-6. Furthermore, the fact that Paul uses Greek words for "one" (εις and μια) before each of the items listed suggests that each of these is a viable argument favoring unity. Since these seven items are

apparently fundamentals of the faith, things which stood out in Paul's mind, let us now adequately examine each of them.

First, he says that there is "one body" (εν σωμα). This Greek word is used in the New Testament to depict a *living human body* (Rom. 6:12), a *dead human body* (John 19:31), the physical *body of Jesus while living* (Matt. 26:12), and the *dead physical body of Jesus* (Matt. 27:58). It is used with a metaphorical meaning regarding the *spiritual body of Christ* (1 Cor. 12:27; Eph. 1:23; 4:12; 5:30; Col. 1:18; 1:24; 2:17). When Paul says that there is one body in the verse before us, he has the Body of Christ in mind. This Body is also referred to as the Church (1:22-23; 5:23, 29-30; Col. 1:24).

In Romans 12:4-5, Paul gives us insight into the multiplicity and oneness of the Body of Christ, he says, "For in one body we have many members, and all the members do not have the same function, so we the many are one body in Christ, and each members of one another." The main point of this passage is that the Body of Christ, even though it consists of many members reciprocally fulfilling their respective functions, is still one Body.

In First Corinthians 12:13, Paul explains how we became members of the Body of Christ, he says, "For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body." In verse 18, we learn that God sovereignly determined the position of each member in the Body, for we read, "But now God placed the members, each one of them, in the body even as he was pleased." In verses 24-25, we observe that God has composed the Body so that instead of being schismatic it is reciprocally caring. Paul says, "But God blended the body, giving more abundant honor to that lacking, that there might not be schism in the body, but that the members might have the same care on behalf of one another." Summarizing, God has created the Body of Christ, the Church, so that each member in it is perfectly synchronized with every other member, that there may be perfect harmony and mutual caring between the members.

Second, Paul says that there is "one Spirit" (εν πνευμα). Having observed that the Body of Christ is the organism through which God is relating to His people in this age of Grace, we now turn our

attention to the fact that there is one Spirit. It is impossible to conceive of the Body of Christ, the Church, apart from the Holy Spirit. Apart from his baptizing believers into the Body of Christ, who actually constitute the Body, there would be no Body (1 Cor. 12:13; Gal. 3:27-28; Eph. 4:5; Col. 2:12). Also, it would be futile to ταlk about the unity of the Spirit apart from the Body of Christ, for it is in the sphere of the Body that the Spirit produces this unity (v. 3; Col. 3:14-15). Paul refers to this dispensation of the Grace of God as a time of the *ministry of the Spirit* (2 Cor. 3:8), when he serves the Lord in *newness of the Spirit* (Rom. 7:6).

That you may better understand how indispensable the Spirit in this Church age, let us look at some of the things which He does. Titus 3:5, says that we are saved through the "*renewing* of the Holy Spirit." According to First Corinthians 12:3, it is impossible to call "*Jesus Lord* except by the Holy Spirit." Ephesians 1:13, says that believers have been *sealed* by the Holy Spirit. According to Ephesians 1:14 (cf. 2 Cor. 1:22; 5:5), the Spirit *guarantees our inheritance,* new glorious bodies. In Rom. 8:16, the Spirit assures us that we are *children of God*. According to Romans 8:26, we depend upon the Spirit for an *effective prayer relation* with God. Summarizing, it is utterly impossible to live pleasing to God apart from the Spirit in this Church age (Rom. 8:4, 12-13; Gal. 5:16, 18, 22-23). Where the one Spirit, the third person of the Trinity, is not recognized and given His proper place, the alternative is humanism with its works of the flesh.

Third, Paul says, "even as also you were called in one hope of your calling." Since we already considered the meaning of the Greek word for *calling* as it appeared in verse 1, and since the main point here is the *one hope* of their calling, we will concentrate on the nature of this hope.

The Greek noun translated "hope" (ελπιδι) means *that which one looks forward to, expectation,* and *anticipation.* Believers may anticipate that several things will take place in the future, but there is "one" (μια), *a single event*, which will be the climax of all their expectations. This one hope is the *ultimate end of God's sovereign purpose* according to Romans 8:30, where Paul says, "And whom he called, these he also justified; and whom he justified, these he

also *glorified*. " In First Corinthians 2:7, speaking of Mystery Truth, Paul says, "which God foreordained before the ages unto our glory." In Second Thessalonians 2:14, speaking of salvation, Paul says "unto which he called you through our gospel, unto the *obtaining of the glory* of our Lord Jesus Christ." The one hope is our *glorification together with* Jesus Christ!

In Philippians 3:14, Paul speaks of this one hope as "the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus." Verse 21 is a part of this same context, Paul says, "who will fashion the body of our lowliness to *conform to the body of his glory*." The *end of His calling* is this one hope (Eph. 1:18). This hope is called the "blessed hope" (Titus 2:13).

5. ***"one Lord, one faith, one baptism,"***

Fourth, Paul affirms that there is only "one Lord" (εις Κυριος). The Greek word "Κυριος" may be used with reference to either God the Father or *God the Son*. In this context it obviously refers to God the Son since God the Father is specifically mentioned in verse six. In Second Corinthians 11:44, Paul speaks about "the one coming and preaching another Jesus whom we did not preach." This implies that there were those who were even using the name of Jesus to preach other lords. There was little or no identity between the Jesus they were preaching and the Jesus, the one Lord, Paul preached. This is also true today; the Jesus many are proclaiming has nothing in common with the one Lord Jesus Christ Paul proclaims in his epistles.

In First Corinthians 8:6, against a background of idols, Paul declares that to us there is "one Lord Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and we through him." In First Timothy 2:5, Paul says that there is "also one mediator of God and of men, the man Christ Jesus." In these verses Paul makes it unmistakably clear that there is only one Lord through whom all things were created and who is able to mediate between God and men (cf. Col. 1:16, 20).

According to Romans 4:1, our Lord "has been designated *the Son of God*" by the Holy Spirit through His resurrection. In Colossians 1:3, Paul says that *God is the Father* of the one Lord Jesus Christ.

According to Romans 6:23, there is "*eternal life* in Jesus Christ our Lord." In First Corinthians 15:57, we learn that we have *victory over death* through our one Lord, Jesus Christ. First Corinthians 12:3 affirms that no one is able to acclaim *Jesus as Lord* apart from the Holy Spirit. Finally, according to Philippians 2:11, every tongue will eventually, voluntarily or involuntarily, confess that Jesus Christ is indeed the one true Lord. Only those who *voluntarily, by the Spirit,* personally acclaim Him as their one Lord will be saved (1 Cor. 12:3).

Fifth, Paul declares that there is only "one faith" (μια πιοτις). The Greek noun translated "faith" (πιοτις), as used in this context, obviously means *that which is believed, the body of truth* or *doctrine believed* or, in short, *it is the one body of Mystery Truth ειven to the Church.* This would be synonymous with the Gospel committed to the Apostle Paul, which he calls *my gospel* (Rom. 16:25), *our gospel* (2 Cor. 4:3), *the gospel preached* by me (Gal. 1:11), *the gospel of the grace of God* (Acts 20:24), *the gospel of Christ* (1 Cor. 9:12), *the gospel of the glory of Christ* (2 Cor. 4:4), *the gospel of salvation* (Eph. 1:13), *the gospel of peace* (Eph. 6:15), *the gospel of the glory* (1 Tim. 1:11), and in his early ministry, he frequently refers to it as *the gospel of God* (1 Thess. 2:2).

Where did Paul get this gospel which he refers to as the *one faith*? Negatively speaking, according to Galatians 1:11-12, he says that "the gospel which was preached by me is not according to a man; for neither did I receive it from a man, neither was I taught it." Positively speaking, according to the last part of Galatians 1:12, Paul says that he received it "through revelation of Jesus Christ." In as much as Paul received his gospel from the Lord, not even he could change it, and anyone who might try to alter it would be cursed (Gal. 1:8-9; 1 Thess. 2:13).

Paul also affirms that he received his Mystery gospel (6:19) through Divine revelation (3:2). He calls the same message *the unsearchable riches of Christ*, which had been given to him for the Gentiles (3:8). Since he had received his Gospel directly from Jesus Christ, he refers to it as "sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ" (1 Tim. 6:3; cf. 1:9). Summarizing, the phrase *one faith*, as

used here by Paul, refers to the total revelation of truth given to him for the Body of Christ, the Church. It is *absolute truth* for the duration of the present dispensation of the Mystery (3:9), and anyone who perverts it is under a curse (Gal. 1:8).

Now let us consider what the relation of believers should be to this one faith. According to the 13th verse, Paul says that all believers should "attain unto the unity of *the faith*." In Philippians 1:27, Paul desires that in one soul they will be "striving together for *the faith* of the gospel." In Second Corinthians 1:24, Paul commendably says, "we are fellow-workers of your joy, for you have stood in *the faith.*" In Colossians 1:22-23, Paul says, "but now you have been reconciled by the body of his flesh through death. If you continue in *the faith* as those who have been foundationed ones." In Colossians 2:6-7, Paul admonishes believers to walk in Christ, "having been rooted and being builtup in him and being confirmed in *the faith* even as you were taught, abounding in thanksgiving." In the light of these passages emphasizing the importance of the *one faith*, may we be those who are "nurtured in the words of *the faith* and of the good teaching" (1 Tim. 4:6; cf. 3:9).

Sixth, Paul says that there is only "one baptism" (εν βαπτισμα). We gave a disproportionate amount of space to the subject of *one faith,* because the value of our ministry depends upon *an accurate understanding of the truth* which constitutes the one faith for the Church. We do not intend to spend as much time on the subject of "one baptism," for it is usually dealt with as a part of the *one faith*.

The Greek word translated "baptism" (βαπτισμα) is a noun form of the verb rendered "I baptize" (βαπτιζω). This verb *literally* means to *dip, immerse,* or *wash*, and in the New Testament, this is generally done in water. Based on the literal meaning of this word a *metaphorical* meaning has developed. To dip or immerse something into a liquid, such as a dye, is *to identify it with that liquid.* Literal baptism is *identification with the water* into which the person was baptized, with varying connotations as to what the water symbolizes. On the other hand, metaphorical baptism, most commonly designated spiritual baptism, emphasizes *direct identification* of the person with that into which he/she is baptized. Both physical baptism into water and spiritual baptism are found in

the New Testament. Our main concern is to explain what the *one baptism* mentioned in this verse is and to support our conclusion with adequate evidence.

In First Corinthians 12:13, the Apostle Paul says, "For by one Spirit we all were baptized into one body." Note, the *Spirit is the baptizer* and the Body of Christ is that into which the person was injected, or that with which he/she was *identified*. Since there is only one baptism, and there are two different kinds mentioned in the New Testament, we are forced to make a choice between the two. In view of the incontrovertible fact of *progressive revelation*, w herein some Kingdom truths *give way* to distinct Church truths, and in view of the all-importance of the baptism by the Spirit, we believe the *one baptism is the baptism of the Spirit* into the Body of i hrist (cf. Gal. 3:27-28; Rom. 6:3-11; 1 Cor. 1:17; Col. 2:12).

5. ***"one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all. "***

The capstone of the seven ones which Paul uses to confirm the unity of the Spirit is that there is "one God and Father of all." We need to recognize that Paul makes this statement against a background of polytheism. In Exodus 20:2-4, God says, *"I am Jehovah your God,* who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. *You shall have no other gods before me.* You shall not make unto yourself a graven image, nor any likeness of anything that is in the heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth." These statements make it obvious that God is ONE, He is jealous and will not have any rivals.

Paul describes the One God as the "Father of all" (πατηρ παντων). The Greek word translated "all" (παντων), grammatically speaking, may be considered either a masculine or neuter form. In the light of the preceding context in which Paul is dealing with *all believers*, and in view of the general meaning of "Father" (πατηρ), it appears that he is using the word *all* (παντων) in the *masculine gender* with reference to all believers. After all, Paul's burden in this context is that all believers may maintain the unity of the Spirit.

Having described God as the Father of all, Paul adds that He "is over all" (επι παντων). It is our conviction that the basic meaning of the preposition rendered "over" (επι) is *upon*, or *on* (in the sense of over), and *on the basis of.* Following this meaning through, God is the *premise, ground,* and *basis* for the existence of all believers. Apart from His sovereign Person we would not exist physically nor have a spiritual relation to Him. On the other hand, carrying through the thought of *upon*, in the sense of being *over* and *above*, we would interpret it to mean that *God is over and above all believers in authority.*

In addition to the above Paul affirms that God is "through all" (δια παντων). The Greek preposition translated "through" (δια), used with the genitive case, most commonly conveys the meaning of *through the agency of* someone or something. This would imply that through the sovereign agency of God we are made believers and empowered to know and do His will (Eph. 3:16). The Holy Spirit of God *moves through* the collective Body of Christ to make it *one in thinking* (2 Cor. 13:11; Phil. 2:2).

Finally, Paul says that God is "in all" (εν πασιν). We interpret this phrase as being in the locative case; therefore, we translate it that *God is in the sphere of all*. When we recognize that the preceding context implies that the word "all" (παντων) refers to *all believers*, then we readily understand how that God through His Spirit is *in them* (John 14:23). All believers jointly constitute a habitation of God in the Spirit (Eph. 2:22).

The so-called Majority Text adds the pronoun "us" (ημιν) to the end of this verse. According to this reading Paul is saying that God is "in us all" (εν πασιν ημιν). This rendering is in full accord with our interpretation that the Greek words for "all" (παντων and πασιν) refer to believers. Adding this pronoun does not change the meaning, but reaffirms that we have correctly limited the meaning of *all* to believers.

Summarizing, the fact that there is ONE GOD, and what He does, lays a fourfold foundation for unity between believers: 1) He is the

Father of the family of believers. 2) His sovereign will is the *basis* for our being made believers. 3) He energizes *through* believers to give them one mind. 4) He *dwells in* all believers via the Holy Spirit.

7. ***"But grace was given to each one of us according to the measure of the gift of Christ."***

In view of the fact that Paul has been emphasizing the need to maintain the unity of the Spirit, why does he now switch over to the subject of gifts? The answer to this question is clear in Paul's epistles. A proper understanding of the gifts given to the Church is essential if believers are going to maintain the unity of the Spirit. The basis for harmony in the Body of Christ is to recognize that "God has placed the members, each one of them, in the body even as he pleased" (1 Cor. 12:18). God's purpose for placing inlividuals in their respective niches in the Body is "in order that there may not be schism in the body, but that the members may have the same concern for one another" (1 Cor. 12:25). Each believer must recognize the gift which God has given to him and diligently use it for the edification of the whole Body (Rom. 12:3-8).

Now let us examine the statement, "But grace was given to each one of us." The verb translated grace "was given" (εδοθη) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that *at a given point of time in the past* God gave grace to each one of them as ηelievers. I logically assume that when God chose us in Christ before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4), that was the time when He gave us our respective gifts. We see God's purpose in the election, creation, and gifting of us as an inseparable sovereign act, the fulfillment of which takes place in the process of history. God both determines and gives these gifts; they are out of the resource of His grace.

Note that "to each one of us" (ενι εκαστω ημων) this grace was given. This implies that *each person* in the Body of Christ is a *significant member* with at least one gift for the edification of the whole Body. The grammar used here makes it very clear that *each individual one* of the total Body of Christ has a gift which must be discovered and exercised for the benefit of all (1 Cor. 12:7).

Paul says that the degree to which grace was given to each one was "according to the measure of the gift of Christ." The Greek word translated "measure" (δμετρον) means *extent, standard* or *fixed limitation.* The noun translated "gift" (δωρεας) denotes that which is *given freely, a free* or *gratuitous gift*. Combining these thoughts, each one of us had *grace* (the gift) given to us according *to the extent and set limitation* of the *free and gratuitous gift* which belongs to Christ. Since the free and gratuitous gift of Christ determines the extent of the grace given to each member of the Body of Christ, we are talking about limitless resources of grace (gifts) which have been given to the members of the Body of Christ, the Church.

8. ***"Wherefore he says, having ascended on high, he led captivity captive, and he gave gifts to men."***

This verse is apparently a quotation from Psalms 68:18. In as much as there is an identity between the thought expressed in it and the thought that Paul wants to express regarding Christ and the giving of gifts to His Church, he uses the concept to affirm what he said in verse seven. There is definite similarity between the first part of this quotation and Colossians 2:15, which refers to Christ's triumph over rulers and authorities in the Cross. The last part of the quotation, however, is the punch line which really supports Paul's main point on this context - the fact that Christ has given gifts to the Church.

9. ***"(And that which ascended what is it except that also descended unto the lower parts of the earth"***

This verse is an explanatory take off from verse 8. It adapts the principle set forth in verse 8 to the descent and ascension of Jesus Christ. We have translated the Greek phrase "And that which ascended" (το δε ανεβη) according to the neuter article (το). Furthermore, the statement, "what is it except that also descended," is an accurate translation of the neuter interrogative pronoun "γης". In this verse Paul is *adjusting the principle* alluded to in the previous verse to fit the descent and ascension of Christ; however, Christ Himself is not actually read into this verse. Also,

keep in mind, this verse is in the form of a question, not an assertion. Note further, the Greek phrase rendered "unto the lower parts of the earth" (γης) may equally well be translated *unto the lower parts of the land, ground, or surface of the earth.*

10. ***"the one who has descended is himself the one who also ascended far above all the heavens, that He might fulfill all things.)"***

Having modified the quotation from the Psalms to enhance the concept that Christ gave gifts to His Church, Paul now fully identifies Christ as the one who had descended and ascended. The Greek phrase translated "the one who has descended" (ο καταβας) consists of the article with the aorist participle and refers back to a time when Christ *came down to* or *went down unto or into* the earth. There are two possible options as to which descent Paul is referring to in this context. We will set them forth in the order of our preference.

First, in view of what Paul says in Romans 10:6-7, he may be thinking about Christ's descent into a place of the dead. He says, "Do not say in your heart, `Who shall ascend unto the heaven?' that is to bring Christ down; or, `Who shall descend unto the abyss? that is to bring Christ out from the dead."' The word "abyss" is a transliteration of the Greek word used here and apparently speaks of a *deep, bottomless place of the dead*. What Paul says here together with what he says in verse 9, namely, that He "descended unto the lower parts of the earth," tends to give strong eredence to the fact that this is the descent he has in mind.

Second, the same word is also used with reference to Christ's descent to earth when He took upon Himself the form of a man (Phil. 2:7). In John 6:33, speaking with reference to Himself, Jesus says, "For the bread of God is the one descending out of heaven and giving life to the world" (John 6:38, 41-42). Apart from the above three citations the only other time Paul uses the basic Greek word for *descend* (καταβαινω) is in First Thessalonians 4:16, where he says that the Lord "shall descend from heaven."

The phrase that the descended one is "Himself the one who also ascended" emphasizes the fact that *the ascended one is the same one who descended.* The reflexive pronoun "αυτος" which we have translated *himself*, clearly points this out. The phrase, "the one who also ascended," (και ο αναβας) also consists of the article with the aorist participle and refers to the time when Jesus Christ ascended into the heavens. In Acts 1:9, Luke gives us a brief historical account of this ascension where he says, "And having said these things, while they were looking up he was taken up, and a cloud concealed him from their eyes (cf. Mark 16:19).

Now let us observe that Christ ascended "far above all the heavens" (υπερανω παντων τωτ ουρανων). The Greek word translated "far above" is formed by combining the preposition "υπερ" with the adverb "ανω" and it means *super-above, exceedingly higher,* and *far beyond* all the heavens. In view of the fact that this is the only time Paul uses this word in relation to the heavens, we interpret this statement as either *far above the atmospheric heavens* or as *a hyperbole and overstatement* emphasizing and exalting the ascension of Christ. Considering the fact that He ascended far above "all" (παντων) the heavens, we prefer the latter interpretation. The next closest reference to Christ possibly going beyond the heavens would be Hebrews 4:14, where we read, "Having therefore a great high priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast the confession." This may be interpreted to mean that He passed through the lower strata of the heavens.

In support of what we have said above, we normally think of God the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit having their place of abode *in the sphere of the heavens* rather than far above them. In Ephesians 6:9, we are told that the "Lord is *in* the heavens" (cf. Col. 4:1). In Hebrews 8:1, the Spirit says that we have a high priest "who is seated on the right hand of the throne of majesty *in* the heavens." Likewise, as believers we think of our position as being *in* the heavens. In Philippians 3:20, Paul says, "For our citizenship exists in the heavens, out of which also we expect a Saviour the Lord Jesus Christ." Paul's statement in Second Corinthians 12:2, where

he speaks about being snatched away "until" (εως) the *third heaven* implies that there were others beyond it.

Now we are given the *reason* for Christ ascending far above all the heavens - "that he might fulfill all things." This is an exceedingly important statement. It has to do with the *perfect provision* which Christ made for both the *establishment and operation* of His Church. His plan was very simple. It originally involved an *individual man*, a sinner saved by grace, named the Apostle Paul. Associated with him were men called *apostles* (church planters), and *prophets* (early church teachers), and *evangelists*.

11. ***"And He himself gave the apostles, and the prophets, and the evangelists, and the pastors and teachers,"***

It is important that we grasp the full impact of the reflexive pronoun "αυτος," which emphasizes the fact that *Jesus Christ Himself*, from His heavenly vantage point, gave the above gifts to the Church. As we have already pointed out, His sovereign provision for the Church was apparently accomplished before the creation of world when God chose us in Him (Eph. 1:4). To recognize that Christ is the *sole head* of the Church, and that in the distant past he sovereignly determined its leadership, is the first step in aligning ourselves with the Divinely controlled Church instead of humanly controlled organizations.

First, Paul declares that Christ gave "the apostles" (τους αποστολους). The English word *apostle* is transliteration of the Greek noun. It is derived from the preposition "απο" and the verb "στελλω" and literally means to *send from, send away*, hence, *to send forth.* It is very important that we acknowledge that there are two different groups of apostles: those associated with the Kingdom and those associated with the Church. We need to also acknowledge that some of those who were originally involved in preaching the gospel of the Kingdom may have later become teachers of the gospel of God's grace.

The Twelve Kingdom apostles were chosen by Jesus Christ while He was here on earth proclaiming the message of the Messianic

Kingdom. They had the responsibility of proclaiming the gospel of the Kingdom to the Jews both during the time when Jesus was here on earth and subsequent to it during the time covered by the first seven chapters in the Book of Acts.

In contrast to the Kingdom apostles, Jesus Christ, *from His heavenly position* as Head over the Church, has made known those men He gave as gifts to the Church. *Paul*, formerly Saul of Tarsus, heads the list of the apostles whom Christ gave to the Church. We want to list the names of some of the men who were specifically designated apostles in conjunction with the Church. This list is not necessarily complete. In Acts 14:14, *Barnabas* is listed with Paul as an apostle. In Second Corinthians 8:23, *Titus* and an *unnamed brother* are called apostles of the churches. In First Corinthians 4:6, 9, *Apollos* is associated with Paul as an apostle. In Romans 16:7, *Andronicus* and *Jounias* are referred to as being notable among the apostles. In Philippians 2:25, *Epaphroditus* is designated an apostle. Through their close association with Paul as an apostle, by implication we would consider *Sosthenes, Silas*, and *Timothy* as apostles (cf. 1 Cor. 1:1; 4:9; 1 Thess. 1:1, 6, 9; 2:4, 6).

As we already indicated in connection with the second chapter, verse 20, the apostles seemed to have had an itinerant ministry primarily outside of local assemblies. They appear to have been involved in establishing churches and correcting problems which developed in the churches. According to 2:20, this was apparently a foundational gift which ceased to exist after the Church was adequately established and *its authority was placed in the written Word* (2 Tim. 3:16). The outreach and church planting ministry of the apostles was gradually taken over by the evangelists (2 Tim. 4:S).

In summary, the outstanding thing that marked the apostle was his *Divine authority* (2 Cor. 13:10; Gal. 1:12; 1 Thess. 2:13). When this authority was transferred into the form of writing, particularly the Pauline Epistles, the apostolic ministry in the churches had fulfilled its purpose.

Second, Paul affirms that Christ gave "the prophets" (τους πσοφητας) to the Church. This word is derived from the combining of the preposition "πσο" and the verb "φημι" and literally means *one who speaks prior* or *beforehand*. As used in the Pauline Epistles, this was not the primary function of the Church prophets. Their ministry, in contrast to the apostles, was mainly an *in-church nτinistry.* After the local assemblies were established by the apostles, they had the responsibility of carrying on the ministry within the assembly. Like the apostles, they too were a *foundational gift* to the early churches. Prior to the revelation of Church Truth in written form in the Word of God, as we have it in the New Testament epistles written to the churches, they were given direct insight by the Holy Spirit. The same Spirit who gave Paul his message *enlightened* them in the same truth (1 Cor. 2:10).

It is extremely important that we understand the relation that existed between the apostles, prophets, and Paul. There is no ques:ion about it, *Paul was the key apostle through whom Christ revealed the Truth for the Church*. He makes this claim very clear (1 Cor. 2:6-10; Gal. 1:8-12; Eph. 3:2-9). Furthermore, he refers to the specific gospel which he preached as *my gospel* (Rom. 2:16; 16:25; 2 Tim. 2:8). No other writer in the New Testament makes such claims to a distinct gospel for the Church. Positing the fact that the message *regarding* the Church and *for* the Church was Divinely revealed to Paul, the second step is that the Spirit gave the apostles and prophets *insight to comprehend and grasp its message,* something entirely new, a message that God is now *saving sinners* by grace and *guiding them to maturity by grace*. Normally it takes years to bring a person out of a legalistic background into a posivion of grace, but by the special revelatory work of the Spirit this happened instantaneously in the minds of the apostles and prophets. They were enabled to mentally grasp the magnificent truth regarding Christ and His Church.

Having observed that the first step was the *giving of Church Truth to the Apostle Paul* and that the second step was *illuminating the minds of the apostles and prophets,* now we come to the third step, the *making known of this truth* through the apostles and prophets. In Ephesians 3:5, speaking of the distinct Mystery Truth for the Church, Paul says, "which to other generations was not

made known to the sons of men as it has now been revealed to his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit." We must keep in mind that in the Book of Ephesians we are in *distinct Church territory* - to inject the Twelve Kingdom apostles in here would be totally foreign to the context. Paul is talking about Church apostles and prophets who had special insight into the Mystery revealed to them by the Holy Spirit.

Now let us take a brief look at the ministry of the prophets as we see it in operation in the church at Corinth, according to the fourteenth chapter of First Corinthians. In verse three we read, "and the one prophesying speaks to man *edification* and *exhortation* and *encouragement*." Verse four says, "the one prophesying edifies (builds up) the church." The emphasis in this chapter is that the prophets were to have an *instructional teaching ministry* that edified.

Third, Paul says that Christ gave the gift of "the evangelists" (τους ευαλλελιστας) to His Church. This noun comes from the combining of the adverb "ευ" with the noun "αγγελος" and *means good news, a message that all is well,* hence, as a result of the well news of the gospel "it is well with my soul," as the song writer has so aptly put it. Adding the proper Greek ending "της" to the verbal form of this word gives us the Greek word "ευαγγελιστης" which means *one who proclaims good news, one who announces tidings that make one well spiritually,* or *one who majors in preaching the gospel of salvation* (1:13). The English word *evangelist* is merely a transliteration of the letters of the Greek word over into English.

Following the literal meaning of this noun we deduce that the evangelist primarily took the Gospel of the Grace of God to the unsaved in New Testament times. The apostles, in their church-planting ministry, were heavily engaged in doing the work of evangelists (2 Tim. 4:5). *Philip*, one of the seven chosen in Jerusalem during the time the Kingdom was being offered to Israel (Acts 6:5), is called an evangelist (Acts 21:8; cf. 8:26-35). In fact, he may well have had a vital part in taking the Gospel to many

cities in Phoenice and Samaria, for we have various records of believers in these areas (Acts 15:3; 21:4, 7).

Philip is an example of one who was originally involved with the Twelve in the offering of the Kingdom to Israel, but with its rejection seems to have carried on an evangelistic ministry outside of Jerusalem. At the beginning his message undoubtedly centered around the fact that Jesus of Nazareth was the prophesied Messiah (Acts 8:5, 13). It is possible that at this time he was beginning to see the redemptive value of the Blood of Jesus Christ (Acts 8:32-35), but there is insufficient evidence to assert that he did. Through his relations with Paul he certainly must have been faced with the fact that *Christ's substitutionary death replaced the Levitical offerings.* Giving Philip the benefit of the doubt, in process of time he undoubtedly made the transition from a Kingdom to a Church evangelist - one who was proclaiming salvation by grace through the Blood of Jesus Christ (Eph. 1:7). The message that Jesus is the Messiah is correct, but inadequate for salvation in this Church age. Salvation by grace rests upon the fact of His death on Calvary.

In view of the fact that an evangelist, Biblically speaking, is one who teaches the gospel of salvation to the lost, who would we classify as evangelists today? First, *the missionary or church-planter* with a salvation message to the lost is an evangelist. Second, the person who *majors in the gospel of salvation to lost people,* regardless of the surrounding circumstances, is an evangelist. Third, since we all have had given to us the ministry of reconciliar on, and since we all are to ambassador for Christ, *we all have the responsibility and privilege of doing the work of evangelists* (2 Cor. 5:18-21).

Fourth, Paul says that Christ gave the gift of "the pastors and eachers" (τους δε ποιμενας και διδασκαλους) to the Church. The grammatical construction in the Greek leads us to conclude that ηese two gifts may be found in a single person. The strongest argument favoring the combining of these two is that we have the Greek article "the" (τους) before each gift with the exception of the last, teachers. The article preceding the Greek word translated ηastors" (ποιμενας) appears to equally apply to the "teachers"

(διδασκαλους). The Greek conjunction between the words translated pastors and teachers is not significant. In this context it may be rendered pastors *also* teachers, or pastors *even* teachers.

Having said what we have about the Greek construction used here, and having no preferential bias to support a single or multiple ministry in a local assembly, we want to describe the nature of these gifts separately. The Greek noun which we have translated pastors" (ποιμενας) literally means *one who tends or takes care of flocks or herds,* hence, *a shepherd*. The metaphorical meaning aastor involves all that a shepherd is, namely, *one who leads, guides,* and *cares for the needs* of the Lord's people. This is the only time Paul uses this word pertaining to a gift or position in connection with the Church. It is used once in the Book of Hebrew with reference to Christ - He is the great shepherd of the sheep (Heb. 13:20). Peter uses it once, he speaks of Christ as the shepherd and overseer of the souls of those to whom he is writing (1 Peter 2:25).

It is interesting that this noun is used only three times in the New Testament epistles; twice with respect to Christ and only once, the verse before us, with respect to man. Furthermore, Peter's use of it in conjunction with the word *overseer* may suggest that it has a similar meaning to this word. In view of the fact that Paul mentions individuals as overseers four times as he speaks regarding the leaders in local assemblies (Acts 20:28; Phil. 1:1; 1 Tim. 3:2; Titus 1:7), and mentions the office of an overseer once (1 Tim. 3:1), it appears to me that the shepherd or pastor (ποιμην) is probably synonymous with the overseer (επισκοπος). Since the concept of overseer is mentioned three times in Paul's later epistles, it may be that the name pastor (ποιμην) was being replaced by the name overseer (επισκοπος).

Fifth, Paul says that Christ gave the gift of "teachers" (διδασκαλους) to the Church. We have granted, grammatically speaking, that the gifts of shepherds and teachers may be combined in one person, but at the same time, the evidence is insufficient to be dogmatic on this point. We definitely want to look at the teacher in terms of the *nature of his job* and *what he is to*

teach. As stated here, it appears to us that the teacher may be a pastor, an overseer, or a leader, but not necessarily. He may be a teacher without any official positions in any local assembly, ministering to the Body at large such as Paul, Timothy, and Titus. On the other hand, a highly desired quality in the leadership of the local assemblies was the ability to teach. In First Timothy 3:2, the overseer is to be qualified to teach. In Second Timothy 2:24, the servant of the Lord is to be competent to teach. I am confident, in view of my understanding of Paul's epistles, that the gift he prized above all in his fellowworkers was that they might be competent teachers (2 Tim. 2:2).

Paul's first concern was *what* the teacher taught. To be a competent teacher one must know his subject matter, the message he is to teach, and be sure that it is God's message for the Church in this age of grace. It must be that which was given to Paul for the Church, for in Second Timothy 2:2, he says, "And what you have heard from me through many witnesses, these things commit to faithful men, who shall be qualified to teach others." According to Galatians 1:8-9, Paul left *no room* for anyone to add anything to his Gospel.

Paul's second concern deals with *how* the teacher is to communicate the truth. In order to be a competent teacher in this Church age one must follow the advice Paul gives in Second Timothy 2:15, where he says, "Be diligent to present yourself approved to God, an unashamed worker, holding a straight course in the word of the truth. " Since the phrase "the word of the truth" (τον λογον της αληθειας) describes the Mystery-Gospel which Paul preached, which is recorded in his epistles, it is in this truth that the teacher is to hold a straight course (2 Cor. 6:7; Eph. 1:13; Col. 1:5; cf. Rom. 9:1; Gal. 2:5, 14; 2 Tim. 2:25; Titus 1:1).

The present participle translated "holding a straight course" is derived from "ορθος" and "τεμνω" and literally means *to cut straight,* hence, *to hold a straight nondeviating, nonperverting,* and *nondistorting* course in the Truth in the Pauline Epistles. This means that as a teacher approaches the Bible his primary emphasis should be to *progressively teach through* the fourteen epistles written by the Spirit through Paul in a *verse by verse*

manner (1 Cor. 2:10; Gal. 1:12; 1 Thess. 2:13). As we follow with Paul in a *straight line*, the Truth deposited with him for the Church (2 Tim. 1:12), we will most accurately and systematically teach all the Truth which Christ has given for the maturing and perfecting of His Body (Acts 20:20, 27; Eph. 4:12-16; Col. 1:27-28).

12. ***"for the perfecting of the saints unto the work of ministering, unto the edifying of the body of Christ,"***

This verse states the *reason why, the purpose* for which Christ gave men as gifts to His church. The emphasis in the following context is not on the apostles and evangelists, who primarily had external-church ministries, nor on the prophets whose ministry was apparently passing away (1 Cor. 13:8), but on the *pastors* and *teachers*. In this section Paul gives us a glimpse into the significant part these gifts have in producing a chain reaction in the Body of Christ. He looks at these gifts as primarily being *prime-movers, initiators*, or *those which start the edification-ball rolling* in the body, which in turn becomes self-perpetuating, edifying itself (vv. 15-16; 5:19-20; Col. 3:16; Heb. 10:24-25). This passage gives us a ringside view into how the Body of Christ is to mutually function.

Now let us consider the fact that these gifts were given "for the perfecting of the saints." The Greek word translated "perfecting" (καταστιομον) is a substantive form of the verb "καταστιζω," which is constituted of the preposition "κατα" and the verb "αρτιζω" and basically means *to adjust thoroughly, to fit or mortise together*, or *to frame and complete* for a given purpose. The thought here is that these gifts were given for the purpose of spiritually *fitting, adjusting,* and *mortising* each saint into an *integrated spiritual being.* Paul is really using this word to depict what is involved in the learning process whereby a fragmented saint is transformed into a consistent, harmonious, and effective servant in the Body of Christ (cf. 1 Cor. 1:10; 2 Cor. 13:9, 11).

The object of perfecting the saints is "unto the work of ministering." The Greek phrase translated "unto the work" (εις εργον) consists of the preposition "εις" used with the word

"work" (εργον) in the accusative case. The meaning of the Greek grammar here may be more fully expressed by rendering it *unto the end of the work of ministering*, i.e., the *object* of perfecting the saints is that they might be equipped to carry on the work of ministering. It is important to observe that the word rendered "saints" (αγιων) is in the plural; all the saints are to be thoroughly trained in the Truth for the Church, that mutually and collectively they may build up the Body of Christ by ministering to one another (Rom. 15:14; Col. 1:28; 1 Thess. 5:14). Through holding to a *straight course of teaching the Truth* revealed in Paul's epistles, teachers are to equip other teachers to *mutually edify* the Church (2 Tim. 2:2).

The object of the work of ministering is "unto the edifying of the body of Christ." As in the previous phrase, here we also have the preposition "εις" used with the word rendered "edifying" (οικοδομην) in the accusative case, which means that the object of perfecting the saints is *unto the end of, to accomplish*, and *to reach the goal* of edifying the Body of Christ. The Greek word translated "edifying" (οικοδομην) is derived, in its verbal form, from "οικος" and "δομεω" and basically means *to build or construct a house.* Metaphorically, as in this verse, it is used to depict the *building-up, edification,* and *intellectual and spiritual advancement* of the Body of Christ, the Church. Summarizing, Christ has given men as gifts to His Church that they might *perfect the saints,* that they in turn might *do the work of ministering*, and that as a result of their mutual ministry *the Church might be edified* (Rom. 14:19; 1 Cor. 14:12).

13. ***"until we all attain unto the unity of the faith and the perfect knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ,"***

This process of teaching the saints to minister and to build up the Body of Christ is to continue "until we all attain unto the unity of the faith." The adverb translated "until" (μεχρι) means *up to the time* or *till there is perfect unity.* The Greek word rendered "unity" (ενοτητα) conveys the idea of *oneness*. The only other time it is used in the New Testament is in verse three, where Paul uses it to

describe the *unity of the Spirit*. In this verse it speaks of the "unity of the faith" (ενοτητα της πιοτεως), i.e., *unity and oneness in the body-of-truth believed, in doctrine,* and *the Truth given to the Church.* The Greek adverb "until" (μεχρι) is elusive and never attained by all the saints; therefore, the teachers must *continuously* perfect the saints, who must do the work of ministering, which progressively builds up the Body of Christ.

Thus we observe, all believers are to be *united in doctrinal perception*, they are to have the *same understanding of the Truth for the Church*, and they are to be of *one mind in the Mystery*, the Gospel of God's grace. Added to this they are to have a "perfect knowledge of the Son of God." We must keep in mind that this verse has *only one verb*, translated "attain" (καταντησωμεως), which means *to come to, to arrive at,* or *to reach.* To arrive at a place of oneness in the Mystery Truth for the Church is to be well on the way to arriving at a "perfect knowledge" (επιγνωσεως), *mature knowledge* of the Son of God, the Head over the Church. These are parallel, overlapping truths.

As a result of teachers given to the Church, their equipping of the saints to carry on the work of ministering, and in turn their edification of the Body of Christ, Paul says that we all are to be "*unified in Church doctrine* and to have an intelligent comprehension of the Son of God. The emphasis in this entire context is on the *teaching* and *mental grasping* of the Truth Divinely revealed for the Church. Paul is *not* talking about experiential knowledge when he says we are to have a "perfect knowledge of the Son of God." The Greek word for "perfect knowledge" (επιγνωσεως) is consistently used with reference to *Divinely revealed knowledge*, and in this case, knowledge of the fact that *Jesus Christ is His Son* and occupies the position of *sole Head over the Church* (cf. 1:17; Col. 2:2; 1 Tim. 2:4).

Paul's desire in this verse is that all believers attain unto unity in the one faith, know perfectly the Truth regarding Jesus Christ, and arrive "unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ." In as much as Paul is directing what he is saying to *all believers*, plural in number, what does he mean by

this phrase? We have already seen in Romans 12:4-5, and in First Corinthians 12:12, that many members constitute the one Body of Christ. Likewise, Ephesians 2:15 declares that Jews and Gentiles are created in Christ "unto one new man" (εις ενα καινον ανθρωποϖ), the Body of Christ (vv. 4, 12, 16,). We interpret the statement "unto a perfect man" as Paul's goal for *the Body of Christ in manifestation*. Paul is looking at the Body of Christ from an earthly vantage point here. It is an organism which is dynamic, growing, and moving toward *perfection* (τελειον), *completion, full development,* and *maturity.*

The final thing Paul wants believers to attain is "unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ." In order to more accurately understand what Paul is talking about here, we are going to look at the meaning of three words he uses. First, the Greek word translated "measure" (μετρον) conveys the idea of a *standard, the limit, the extent,* or *that allotted.* Second, the word translated "stature" (μλικιας) may designate *height* (Matt. 6:27; Lk. 19:3) or *age* (Jn. 9:23; Heb. 11:11). In the latter case it usually refers to a particular age or period. Third, the Greek word translated "fulness" (πληρωματος) speaks of *that which fills up, completeness,* and *abundance.*

Now with these meanings in mind let us examine the statement, "unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ." In keeping with its most common meaning in the New Testament, we are giving the Greek word " μλικιας" the meaning of *stature or height.* It appears that the Greek word "μετρον" means *extent or limit* in this phrase. The Greek word "πληρωματος" seems to have its basic meaning of *fulness* and *completeness*. Combining these meanings, Paul's desire is that they may move ahead *unto the extent of the fulness that belongs to Christ*, or *unto the limit of the completeness which belongs to Christ.* In other words, Paul wants the minds of believers to expand to comprehend *the extent of the fulness which belongs to Christ and His Body*. This is in full accord with what Paul says in 1:23, namely, that the Church, the Body, is the fulness of God. It is also in keeping with his desire for believers in 3:19, that they might be filled unto all the fulness of God.

Summarizing, again we emphasize, the teachers Christ gives to His Church are to initiate and continue perfecting the saints, who in turn are to do the work of ministering, which results in the edification of the Body of Christ. This process is to go on until all the members of the Body of Christ *reach* four goals: 1) unity in doctrine; 2) a perfect knowledge of Christ; 3) a perfect Body; and 4) comprehension of the fulness of Christ and His Church. Since these goals will not be attained until after Christ returns for His Church, we are to continuously endeavor to attain them.

14. ***"that no longer we may be children, being tossed by waves and carried about by every wind of teaching, by the sleight of men, by craftiness with methodical deception"***

Paul's *purpose* in setting forth the above cycle of development, which enables us believers to attain an intelligent understanding of the Truth regarding Christ and His Church, is "that no onger we may be children." The Greek noun translated “children" (νηπιοι) basically means *those not speaking, infants* (Heb. 5:13), or from *small children through minors* (1 Cor. 3:1; 3:11). In this verse it speaks of those who are childlike, immature, and easily swayed. The use of the Greek conjunction "ινα" with the subjunctive mood indicates that the ultimate purpose of perfecting the saints is that they may be stable and resistant to false doctrine. The adverb translated "no longer" (μηκετι), *not yet, and not still* implies that untaught, unestablished, and weak believers are prone to vacillate between truth and error. If believers are going to be established in this Church age, ignorance must be replaced with the Truth of the Mystery (Col. 1:25-28).

One of the characteristics of spiritual infants is that they are constantly "being tossed by waves and carried about by every wind of teaching." The Greek participle translated "being tossed by waves" (κλυδων) comes down from the noun "κλυδωνιζομενοι" and means to *wash, dash,* and *surge*. The present passive participle used here portrays untaught believers as continuously being tossed to and fro on the crest of every wave, being dashed about by the surges of false doctrine. Instead of having stamina, based

upon God's Word given to the Church, they are naively agitated in the sea of humanistic religions and the pseudo claims and visions of men (Gal. 1:7; 2:4; Col. 2:8).

Another characteristic of spiritual babies is that they are "carried about by every wind of teaching." The present, passive participle translated "carried about" (περιφερομενοι) is derived from the Greek preposition "περι" and the verb "φερω," which joined, mean to *bear about, carry around,* or *to carry hither and yon* (2 Cor. 4:10). The present tense and passive voice indicate that they are continually being conveyed about by every wind of teaching.

The Greek phrase rendered "wind of teaching" (ανεμω της διδασκαλιας) may also be translated by every *breath* or *breeze* of teaching or doctrine. The passive suggests that every breeze of false doctrine influences and sways them. Paul deplores this spiritual instability. The reason Christ gave teachers to the Church is that they might perfect and equip the saints to do the work of ministering that the manifest-Body of Christ might be built up and solidified.

Now let us look at the *source* of this false teaching which corrupts the minds of those who are spiritually immature. If we interpret the Greek case used as instrumental, it takes place "*by* the sleight of men, *by* craftiness with methodical deception." On the other hand, if we interpret the Greek case as locative, it takes place *"in the sphere of* the sleight of men, *in the sphere of* craftiness with methodical deception." The instrumental case emphasizes the *means by which* this corrupting is effected, by trickery and craftiness. The locative case emphasizes the *sphere or arena* in which the corrupting is accomplished, the area of the devil's methodical deception. The Greek word translated "sleight" (κυβετα), in verbal form, literally speaks of *playing at dice, dicing,* hence, men who are *versatile in conniving and using trickery* to infiltrate minds with their false teaching.

It appears that we most accurately understand this phrase to mean that conniving tricksters *operate in the sphere of crafty, cunning, and wily methodical deception.* The Greek phrase translated

"methodical deception" (την μεθοδειαν της πλανης) speaks of a calculated, systematic, and contrived method of deception. According to the Greek grammar used, this could be looked at as the *cunning craftiness associated with the particular methods belonging to the deceiving process* used to lead weak individuals astray. The devil is behind this deceptive process, for in Ephesians 6:11, Paul commands believers, "Put on all the armor of God that you might be able to stand against the *methods* (μεθοδειας) of the devil." In a very methodical manner the devil uses conniving religious tricksters to permeate the minds of the weak with false teaching. The antidote against this false doctrine is for believers to be built up in the Truth for the Body of Christ, even the Mystery, which establishes and makes solid in the faith (Rom. 16:25).

15. ***"and speaking the truth in love, let as grow into him in all things, who is the head, Christ."***

In as much as verse 14 is injected into this context *to explain one of the reasons or purposes* why the Body of Christ is to be built up, and that this verse is really a *continuation of the thought* from verse 13, we prefer to translate the first phrase in this verse, "and (δε) speaking the truth in love" instead of "but speaking the truth in love." Emphasizing this continuity between verses 13 and 15, we have the thought that all believers are to be involved in attaining unto the fulness of Christ *and* speaking the truth in love. In view of the use of the passive voice in verse 14, which puts the spiritually veak in a position of submission to the methods of the devil, we prefer to translate the Greek conjunction "δε" as *and*, skipping lack to verse 13 for continuity in the train of thought. In all fairness, we must grant that "δε" may also be translated *but*, in which case "speaking the truth in love" would be in contrast to being deceived spiritual infants.

The key word in this verse is the Greek participle translated speaking the truth" (αληθευοντες). As the *subject*, this participle in the nominative case and the present tense, which means that as believers we are to be *continuously-speaking-the-truth ones.* Paul's emphasis here is not on speaking that which is true, but on speaking that which is *the Truth for the Church* in this dispensation

of grace (Eph. 3:2). The two times the verb form behind this participle is used in the New Testament it contains the idea of *speaking* the truth even though the word *speaking* is not an explicit part of it. Note Paul's use of it in Galatians 4:16, where he asks, "So then have I become your enemy *by speaking the truth* to you?" As used in the classical Greek the English word speak is also commonly inferred or implied.

Recognizing that "speaking the truth" (αληθευοντες) is a valid usage-meaning of this present participle, now let us consider the sphere in which this truth is to be spoken. It is possible to verbalize the truth out of a heart of bitterness, animosity, and hatred for the sake of vengeance, but such motivation is unacceptable with God (1 Cor. 13:1-3). According to Second Corinthians 5:14-15, the love of Christ was that which constrained Paul to live for Christ; likewise, here he instructs all believers to continuously speak the Truth of the Gospel "in love" (εν αγαπη), i.e., *in the sphere of love, kindly concern,* and *affection*. Christ's love for us, a love which caused Him to die for us, should be the first thing that motivates us to speak and share the Truth of the Gospel with others.

The second thing that should motivate us to speak the truth in love is a *love-for-the-Truth itself* (2 Thess. 2:10). Even as God has put within us a love for Himself (Rom. 5:4; 1 Jn. 4:10), likewise, He instills in believers a love for His Word and readiness to hear it (1 Thess. 2:13; 1 Jn. 4:6). As we love the Truth given to the Church, as we bathe our minds in the amazing greatness of God's grace toward us sinners, love for this Truth *impels us to share it with others* (1 Cor. 9:16-17; 2 Cor. 5:17-21).

The third thing which motivates us to speak the truth in love is the *love-for-people* God has implanted in us. Love motivated God to act on behalf of us when we were rebellious sinners (2:4), love and compassion for the distressed multitudes stirred Jesus to pray for more workers (Matt. 9:36-10:1), and God the Holy Spirit enables believers to show this same love toward fellow believers (4:2; Phil. 2:1) and the elect among the lost (Rom. 1:14-15; 2 Tim. 2:10). The first fruit of the Spirit is love (Gal. 5:22), and motivated by this love for others, we are to speak the Truth to them (Col. 1:28-29).

Summarizing, we have examined three possible interpretations of the phrase "in love." First, we speak the truth because we are motivated by the *love of Christ*. Second, we speak the truth because we *love its message* and want to share its amazing grace. Third, we speak the truth because we *love people* and want them to be liberated from sin.

As a result of speaking the Truth in love, Paul says, "Let us grow into him in all things." The Greek verb which we have translated "let us grom " may also be rendered *let us increase* or *let us be enlarged.* We interpret this verb as a hortatory subjective, almost comparable to a command, which lays *strong emphasis on our need to grow and increase into Christ*. The phrase translated "into him" (εις αυτον) consists of the preposition "εις" with the pronoun "him" (αυτον) in the accusative case. This grammatical construction commonly conveys the idea of *unto* or *unto the end* of him, i.e., Christ, "who is the head."

In view of what Paul says here, and in the immediate context (vv. 12-13), the thought is that believers, speaking the truth in love, are to grow in all things unto the end of being *mature in the Body of Christ.* The phrase "all things" (τα παντα) means that in every aspect of our lives we are to develop and grow to be more like Christ, the Head over the Body, the Church.

16. ***"out of whom all the body being fitly joined and knit together through the supply of every joint, according to the working in measure of each individual part, produces the growth of the body unto the edification of itself in love."***

The antecedent of the pronoun "whom" (ου) is Christ, the Head of the Body, the Church. The Greek phrase translated "out f whom" (εξ ου) consists of the preposition "εξ" used with the ablative case, and as such it indicates that *Christ Himself is the source* of that which is essential for the growth of the Church. The statement, "out of whom all the body," implies that Christ is the source of every single aspect of the Body, the Church, and takes us back to Him as the one who fits and knits the multiplied parts into a dynamic, growing, and united whole. This certainly makes it clear

that the True Church, the Body of Christ, which is a living organism, is *totally the work of Christ* (1:4; 2 Tim. 2:10).

The first thing we observe is that the body is "being fitly joined" together by Christ. The Greek participle translated "being fitly joined together" (συναρμολογουμενον) is derived from "συν" and "αρμος" and "λογος," which combined basically mean *to join together, to fit or frame together,* or *to put together.* Since this verb is in the present tense and passive voice it indicates that Christ, in an objective relation to the Body through the Holy Spirit, is continuously joining and fitting the Body together. The passive voice precludes the thought that believers fit themselves into the Body of Christ.

The second thing we note is that the body is "being knit together" (συμβιβαζομενον). This Greek participle is derived from "συν" and "βιβαζω," which basically mean *to cause to come together, to bring together,* and *couple together*. The context following its use in this verse suggests more than just a coming together, but also a *fastening* and *tying* with ligaments. The present tense and passive voice portray a *continuous process* whereby Christ, through the Holy Spirit, is knitting and tying together all the Body into a single unit. Again we emphasize, the passive voice makes it clear that Christ is the one who is *sovereignly* knitting together His Body, the Church, through the agency of the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 12:13; Gal. 3:27-28).

Now let us consider *how* all the Body is being knit together, that it is "through the supply of every joint." The Greek noun translated "joint" (αφης) has the basic meaning of that which *fastens, connects,* or *binds together.* As used in this verse its main emphasis seems to be on that which binds the joint together, hence, ligaments. In Colossians 2:19, Paul expresses the same general idea, for he says that out of Christ all the Body, "through the joints and ligaments is supplied and knit together, growing the growth of God." Since Paul uses the two words, *joints* (αφων) and *ligaments* (συνδεσμων) in Colossians to convey the same idea, we conclude that the word joint (αφης) in this sixteenth verse before us is intended to include *the joint and ligaments as a single unit.*

Having observed that this process of knitting together is through the supply of *every joint*, we identify every joint (πασης αφης) as being *every member* in the Body of Christ. The Greek preposition "δια" used with the genitive case emphasizes that the knitting together of the Body of Christ is *through the agency of the supply of every member*. As we have already said, the passive voice used above excludes all humanism from this Body building process, and what we have here is the Holy Spirit, through the agency of every member, supplying that which is necessary to knit together all the Body. The Greek word for "supply" (επιχορηγιας) emphasizes that it is the *super-supply* and *abundant provision* of the Holy Spirit through each member that knits and binds the total Body together.

As we continue to observe the manner in which the Body of Christ is joined and knit together, Paul adds that this process takes place "according to the working in measure of each individual part." The Greek word rendered "working" (ενεργειαν) basically conveys the idea of *working in, laboring in,* and *acting in*. Transliterated into English it forms our English word *energy*. It is used seven times by Paul to depict *Divine energizing*, once regarding satanic energizing, and *never* with reference to human energizing. The thought here is that the Body is being knit together by that which is supplied through each member and this conforms to (κατα) God the Holy Spirit's *working in* or *energizing in* each individual part.

What does Paul mean by the statement, "according to the working in measure"? Since the preposition translated "according to" (κατα) means *in keeping with* and *conforming to* the working and energizing of the Holy Spirit, how does the word "measure" (μετρω) qualify this meaning? As we already noted in connection with verse thirteen, as used here, this word conveys the idea of limit, extent, and allotment. This indicates that the body is being knit together in accordance with the *extent or degree* to which the Holy Spirit is energizing through each individual part, i.e., through each member. This extent of energizing is intertwined with the *allotment of gifts* and talents which are intrinsic in the members of the Body of Christ (vv. 7, 11).

All that is described in the forepart of this verse "produces the growth of the body unto the edification of itself in love." The Greek verb translated "produce" (ποιειται) is in the present tense and third person singular. The subject of this verb is Christ, who is conceived as inseparable from His Body, *producing, making*, and *causing* growth of the Body. The Greek word translated "growth" (αυξησιν) means *increase* or *enlargement*. This nounαl form is used only one other time in the New Testament, Colossians 2:19, where Paul speaks of the Body "growing the growth of God." This verse implies that Christ is the *source* (εξ ου) of the development of the Body, but at the same time its growth is referred to as being of God. This context in Colossians, corroborated by our context in this sixteenth verse, confirms the fact that God the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are all involved in the growth and enlargement of the Body of Christ. As we have emphasized, the growth of the Body is totally of God, it is *Divinely produced*, and excludes all human effort.

Finally, we observe that this growth of the Body is "unto the edification of itself in love." Previously we noted an emphasis on the individual members of the Body being joined and knit together through the energizing of the Holy Spirit in keeping with the gifts allotted to each one. Through this process, growth and enlargement takes place among the members. All this is unto the end of the Body building itself up (εαυτου) in the sphere of love.

17. ***"I therefore say this and testify in the Lord, that you no longer walk as the Gentiles also walk, in the vanity of their mind,"***

Having emphasized the need to maintain the unity of the Spirit, which is accomplished through the gifts given to the Church via the perfecting of the saints, who in turn have the responsibility of building-up the Body of Christ, Paul now exhorts them to have a *different life-style*. The phrase "I therefore say this," being in the present tense, suggests that Paul *continuously* appealed to believers to shed their old ways of living. The added statement, "and I testify" (μαρτυρομαι), is also in the present tense and

reinforces the urgency of Paul's appeal. Observe that Paul is making this twopronged appeal "in the Lord" (εν κυριω). This may be interpreted as *in the sphere of* the Lord (locative case), or *by means of* the Lord (instrumental case). The important point is that Paul's incessant, urgent appeal was *backed by Divine authority*.

The statement, "that you no longer walk as the Gentiles also walk," implies that at least some of them were still walking like the unsaved Gentiles. The Greek adverb translated "no longer" (μηκετι) is derived from "μη" and "ετι" and means that they are *not yet* and *not still* to be continuing in their old life-style. The Greek pronoun translated "you" (υμας) refers to the believers to whom Paul is writing, those associating themselves with the various assemblies receiving this encyclical epistle. This statement indicates that there should be a *sharp contrast* between how the saved and unsaved live.

Paul's use of the adverb rendered "no longer" (μηκετι) strongly suggests that these believers were primarily saved Gentiles. There would be a natural tendency for their heathenistic practices to cling to them. Some of the most obnoxious practices are mentioned in Acts 15:29, where the Galatian believers are told to "abstain from things sacrificed to idols and from blood and from things strangled and from fornication," things which were particularly offensive to the Jewish mind-set.

Paul describes the Gentile walk as "in the vanity of their mind." The Greek noun translated "vanity" (ματαιοτητι) expresses the idea of a mind which is *idle, fruitless, useless*, and *unprofitable*. In Romans 8:20, we note that *creation* has been subjected to *vanity* (ματαιοτητι), which is referred to as "bondage of corruption" (v. 21). The meaning of this word, in its basic noun form, is elucidated in Titus 3:9, where Paul says, "and foolish questions and genealogies and strife and law fightings avoid, for they are unprofitable and *vain* (ματαιοι)," i.e., they are fruitless and useless. The verb form of this word is used in Romans 1:21, where Paul says of the depraved Gentile world, "they were made *vain* (εματαιωθησαν) in their reasonings." As a result of their refusal to

glorify and give God thanks, the passive voice affirms, *they were made idle, useless,* and *fruitless* in the operation of their minds.

18. ***"having the mind darkened, having been alienated from the life of God, because of the ignorance that is in them, because of the hardness of their heart,"***

An amplified translation of this verse would be, "being those who had been darkened in the mind, and who had been made alienated ones from the life of God, because of the ignorance existing in them, because of the hardness of their heart." The perfect passive participle rendered "having darkened" (εσκοτωμενοι) indicates that at a given point of time in the past, and the results continuing, their minds had been *darkened, blinded, deprived of light,* and *made spiritually obscure*. The use of the passive voice declares that this darkness was imposed by an outside person, namely the devil. As those who had been given up by God (Rom. 1:24, 26, 28), due to their refusal to worship Him as God, Satan had free reign to darken and obscure their minds to the truth (Rom. 1:23; cf. Rom. 11:10).

The specific area this darkness affected was their *minds*. The Greek noun translated "mind" (διανοια) is derived from "δια" and "νοεω" and very literally means to *think through*, hence, *the mind in action, the process of thinking,* and *the ability to reason*. As a result of the Adamic Fall, and man's reaffirmation of it, his intellectual processes have been darkened in the spiritual sphere. The natural man is *totally incapable* of reasoning and thinking God's thoughts. In dealing with this depraved mind-set, Paul says in First Corinthians 2:14, "But the natural man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness unto him, and he is not able to know them, because they are spiritually discerned."

Now let us look at the statement, that the Gentiles have "been alienated from the life of God." Like the Greek word for *darkened* (εσκοτωμενοι), the Greek word for "alienated" is also a perfect, passive participle. Both words apparently go back to the tragic Adamic Fall, when man's rebellion against God began. What happened there and the resulting consequences of darkness and

alienation still continue in full effect. The Greek word "alienated" (απηλλοτριωμενοι) is derived from "απο" and "αλλοτριοω" and literally means to be *from another*, hence, *aliens, foreigners,* and *those separated from the life of God*, i.e., from the life which *belongs to God*, the life which God originally gave to Adam and Eve and gives to those believing in Jesus Christ (2:12; Col. 1:21; 3:3-4).

Paul proceeds to give two reasons why the Gentiles had their spiritual perecption darkened and why they had been alienated from the life of God. First, it was on account of the ignorance existing in them, and second, on account of the hardness of their heart. The Greek noun rendered "ignorance" (αγνοιαν) comes from "α" and "γινωσκω" and literally means to be *without knowing, void of knowledge,* hence, to be *ignorant* or *stupid*. The use of the preposition "δια" with the accusative case affirms that this stupidity in them was the cause of their darkened intellect and alienation from Divine life. The use of the present participle "ουσαν" implies that this ignorance still remains in them (Acts 17:30; 1 Peter 1:14).

The second reason for their darkened and alienated condition was their hardness of heart. The Greek word rendered "hardness" (πωρωσιν) means a *stony, petrified, calloused*, and *unimpressionable* heart. The Greek noun translated "heart" (καρδιας) is often used almost interchangeably with our English word *mind plus emotional feeling* added (cf. Rom. 1:21; 2:5; 10:6). Putting these thoughts in their proper grammatical sequence, according to the Greek, first there is *ignorance and hardness* which resulted in *darkness and alienation* which resulted in their *walking in the vanity of their mind.*

19. ***"Who being beyond feeling gave themselves over to sensuality to work all uncleanness in covetousness."***

The Greek word translated "being beyond feeling" (απηλγηκοτες) is a perfect active participle. The word is derived rom the preposition "απο" and the verb "αλγεω" and means to be *away from a feeling of pain, suffering, and grief, hence, to cease to have a sense of pain, to be insensible and calloused to the Truth.* The perfect tense and

active voice indicates that they themselves, in ve downward spiral, had reached the point where they were insensitive to the will of God and abandoned themselves to the working of evil. Previously, we observed how the devil had darkened their minds and alienated them from the life of God; but here *they themselves are the chief actors*, those who "gave themselves over" (παρεδωκαν), *delivered*, and *surrendered* themselves to sensuality.

The Greek noun translated "sensuality" (ασελγεια) conveys the thought of *lewdness, lustfulness*, and *licentiousness*. The point Paul is making is that they utterly abandoned themselves to arageous sexual behavior unto the end to "work" (εργασιαν), *perform, practice,* and *engage* in all uncleanness. Since the phrase “all uncleanness" (ακαθαρσιας πασης) is singular it may also be rendered *every act of uncleanness,* filthiness, and lewdness. With one exception in Matthew 23:27, Paul exclusively uses this word in the New Testament (nine times), generally with reference to sexual sins (Rom. 1:24; 6:19; Gal. 5:9).

As those who were insensitive to the Truth of God, they recklessly abandoned themselves to the lustfulness of the flesh and engaged in every form of sexual uncleanness such as sodomy and lesbianism (Rom. 1:26-27). All this took place *in the sphere of covetousness.* The Greek noun rendered "covetousness" (απλεονεξια) has the basic idea of *having more than another*, hence, it is *taking advantage of, overreaching,* and *extortion*. It is used with this meaning both in the monetary realm (2 Cor. 9:5; 1 Thess. 2:5) and in overreaching and taking advantage of others to satisfy sexual desires and lusts (5:3; Mark 7:22; Col. 3:5). The emphasis in the verse before us in that the degradation of the Gentiles took place in the sphere of covetousness, i.e., they were greedily overreaching and taking advantage of others in their quest to satiate the lust of their flesh. This undoubtedly took place in the area of fornication, adultery, sodomic abuse of children, and in debauching pornography (1 Thess. 4:6; 2 Tim. 3:6).

20. ***"But you have not so learned Christ,"***

In contrast to the immoral life-style of the Gentiles, Paul reminds his readers that there is no place for these things in their lives - you have not learned Christ in this way. The pronoun "you" (υμεις) is very significant. Its antecedent consists of all the believers Paul is writing to in this encyclical epistle. They are a special *you group,* the elect, the Lord's people, members of the Body of Christ, God's Family. All those not in this *you group*, God's Family, whether Jews or Gentiles, lie in the evil one, the devil (1 John 5:19).

Against a background of outrageous Gentile conduct, Paul declares that those to whom he is writing "have not so learned Christ." The phrase "not so" (ουχ ουτως) may be translated *not thus, not in this manner,* or *not in this way.* The thought is that the way the Gentiles live has *nothing in common* with the way believers have learned Christ. The Greek word translated "learned" (εμαθετε) is in the aorist tense and active voice and means that through the ear or eye gate they did *not learn, acquire knowledge of,* nor *comprehend* Christ. The word "Christ" (Χριστον) has the article preceding it, as the direct object receives that action of the verb, and is best understood as representing *the Christ* in terms of His body and its standards. In other words, to learn the Christ would be to acquire knowledge about His Body and how members of it are to live (Phil. 4:9; 2 Tim. 3:14).

21. ***"if indeed you have heard him and were taught in him, even as the truth is in Jesus,"***

The statement, "if indeed you have heard him and were taught in him," leaves room for some associating with these churches to be void of the Truth for the Church, hence, still unsaved (1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23). Also, this statement may be interpreted to mean that some were so scantily taught that they did not know how believers should live.

Now let us look at two aspects of this statement. First, it appears to be possible to interpret the clause, "if indeed you have heard him," as meaning that they heard a message *from Christ*. On the other hand, it may be interpreted to mean that they had heard a message *regarding Christ*. Second, likewise, it is possible to interpret the

clause, if indeed you "were taught in him," as meaning that they were taught *in the sphere of Him*, i.e., in the things pertaining to Him. The first interpretation looks at Christ as *the one doing the teaching.* The second interpretation makes Christ *the object of the teaching,* He is the one around whom the teaching centers. Grammatically speaking, we prefer the second interpretation, that Christ is the *central object* of the teaching.

Having made the foregoing statement, Paul says, "even as the truth is in Jesus." Consistently preferring to interpret the "εν" in this verse as being in the locative case, the thought is that *the truth is in the Sphere of Jesus.* In John 14:6, Jesus affirms that He is the very embodiment of truth. Paul frequently uses the word truth (αληθεια) to describe the gospel of the Grace of God (1:13; Col. 1:5). God's desire is that all men be given an opportunity to come - a perfect knowledge of the Truth in Christ (1 Tim. 2:4; 2 Tim. 2:15.)

In this present Church age God relates to men through Jesus Christ, the head over the Body, the Church. The Truth for the present dispensation of Grace centers in Him. In Ephesians 1:22, Paul declares that God the Father subjected all things under the feet of Jesus Christ, "and made Him the head of all things relating to the Church." This means that Christ is the sole and exclusive head over every single thing which pertains to the Church (5:23; Col. 1:18; 2:10). Since the Truth for the Church revolves around Christ, and this Truth is revealed in the New Testament epistles written to the churches, we should focus our attention on these epistles (3:2-10).

22. ***"you put away accordingly the former way of living, the old man who is being corrupted according to the lusts of deceit"***

Paul again emphasizes the main point which he introduced in verse 17, that they no longer are "to live as also the Gentiles live in the vanity of their mind." In keeping with the new life which they now have in Christ, and the Truth which is in Him, they are to "put away" (αποθεσθαι) their former life-style. The Greek word translated "put away" is derived from the words "απο" and "τιθημι"

and literally means *to place* or *put from you*, hence, *to put off* and *lay aside.* The use of the ingressive aorist strongly emphasizes their need to put away the old life as long as it keeps raising its ugly head. The use of the middle voice focuses attention on the fact that as those who are alive in Christ *they have the responsibility*, through the energizing of the Holy Spirit, to put away their former manner of living. According to Acts 7:58, where this same verb is used, they are to put off their old life as the witnesses put off their garments beside the feet of Saul (Rom. 13:12; Heb. 12:1).

Again, we note Paul's use of the pronoun "you" (υμας) to specifically address what he is saying to believers, members of the Body of Christ. God has one major concern for believers - that their life-style conform to their righteous position in Christ (2 Cor. 5:14-15). On the other hand, the Word of God never tries to tell unbelievers how to live, God's major concern for them is that they be saved (1 Tim. 2:4; 2 Tim. 2:10).

In view of the fact that Paul instructs them to put away their former way of living, and in the 18th verse tells them to no longer live like the unsaved Gentiles, we suggest that this epistle is *primarily addressed* to believing Gentiles. In saying this we do not intimate that the saved Jews had nothing to put away, for they had a most difficult task in this area, particularly in freeing themselves from the Law of Moses (Phil. 3:4-9).

Now let consider what they were to put away, namely the "former way of living" (προτεραν αναστροφην). This refers to their *previous* and *earlier mode of life, conduct,* and *life-style* (Gal. 1:13; 2 Peter 2:7). Paul now proceeds to add, in *apposition* to "the former way of living," the phrase, "the old man who is being corrupted." In contrast to the new man (v. 24), who is a new creature in Christ (2 Cor. 5:17), the rebellious progeny of Adam is designated as the old man (Col. 3:9). The apposition relation between the former manner of life and the old man indicates that these are comparable thoughts. Where we see a person living in the manner described in verses 17-19, we have an old man behind it, and where we have an old man these characteristics will express themselves. According to Romans 6:6, "our old man has been crucified with

(Christ), that the body of sin may be made unproductive, that we may no longer serve sin." Christ's death provides the potential for the death of our old man, but since none of us even approach the lower rungs of sinless perfection, we are constantly plagued with the presence and expression of our old man (Rom. 7:7-25).

Paul says that this old man is in the process of "being corrupted according to the lusts of deceit." The participle translated “being corrupted" (φθειρομενον) is in the present tense which indicates that this is a *continuous process* taking place daily. The fact that this participle is in the passive voice affirms that an *outside rerson, Satan,* is the one producing this corrupting influence (Acts 5:3; 1 Cor. 7:5). This corrupting, *spoiling*, and *ruining* continuous, takes place "according to the lusts of deceit." The Greek word for "lusts" (επιθυμιας) means *desires, longings,* and *cravings* of deceit. The Greek word for "deceit" (απατης) conveys the idea of *tricking, cheating,* and *deluding.* Thus we observe, Satan uses the desires, longings, and cravings of the old man, and satiates them through the use of trickery, cheating, and deluding, thereby connually corrupting the old man.

23. ***"and to be renewed in the spirit or your mind,"***

Having admonished them to put off the old man, the one being continuously corrupted by deceitful lusts, Paul now instructs them to be renewed in the spirit of their mind. The Greek verb translated "renewed" (ανανεουσθαι) is derived from the preposition "ανα" and the word "νεος" and literally means to *new up*, hence, *to renew, make new again,* and *to renovate*. Again we observe, this infinitive is in the present tense which means that this renewing is a *continuous process,* it takes time and should be going on during our entire life span. Also, this infinitive is in the passive voice, which means that this is not a humanistic-self-renewal, but it is the work of an *outside person,* the Holy Spirit (Rom. 8:4-6; 12:2).

Now let us examine the statement that this renewing and renovating takes place "in the spirit of your mind." Expanding this translation, Paul says you need to be renewed *in the spirit which belongs to the mind which belongs to you.* The point we are trying to bring out is that

the Greek word translated "spirit" (πνευματι), as used here, is commonly very closely associated with our English word "mind." The spirit and mind are best perceived as aspects of man's intellectual control panel. The spirit is the juncture through which the Holy Spirit relates to man (Romans 8:16) and impresses His message, the Word of God, upon the mind. It is exceedingly important that we recognize that it takes *time* for spiritual growth to take place.

Lest we superficially exegete what is written in this verse, we need to refresh our thinking regarding man's rebellion against God, and how it has left him *mentally incapacitated* in the spiritual sphere. First, it cut him off from communication with God, *he died spiritually* (Rom. 6:23; Eph. 2:1). Second, according to Romans 1:21, after they refused to glorify God and give Him thanks, "they were made *vain in their reasonings* and their *nonunderstanding heart was darkened*." The language used here suggests that, spiritually speaking, they were *mentally deranged*. According to Titus 1:15, "the mind and conscience has been defiled" of natural men. Third, the natural descendant of Adam, who is a sinner by nature, is *totally unable and incapable of receiving* and knowing the things of the Spirit (1 Cor. 2:14).

Due to the destitute state in which the Adamic Fall has left all men, none would nor could be saved if left to themselves. Apart from God's Grace, selectively extending faith unto sinners, the entire human race would be lost. But thanks be unto God, He has *loved* us, *been merciful* to us, and made us *spiritually alive* together with Christ (2:4-6). Now, through His Holy Spirit, He is ceaselessly endeavoring to renew our spirit/minds into His own likeness and image in which He created Adam and Eve. According to First Corinthians 2:16, with Paul, we need to have the *mind of Christ* - daily growing to be like Him through submission to the Holy Spirit (5:18).

24. ***"and put on the new man who according to God has been created in righteousness and holiness of the truth."***

Even as the old man has been identified with Christ in death, and is to be put off, likewise the new man, who is a new creation, is to be put on (Gal. 6:15). The Greek infinitive translated "put on" (ενδυσασθαι) is derived from "εν" and "δυω" and basically means *to*

get into, hence, *to put on,* or *to clothe and invest oneself*. The aorist tense used here is interpreted to mean that the new man is to be put on as a *once-and-for-all* transaction.

The use of the middle voice indicates that this putting on is the *responsibility of believers* empowered by the Holy Spirit. Colossians 3:10 favors the thought that the new man is put on as a *single act,* for we read, "having put on the new [man] the one being connuously renewed unto a perfect knowledge according to the image 'the one who created him." The present participle translated "the one being continuously renewed" (τον ανακαινουμενον) brings out the fact that even though put on once-for-all the new man needs to be *constantly renewed* in order to be brought into alignment with the image of God.

Now let us examine more closely the characteristics of this new man. First, this is the only time the Greek word "καινον" is used to depict a new man in the sense of an individual believer in Christ. The Greek word "νεον," however, is used in Colossians 3:10, to set forth the same thought even though the word man (ανθροπος) is not in the context. Second, the Greek word for new (καινον) is used twice with reference to a new creature or creation. If we grant that the new man and new creation are identical, which we do, it logically follows that the putting on of the new man is a once-for-all transation. Third, even as the old man designates the Adamic nature and its deeds, likewise the new man designates the opposite, those have been made the very righteousness of God in Christ with righteous fruit. When a person is saved the new man is sovereignly put on for eternity, the believer is newly created by God the Holy Spirit (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15; Titus 3:5).

The best definition of the new man is included in the verse before us. The phrase, "who according to God has been created in righteousness and holiness of the truth," may well be looked at as in *apposition* with the phrase "the new man" (τον καινον ανθρωπον). This statement makes it clear that God is the one who has created the new man, i.e., he "according to God has been created" (κατα θεον κτισθεντα). The preposition " κατα" used with the accusative case implies that this new man has been

created *in keeping with* and *conforming to God's design,* which means he is created in accordance with God's blueprint. Since the verb translated "has been created" is in the aorist tense and passive voice, it means that at a given point in time the new man was instantaneously *created, called into being*, and *fashioned* as potentially God's ideal man. In the New Testament *God* is always the subject of the verb for create (κτιζω), the verb used in this verse.

We note that this new man was created by God "in righteousness and holiness of the truth." The Greek words rendered righteousness and holiness are obviously in the locative case, and as such, indicate that the new man was created *in the sphere of* righteousness and holiness, which means that these are his intrinsic characteristics. Forensically speaking, the new man is *absolutely righteous and holy* in Christ before God the Father. This does not mean, however, that this righteousness and holiness is going to be fully reflected in his life-style. The fact that he is absolutely righteous and holy is *the basic premise* for a right and holy walk. Because we are righteous and holy in Christ - we are exhorted to have a righteous and holy life-style. In other words, God asks us *to be in life* what we are in Christ before Him. Ephesians 2:10 states the reason we have been created in Christ, for it says, "having been created in Christ Jesus for [on the basis of] good works."

Finally in this verse, we note that the righteousness and holiness are "of the truth" (της αληθειας). The phrase "the truth" is in the genitive case which denotes *possession* and conveys the idea that the righteousness and holiness Paul is speaking of here *belong to the truth.* Paul's most common use of the word *truth* (αληθεια) pertains to the *Mystery*, the message for the Body of Christ, the Church (Col. 1:5-6; 2 Tim. 2:15, 25). We must keep in mind that the righteousness and holiness intrinsic in the new man are according to the standard of the *Truth of the Mystery*, the Truth found in the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24).

25. ***"Wherefore having put away the lying, each one speak truth with his neighbor, because we are members of one another."***

Lying is a prominent characteristic of the old man. The devil is the father of the lie, he used the principle of lying to deceive Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden (John 8:44). Here Paul is addressing believers whose old man had been crucified with Christ, had been put off, had been shoved away, but, as we have already observed, constantly kept expressing himself in deeds contrary to the Truth of the Gospel. We must keep in mind that the old man has been forensically crucified with Christ on Calvary, but believers who are alive in Christ have the *responsibility, energized by the Holy Spirit*, to forbid him license to express his sinister works in their lives.

One of the most subtle methods the devil uses to further his cause among believers is *the lie*, "lying" (το ψευδος). Our English word *pseudo* is a transliteration of the Greek word used here. Paul is literally instructing them, that as those who have put away lying, prevarication, and all that is false and pseudo, they should continuously be speaking the Truth. Collectively, to all of them, Paul says, *you are to speak the truth* (λαλειτε αληθειαν). Having made this collective emphasis, he adds the singular, each one (εκαστος) with his "neighbor" (πλησιον), i.e., *the one near him*.

The reason why believers are not to lie, but to speak the truth, is "because we are members of one another." The implication is what some believers were actually lying to one another, for this is inferred by the statement that "we are members of one another." The reciprocal pronoun implies, at the very least, that some were ηseudo and false in their relations with others. In First John 2:21, we note, "Because every lie is not out of the truth," i.e., its source and origin is not the truth, it is the opposite.

26. ***"Be angry and do not sin; let not the sun go down upon your uncontrolled anger,"***

At first glance, the statement "be angry and do not sin," may appear to involve an inherent contradiction (v. 31); however, a closer examination of how this word is used indicates that there is a *justifiable anger*. That which distinguishes anger is the reason and motive behind it and *what or whom* it is directed against. God

the Father and Son are commonly referred to as being angry (Rom. 1:18; 3:5; 9:22; Col. 3:6; Heb. 3:11; Rev. 6:16).

The Greek word translated "be angry" (οργιζεσθε) is in the present tense, imperative mode, and passive voice. The use of the passive voice makes it clear that Paul is not speaking of a humanly generated anger, but of a *Holy Spirit generated anger* against sin and its cause. The use of the imperative mode indicates that he is *commanding* them, in conjunction with the Holy Spirit, to express *indignation* and *rage* against that which is contrary to the Word of God. The present tense suggests that believers are to continuously assume this posture of righteous indignation against all sin, particularly that in their midst.

The declaration, "do not you sin" (αμαρτανετε) is in the second person plural, specifically directed to them as believers, and means that they are *not to continue* (present tense) *in a course of sin, missing the mark,* and *error.* The implication is that anger, indignation, and disgust with sin, personally and collectively, is essential for the cleansing of the local assembly. Certainly, we are justified in being angry with sins in the society in which we live, particularly those which tend to contaminate believers and their families, especially those promulgated through the misuse of our taxes such as teaching the evolutionistic lie and those which condone and encourage sexual promiscuity, but still we are drawn back to the fact, the main emphasis of this verse is that we as believers are to be angry with our sins and stop *continuing to sin*.

Having emphasized the importance of anger against sin in bringing about a cessation of sin in the lives of believers, Paul adds a warning against excessive anger which may get out of control. Even as the first part of this verse is a command, likewise the last part is a command, "Let not the sun go down upon your uncontrolled anger." The Greek word which we have translated "uncontrolled anger" (παροργισμω) is derived from "παρα" and "οργιζω" and literally means *anger beside, beyond anger*, or an *added to anger,* hence an excessive and uncontrolled anger. It is possible for anger and indignation to reach the point where it becomes *counter-productive*, i.e., it may produce loathing,

abhorrence, and emasculation of self and others, resulting in dejection and bitterness rather than a ceasing from sin.

This uncontrolled anger may in itself become the *cause of sin*. Anger beyond control is the enemy of rational thinking and acting. It can lead to irresponsible thoughts and acts. Granted that we believers may have transient flashes of such anger, we may temporarily lose our cool, but Paul is commanding us not to allow this condition to become a permanent state or frame of mind. One may become exceedingly angry during the day, but he has the responsibility in the Spirit to bring it under control, and not to harbor it until the close of the day, or until the sun sets. This is the only time the noun form of the Greek word "παροργισμος" (uncontrolled anger) is used in the New Testament; however, the verb form is used in two instances. In the sixth chapter, verse 4, Paul instructs fathers not to be excessively or uncontrollably angry with or against their children. In Romans 10:19, Paul quotes what God said through Moses to Israel, "On the basis of a nation without understanding I will make you exceedingly angry." Both the etymological and usage meaning of this word sustain the thought of acessive or uncontrolled anger.

27. ***"Neither give place to the devil."***

In the sentence which begins with verse 26 and ends with verse we have four commands: 1) be angry, 2) do not sin, 3) do not let vhe sun set on your excessive anger, and 4) do not give place to the devil. To continue in a state of excessive and uncontrolled anger would make believers vulnerable to the cunning methods of the devil (v. 14). Uncontrolled anger would certainly provide ideal cir: umstances for the devil to lay his snare for believers (1 Tim. 3:7; 2 Tim. 2:26). Instead of giving place to the devil, and succumbing to his methods, Paul instructs believers to be strong to stand against his sly onslaughts (6:11).

28. ***"The one stealing let him no longer steal, but rather let him lsbor working the good with his own hands, that he might have to distribute to the one having need."***

This verse implies that there were some who professed faith in Christ who were still stealing. The participle translated "the one °aling" (κλεπτων) speaks of *one who is a thief* or a *kleptomaniac*. The fact that this participle is in the present tense suggests, at least on the part of some, that their kleptomaniac tendencies were still active. Also, the phrase, "Let him no longer steal" (μηκετι κλεπτετω) means that the thief is *not yet* and *not still* to continue his thievery. This verb is in the imperative mode - it is a definite *command* - this epistle orders all stealing to stop.

The alternative to stealing is *to labor* (κοπτατω). This verb is in the present tense and imperative mode and means that he is *commanded* to continuously *labor and toil until he is tired and weary.* In other words, stealing is to be replaced by *hard, exhaustive work.* This involves the thief "working the good with his own hands." This phrase contains three aspects: first, the present participle "εργαζομενος" indicates that the stealer is to become a *continuous worker*, he is to be productive; second, he is to engage in work "with his own hands" (ταις ιδιαις χερσιν), i.e., he is to do *therapeutic manual work* with the hands which stole; third, this work is to align with "the good" (το αγαθον), *that which supplies man's basic needs* (2:10). Summarizing, he is to continuously do manual labor in the area of good.

The reason the thief is to become a laborer is "that he might have to distribute to the one having need." The Greek infinitive translated distribute (μεταδιδοναι) means that he might share, give to, and aid the one who has physical needs. This could very well include the one from whom he had previously stolen. Our primary interpretation is that "the one having need" would be a believer, but in some instances he could also be a nonbeliever.

29. ***"Every rotten word, let it not go out of your mouth, but if anything is good for edifying according to the need, that it may give grace to the hearers."***

Having dealt with lying, excessive anger, and stealing, Paul now turns his attention to the *speech* of believers. He knew the filthy language of the market place, and he knew that most of those to

whom he is writing had come out of such a background, and he was aware of the fact that the conversion of the tongue takes time. Following the Greek word order, he commands them, "Every rotten word, let it not go out of your mouth." This may also be more freely translated: do not let any rotten word proceed out of your mouth. The Greek word translated "rotten" (σαπρος) basically means that which is *putrid, foul*, and *corrupt*. Jesus uses the same word to describe rotten trees and rotten fruit (Matt. 12:33).

The Greek phrase translated "let it not go out" (μη εκπορευεσθω), is constituted of the preposition "εκ" and the verb "πορευομαι" and conveys the idea of *to go out, pass out,* and *depart from*. Since this verb is in the present tense and imperative mode, Paul is commanding them to never permit a single rotten word to pass their lips. It is natural for rotten speech to flow forth from the depraved, rotten hearts of the unregenerate. Likewise, for those who have been made righteous in Christ (2 Cor. 5:21), and who are filled with the Holy Spirit, it should be natural for our speech to befit this righteousness. To allow rotten speech to go out Of our mouths results from grieving the Spirit and a flashback of the old man (v. 30).

In contrast to the rotten, filthy speech of the world, as emphasized by the Greek conjunction "αλλα," believers are to speak anything which is "good for edifying according to the need." The governing phrase in this statement is "the need" (της χρειας), that which is *useful, necessary*, and *requisite*. If we are among unsaved nen, their need is salvation, and we will speak that which is good or edifying them on this subject, namely that the gospel is the power of God "unto salvation to everyone believing" (Rom. 1:16), and "that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures." If we are among those who are saved, that which is good for edifying "admonishing every man and teaching every man in all wisdom, that we may present every man mature in Christ" (Col. 1:28). Summarizing, the contents of our talk and conversation should always fit the need of those around us - being good for supplying and filling the need.

Having told them that what is good for building-up should be spoken, as determined by the need, Paul adds, "in order that it may give grace to the hearers." The Greek noun translated "grace" (χαριν) basically refers to that which God has freely given to men in this present dispensation (3:2). God uses believers, their mouths, to give His grace to both the lost (2:4-9) and to the saved (1 Cor. 4:10; 2 Cor. 5:20; 9:8). Instead of accommodating the world ssystem, speaking its rotten words, we believers need to recognize that it is our privilege and responsibility to use every occasion to give God's grace to those who will hear us. Keep in mind that Paul addressing these words to all believers - all are to be dispensers of the Grace of God.

30. ***"And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed unto the day of redemption."***

As this statement is placed in the midst of this context, it obviously has reference to what has preceded it as well as what follows it. This means, on the one hand, that lying, excessive anger, stealing, and rotten speech grieve the Holy Spirit. On the other hand, failure to replace these with speaking the truth, laboring to help those in need, and sharing the grace of God with hearers may be even greater sins of omission which grieve the Spirit.

The Greek verb translated "grieve" (λυπειτε) is in the present tense and imperative mode which means that Paul is *commanding* believers *not to continuously* grieve, *cause pain, sorrow*, and *mourning* to the Holy Spirit. This same word is used to depict Jesus' mind-set in Gethsemane (Matt. 26:37). Since this word is always used in the New Testament to describe the mental and emotional status of *persons*, and is used here regarding the Holy Spirit, the conclusion is inescapable - *He is a person*. Generally speaking, we can affirm that any thinking and acting which is contrary to the Word of God given to the Church will grieve the Holy Spirit during this dispensation of grace.

That there may be no misunderstanding as to the identity of the Holy Spirit Paul adds the phrase "of God" (του θεου). The use of the genitive case signifies that the Holy Spirit is *possessed* by God, *belongs* to God, and aligns with total revelation - *He is the*

third person of the Godhead (cf. Matt. 28:19; 2 Cor. 13:13; Jude 20-21).

Further, in identifying the Holy Spirit, Paul says that He is the one "by whom you were sealed unto the day of redemption." We need to carefully examine the meaning and implications of the Greek verb rendered "sealed" (εσφραγισθητε). This verb is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that at a *given point in time,* when they exercised Divine faith in Jesus Christ, they were wrought upon by an *outside agent,* the Holy Spirit, who sealed and secured them as God's very own in the Body of Christ. We have translated the prepositional phrase "εν ω" as *by whom* (instrumental case); however, it may equally well be translated *in whom* (locative case). The instrumental case emphasizes that the Holy Spirit is *the one doing the sealing*, while the locative case points to *the sphere in which believers are sealed*, namely the Holy Spirit. If we go the locative route we must acknowledge that in conjunction with our position in the Holy Spirit, we are sealed and secured in the Body of Christ of which the Holy Spirit is an integral part and into which He baptizes us (1 Cor. 12:13).

Paul declares that this sealing work of the Holy Spirit extends out in the future "unto the day of redemption." The Greek preposition "εις" used with the accusative case *very definitely affirms* that this sealing work *holds believers fast and secure* until the '`day of redemption" (ημεραν απολυτρωσεως). This is the only time the phrase "day of redemption" is used in the New Testament; however, the idea of a future redemption is clear (Rom. 8:23; Eph. 1:14). Also, Paul says that the Spirit Himself is the guarantor that we will inherit our glorified bodies (Rom. 8:30; Phil. 3:21), a guarantee which will be actualized on the day of redemption (Eph. 1:13-14; 2 Cor. 1:22; 5:5). Summarizing, the sealing work of the Holy Spirit secures us in Christ and *guarantees that we will inherit redeemed, glorified bodies* like Christ.

31. ***"And all bitterness and wrath and anger and clamor and blasphemy, let it be taken away from you, with all evil."***

In this verse Paul commands that five specific things be removed from the lives of believers plus every form of evil. It is important to note that the verb in this verse is in the aorist tense, imperative mode, and the passive voice. This means that Paul is commanding believers to allow an *outside agent*, God the Holy Spirit, in a once for all *single transaction*, to *take, lift*, and *remove* these things rom them. On the one hand, the imperative mode of command indicates that believers hold the key which determines their spiritual growth. On the other hand, in response to the proper use of this the Holy Spirit is the *one who produces* spiritual maturity. When the Holy Spirit, conjoined with the human spirit, is given the green light to cleanse believers of sin, we have Divine cleansing as opposed to ineffectual human reformation (Matt. 12:43-45). Since Paul directs what he says to the minds of believers, we logically assume that the key to spirituality centers in the mind and will, not merely on a human plane, but under the influence of the Holy Spirit (Phil. 2:13; 2 Tim. 3:12).

Preceding the list of five things in this verse Paul uses the word "all" (πασα). Even though not repeated, we understand that this word equally applies to each of the items following it. Since it is in the singular it may also be translated *every expression* or *every vestige* of each of these things is to be removed. It emphasizes the need for a thorough cleansing from each of these sins.

The first negative sin which is to be stripped from the lives of believers is "bitterness" (πικρια). This word describes an attitude which is commonly indulged in by the unsaved. It is a *bitter, sour*, and *harsh* frame of mind generally directed against persons or God. Peter uses this word to describe the condition of Simon in Samaria (Acts 8:23). Paul uses it to define the condition of sinners, a context in which it is closely associated with cursing (Rom. 3:14). The Hebrews are warned against becoming bitter and many being defiled by it (Heb. 12:15).

The second sin which is to be taken from believers is "wrath" (θυμος). It conveys the idea of *strong swellings of passion and rage.* It is designated as one of the works of the flesh (Gal. 5:19-20). It is a sin which the Colossians are to put away (middle voice;

Col. 3:8). Paul never uses it to depict the wrath of God; however, John does in the Book of Revelation.

The third sin which is to be removed is "anger" (οργη). This noun expresses the idea of *anger, indignation, vengeance*, and *punishment*. Paul commonly uses it to describe God's anger and wrath against sinners (Rom. 1:18; Col. 3:6). He uses the verb form once with reference to the anger of believers against sin (v. 26), and justifies its use as such, but *always condemns what the noun form depicts* in the lives of believers (Col. 3:8; 1 Tim. 2:8).

The fourth sin which is to be taken from believers is "clamor" (κραυγη). This noun is used only six times in the New Testament and has no evil connotations except in the verse before us. The verb form of this word is frequently used, most commonly with the idea of to make oneself heard by crying out or shouting (Matt. 9:27; Mark 9:24; Rom. 8:15). Sometimes it is used of the frenzy cry of mobs clamoring for vengeance (Matt. 27:23; Acts 7:57; 19:28; 21:28, 36). Paul is apparently commanding believers to allow the Holy Spirit to restrain them from riotous, clamorous, mob situations.

The fifth sin which is to be lifted away from believers is "blasphemy" (βλασφημια). Our English word *blasphemy* is a transliteration of the Greek word used here, and it basically means calumny, slandering, and reproach. In Matthew 12:24-32, we learn that blasphemy was to attribute the work of the Holy Spirit to the devil (Beelzebul) and to speak *against* (κατα) Jesus or the Spirit (v. 32). In short, blasphemy is an effort to *destroy the integrity* of a person. According to First Timothy 6:3-4, blasphemy results when men refuse to follow the sound words of Jesus Christ for this Church age (cf. Col. 3:8).

Recognizing that the five sins listed above cover only some of their most glaring problems, Paul adds the phrase, "with all evil." The Greek word for "evil" (κακια) is a general term which includes all *wickedness, wrongness, badness*, etc., all that is opposed to righteousness. As those who have been made righteous in Christ (2 Cor. 5:21) our lives are to be free from that which is contrary to it, e., we are commanded to allow the Holy Spirit to remove all evil from us.

31. ***"Be you kind unto one another, compassionate, forgiving yourselves as also God in Christ forgave you."***

In the forepart of this paragraph, verses 25-31, Paul dealt primarily with the need to replace negative with positive qualities and ordered them to allow the Spirit to eradicate all evil from their life-style. All that he has said was preparing the way for the pinnacle truth set forth in this verse. Here we have one of the finest statements to be found in the New Testament of how believers ought to mutually relate to one another. If we began to practice what Paul says here men would again see the *revolutionary power of the Gospel* (Acts 17:6).

As we approach this verse we recognize that it has *one leading verb* which applies to the three concepts following it. This verb is in the present tense and imperative mode which means that it is a *command* which is to *continuously* be carried out. We have translated it “Be you" (γινεσθε). This verb places the *responsibility* upon believers, those who are spiritually alive in Christ, synchronized with the Holy Spirit, to obey and carry out the commands given in this verse, namely to be kind, compassionate, and forgiving (Rom. 6:16.)

First, Paul says, "Be you kind unto one another." The Greek word translated "kind" (χρηστοι) is derived from the verb "χραομαι" which means *to use* or *make use of.* Behind the concept of being kind is doing something that is useful. This means that kind believers are going to *provide* one another with that which is *useful for their spiritual and physical welfare.* When Jesus said His yoke is kind (χρηστος) he was referring to its *usefulness* and *beneficence* for the person assuming it (Matt. 11:30). Paul uses this word and its cognates most frequently regarding God (Rom. 2:4; 11:22; Eph. 2:7). Believers are to *reciprocally* (αλληλους) express this useful kindness unto *each other* (Gal. 5:22; Col. 3:12).

Second, Paul commands them to be "compassionate" (ευσπλαγχνοι) unto one another. This Greek noun is derived from

"ευ" and "σπλαγχνον" and very literally means to have a *good intestine feeling, a good gut feeling,* i.e., a good feeling toward one another from the depth of one's physical being. Physiologically, it appears that it is in this area that we sense the deepest feelings when tragedy strikes those close to us, such as loss of appetite and helpless pity. As we grope for the best way to bring the meaning of this word over into English we feel the words *compassionate* and *tenderhearted* are acceptable. The only other time this particular word is used, with the prefix "ευ," is by Peter, who commends it as an admirable Christian characteristic (1 Peter 3:8).

Again we observe that the reciprocal pronoun "αλληλους," translated *one another*, applies to this noun. Paul commands us as believers to have deep feelings of compassionate concern and caring for one another. We are to have an empathetic sensitiveness to the spiritual and emotional needs of other members in the Body of Christ. This word, apart from the prefix "ευ," is used by Paul several times with practically the same meaning. In Philippians he speaks of compassion as a characteristic of Christ (1:8; 2:1). He instructs the Colossians to put on compassion (3:12). Summarizing, all believers, not just those in local assemblies, are to show a genuine mutual compassionate concern for each other as fellowmembers of the Body of Christ.

Third, Paul commands believers to mutually be "forgiving yourselves." The Greek participle rendered "forgiving" (χαριζομενοι) basically means *showing grace, graciousness, freely giving;* hence, it often conveys the idea of forgiving. Sad to say, but it is true, on the basis of both biblical and historical facts, no believer has reached a state of perfection. Regardless of how mature believers may be, as long as there is sin in their lives, there will be a continual need to forgive one another. God's grace is the basic ingredient in this process. Grace prompts believers to ask for forgiveness, and grace *enables* believers *to grant* forgiveness. The language used here declares that this is a mutual process between believers - it leaves no room for a father confessor (1 Tim. 2:5). We have a companion statement to this in Colossians 3:13, where

Paul says, "upholding one another and forgiving yourselves if anyone against anyone may have a complaint."

Having declared that believers are to reciprocally forgive one another, Paul cites the supreme example of this, "as also God in Christ forgave you." When we were dead in trespasses and sins, God saved us by His grace (Eph. 2:1-9). For God to be just, and to simultaneously forgive sinners, by grace He provided a substitute for man's sin, Jesus Christ on Calvary. Even as God has forgiven ıs in Christ, in the sphere of His substitutionary death, likewise, we are to forgive members of His Body (Col. 3:13). It is very important to note that God took the *initiative* in providing a sacrifice for our sin, on the basis of this sacrifice we are forgiven, and *because we are forgiven* we are in a position to forgive others. Furthermore, the example of how God has forgiven us illustrates how we are to forgive one another. In this dispensation of grace, God the Holy Spirit uses the principle of grace in the process of conforming believers to His Word. Contrast the *principle of grace* for this Church age with the principle of law for the Kingdom age (Matt. 6:12, 14-15).

Chapter 5

1. ***"Be you therefore imitators of God, as beloved children,"***

This verse begins with the same verb as the previous verse; Paul is *commanding* them to *continually* be imitators of God. The Greek noun translated "imitators" (μιμηται) conveys the idea of *patterning* and *modeling* their lifestyle after God. It may be translated *followers* to the extent that it emphasizes identity with God's actions. The thought here is obviously an extension of the ηreceding verse; believers are to be imitators and followers of God in forgiving one another. In other words, His pattern in forgiving m is to be *our pattern* in forgiving ourselves, i.e., me forgiving you and you forgiving me.

Having declared that we are to be imitators of God, Paul adds the phrase "as beloved children." He is apparently looking at God as the Father and believers as the children in the Family of God. The Greek word translated "beloved" (αγαπητα) refers to those ho are the *recipients of God's love*. It is a title given, not on the ¯ais of what one is, but on the basis of *who one is.* In the Synoptic gospels it is used almost exclusively of Jesus Christ (Matt. 3:17; `ark 1:11; Luke 9:35). Paul uses it of the carnal Corinthians, of e more spiritually minded Philippians, and of individuals associated with him (1 Cor. 4:14; Phil. 2:12; 2 Tim. 1:20). As those who were the recipients of God's sovereign love (1:4-5), as those who are the objects of His love, they are to pattern their lives after His grace.

2. ***"and walk in love, even as also Christ loved us and gave himself up for us an offering and a sacrifice to God unto an odor of a sweet smell."***

In the latter part of the previous verse Paul orders believers to continually forgive themselves, and he uses *God's example* of forgiving to reinforce his point. In this verse his main point is that believers are to continually "walk in love," and he uses *Christ's example* to stimulate believers to do so. The Greek word translated "walk" (περιπατειτε) comes from the preposition "περι" and the verb "πατεω" and literally means to *walk around, walk about*, hence, it

refers to the way believers *live*, their *conduct* and *lifestyle*. Since this verb is in the present tense and imperative mode, it means that we believers are *commanded* to *continuously* walk in the sphere of love (locative case). If we interpret the phrase "εν αγαπη" as in the instrumental case, which would be possible, then the thought is that we are to walk *by love, by means of love*. In the first case our walk and life is to be *surrounded by love*, and in the latter case our walk is *motivated, impelled*, and *undergirded* by love. Regardless of which case we prefer, with its emphasis, this verse makes it clear that love is to both *circumscribe and motivate the way believers live.*

In dealing with this verse we need to consider the *nature of love, what is love?* In view of what follows in this verse *love is objective*, it is an attitude which reaches out unto others *to help and benefit them,* and it is willing to make any sacrifice which is necessary to do this. Love is not a static concept, but a *dynamic expression* of the truth of God's Word toward others (1 Cor. 8:1; 13:4; 16:14; Gal. 5:6; Eph. 4:2; 1 Thess. 1:3; Heb. 6:10).

Since Christ's love toward us is used as an example of how we are to walk in love, let us examine the manner in which He loved us. Paul says "He gave himself up for us an offering and a sacrifice to God unto an odor of a sweet smell." The phrase translated "He gave himself up" (παρεδωκεν εαυτον) is in the aorist tense and means that *at a given point* in history *He gave himself over* and *delivered himself up* to death on the Cross. The active voice indicates that *He himself* both made and carried out the decision to die on behalf of sinners. Jesus' statement in John 10:11 verifies this, for He says, "I am the good shepherd; the good shepherd lays down his life on behalf of the sheep."

The fact that He died at a given point in time, a death never to be repeated nor reenacted as in the Mass, is clearly affirmed in the New Testament. In Romans 6:10, Paul says, for the death "which He dies, He died to sin once-for-all." In Hebrews 7:27, speaking of how the priests had to first make an offering for their own sins, the writer says of Jesus, "having offered himself he did this once-for-all." Hebrews 10:10 indicates that according to God's will "we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ

once-for-all." The Greek word translated "once-for-all" (εφαπαξ), in all the above passages, conveys the idea of a sacrifice which is *effective for all time.*

Now let us consider the significance of the statement that He gave himself up "for us" (υπερ ημων), *on behalf of us, in place of us*, or *instead of us.* This certainly emphasizes the fact that He became our sin-substitute. According to Romans 6:23, "the wages of sin is death." Since Jesus lived an apart-from-sin life (Heb. 4:15) there was no cause of death in Him, hence He was qualified to assume the sins of others. Paul's point here is that love prompted Him, the perfectly qualified one, to assume the responsibility for our sin, even death, and to die in our place (Luke 22:20; 1 Cor. 15:3). Theologically speaking, this is known as the substitutionary atonement (Isaiah 53:4-6).

Jesus Christ died for us that He might give himself as an "offering and a sacrifice to God unto an odor of a sweet smell." The Greek word rendered "offering" (προσφοραν) literally means *that which is brought to,* hence *that which is offered up* or *an offering*. The Greek noun for "sacrifice" (θυσιαν) speaks of *that which is killed in sacrifice,* hence *the thing sacrificed* or *the innocent victim*. In this verse we note that *Jesus himself* (εαυτον), in His very person, was that which was offered and sacrificed. This truth is conurmed in Hebrews 10:10, where we read, "we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ" (cf. Heb. 10:14). Also, in Hebrews 9:26, we are told that now at the end of the ages He has been manifested unto the end to put away sin through the sacrifice of himself" (cf. Heb. 10:12). Keep in mind, according to this verse, love motivated Jesus to give Himself as an offering and sacrifice for us.

Finally, we see that Jesus gave Himself as an offering and a sacrifice "to God unto an odor of a sweet smell." Man's sin is a direct affront, act of defiance, and rebellion against God. If God, who in His nature is just, holy, and righteous is going to maintain the integrity of His person, and at the same time forgive sin, there must be a just compensation for sin. According to Romans 3:24-26, God maintains His righteousness and justness on the basis of the

compensation provided by Jesus Christ giving Himself as an offering and sacrifice to God. Paul describes the offering and sacrifice of Jesus Christ as an "odor of a sweet smell" (οσμην ευωδιας). These Greek nouns respectively mean a *smell or odor* and a *sweet smell, good odor,* or *what is fragrant*. The obvious meaning of this phrase is that Jesus' personal offering and sacrifice was *highly pleasing and acceptable to God*, enabling Him to simultaneously be just and to justify sinners (Phil. 4:18).

3. ***"But fornication and all uncleanness or covetousness let it not be named among you, as proper for saints,"***

Thus far in this chapter Paul has instructed them to do two positive things: 1) they are to be imitators of God, and 2) they are to walk in love. In this verse he commands them to stay away from fornication, uncleanness, and covetousness. The Greek noun translated "fornication" (πορνεια) primarily refers to illicit sexual relations outside of marriage (1 Сот. 7:2; 1 Thess. 4:3); between those unmarried and married (1 Cor. 5:1); and by those who are married (Matt. 5:32). It is much more frequently used than the noun for adultery (μοιχεια), which is never used by the Apostle Paul.

The Pauline Epistles take a very firm stand against every form of fornication. In First Corinthians 6:13, he says, "the body is not for fornication, but for the Lord." In verse 18, he commands them to "flee from fornication ... and the one fornicating sins against his own body." In Galatians 5:19, Paul lists fornication as one of the works of the flesh. In Colossians 3:5, Paul instructs those at Colossae to "put to death therefore the members upon the earth, fornication" being the first sin he mentions. In First Thessalonians 4:3, he says, "For this is the will of God, your sanctification, that you abstain from fornication." Where there is a lack of self-control, Paul's answer to fornication is marriage (1 Cor. 7:2).

The second thing they are to stay away from is "all uncleanness" (ακαθαρσια πασα). With the exception of Matthew 23:27, this word is exclusively used by Paul, a total of 9 times. It may mean uncleanness in a general sense, however, Paul most commonly uses it in contexts which are dealing with *sexual uncleanness*. This

is obvious in Romans 1:24, where in uncleanness they dishonor their bodies among themselves. It is often associated with the word fornication, as in the verse before us, making the two bedfellows (2 Cor. 12:21; Gal. 5:19; Col. 3:5; 1 Thess. 4:3-7). This is actually a second rap against sexual sins.

The third thing they are to stay away from is "covetousness" (πλεονεξια). This Greek word means *taking advantage of, grasping,* and *overreaching another*. It is used of a grasping for material things and of overreaching in the sexual sphere (2 Cor. 9:5; Eph. 4:19; 1 Thess. 2:5; 4:6). In Colossians 3:5, it is defined as *idolatry*, the worshiping of something.

Paul says that none of the foregoing sins are to be named among you. This implies that fornication, uncleanness, and covetousness are not to be designated nor mentioned in their midst as something "proper" (πρεπει), fitting, and suitable for saints to practice (1 Cor. 5:11).

4. ***"neither filthiness and foolish talking or jesting, which are not fitting, but rather giving thanks."***

The sentence, of which this verse is a part, began with verse 3. Picking up the train of thought, Paul is saying, "neither let it be named among you ... also filthiness and foolish talking or jesting." Previously he told them not to even mention fornication, uncleanness, and covetousness as acceptable practices for saints - away with such a thought! In the latter part of the sentence as we have it in this verse, he adds three additional things seemingly associated with the mouth, sins which *do not come up to* Christian standards.

The Greek word translated "filthiness" (αισχροτης) literally speaks of that which is *deformed*, the opposite of good, hence that which is *indecent, dishonorable,* and *shameful*. Since the other two words in this series of three deal with improper speech flowing out of the mouth, this word is apparently referring to indecent and shameful speaking (cf. v. 12). As used by the Apostle Paul, this word is not used in conjunction with licentious sexual sins, as mentioned above, but to define less serious acts such as breaking

human customs (1 Cor. 11:6; 14:35). The translation "filthiness," a common translation, tends to be too strong; a better rendering could be *shameful* or *dishonorable* speaking.

The Greek word rendered "foolish talking" (μωρολογια) is derived from the words "μωρος" and "λογος" and means *moron speech*, hence *dull, stupid,* and *foolish talk*. This is the only time this word is used in the New Testament; however, on the basis of it' components its meaning is evident. Its meaning in the classical Greek is the same - *silly talk.*

The Greek word translated "jesting" (ευτραπελια) is used only here in the New Testament. It is derived from "ευ" and "τρεπω" and basically means *turning* and *guiding well*, hence, as used in the classical Greek, it means *wittiness, liveliness,* and *pleasantry*. If Paul is using it with this same meaning in mind, then it appears that he is looking at undue wittiness, pleasantry, and facetiousness as negative nonedifying things, and a waste of time. On the other hand, he may be looking at wittiness bordering on ribaldry, indulgence in coarse language and vulgar jokes. As we consider the standard for believers set forth here it is appropriate that we keep both possible meanings in mind, for we are to continuously be "redeeming the time, because the days are evil" (v. 16).

Regarding shameful, foolish, and jesting speech, Paul says, "which are not fitting." The Greek word translated "fitting" (ανηκεν) literally means to *come up* to a given standard, hence, that which is *fitting, becoming,* and *appropriate*. Paul's use of this word posits the fact that there was a basic standard for Christian speech, and that these three things do not meet that standard. This meaning is verified by its use in Colossians 3:18, where wives are to be aligned under their husbands as is *fitting*. According to the Truth given to the Church, Philemon had a standard, he knew how to fittingly relate to Onesimus (Phile. 8). Thus we note, shameful, foolish, and jesting talk are not placed in the same category with fornication, uncleanness, and covetousness; however, they are things which *fall below the accepted Christian standard* and are to be eliminated.

Thus far in this fifth chapter we have been given two positive commands: 1) we are to be imitators of God; 2) we are to walk in love. Paul now adds a third command, instead of being involved in things which are improper and unfitting, he emphatically says, rather we are to be "giving thanks" (ευχαριστια). This word is derived from "ευ" and "χαρις" and basically means *good grace,* hence it is an expression of *gratitude, gratefulness,* and *thankfulness to God.* Shameful, foolish, and jesting conversations are to be replaced by conversations which major in thanking God for His marvelous grace.

5. ***"For you certainly know this, that every fornicator or unclean person or covetous man, who is an idolater, does not have inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God."***

Whereas in verse 3, Paul condemned the presence of fornication, uncleanness, and covetousness among believers, he now speaks of the plight of the person engaging in these sins. The phrase we have translated "you certainly know" (ιστε γινωσκοντες) consists of a verb and participle, *both meaning to know*. This is obviously purposeful redundance to emphasize the fact that they *knew, beyond any shadow of doubt*, that the one committing these sins would be deprived of inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God.

Granting that this letter was written as an encyclical epistle, primarily to the churches in Asia, how can Paul be so sure they knew the consequences of the above sexual sins? According to the historical background in the Book of Acts, when Paul was forced out of the synagogue in Ephesus, "he daily dialogued in the school of Tyrannus. This took place for two years, so that all those dwelling in Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks" (Acts 19:9-10). In his final words to the Ephesian elders, Paul also says, "Wherefore you watch, remembering that for three years night and day I did not cease admonishing each one of you with tears" (Acts 20:31). As a result of this intense daily ministry at Ephesus, continuing from the beginning in the Synagogue and then the school of Tyrannus for *up to three years*, all Asia heard

the Word, churches were established, and believers knew that God's judgment rested upon those involved in sexual sins.

Now let us look at the statement that the covetous man is an "idolater" (ειδωλολατρης), one who worships idols. As we observed in discussing covetousness in verse 3, a covetous man focuses his attention on various *objects* such as *material wealth, power*, and *sex*. The objects which a covetous man grasps after and endeavors to possess become his idols, hence he is called an idolater.

Those to whom Paul is writing knew that the habitual fornicator, unclean person, and covetous man "does not have inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God." The Greek word translated "inheritance" (κληρονομιαν) *looks forward to receiving a future possession in the future kingdom of Christ and of God*. Paul's use of the word "inheritance" precludes the thought that this kingdom is to be identified with the Church, the Body of Christ (cf. 1 Cor. 6:9-10; Gal. 5:19-21; 1 Peter 1:4). Of course, these habitual sinners are not members of the Body of Christ, and because they are not, they have no future inheritance in the future kingdom.

6. ***"Let no one deceive you with empty words, for because of these things the wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience."***

The statement, "Let no one deceive you with empty words," implies that there were many roving around endeavoring to deceive the early Christians. The Greek verb translated "deceive" (απατατω) means to *lead into error, to cheat*, and *to delude*. Regardless of who the person may be, his position, prestigious claims, and degrees, Paul says, *don't let him deceive you*. In First Timothy 2:14, this same word is used to describe Adam, for we read, "and Adam was not deceived." Paul associates this deceiving process with the old man, "the one being corrupted according to the lusts of deceit," i.e., Satan appeals to certain lusts and desires of the flesh as an avenue to deception (4:22).

If we are going to be on guard against being deceived, we need to know the means used to deceive, namely, "empty words." The

Greek phrase rendered "empty words" (κενοις λογοις) means words and speech *void of substance, destitute of value*, or that are merely a *sounding vacuum*. First, the thought is that these deceivers do not have any substance behind their criticism of the Gospel. In fact, they do not know what the Gospel is; therefore, are incapable of intelligently refuting it (1 Cor. 2:14). Second, these deceivers do not have anything of substance and value to offer in place of the Gospel. Their promises, cast in persuasive speech, are nothing more than a hollow vacuum. Colossians 2:8, enlarges on the meaning of this verse, for it reads, "Take heed lest anyone shall lead you away as prey through philosophy and empty deceit, according to the tradition of men, according to the principles of the world, and not according to Christ."

Having warned them against allowing any person to deceive them, Paul goes on to say, "for because of these things the wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience." The pronoun translated "these things" (ταυτα) refers back to the things mentioned in verses 3-5, particularly, to the gross sexual sins of fornication, sexual uncleanness, and uncontrolled covetousness in the sphere of sex. Some had apparently been trying to deceive them into thinking that they should and could still indulge in these practices, but Paul's answer is *an emphatic no!* These are the very sins which call forth the wrath of God upon the sons of disobedience. Paul has already made it clear that the one habitually practicing these sins has no inheritance in the future kingdom, and now he adds that this is the reason God pours out His wrath upon the sons of disobedience.

The phrase translated "the wrath of God" (η οργη του θεου) is commonly used in the Bible. It refers to *God's anger, indignation*, and passion against sinners, those unsaved, who totally disobey His Word. The person who professes to be Christian, but who habituallly practices these sins, thereby invalidates his profession, reveals it as false, and categorizes himself among the sons of disobedience destined for the wrath of God. In contrast to the wrath of God coming upon the sons of disobedience (2:2; Col. 3:6), those who are sons of God (Rom. 8:19; Gal. 3:26) will be saved from the com:ng wrath (Rom. 5:9; 1 Thess. 1:10). In conclusion, let no one deceive you, the one who emptily professes to be saved by God's Grace, but at the same time is wallowing in these sexual sins, is

self deceived (James 1:26), and is destined to suffer the wrath of God (Rom. 1:18).

7. ***"Therefore do not be partakers with them"***

The Greek particle translated "therefore" (ουν) logically ties what follows to what has preceded. In view of the fact that the wrath of God is coming upon the sons of disobedience, therefore, do not be partakers with them" or you will suffer the same consequences. The Greek noun translated "partakers" (χαρι) comes from a combining of "ουν" and "μετα" and "εχω" and basically means to *hold together with*, hence, to be *partakers with, sharers with*, and *partners with.* Since the Greek word for "them" (αυτων) is in the genitive case, a common usage in the Greek language, the full thought is that believers are not to share in all the *things which belong to* the sons of disobedience, i.e., in their sins and lifestyle. This verse strongly emphasizes the need for believers, true members of the Body of Christ, to separate themselves from the licentious sexual lifestyle of the sons of disobedience (cf. 1 Cor. 6:14-17; 1 Tim. 5:22). Neither should we subject our young children to the humanistic, contrary-to-the Scriptures, sex courses being offered under the guise of education in our public schools!

8. ***"for you were once darkness, but now are light in the Lord; walk as children of light"***

Having ordered them not to share the abominable lifestyle of the sons of disobedience, Paul reminds them that they were once in the same category, at which time their status was *darkness*, but now their status is *light*. In other words, he gives natural men in the flesh two different names. The first one based on *what they do,* they are disobedient to God, hence are called sons of disobedience. The second name based on *what they are*, namely, *darkness*. Paul commonly refers to sinners as being darkness (2 Cor. 6:14; 1 Thess. 5:5), or in the sphere of darkness (1 Thess. 5:4).

The Greek adverb translated "now" (νυν) is dramatically used by the Apostle Paul to show that a *great change* has taken place.

Once they were darkness, but *now* they are just the opposite - they are "light" (φως) in the Lord. God is referred to as light (1 John 1:5; 1 Thess. 5:5; 1 Peter 2:9). Jesus Christ is designated as the light (John 1:8-9; 3:19-21). In as much as God the Father and Son are light, it logically follows that those in the Lord are also light (Col. 1:12; 1 Thess. 5:5). The devil and all natural men in the flesh exist in the sphere of darkness, whereas the Lord and all His saints exist in the sphere of the light and are designated as light. The moment God sovereignly *puts one in the Lord* he is transferred out of the realm of darkness into the realm of light. It is obvious that no one can effect this transfer himself. *Only God* is able to snatch one from Satan's control and transfer him into the light in the Lord (John 6:44; Gal. 1:4; Col. 1:13).

When one is made alive in Christ, joined together with Him in the light, he is spiritually living and *responsible* for his thoughts and actions. Paul never tries to tell the person who is dead in satanic darkness how to live, for dead men cannot respond, but he does emphasize the need for those who are alive in the light to live according to the standard for their new life in Christ. This standard is set forth in the New Testament epistles of which those written by the Apostle Paul are the heart. God's saving us by His grace, giving us Divine life, and identifying us with Himself in the light, has as its object a good-works lifestyle (Eph. 2:10).

9. ***"(for the fruit of the light is in all goodness and righteousness and truth),"***

The Majority text reads: "(for the fruit of the Spirit is in all goodness and righteousness and truth)." In view of the context we consider that the reading "fruit of the light" aligns best with the original manuscript. The Majority text was apparently influenced by Galatians 5:22-23; however, only the word "goodness" (αγαθωσυνη) is common to both passages. Even though we follow the flow of the context, and recognize that the lifestyle of believers is to be *in keeping* with the fact that they are children of the light, we also recognize that a fruitful lifestyle is the work of the Holy Spirit. The reading "the fruit of the light" emphasizes the *kind* of fruit they are to have; it is to be fruit which is produced by and conforms to the light. Since the word light (φως) is descriptive of

Deity, of which the Spirit is a part, the meaning of these two readings merges into one, with only a slightly different emphasis.

Having instructed them to walk as children of light in the ηrevious verse, Paul now proceeds to tell them what such a walk in. olves. He draws a word picture showing the light producing fruit. This fruit is in three different spheres: 1) in all goodness, 2) in all righteousness, and 3) in all truth.

Now let us briefly examine these three nouns which describe the spheres in which believers are to walk. The Greek word translated "goodness" (αγαθωσυνη) is a very *general term* mean the opposite of badness (κακος). Paul is the only one who uses this word in the New Testament (four times total) and always with a literal meaning. This word is like an umbrella which covers many specific acts of goodness delineated in the New Testament epistles.

The Greek word translated "righteousness" (δικαιοσυνη) is also a *general term.* It conveys the idea of *that which is right* as opposed to that which is wrong, i.e., as judged by God's absolute standards. Paul is the major user of this word in the New Testament. He uses it with reference to God (Rom. 3:5; 10:3), Jesus Christ (Rom. 10:4; 1 Cor. 1:30), to describe that which God freely gives by grace (Rom. 3:21-22; Phil. 3:9), and to depict a righteous lifestyle before God (Rom. 6:13; Phil. 1:11; 1 Tim. 6:11). The fruit of the light involves doing all that is right, according to the Truth given to the Church, in the sphere of righteousness.

Last, the fruit of the light is in the sphere of all truth. The Greek word translated "truth" (αληθεια) is used here regarding the specific Truth given to the Church. It is specific in that it is limited to the Truth for this present church age. It is general in that it encompasses all the Truth for this present dispensation of grace. In speaking of this Truth in Second Timothy 2:15, Paul says that believers are to hold a straight course in it, i.e., it is to be the Truth on which we focus our attention. As children of light, we are to live in the sphere of all truth, which means that we must know the Divine Truth revealed to and through the Apostle Paul for the Church.

10. ***"proving what is well-pleasing to the Lord"***

As those who are *light* in the Lord, the walk of believers is to conform *to what they are*, which entails living in the sphere of all goodness, righteousness, and truth, and as they do this they need to be "proving what is well-pleasing to the Lord." The Greek participle translated "proving" (δοκιμαζοντες) basically means *proving through testing, trying, scrutinizing,* and *examining*. A quick examination of how Paul uses this word will help us grasp its meaning. In Romans 12:2, he exhorts believers to be transformed unto the end that they may "prove what is the will of God," i.e., through testing and scrutinizing. In Philippians 1:10, Paul desires that the love of believers may abound in the sphere of perfect knowledge and all discernment, "unto the end that you prove the things differing." This means that they are to test and scrutinize the contents of the Bible, recognize that it does contain truth given for different Divine economies, and major in the Truth given to the Church.

Another very significant passage which throws additional light on the verse before us is First Thessalonians 5:21, where Paul instructs them, "prove all things, hold fast to the good." When Paul wrote this statement to the Thessalonians this epistle would be their sole written guide for Christian conduct in this Church age. The only other data they had was what he had taught them while he was at Thessalonica (Acts 17:2-3). Likewise, in writing this encyclical epistle to the various churches, Paul recognized that its contents may have been the only guide some of them had to steer aright their Christian walk, i.e., apart from what had been orally transmitted to them. In other words, these early believers had very little information regarding the details of the Christian walk.

The Christian walk in this Church age is based upon grace. Many general principles are involved in the application of grace to the lifestyle of believers. Faced with the problem of applying these principles to their daily lives, the Corinthians had many blank spots, which caused them to send a series of questions to Paul. Together with answers to these questions, plus answers to other problems Paul knew they had, we have some very choice information in First

Corinthians on what God's will is in like situations. Scattered throughout Paul's fourteen epistles we have many applications of the principle of grace, and we can see how it is to be applied without actually testing and proving it. When we meet new situations, for which we have no precedent in the New Testament epistles, then we need to test and scrutinize how we should apply the general principles given to us, that in turn we do that which is pleasing to the Lord.

Thus we need to acknowledge that the position of these early believers, prior to the availability of all the New Testament Church Epistles, was different from our position today. They had to carefully examine, scrutinize, and test how they should act in each situation so as to conform to the general principles of the faith. As believers today we have a much more detailed compendium of Truth for the Church, including all the principles revealed, and for the most part, examples of the application of these principles to real life situations. Even as most legal cases are determined on the bases of precedent, how the same law was applied in a former court case, likewise, God the Holy Spirit has handed down to us in the New Testament all the information we need to live lives pleasing to the Lord (Rom. 12:1; 2 Cor. 5:9; Heb. 13:21).

11. ***"and do not participate in the unfruitful works of darkness, but rather even reprove,"***

The central phrase in this verse is "the unfruitful works of darkness" and the attitude of believers toward them. Negatively speaking, they are not to participate in them. Positively speaking, they are to actively reprove them. The Greek verb translated "participate in" (συγκοινωνειτε) is derived from "συν" and "κοινωνος" and literally means that believers are not to have *in common with*, hence, *partake with, share with,* or *have fellowship with.* In Revelation 18:4, this verb is used in a similar manner. In the wake of the fall of Babylon the Great, a voice out of heaven says, "My people, come out of her, that you may not *participate in* her sins, and that you may not receive of her plagues." In First Timothy 5:22, Paul uses the basic form of this word in a like context, where he says, "Do not quickly lay hands on anyone, neither *participate* [κοινωνει] in the sins of strangers; keep yourself pure."

This is the only time the phrase "the unfruitful works of darkness" is used in the New Testament. It refers to works in Satan's domain (6:12) produced by his captives (5:8). The Greek word rendered "unfruitful" (ακαρποις) means that these works are *without fruit, barren,* and *valueless.* We must keep in mind that if there is going to be any fruit in the life of a human being, it must be produced by God the Holy Spirit (Gal. 5:22-23), for darkness is incapable of producing anything but noxious barrenness before God. Paul also refers to these "unfruitful works of darkness" as *works of darkness* (Rom. 13:12), *works of the flesh* (Gal. 5:19), and *evil works* (Col. 1:21). We need to acknowledge that God judges works, not on the basis of their external appearance, but on the basis of the *motivation* behind them (Matt. 6:2-4).

Believers are to not only refrain from the unfruitful works of darkness, but they are to actively reprove them. The Greek verb translated "reprove" (ελεγχετε) means they are to *rebuke* and *refute*, hence, *convince* and *convict* those involved in these works that they are sinning against God. We must not interpret this to mean that believers are to spend their time reproving the world. Such an interpretation would be inconsistent with First Corinthians 5:11-12, where Paul says, "But now I have written to you not to mingle with anyone *named a brother* if he may be a fornicator or covetous or an idolater or a reviler or a drunkard or an extortioner, with such a one not to eat. For what business do I have judging those *outside*? Don't you yourselves judge those inside?" In the verse before us Paul is ordering believers to reprove and rebuke the infiltration of the works of darkness in their midst. Believers in local assemblies are to convict the carnally-minded in their midst that these evil works are contrary to God's righteous standard (cf. 1 Tim. 5:20; Titus 1:9).

12. ***"for it is a shame to even speak of the secret things being done by them"***

This verse emphasizes how disgraceful the above mentioned works of darkness were to the Apostle Paul. To explicitly delineate these nauseating gutter sins would have shown very poor taste, a sensual level to which he refused to stoop, for such may well have incited instead of dampening the lusts of the flesh. The unreserved portrayal

of sins, that one may more clearly condemn them, had the potential to stir up latent flesh-desires and to do more harm than good. Education, particularly in the sphere of the desires and lusts of the flesh, when taught void of the dynamic-moral-restraints of the Word of God, commonly increases licentiousness and sexual promiscuity. Indulging minds in that which is evil is contrary to the Bible. In Romans 16:19, Paul says, "I want you to be wise in the good, and innocent [unmixed] in the evil." (cf. Phil. 4:8).

Looking at this verse more specifically, we note that the phrase translated "the secret things" (τα κρυφη) speaks of the *hidden, concealed,* and *covert* things they were practicing. Paul would not use the degrading language necessary to describe these things. Instead he says it is even a "shame" (αιοχρον), *disgraceful, indecent*, and *vile* thing to speak or refer to their undercover sins. In Second Corinthians 4:2, Paul says, "but we renounced the secret things of shame, not walking in craftiness neither corrupting the word of God." In other words, Paul affirms that his lifestyle was the *opposite* of those engaged in the works of darkness (cf. Phil. 3:19).

13. ***"but all things being reproved by the light are made manifest,"***

This verse indicates that everything which endures the scrutinizing reproval of the light is manifested. First, observe that "the light" (του φωτος) is the one doing the reproving. In view of the preceding context and other passages which deal with the same subject, the light referred to here obviously goes back to Deity, the Father and Son. The Apostle John calls *Jesus Christ the light* several times (John 1:4-9; 8:12; 12:36) and also applies the title to *God the Father* (1 John 1:5). In at least four instances Paul uses the word "light" interchangeably with the word "God" (Rom. 13:12; Eph. 5:8-9; 1 Thess. 5:5).

In view of the above citations the Lord God is the one who reproves, rebukes, and convicts. The 11th verse suggests that this reproving may, to a greater or lesser extent, be accomplished through believers who are light in the Lord (cf. v. 7). In as much as God is a penetrating, consuming light, who in His very nature cannot look upon sin, it follows that He must utterly consume it. Since this is true the

only thing left to be manifested is light - that which is identified with God who is light (cf. 1 Cor. 3:12-15).

14. ***"for everything being made manifest is light. Wherefore he says, Arise, the one sleeping, and stand up from the dead, and Christ will shine upon you."***

Since the U.B.S. Greek text divides verses 13 and 14 as above, we have followed the same but have exegeted the forepart of this verse with the previous verse, pointing out that nothing is being manifested (φανερουμενον), *made visible*, and *caused to appear* except that which is light. The statement "wherefore he says" (διο λεγει) means that *on account of this* or *therefore* they are to *rise up* and *awaken* from their spiritual slumber. Furthermore, they are to *stand up* and *raise themselves* out from among those spiritually dead. The fact that both of these verbs are in the active voice and imperative mode makes it clear that Paul is speaking to *carnal Christians*. In conjunction with the Holy Spirit they have the responsibility to get moving under the control and dynamic of the Spirit. As believers are in a right spiritual relation to the Lord, Christ will *shine upon them* (επιφαυσει), *give them light*, spiritually enlighten them, and take them into a fellowship relation with Himself in the light (2 Cor. 4:6; 1 John 1:7).

15. ***"Therefore take heed to how accurately you walk, not as unwise but as wise,"***

The forepart of this could also be translated, "Therefore accurately take heed to how you walk." Our first and preferred translation associates the adverb "accurately" (ακριβως) with the verb "walk" (περιπατειτε), while the second translation associates this adverb with the verb "take heed" (βλεπετε). In the first case the emphasis is on how accurately our Christian walk conforms to the Truth given to the Church. In the second case the emphasis is on accurately examining the Word to determine *how* we are to walk. Since the emphasis is of both translations dovetails into one elongated thought, we will briefly explore both.

Since the translation "accurately take heed" logically progresses toward its application "accurately walk," we will consider it first. The verb translated "take heed" (βλεπετε) is in the present tense, imperative mode, and active voice. It is a command to continuously *exercise their faculty of sight, to look at,* and *observe*, particularly that which is written. As we take heed to what Paul says in his epistles, he gives us no alternative; we are to take heed to the Truth deposited with him for the Church (Gal. 1:12; 2 Tim. 2:2). According to Second Timothy 2:15, we are to be unashamed workers, "cutting straight the word of truth," the message of the Mystery revealed for the Church today. As we "accurately" (ακριβως) *exactly, precisely,* and *strictly* adhere to the Truth for the church, we *know* what ingredients constitute an accurate walk in this dispensation of grace (cf. Gal. 5:22-23; Eph. 2:10; Col. 1:10; 2:6-7).

Now that we have considered the Truth which gives *direction* to our walk, which delineates how we are to walk, let us consider how we are to accurately apply this Truth to our walk. The Greek word translated "walk" (περιπατειτε) comes from combining the words "περι" and "πατεω" and literally means *to walk around, walk about, roam,* and is most commonly used by Paul to depict one's *general movements, the way one moves,* or a person's *lifestyle*. It is one thing to know how we are to live as believers, and something else to accurately transfer this knowledge into lifestyle. For example, I know what the fruit of the Spirit is, I can glibly rattle off the nine characteristics defining it, but this does not mean that it has been integrated into my lifestyle (Gal. 5:22-23). Paul's emphasis here is that our walk and lifestyle are to accurately, precisely, and meticulously align with the Truth for the Body of Christ (cf. Phil. 4:9).

Having emphasized the need to accurately scrutinize the Word and to accurately live according to it, Paul adds the words, "not as unwise but as wise." The Greek word translated "unwise" (ασοφοι) means the *opposite of wise*, hence, *those void of understanding, foolish,* and *imprudent.* All who are involved in the works of darkness and asleep in carnality lack wisdom, are unwise, and are out of harmony with creation. This is Paul's evaluation of disobedient carnal Christians: their lifestyle categorizes them as void of wisdom, hence, ignorant and stupid.

On the other hand, believers who have the fruit of the light in their lives (v. 9), who are living in accordance with the Truth for the Church, and are prepared to stand before the Judgment Seat of Christ and be judged according to their works (1 Cor. 3:13-14, 17; 4:5) are described as "wise" (σοφοι), *intelligent, learned*, and *knowledgeable*. Keep in mind, when Paul speaks about believers being wise he is referring to those identified with the wisdom of God (Rom. 16:19, 27). In contrast, he speaks very disparagingly of those exulting in the wisdom of men (1 Cor. 1:25, 27; 3:18; Col. 2:23).

16. ***"redeeming the time, because the days are evil."***

Instead of unwisely living in carnality, believers are to be alert, wise, and redeeming the time. The Greek word rendered "time" (καιρον) may refer to the *present time* (Rom. 3:26), a *future time* (1 Cor. 4:5), the *gamut of time* in which we live (Gal. 6:10), and time in the sense of *suitable situations, fitting circumstances,* and *opportunities* (Col. 4:5). We are primarily interested in the latter meaning in this verse, i.e., in the sphere of time we have suitable situations, open door circumstances, multiplied opportunities to make the Gospel of God's Grace known to others. The main emphasis in this verse centers on time - *how* believers are to use it and *why*.

First, we believers are to be redeeming the time. The Greek participle translated "redeeming" (εξαγοραζομενοι) is in the present tense and is derived from "εξ" and "αγοραζω" and literally means *to buy out, to buy up,* and *to acquire or purchase from*. The literal thought is that believers are to continually be *buying out of time* every opportunity to edify and instruct one another in the Truth for the Church, the Mystery. The following context strongly suggests that in this verse Paul is emphasizing the need for believers to buy up every opportunity to mutually instruct one another. In a similar passage in Colossians 4:5, he emphasizes the need to buy up every opportunity to share the Gospel with the lost, those outside, for he says, "Walk in wisdom toward those outside, redeeming the time." Combining these two thoughts, time consists of a series of opportunities to teach the Truth of the Word to both the saved and the lost. In Galatians 6:10, Paul affirms that time is to be used for the benefit of both believers

and unbelievers, for he says, "Then therefore as we have time [opportunity], let us do that which is good toward all, especially toward the family of the faith."

Paul now states the reason believers are to redeem the time, namely, "because the days are evil." The Greek word for "days" (ημεραι) may refer to the interval between sunrise and sunset or to both night and day (24 hours). When used in the plural, as here, it speaks of *an extended period of time,* i.e., a time when evil is unusually rampant. Paul also speaks of this time as the *last days*, an extended period when there will be grievous times (2 Tim. 3:1). Since many days constitute an *age* (αιων), and Satan is the god of this age (2 Cor. 4:4), it follows that all days have been evil since the Adamic fall, but they are getting worse in the last days (cf. 1 John 5:19; 2 Tim. 3:13).

Because surrounding evil tends to infiltrate the minds of believers, it is imperative that every opportunity be utilized by believers to build each other up in the faith. In Ephesians 6:13, Paul says, "Take up all the armor of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day." In Hebrews 3:12-13, in view of the danger of an evil heart of unbelief overtaking some of them, they are admonished to exhort themselves daily, i.e., redeem the time by encouraging one another in the Word. Furthermore, evil days makes it all the more imperative to make known the Gospel of reconciliation to the lost (2 Cor. 5:18-21).

17. ***"On account of this do not be foolish, but understand what the will of the Lord is."***

Let us examine the statement, "On account of this do not be foolish." What is the antecedent of the pronoun translated "this" (τουτο)? It most logically is that which has immediately preceded it, *the fact that the days are evil* which in turn is a statement which has grown out of the shameful practices alluded to in verse 12. In view of the evil days surrounding believers it behooves them all the more not to be foolish. The Greek noun rendered "foolish" (αφρονες) comes from "α" and "φρην" and basically means that they are not to be those who *do not use their minds or intellects*, hence, *senseless fools* or *stupid ones*. In First Peter 2:15, this word is closely associated with *ignorance*, for we read, "because this is the will of God, to silence the ignorance of

foolish men by doing good." For believers to be sitting around twiddling their thumbs, in these evil days, instead of teaching the Word to both the saved and lost, is, according to what Paul says here, *to categorize themselves as fools and stupid ones.*

In contrast to being foolish, Paul says, "but understand what the will of the Lord is." The use of the strong adversative "αλλα," which is a hyper "but" in the English, emphasizes a *sharp contrast* between being foolish and knowing the will of the Lord. The highest imaginable thing for believers is to understand what God's will is for them in this Church age. This entails proper orientation in the Bible, recognition of the specific Truth revealed for the Church, and diligent study and practice of it. The Greek verb translated "understand" (συϖιετε) is derived from "συν" and "ιημι" and literally means *to send with* or *send together,* hence, it has the idea of thoughts coming together to produce *understanding, comprehension*, and *perception*.

It is obvious that God's will, as presented in this context, is the opposite of the works of darkness (v. 11), of shameful secret sins (v. 12), of being in a state of carnal stupor (v. 14), and of slothfully wasting time (v. 16). Knowing God's will involves being transformed "by the renewing of the mind, unto the end to prove . . . what is the will of God" (Rom. 12:2). It involves a balance between *intellectual perception* of what is written in the Word and *experiential practicing* of the same. In writing to the Colossians, Paul says, "we do not cease praying for you and asking that you may be filled with the perfect knowledge of His will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding, to walk worthily of the Lord unto the end to please in everything" (Col. 1:9-10; cf. 4:12). It is our conviction, based upon the Pauline Epistles, that understanding the will of God involves an endless interaction between *knowledge and implementing it*, between *knowing and doing.* This progressive interaction begins with diligently studying the New Testament epistles written to the churches, specifically those written by the Spirit through the Apostle Paul.

18. ***"And do not be drunk with wine, in which there is abandonment, but be filled with the Spirit."***

It is no accident that understanding the Lord's will and the command to be filled with the Spirit are in contiguous verses. Spirit-given insight

into the intended meaning of the Word of God is the most basic prerequisite to comprehending the will of God. Briefly speaking, the Spirit of God uses the Word of God to give believers insight into the will of God.

The clause, "And do not be drunk with wine," has two significant implications. First, they were overly imbibing to the point of actually getting drunk. Second, Paul uses the effect wine has upon a person, how it controls him, as a background to aid them in understanding the filling of the Spirit. Historically speaking, we deduce that many of the new or professed converts were immoderately drinking and becoming intoxicated, something which *Paul forbids*. In contrast to their wine-produced, profligate, and irrational behavior, Paul commands them to be controlled by the Spirit.

So much for a brief survey of this passage: now let us exegete its meaning from the Greek. The word translated "wine" (οινω) is commonly used in the New Testament, a total of some 35 times. When it has the adjective *new* (νεος) associated with it, the obvious meaning is unfermented wine (cf. Matt. 9:17; Lk. 5:37). When this word stands by itself, unless the context specifically indicates otherwise, it always means fermented wine both in the New Testament and in extrabiblical literature. John the Baptist abstained from the use of wine (Luke 7:33), Jesus drank it moderately (Luke 7:34), Paul limited its use (1 Tim. 3:8; Titus 2:3), and recommended a little to Timothy for medicinal purposes (1 Tim. 5:23). This is a brief *objective appraisal* of what the New Testament Greek says about wine.

The command not to be "drunk" (μεθυσκεσθε) with wine implies that it had some alcoholic content. This Greek verb for *drunk* is in the present tense, imperative mode, and passive voice, and as such is a *command not to continue being made drunk, intoxicated,* and *inebriated* with wine. First Corinthians 11:21, in dealing with what took place at the Lord's Table, indicates that some actually become drunk (ος δε μεθυει). With this kind of a background in mind, it is easy to see why Paul says what he does in this verse, *firmly prohibiting drunkenness.*

Now to examine the statement, "in which there is abandonment." The antecedent of the pronoun "which" (ω) is wine (οινω). The emphasis is on the fact that *the wine produces* "abandonment" (ασωτια), *desertion*, and the *forsaking* of a sound mindset. It appears that in the two other instances this word is used in the New Testament there is probably drinking in the background (Titus 1:6; 1 Peter 4:4). The idea of profligate, reckless, and dissipated living naturally follows this forsaking of sound-mind-control. Looking at this word in another way, it may speak of abandonment to the control of wine, i.e., wine-control instead of Spirit-control.

Now for the positive thrust of this verse, in contrast to being abandoned from a sound mind to the control of wine, Paul emphatically declares, "but [αλλα] be filled with the Spirit." The Greek verb translated "filled" (πληρουσθε) means to *fill up, make full, completely pervade,* etc. This statement could also be rendered "be filled in the Spirit," i.e., be made full in the sphere of the Spirit. The fact that this verb is in the present tense, imperative mode, and passive voice means that believers are to *continually submit* to being filled with the Spirit.

If we look at this statement as the opposite of being controlled by wine, then we may well consider being filled with the Spirit as synonymous with *being controlled by the Spirit* (cf. Lk. 4:1; Rom. 8:14). If, on the other hand, we prefer the alternate translation, "be filled in the Spirit," and compare it with the statement "you have been made full in Him" (Christ; Col. 2:10), then it speaks of our *fulness in the sphere of the Spirit, identification with Him, flowing with the Spirit* in the Word of God. Regardless of which translation we prefer, in the final analysis both add up to the fact that we are to be *moving with the Spirit* - controlled by or flowing with.

19. ***"speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual odes, singing and making melody in your heart to the Lord,"***

Having observed that believers are to be moving in harmony with the Spirit, a relationship made possible by an intimate cooperative relation between the Spirit of God and the spirits of believers, now let us consider the results of this flowing with the Spirit. In the next three

verses (19-21) we take a look at what happens when believers are filled with the Spirit, controlled by the Spirit, and flowing with the Spirit.

In verses 19-21, Paul gives us a pattern for an ideal local assembly meeting at that particular period of time. What he says to these churches in this encyclical epistle must be interpreted in the light of the Truth which was available to them at that point in history. He could not instruct them to study all his epistles, for few or none of them were available to most of these churches when he wrote this epistle. The Truth which he was able to commend for their use was limited to the Truth which was available to them. It is interesting that he does not suggest that they make the Old Testament the center of their worship service. If Paul were writing to us today, those who have his fourteen epistles in the canon of Scripture, I am certain that he would instruct us to major in teaching them in our local assembly services (Rom. 16:25-26; 1 Cor. 2:6-10; Gal. 1:6-12; Eph. 2:1-10; 3:2-12; 6:19-20; Phil. 4:9; Col. 1:24-29; 4:2-4; 2 Thess. 2:13-17; 1 Tim. 1:11; 4:6-16; 6:2-5, 20; 2 Tim. 1:8-14; 2:2; 3:10-17; Titus 2:15; 3:8).

Recognizing that what Paul says in this section must be kept in its historical setting, let us begin exegeting the 19th verse. As those who are filled with the Spirit, Paul says you are to be "speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual odes." The Greek participle translated "speaking" (λαλουντες) is in the present tense, which means that they are to continually, every time they meet, speak to themselves. Since both this participle and pronoun are in the plural, the thought is that they are to *mutually speak to one another*, i.e., they all have a responsibility to build each other up in the faith. According to the 14th chapter of First Corinthians this speaking is to be done in an orderly manner.

First, we observe that they were to speak to themselves in *psalms*. The Greek noun translated "psalms" (ψαλμοις) literally means a touching and feeling, particularly a pulling, twitching, and twanging with the fingers on the strings of a musical instrument. It primarily refers to music, and secondarily, to the words set to it, hence *a sacred song, words arranged to be sung,* or *a psalm.* Bear in mind, the English word "psalm" is merely a transliteration, a transposing of the Greek letters over into English, and is not a definition.

Furthermore, since there is no article preceding the word "psalms" (ψαλμοις), we cannot affirm that it refers to the Psalms of David. Our preferred interpretation is that these psalms were taken from Church Truth which had been orally transmitted from the Apostle Paul. They were choice portions of Truth that exalted the Lord Jesus Christ (cf. 2 Tim. 2;11-13). It is possible that they may have used some of David's psalms, but the above interpretation aligns better with the historic circumstances and Paul's minimal use of the Psalms in his epistles.

Second, we note that they are to speak to themselves in *hymns*. The Greek noun rendered "hymns" (υμνοις), of which the English is a transliteration, is used in the classical Greek to denote a festive song, generally in praise of gods or heroes. It is used in the New Testament to depict a song of praise to the Lord. This may be interpreted to mean a hymn of praise to the Lord Jesus Christ or to God the Father (Col. 3:16). We assume that these hymns contained words which exalted Christ as Head over the Body, the Church, otherwise Paul would not have recommended them as a part of their worship service in the local assembly.

Third, they were to speak to themselves in *spiritual odes*. The Greek noun transliterated "odes" (ωδαις) apparently refers to lyric poems or dialogues which are very expressive. In as much as the word "spiritual" (πναυματικαις) immediately follows the noun for odes, Paul is very clearly speaking of spiritual odes, i.e., odes which are spiritual in nature, and it is also possible to apply it to the foregoing psalms and hymns - they are spiritual rather than secular. Spiritual odes undoubtedly involved a great deal of Truth for the Body of Christ presented in a personal and expressive manner (cf. Col. 3:16; Rev. 5:9; 14:3).

Fourth, they are to be singing and making melody in their heart to the Lord. The Greek word rendered "singing" (αδοντες), as used in the classical Greek, covers the total gamut of singing and praise. According to Colossians 3:16, this singing is to be encircled with grace. In the Book of Revelation it is used three times regarding the singing of odes.

The Greek participle translated "making melody" (ψαλλοντες) is in the present tense. It is based on the *verb form* of the word translated psalms. It has the basic idea of *touching, twitching,* and *striking* the strings of a musical instrument. It could convey the idea of just music or music combined with the voice in singing. In Romans 15:9, in a quotation from the Psalms, it most likely links together playing and singing (cf. 1 Cor. 14:15). It is associated with a happy and cheerful frame of mind (James 5:13). Thus we note that *making melody* is a good translation; something which can be done on an instrument, by the voice, or most commonly by synchronizing both.

This singing and making melody is not going through superficial actions, but it is to take place in the sphere of the heart. It is interesting that even though Paul is writing to believers as a whole in the various local assemblies and always addresses them in the plural, yet the word "heart" (καρδια) is in the *singular*. Instead of saying, "making melody in your hearts," which we would expect him to say, he says "making melody in your heart." Apparently he looked at a spirit-filled, spirit-controlled local assembly as being *one in heart* (cf. Acts 4:32; Gal. 3:28; Eph. 2:15). There is no question about it, the language Paul uses to describe an ideal assembly flowing in the Spirit portrays a *happy and united people* praising and exalting the Lord (cf. Col. 3:16).

Finally, all the speaking in psalms, hymns, and spiritual odes, plus the singing and making melody mentioned in this verse are unto *one end - to the Lord.* In contrast to humanism, which does everything unto the praise of man, we believers are to do everything in our assemblies unto the praise and glory of the Lord! Furthermore, keep in mind, the only way this can take place in our assemblies is when believers are filled and flowing with the Spirit (Rom. 8:14-16, 26-27).

20. ***"giving thanks all the time for all things in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ to the God and Father,"***

As we approach this verse we need to keep in mind that what Paul says in it is primarily directed to the local assemblies to which he is writing this encyclical epistle. In addition to all that he has said in verse 19, they are to be "giving thanks all the time." The present participle translated "thanks" (ευχαριστουντες) comes from

combining "ευ" and "χαρις" and literally means that they are to continuously express *good grace, gratefulness,* and *thankfulness* to God. The present tense implies that they are to continually do this; however, the addition of the adverb "παντοτε," which means *all the time, always,* and *ceaselessly*, emphasizes that there is to be no cessation in giving thanks.

The Greek words translated "for all things" may even more literally be translated "on behalf of all things." Since the word rendered "all things" (παντων) fits both the neuter and masculine genders, our preferred translation is "all things," but it may also be rendered "all men." There are times when it is difficult to give thanks for all things, when everything seems to go wrong, but it is even harder to give thanks for all men, particularly for evil men who delight in making life miserable for us believers. Apart from recognizing *God's total sovereignty* over our lives it is impossible to give thanks for everything and every person!

Observe that this thanks is to be directed to "the God and Father" (τω θεω και πατρι). This may be translated "to the God and Father" or "to the God even Father." Both translations express the same basic meaning. Prayer is not to be addressed to God the Son nor to God the Holy Spirit, but to God the Father. This is an inviolable principle, clearly set forth in the Pauline Epistles, and must not be violated (cf. Rom. 1:8; 7:25; Col. 1:3; 3:17). To direct our prayers to Jesus Christ, void of Scriptural precedence for doing so, is to show blatant and negligent disrespect for God the Father.

All thanksgiving and prayer is to be couched "in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ." In dealing with the subject of prayer, as recorded in Paul's epistles, he directs it to *God* (1 Cor. 1:14; Phil. 1:3; 4:6); *to God the Father* (Col. 1:3, 12; 3:17); *in the name of* Jesus Christ (Phil. 2:10); and *through* Jesus Christ (Rom. 1:8; 7:25; Col. 3:17). Even though not always expressly stated, we assume that all thanksgiving is to be made either *in the name of* or *through* Jesus Christ. Our access into God's presence and our privilege to converse with Him are totally dependent upon Christ's substitutionary death (Jn. 14:6; Eph. 2:18; 3:12).

21. ***"being subordinate to one another in the fear of Christ."***

The Greek word translated "being subordinate" (υποτασσομενοι) is derived from the preposition "υπο" and the verb "τασσω" and means that they are to *arrange themselves under, to put themselves in an inferior role,* and *be submissive to one another*. The fact that this is a participle means that *they* are to be *subordinate ones*, the use of the middle voice indicates that they themselves are to assume this secondary role, and the present tense implies that they are to *continually* live in this manner. Even as this word is used to describe the subordinate relation of the Church to Christ, likewise, the members of the Church are to be subordinate to "one another" (αλληλοις), i.e., each one is to take the initiative in assuming an inferior rank (v. 24; 1 Cor. 16:16). Apart from Paul, Peter most commonly uses this word (6 times). He uses it to describe the relation of believers to human government, of wives to their husbands, of young men to older men, and of heavenly hosts to Christ. It may not always be easy for us to honestly assume this secondary role, but when we recognize that all believers are new creations in Christ, the work of God the Holy Spirit, and have special Divine qualities and gifts, we can sincerely arrange ourselves under one another (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15; Rom. 12:3, 6, 10, 16).

This subordination to one another is to be "in the fear of Christ." In order to accurately understand the meaning of this statement we need to carefully examine the meaning of the Greek word translated "fear" (φοβω). Greek lexicons, both New Testament and classical, give it the possible meanings of *terror, dread, fright, respect,* and *reverence.* According to Second Corinthians 5:11, the fear and terror of the Lord spurred Paul to persuade men. Second Corinthians 7:1, implies that the fear of God motivates cleansing and sanctification from sin. We observe in Philippians 2:12, that fear is an incentive for believers to bring forth good works. According to First Timothy 5:20, the fear of public reproval and rebuke deters believers from sin.

The manner in which the Greek word "φοβος" is used in the above passages sets a strong precedent in favor of translating it *fear, fright,* and *dread* in this verse. The thought is that believers, being *motivated by the fear* of disobedience and its consequences, are to arrange

themselves under one another. In the statement, "the fear of Christ," the Greek noun transliterated Christ (Χριστου) is in the genitive case, which indicates possession, i.e., fear which *belongs to Christ*, the dread of incurring His displeasure by not submitting to one anther. It is fear of the judgment Christ will execute (2 Cor. 5:10-11; Phil. 2:11-12); fear of suffering the consequences of disobedience (1 Peter 1:17); hence, that which propels believers to *obey His Word by being subordinate* to each other.

22. ***"The wives (being subordinate] to your own husbands as to the Lord,"***

Note that we have placed the participle *being subordinate* (υποτασσομενοι) in parenthesis because it is *not repeated but implied* in this verse. This is logical when we recognize that verse 21 flowed into verse 22; there was no break between them in the original manuscript, the same verbal adjective expressing what both believers and wives are to do. Even as believers are to subordinate themselves to one another, likewise, wives are to subordinate themselves to their husbands.

Let us examine the phrase that wives are to be aligned under their husbands "as to the Lord." The Greek adverb translated "as" (ως) conveys the idea of *like as, even as,* and *as it were* to the Lord. In view of the following context, the noun "Lord" (Κυριω) obviously refers to the *Lord Jesus Christ*. Even as all believers are to arrange themselves under the Lord, to assume a subservient relation to Him, and to occupy a subordinate position in His Body; likewise, wives are to voluntarily *arrange themselves* under their husbands. Subordination to the Headship of Christ is according to absolute Truth - He must be obeyed. Subordination to husbands must align with subordination to Christ, and if there is a contradiction, subordination to Christ takes precedence (Luke 14:26; Acts 4:19; Col. 1:18).

23. ***"because the husband is head of the wife as also Christ is head of the church, himself the Savior of the body."***

Adhering to the literal Greek, we have translated the conjunction "οτι" as *because* for it more specifically states the *reason why* wives are to

be subordinate to their husbands. Paul gives a very brief reason for the husbands headship in First Timothy 2:13-14, where he says, "For Adam was formed first, then Eve; and Adam was not deceived, but the woman being thoroughly deceived fell in the transgression." Two reasons for the husband's position as head may be deduced from these verses: (1) he was *created first*, (2) he was *not deceived*. Whereas Satan was unsuccessful in deceiving Adam, he was successful in deceiving Eve (Gen. 3:7). Paul's very brief statement does not deal with the fact that Adam was subsequently deceived; however his epistles clearly affirm that sin goes back to Adam's doorstep (Rom. 5:14; 1 Cor. 15:22). In comparison to the woman, Eve, since Adam was *first in creation* and *not first in being deceived*, he is her head. Regardless of the reasons why men are given headship responsibility, and regardless of what our finite minds conceive as fair, *the fact remains unalterable* - the husband is the head of the wife (1 Cor. 11:3).

The truth of Christ's headship over the Church was so well established when Paul wrote this epistle that he could use it to illustrate how husbands should be the head of their wives. The implication is that these early believers were sufficiently knowledgeable in the Mystery, the truth regarding Christ and His Church, so that Paul could use it as the ideal for mundane marital relations. This gives us insight into the central theme of Paul's gospel between 55 and 60 A.D. He was increasingly focusing on the *new spiritual organism,* the mystical Body of Christ, the Church, new Truth revealed to him by Jesus Christ via the Spirit (1 Cor. 2:10; Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-3).

The Greek word used to depict a husband as head of his wife and Christ as head of the Church is "κεφαλη." It may be used to denote a *physical head* (Matt. 6:17; 14:8), a *head cornerstone* (Matt. 21:42), and a *head, chief, and superior position* over others (1 Cor. 11:3; Eph. 1:22). The Apostle Paul clearly affirms five times that Christ is the Head of the Church (1:22; 4:15; 5:23; Col. 1:18; 2:19). In this position of headship He has given some as apostles and prophets, who had the responsibility of establishing and instructing the early New Testament churches (4:11). He has also given to His Church evangelists, pastors and teachers, continuing gifts (4:11), together with overseers, elders, and ministers (1 Tim. 3:1, 8; 5:17). There is *no*

mention of priests, cardinals, and popes in the New Testament. These are extraneous trappings which are utterly foreign to the Church over which Christ is the sole Head.

Paul adds that Christ is also "himself the Savior of the Body." Literally speaking, the Savior is one who *saves, rescues,* and *delivers* from sin. The emphasis may be on saving from original sin or saving from *the presence of sin* in believers' lives. As used in this verse we interpret it to mean both, i.e., Christ has saved us from sin and placed us in His Body, and as members of His Body, He continues to save us from the sins which beset us.

24. ***"But as the church is subordinate to Christ, likewise also the wives to their husbands in everything."***

Having observed that Christ is the Head and Savior of the Church, and that the members of the Church are subordinate to Him, Paul uses this as a pattern of how wives are to be arranged under their husbands. Even as the Church is subject to Christ in everything which pertains to it (1:22), in the same way wives are to be subject to their husbands in everything. According to this verse there are no areas in which wives are not to be subordinate to their husbands.

As we apply the pattern of Christ and His subordinate Church to wives being subordinate to their husbands, we must keep in mind that the Head of the Church is *perfect*, whereas some husbands may be very imperfect, demanding that their wives submit to that which is contrary to Christ and His Word. When a wife is confronted with obedience-to-husband versus disobedience-to-God, she is morally obligated to obey God (Acts 4:19). As believers we are to be governed by absolute morality, God's standards are inviolable, and if a wife breaks these standards by submitting to a sinful husband, *she has sinned against God.* Obedience to a husband does not justify disobedience to God. The Divine-human relation always takes precedence over human-human relations.

25. ***"The husbands, love the wives, even as also Christ loved the church and gave himself on behalf of it,"***

Having instructed the wives to be subordinate to their husbands as the Church is to Christ, Paul explains Christ's relation to the Church as an ideal example of how husbands should relate to their wives. His main emphasis in the following verses is that husbands must love their wives. As the present tense and imperative mode indicate, he *commands* husbands to *continuously* love their wives. This statement has interesting ramifications. It expands love beyond the sphere of mere emotions and feelings, elevating it into the *rational and spiritual sphere.* Peter expresses the same concept when he tells husbands to dwell with their wives *according to knowledge* (1 Peter 3:7).

Since "love" (αγαπαω) is the key word in this and the following verses, we need at least a minimal grasp of its meaning. As used in the classical Greek it means *to receive willingly, readily, to welcome,* and *to entertain*. In the New Testament it is *to highly value, esteem, to delight in, to be genuinely concerned for, to be solicitous for one's welfare,* or *to show a preference for.* Paul gives us an excellent definition of love in First Corinthians 13:4-7, where he says, "Love is longsuffering, kind, love is not jealous, not haughty, not arrogant, does not act improperly, does not seek its own, is not provoked, does not think upon evil, does not rejoice in iniquity, but rejoices with the truth; bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things." In summary, as love is solicitous for the welfare of others, it assumes a patient and lowly mind-set, it emphasizes their positive characteristics and minimizes that which is negative.

The example of how husbands are to love their wives is "even as also Christ loved the church and gave himself on behalf of it." The magnitude of Christ's love for the Church is portrayed in His dying for it, an incontrovertible historic fact (Matt. 26:28; Rom. 5:8; Gal. 5:20; Eph. 1:7). If we literally follow Christ's example, as set forth in this verse, then husbands are to love their wives to the extent of being willing to die for them. The inexhaustible love of God in Christ is seen in His commending His own love unto us, "that while we were yet sinners Christ died on behalf of us" (Rom. 5:8). Husbands are to love their wives even when they are unlovable.

26. ***"in order that he might sanctify having cleansed by the washing of water in the word,"***

This verse explains the *purpose* for which Christ gave Himself on behalf of the Church, namely, that He might sanctify it. The Greek verb translated "sanctify" (αγιαση) basically means to *separate* from that which is common, hence, *to set apart*, to place in a holy category, to separate unto God. This is speaking about the perfect, holy, and sanctified position members of the Church have before God on the basis of Christ's substitutionary death. Paul uses the perfect tense and passive voice in affirming that this sanctification *has been completed by God* (Acts 20:32; 26:18; 1 Cor. 1:2). In First Corinthians 1:30, Paul says that Christ has been *made unto us believers sanctification*, i.e., through identification with Him we occupy a holy position in God's presence. The Grace of God freely provides this forensic sanctification to God's elect (2 Tim. 2:10).

Now let us examine the meaning of the statement, "having cleansed by the washing of water in the word." The Greek participle rendered "having cleansed" is in the aorist tense, and as such indicates that this cleansing *took place prior* to the sanctifying, i.e., because believers are cleansed they are forensically sanctified. As used in this context the Greek participle translated "having cleansed" (καθαρισας) means that Christ died to *make clean and pure from the filth of sin* those destined to constitute the Church (Heb. 10:2; 1 John 1:7).

We note that this cleansing was effected "by the washing of water in the word." The Greek word translated "washing" (λουτρω) speaks of a *bathing* and *ablution*. The only other time this word is used in the New Testament is in Titus 3:5, where Paul says that God saved us "through the *washing* of regeneration and the renewing of the Holy Spirit." In both of these instances this Greek word is apparently used with a *figurative meaning*. The agent used in this figurative washing was "water" (υδατος). Looking at this statement as a whole, we have a picture of water, it is being used for bathing, and this is taking place in the sphere of the "word" (ρηματι) of God (6:17; Heb. 1:3; 6:5; 11:3; cf. Rom. 10:17). Looking at this threefold picture from a strictly literal point of view, the items in it do not fit together; it is senseless. On the other hand, viewing it from a literal-intended-meaning perspective, and recognizing that "washing" (λουτρω) and "water" (υδατος) are figurative terms, the meaning begins to emerge.

In Titus 3:5, we observe that the word "washing" (λουτρου) is subsequently associated with the Holy Spirit. In John 7:38-39, the word "water" (υδατος) is figuratively used of the Spirit. If we interpret the "washing of water" (λουτρω του υδατος) as a washing and bathing of the Holy Spirit in the sphere of the Word of God, then the figurative language used in this verse makes good sense. This is in accordance with a recognized biblical principle - that the Holy Spirit uses the Word of God to accomplish the Work of God. Granting the validity of this interpretation, first, we recognize that Christ gave Himself up as a *sin-offering*; second, on the basis of this sin-offering those predestined to constitute the Church were cleansed; third, the Spirit of God used the Word of God to effect this cleansing; fourth, Christ's ultimate purpose was a set-apart-unto-God, a sanctified, and a perfectly holy Church.

27. ***"in order that he might present to himself the glorious church, not having spot or wrinkle or any such things, but that it might be holy and blameless."***

To bring out the full impact of the Greek, the first part of this verse could be literally translated, "in order that he *himself* might present to himself the glorious church." The latter translation emphasizes the fact that Christ Himself is the *sole* cleanser, sanctifier, and perfecter of the Church. We members of the Church have made *no contribution* toward our perfectly sanctified position before God. It is totally based on the fact that Christ gave Himself for us, i.e., based on His substitutionary death on our behalf. The Greek verb translated "present" (παροστηση) is derived from "παρα" and "ιστημι" and literally means *to place beside* or *to place in His presence* the glorious Church. It apparently refers to the placement of the glorious Church under His headship in the heavenlies.

Now let us look at the phrase translated "the glorious church." The Greek word most commonly translated *glory* (δοξα) is used some 155 times in the New Testament. The word translated "glorious" (ενδοξον) in this verse, in comparison is used only 4 times. It is derived from "εν" and "δοξα" and literally means *in glory, in the sphere of glory*, or the prefix may add emphasis, i.e., giving it the meaning of

exceedingly glorious. In view of the etymology of this word we have raised the question: (1) is the thought that Christ might present to Himself *in the sphere of heavenly glory* the Church? or (2) that He might present to Himself the *exceedingly, super glorious* Church? In the light of the way this word is used in the New Testament we prefer the latter meaning. The first interpretation would emphasize *the place* where He presented or placed the Church under His headship; whereas the second interpretation would emphasize *the superbly glorious nature of the Church* which He presented to Himself. Both thoughts are true, the Church is with Christ in the glorious heavenly sphere, and as such, it is an exceedingly glorious Church.

Negatively speaking, Paul says that the Church does not have "spot or wrinkle or any such things." The Greek word translated "spot" (σπιλον), as used in this context, means that it *does not have a single spot, stain,* or *soil mark* defacing it. The verb form of this word is used twice in the New Testament (James 3:6; Jude 23). In both instances it speaks of defiling and staining spots of sin. This means that the Church, the Body of Christ, in its glorious heavenly position, is *entirely free from sin stains.*

The Greek noun translated "wrinkle" (ρυτιδα) describes *a fold which draws together,* hence*, a wrinkle*. According classical and Papyri Greek it is related to wrinkles in the skin resulting from age. It implies that the Church has nothing that disfigures it, age takes no toll on it. Having specifically stated that the Church has no spot or wrinkle, Paul adds, "or any such things." This is a blanket statement assuring us that the Church is free from every imaginable defect or sin.

The statement regarding the Church, "that it might be holy and blameless," is an expression of the reason Christ gave Himself in verse 25. The three ινα clauses following verse 25 make it clear that He gave Himself that He might *sanctify the Church* (v. 26); He gave Himself that He might *present it to Himself a superbly glorious Church;* and He gave Himself that the Church might be *holy* and *blameless*. The Greek word for "holy" (αγια) means that it might be set apart unto God from that which is common. The Greek word rendered "blameless" (αμωμος), *faultless*, and *blemishless* reaffirms the perfect nature of the Church. According to Ephesians 1:4, we

were chosen in Christ to be what this passage says we are in the Church (cf. Col. 1:22).

28. ***"Likewise husbands ought also to love their own wives as their own bodies. The one loving his own wife loves himself,"***

The Greek adverb translated "likewise" (ουτως) means that in *the same manner* and *same way* that Christ loved the Church husbands ought to love their own wives. The verb rendered "ought" (οφειλουσιν) implies that husbands, according to their marriage contracts and bonds, are *indebted* and *obligated* to love their own wives. As fellow believers, husbands and wives are also obligated to love one another, for in Romans 13:8, Paul says, "Owe nothing to no one, except to love one another" (cf. 1 John 4:11). The same basic Greek verb "οφειλω" is used in all these verses. The nature of the husband-wife relation plus the nature of the believer-believer relation places husbands under a *double obligation* to love their wives.

Furthermore, husbands are indebted and obligated to love their own wives as their own bodies. The Greek adverb translated "as"(ως) means that their love for their wives is to be *like as, even as*, or *the same as* that for their own bodies. First, we may interpret this as meaning that husbands are to love their wives to the same degree that they love their personal bodies. Their egocentric love is to be duplicated so as to include a wife-centric love. Note, Paul does not condemn the husbands for their loving concern for their bodies, and taking good care of them, but he wants this *same loving concern to be transferred* to their wives. Second, Paul is telling them to love their wives as those who are looked at as their own bodies or as those who *represent their own bodies* in other words, even as the Church is the Body of Christ the wives are the bodies of their husbands (cf. 1 Cor. 7:4) and are to be loved as such (cf. Matt. 19:5-6; Rom. 13:9).

Paul now adds the explanatory statement, "The one loving his own wife loves himself." This statement *removes the gap* between a husband and wife. He is no longer thinking of them as two objective persons, but as *one subjective person*, with a single identity. He is gradually approaching the climax where he positively identifies them as one flesh. This statement adds credibility to the second

interpretation in the preceding paragraph, that the bodies of the husbands and wives amalgamate into one (v. 31).

29. ***"for no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, even as also Christ the church,"***

The Greek word translated "ever" (ποτε) expresses the thought that no one *once* or *at any time* has hated his own flesh. There is obviously a dual meaning in this verse. First, when Paul says that no one has at any time hated his own flesh, but rather nourishes and cherishes it, he is dealing with the normal attitude of human beings toward themselves. Normally, a human being endeavors to preserve himself and provide for his physical and emotional needs. Second, in the light of the context, the phrase "his own flesh" must be interpreted to include his wife, the two as one flesh. It appears that the first part of this verse primarily refers to the husband, and that the middle part primarily refers to the wife. The main recipient of the *nourishing* (εκτρεφει), *feeding*, and *adequate nutrition* and of the *cherishing* (θαλπει), *warming* and *affection* is the wife.

The last phrase in this verse, "even as also Christ the church," is very significant in understanding what has preceded it. We must keep in mind that Paul's object in this context is to stimulate husbands to show greater love and concern for their wives. The above phrase involves two parties, Christ nourishing and cherishing His Church. If this is to be a *meaningful example* of what has preceded it, then it too *must involve two parties*, the husband nourishing and cherishing his wife. This forces us to recognize that the phrase, "his own flesh," consists of the joint flesh of the husband and wife, designated *one flesh* (v. 31). This verse makes it clear - a husband's love for his wife will be seen in his providing for both her physical and emotional needs, namely, food, shelter, and affection (1 Tim. 5:8).

30. ***"because we are members of his body."***

The Majority Text adds to this verse the words "out of his flesh and out of his bones." In as much as the context makes it clear that Paul is speaking of the Body of Christ here, and flesh and bones are foreign to this spiritual organism, we consider this addition an extraneous copyist injection. It is imperative that we look at this verse

as an integral part of the preceding verse. Observe that Christ nourishes and cherishes us *because* we are members of His Body. This verse begins with the conjunction "οτι," which is best translated *because, on account of the reason,* or *since*. This verse gives the reason why Christ nourishes and cherishes the Church - because we are members of His Body which He loves as husbands love their own bodies (v. 28). As the integrated husband loves his flesh, including his wife as a part of it, so the totally integrated Christ loves us as a part of Himself, as members of His Body. The fact that we believers are members of the Body of Christ is emphasized in Paul's epistles (Rom. 12:5; 1 Cor. 12:27).

31. ***"For this cause a man shall leave his father and mother and shall be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh."***

This is a Greek translation of Genesis 2:24. In view of the fact that this verse was originally written in the Hebrew language, we want to give an expanded translation from it. "Therefore a man shall forsake, leave his father and mother and shall be glued, attached, joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh." The main reason Paul quotes this passage is to *show the identity* between what he has been writing, under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, and what was written at the beginning. It corroborates his argument that husbands are to love their wives in the same way they *love their bodies*, for they are joined-bodies (v. 28). It supports his point that you cannot separate a husband's *love for himself* from his love for his wife, for she is attached to him, a part of himself (v. 28). It confirms that when husbands nourish and cherish *their flesh*, which is inseparable from their wives, they are displaying love toward their wives, for they are one flesh. Love for one's body, self, and flesh includes love for his wife, a principle corroborated by this quotation.

32. ***"This mystery is great, but I speak regarding Christ and the church."***

Since the word "mystery" (μυστηριον) is used by Paul to denote a *revealed secret*, what he has been saying in verses 23-30 is new. This is the *first time* that Christ's relation to His Church has been made the pattern for a husband's relation to his wife. Paul has

something new to say to husbands and wives who are members of the Church; their love, mutual nourishing and cherishing is *to exceed* all that God had previously revealed to His people regarding the marital relation. Redeemed through the precious Blood of Christ, filled and empowered by the Holy Spirit, the superb love of Christ for His Church is to be reflected through the husbands upon their wives. The revealed secret - *Grace*, not law - is to be the source of a new selfless love which permeates this relationship!

33. ***"Nevertheless also you yourselves, each one individually, let him love his own wife in the same way as himself, and the wife that she might fear the husband."***

This verse is a *brief summary* of what Paul has already said in verses 22-32. He addresses it to all the husbands, as indicated by the plural "you" (υμεις), but then gives *each husband* specific instructions. The Greek word "πλην," used as a conjunction in this context, may be translated *nevertheless, moreover, however,* or *but*. Its purpose is to tie this summary together with what Paul has already said. Addressing it to all the husbands in the given local assemblies may be interpreted to imply that they had the responsibility of encouraging one another unto the end that each one might love his wife as himself.

The meaning of the Greek adverb translated "in the same way" (ουτως) is not adequately brought out in most translations. It refers back to what has preceded it, namely, how that Christ loved the Church and gave Himself for it (v. 25, 29, 32), and *in the same way, in this manner, thus* let each husband love his own wife. This same adverb is used in verse 28, and in that case as well as this, it refers back to the example of Christ's love for the Church. Further evidence that this adverb refers back to the example of Christ's love for His Church is found in the last half of the preceding verse (32) - it relates to new Christ-Church truth pertaining to marriage.

The Greek phrase translated "as himself" (ως εαυτον) is obviously a restatement of verse 28; here Paul says, "The one loving his own wife loves himself." Since the husband and wife are viewed as one flesh, and *himself* and *herself* are two parts which constitute an

integrated whole, it follows that when a husband loves himself he also loves his wife.

In the first three verses of the preceding paragraph (22-25), Paul instructs wives to be subordinate to their husbands. In the next eight verses (26-32), plus the forepart of this verse, he commands husbands to love, nourish, and cherish their wives. Now, in the last verse in this paragraph (33), and in the last part of it, he reverts back to the responsibility of the wife, saying, "and the wife that she might fear the husband." As we observed in discussing verse 21, the Greek word translated *fear* (φοβος) conveys the meaning of *fear, fright, dread, reverence,* and *respect.* We also noted, on the basis of its actual usage in the New Testament, that there is a strong precedent for rendering it fear, fright, and dread. Being forced to acknowledge that the most literal meaning of the Greek word "φοβως" is fear, and that we have no choice but to use this English equivalent, we need to examine *why* Paul uses this particular word.

We must keep in mind that the instructions Paul gives in this verse were given to Christian women living in the Roman Empire. Apart from the Jews, Rome held sway over peoples who worshiped many heathen gods. Many were involved in hedonism, making self-pleasure the chief end of their existence. Physical force has always been the master in the sin-dominated world in which we live (Matt. 20:25), and at that point in history, husbands, being the stronger, often had power even unto death over their families. Recognizing that many of these Christian wives had husbands who had come out of backgrounds where force ruled, or that some had unsaved husbands who still ruled with a rod of iron for their own pleasure, Paul fittingly instructs wives to fear lest they incur the wrath of their husbands. Wives today who find themselves married to tyrant-type husbands undoubtedly understand that what Paul says here is most appropriate. We like to think that in an ideal marital relationship the wife's obedience will be *prompted by love* rather than fear (2 Cor. 5:14; Titus 2:4).

Chapter 6

1. ***"Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right."***

Having explained how the husbands and wives are to live in relation to each other, Paul now tells children how they are to live in relation to their parents. First, they are to obey their parents. The Greek verb translated "obey" (υπακουετε) is derived from the preposition "υπο" prefixed to the verb "ακουω" and literally means *to hear under, to hear,* and *to listen,* hence*, to obey.* The first step in obedience is hearing and understanding, and the second step is acting in accordance with what is heard. Meticulous listening coupled with understanding are prerequisites for accurate obedience. This verb is used to depict the obedience of slaves to their masters (v. 5), obedience to the gospel (Rom. 6:17), and of Sarah's obedience to Abraham (1 Peter 3:6).

Children are to render this obedience to their parents. The noun translated "parents" (γονευσιν) is always used in the *plural* in the New Testament, referring to both the fathers and mothers as progenitors. The personal pronoun "your" (υμων) indicates that the obedience is to be to the child's *own* parents. The fact that children are to obey their parents implies that parents have the *responsibility* of requiring this obedience. From infancy on parents must impress upon their children the need to *listen, understand*, and *respond* accordingly. This is a parental responsibility, it is exclusively a parental role, and cannot be learned by children except in a parent-child relation. Now can a child learn to obey his/her absentee mother?

Paul's command, "Children, obey your parents," is qualified by the addition of the phrase, "in the Lord" (εν κυριω). This means that if the parents are in the Lord, if they know the Lord, their children are to obey them. On the other hand, it does not say that if parents are not in the Lord the children are not to obey them. In Colossians 3:20, Paul makes a similar but unqualified statement, "Children, obey the parents in all things." Keep in mind that Paul's instructions are limited to Christian children, for he never tells unbelievers how to live; furthermore, in that world we can logically assume that the children followed their parents in believing (Acts 16:32-34). It appears to me

that we can positively affirm that Paul is commanding Christian children to obey their Christian parents. On the other hand, it was outside of his jurisdiction to say anything about how the unsaved should live (2 Tim. 2:10).

The reason Paul gives *why* children should obey their parents in the Lord is "for this is right." The Greek word rendered "right" (δικαιον) means that it is *just, fair*, and *equitable*. Considering what parents do for their children it would be equitable for them to requite it with obedience, but this is not Paul's reason for obedience here (1 Tim 5:4). In Colossians 3:20, the reason given for obedience is "for this is well-pleasing in the Lord." The key thing we need to see is that God's *Divine standard has decreed that children are to obey their parents.* This is right according to this verse; it is *well-pleasing* according to Colossians 3:20; and respect and care for parents is *acceptable* in the sight of God according to First Timothy 5:4.

2. ***"Honor your father and mother, which is the first commandment with promise,"***

The Greek word translated "honor" (τιμα), which is a Greek translation of the Hebrew taken from the Septuagint means *to highly esteem and honor* individuals *as worthy, important,* and *weighty*. It is used to describe the honor due both the *Father* and *Son* (John 5:23; 8:49). Peter instructs believers to honor *all men* and *kings* (1 Peter 2:17). Under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, Paul repeats this fifth commandment of the Law of Moses, *as a part of the body of Church Truth.* It means that children are to look upon and respect their parents as being of great value and importance.

Paul says that the command to "honor your father and mother" is "the first commandment with promise." As one scans the Ten Commandments, he observes that the fifth commandment pertaining to children-parent relations is the only one, if obeyed, that promises something in return.

3. ***"in order that it might be well with you and you shall be a long time upon the land."***

The use of the Greek hina clause indicates that God gave the Hebrew children two definite reasons for obeying their parents. First, things would go "well" (ευ), *good*, and *prosperous* for them. God definitely promised Israel that things would go well with them, they would prosper, and have good success if they kept His Law (Josh. 1:7-8). Second, they would be a "long time" (μακροχρονιος), of long duration, upon the "land" (εγης), i.e., promised land. We must keep in mind that obedience to the Law assured Israel of continuance in the land (Deut. 5:16), but disobedience resulted in her being scattered from the land (Deut. 28:63-64). Thus we observe, God gave the Hebrew children the promise of prosperity and continuance in their land if they honored their father and mother.

In contrast to Israel under the Mosaic Law, with its blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience, the Church consists of a heavenly people with its citizenship in heaven (Phil. 3:20). As members of the Church, the Body of Christ, we are perfectly righteous in Christ, and because we are righteous we are to live righteously. Children are to do *what is right*, obey their parents, because they are *motivated by love to please God* (2 Cor. 2:14; 1 Thess. 4:1). We do not deny the positive advantages which accrue to children who obey their parents in this Church age, for *to know how to obey* is imperative in all human relations, but unlike under the Law, they are to obey their parents *because God has told them to do so* and not for some physical advantage. It is in itself a positive *spiritual act of obedience* to God.

4. ***"And fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but nurture them in the training and admonition of the Lord."***

Having commanded children to obey and honor their parents, and recognizing that the responsibility rests on the parents to require this obedience and the potential clashes which may evolve, Paul cautions the fathers against overreaction. First, why does Paul address the "fathers" (πατερες) only and not also the mothers? The main reason is because the father has the God-given rresponsibility, as head of the home, to see that his family is properly cared for and disciplined (1 Tim. 3:4-5). True, in actual practice both the father and mother will

be involved in the disciplining process, but in the final analysis the father is responsible to see that it is properly carried out.

Negatively speaking, the fathers are not to "provoke to anger" (παροργιζετε) and *stir up to wrath* their children. This verb is derived from the preposition "παρα" prefixed to the verb "ποργιζω" and basically means *beside* or *beyond anger*, hence, *excessive anger* or a *loss of cool*. This verb is used only twice in the New Testament (Rom. 10:19). The noun form is used once in the New Testament (Eph. 4:26) with the obvious meaning of excessive anger. It is frequently used in the Septuagint to depict God's reaction to the abominable sins of Israel - He was *exceedingly angry* with them.

We recognize that all correction inevitably evokes some indignation; however, fathers are to discipline their children in a manner that will not stir up excessive anger which would be counterproductive. Inequitable discipline incommensurate with the act of disobedience will aggravate those being disciplined, put them on the defensive, and make a bad situation worse. In Colossians 3:21, fathers are told not to provoke (ερεθιζετε), arouse, irritate, and wrangle with their children, that they may not become discouraged and disheartened.

Positively speaking, fathers are to nurture (πεκτρεφετε), rear, raise, and bring up their children in the discipline and admonition of the Lord. The use of the Greek conjunction "αλλα" emphasizes *contrast* - instead of angering and irritating their children they are to spiritually nourish them in the training and admonishing which the Lord has for them. The Greek verb "nurture" (εκτρεφετε) comes from combining the preposition "εκ" and the verb "τρεφω" and implies the feeding, training, and disciplining necessary in the process of raising children. The emphasis in this verse is on the children's *spiritual training*, i.e., it is training and admonition "of the Lord" (κυριου), which the Lord possesses, which belongs to the Lord. Of course, this first includes training in the Truth which the Lord has given to us as members of the Body of Christ. This means thoroughly training our children in the basic truths pertaining to Jesus Christ, *who He is* as presented in the Four Gospels, and *His headship over the Church and our relation to Him* as set forth in the New Testament epistles (particularly the 14 written by Paul).

Now let us examine the two Greek words which we have translated "training" and "admonition." These words explain the *methodology* parents are to use in directing and establishing their children in the Word of the Lord. First, the word "training" (παιδεια) is in the same family as the word for child (παις,παιδος), and basically pertains to *child-training, educating, instructing, disciplining,* and *correcting*. If we give the word disciplining the broad meaning that is commonly given to it today, namely, training, instructing, and correcting, then it would be a very good translation. Early disciplining of children is the best way to avoid later provoking them to anger (2 Tim. 3:15; 1 Peter 2:2).

Second, the Greek word translated "admonition" (νουθεσια) is derived from "νους" and "τιθημι" and basically means *to put in mind*, hence, *reminding, admonishing,* and *warning.* The idea of warning comes through loud and clear in the meaning of this word (cf. 1 Cor. 10:11; Titus 3:10; 1 Thess. 5:14; 2 Thess. 3:15). This means that parents are to continually put in the minds of their children warnings against sin and its consequences (1 Cor. 4:14; Col. 1:28). These warnings must also be against those who are enemies of the Gospel of God's Grace (Phil. 3:17-19).

5. ***"Slaves, obey the masters according to the flesh with fear and trembling, in singleness of your heart as to Christ,"***

Having dealt with the relation of all believers to one another, wives to their husbands and husbands to their wives, and children to their parents and vice versa, Paul now explains how Christian slaves are to relate to their masters. The Greek noun translated "slaves" (δουλοι) may be used in different ways. As used here it refers to a *slave, bondman,* or *one in a servile condition* (1 Cor. 7:21; Col. 3:11). It speaks of those in bondage and subjugation as opposed to those who are free (1 Cor. 7:22; Gal. 3:28; Col. 3:11). On the basis of extrabiblical Greek, it may refer to those who are born slaves or to those who are captives of a conqueror. The later is more graphically depicted by the Greek noun "ανδραποδον," which gives us the picture of a captive falling at his conqueror's feet. The word "δουλος" is commonly used in the New Testament to describe those who are owned, subjected to, and under the absolute control of others. This

use may be literal, as in the case of this verse, or metaphorical of believers relation to the Lord (Rom. 1:1; Phil. 1:1).

Paul orders Christian slaves to obey their "masters according to the flesh." The Greek verb for "obey" (υπακουετε) is identical to that used to describe the relation of children to their parents. It means that they are to *submissively hear, receive through the ear gate,* and *listen to orders* and *obey them.* Accurate listening is the precursor of accurate obedience. Since the Greek word translated "lords" (κυριοις) may, in the singular, be rendered the Lord Jesus Christ or the Lord God, Paul specifies that he is talking about according-to-the-flesh or human lords (master, Col. 3:22). The use of the present tense and imperative mode implies that they are to continuously obey the commands of their masters.

This obedience is to be coupled with "fear and trembling." We previously observed that the most prevalent meaning of the Greek word for "fear" (φοβος) in both the New Testament and extrabiblical Greek is expressed by the English equivalents *fear, fright, dread*, or *to be afraid*. The Greek word translated "trembling" (τρομου) comes from the verb "τρεμω" of which our English verb *tremble* is a free transliteration, conveying the thought of quaking and quivering from fear. Paul uses these two words together four times in his epistles (1 Cor. 2:3; 2 Cor. 7:15; Phil. 2:12). There is no question about it, Paul is telling these slaves that they are to fear and tremble at the thought of disobedience - the consequences it will bring upon them from their earthly masters and from their heavenly Master. As we bathe ourselves in Paul's epistles we begin to grasp the *importance of fear as a strong deterrent to sin*. The use of both of these words together *doubly emphasizes* that fear of the consequences should dissuade them from even the thought of disobedience to their masters.

As these Christian slaves obey their masters with fear and trembling, Paul says, do it "in singleness of your heart as to Christ." The Greek word rendered "singleness" (απλοτητι) means that which is simple, unmixed, uncompounded, hence, a heart which has *one single purpose, one bent, one desire,* and *one object,* to render obedience to their masters as to Christ. In other words, he does not want them to hold in reserve optional mind-sets, half-hearted commitments, and

alterable allegiance to their masters. They are to be 100% committed to meticulously obeying their masters even as they are to meticulously obey Christ (Col. 3:22; 1 Tim. 6:1; Titus 2:9).

6. ***"not according to eye-service as men-pleasers, but as slaves of Christ doing the will of God out of the soul,"***

The Greek word translated "eye-service" (οφθαλμοδουλιαν) is not found in the Septuagint nor in extrabiblical literature prior to Paul's use of it. He uses it twice in his epistles (Col. 3:22). It is a compound word which he apparently coined by combining "οφθαλμος" (eye) with "δουλεια" (slavery or servitude) and it obviously means that *while under the eye of the master one is in bondage and servitude.* Paul does not want their faithfulness to be limited to the time the master is watching them, as those who try to make a good superficial showing in his presence, but rather he desires that they steadily do their work regardless of the master's presence or absence.

Those who operate on a sight basis are "men-pleasers" (ανθρωπαρεσκοι) according to what Paul says in this verse. This word consists of a combination of the Greek words "ανθρωπος" and "αρεσκος" and speaks of those motivated to please men for their own advantage. This noun is used once in the Septuagint (Psa. 52:5), where we read, "because God has scattered the bones of the men-pleasers, they have been put to shame, because God despised them." The only other time this word is used in the New Testament is in the allied verse in Colossians 3:22; however, Paul uses the Greek verb "αρεσκειν" (please) in Galatians 1:10 and First Thessalonians 2:4 to express the same thought. It is logical that the use of this word is limited to biblical Greek, for it speaks of *the opposite of* what should be the normal lifestyle of every believer, *pleasing God* (1 Cor. 7:32; 1 Thess. 4:1; 2 Tim. 2:4).

Paul uses the strong adversative conjunction "αλλα" (but) to draw a *sharp contrast* between rendering "eye-service as menpleasers" and what their priority should be, namely, "doing the will of God out of the soul." They need to recognize that *first* they are slaves of Christ, they have been bought with the price of His precious Blood (Matt. 26:28; Rom. 5:9; 1 Cor. 6:20), *they belong to Him*, and are to obey Him by

doing the will of God. Paul is trying to give these slaves a *new perspective,* they are equal with every other believer regardless of socio-economic status, and from this vantage point they are to continuously do their work as the will of God. Second, as physical slaves they were to obey their earthly master, and the work which these masters gave them to do was *for them the will of God*, and they were to do it as unto Christ their Master out of the depths of their "soul" (ψυχης), their innermost being (Phil. 1:27; Col. 3:23). Never forget, if there was a conflict between what the masters commanded their slaves to do and the Word of God, then what the masters said must be interpreted as the *will of men*, and the Word of God must be obeyed regardless of the cost.

7. ***"with good will serving, as to the Lord and not to men,"***

The Greek word translated "good will" (ευνοιας) comes from "ευ" and "νους" and means to have a *good mind, good mind-set*, or *a good mental attitude.* The present Greek participle "δουλευοντες" means that they are to continuously do their work as slaves with a good frame of mind and a good attitude toward their masters. This would seemingly be impossible to heartless cruel masters if such were the true object of their service. It is, however, possible to serve with a good mental attitude if the *Supreme Object* of the service is the Lord and not men.

When the love of Christ constrainingly lays hold of believers, when they recognize that He died for all, and that they are no longer to live for themselves and men, but for Him who died and rose for them, then regardless of physical circumstances, they can joyfully do their work as unto Christ (2 Cor. 5:14-15; cf. Col. 3:24).

8. ***"knowing that each one, if he may do anything good, he shall receive this from the Lord, whether slave or free."***

In the preceding verse Paul has emphasized the need for Christian slaves to do their work *as unto* the Lord Jesus Christ and not unto men. In this verse he gives a further reason for directing their service unto Christ - He is the one who rewards all good-doing. Paul projects beyond this life for an adequate motive to stimulate them to faithfully

render their service as unto Christ. Some of them undoubtedly had unbelieving, cruel masters, inhumane tyrants who were never satisfied with their output and who stripped them of every incentive to serve them. They were frustrated, discouraged, and disillusioned, and even though they were believers they found it hard to willingly serve those who were maltreating them. In the midst of such circumstances Paul tells them to *look up*, to behold their Supreme Master in the heavens, who will reward them for every good thing they do.

The Greek participle translated "knowing" (ειδοτες) is from the verb "οιδα," a perfect tense, which has a usage-meaning which hovers between the perfect and present tenses. In this context the perfect tense comes through clearly - they are those who *have* and *continue to have* basic prophetic knowledge, that good-doing will be requited with good. This is a common truth that is taught by the Holy Spirit through the Apostle Paul (Rom. 2:6-7; 1 Cor. 3:8; 4:5; 2 Cor. 5:10; Col. 3:24-25). In this verse Paul refers only to the fact that good will be recompensed with good; however, in the above cited passages the general thought is that good works will be rewarded with that which is good and that evil works will be rewarded with judgment and punishment (2 Thess. 1:9). Note, in the verse before us, Paul just uses the *positive*, the receiving of that which is good, to motivate them to greater faithfulness.

It is important to observe that they are to do all things as unto the Lord, the same one from whom they receive good for the good they do. The Lord impartially allots good according to the measure believing slaves have done good. He is not a respecter of persons (Rom. 2:11). It does not make any difference whether the person is a "slave" (δουλος) or a "free man" (ελευθερος); all will be rewarded equitably according to their work.

9. ***"And masters, do the same things toward them, withholding the threat, knowing that both their and your Lord is in heaven, and there is no respect of persons with Him."***

Having ordered the Christian slaves to obey their masters, and while working for them, to work as unto their Master in heaven, Paul now addresses the Christian masters. First, he tells them to do "the same

things" (τα αυτα) toward their slaves. In view of the, foregoing context, the masters, even as the slaves, are to do *God's will* out of the depth of their souls. God's will for the slaves is obedience to their masters; whereas His will for masters is that they treat their slaves *right, fair,* and *equitable* (Col. 4:1). Furthermore, as slaves are to serve their masters with *a good mind-set*, likewise, masters are to supervise their slaves with a good mind-set, i.e., they are to have a *positive* and *gracious attitude* toward them (4:32; Col. 3:13).

Second, Christian masters are to be self-controlled, "withholding the threat" (ανιεντες την απειλην). The Greek participle translated "withholding" (ανιεντες), as used here, means to *desist from, leave off,* or *omit the threat.* The Greek noun rendered "threat" (απειλην) is consistently used with this meaning in the New Testament (Acts 4:29; 9:1). Masters are not to tell their slaves that if they do or don't do so and so, they will recriminate with certain loss, damage, or punishment to them. In other words, according to what Paul says here, Christians are *not to use the threat* as a means by which to control or modify the behavior of others (cf. Acts 4:17).

The reason Christian masters are to treat their slaves right and cease from threatening them is because their mutual "Lord is in heaven." The status of all believers in the Body of Christ rests upon the premise - *the Grace of God*. Who a person is in the flesh has *nothing to do* with Christ becoming the Lord of his life, a relationship brought about by the sovereignty of God (Rom. 9:11-16). Furthermore, those who have been sovereignly placed under the Lordship of Christ, their heavenly Master, must recognize that there is "no respect of persons" (προσωπολημψια ουκ), receiving of faces, with Him. Masters who mistreat their slaves will be judged as *readily* as slaves who disobey their masters. Whether the masters or slaves do good or evil, they will be repaid *equally*, good for good and punishment for evil (Col. 3:25).

10. ***"Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might."***

The Greek phrase translated "finally" (του λοιπου) is used seven times by Paul, usually toward the end of his epistles, with the idea that he is *about to consummate* what he is saying (2 Cor. 13:11; Gal.

6:17; Phil. 3:1; 4:8; 2 Tim. 4:8). The final command he wants to press upon their minds is to "be strong in the Lord" (πενδυναμουσθε εν κυριω). This Greek verb is derived from "εν" and "δυναμοω" and literally means to have *inner power*, hence, *to be empowered* and *invigorated in the Lord*. This verb is used exclusively by Paul, seven times in the New Testament. Five times it refers to the inner strength which is available in the Lord (Phil. 4:13; 1 Tim. 1:12; 2 Tim. 2:1; 4:17). The phrase rendered "in the Lord" (εν κυριω) is in the locative case and means that this inner power is to be found *in the sphere of the Lord.*

Believers are not only to be spiritually invigorated in the Lord, but also "in the strength of his might." This Greek noun rendered "strength" (κρατει) means the power and *force* which *belong to* His might. Since the root meaning of this word is to complete and perfect, Paul may well be referring to the *dynamic perfecting force* in which believers are to be strong. This dynamic force belongs to, comes forth from the reservoir of "his might" (ισχους αυτου), i.e., from the Lord's limitless *ability*. The two nouns translated "strength" (κρατει) and "might" (ισχυος) are obviously used together to emphasize the *magnitude of the Lord's strength and power* in the sphere of which believers are to be spiritually strong in the Lord (1:19).

This verse sets forth a principle which is diametrically opposed to secular humanism which *revolves around man.* The Biblical view is that man is *totally depraved* and *incapable in himself* to transform himself into a righteous being. Since perfect righteousness is God's object for His elect, He sovereignly rescues them from sin, makes them righteous in Christ, and provides the power necessary for living righteously. Secular humanism refuses to acknowledge that man is a *sinner by nature*, endeavors to free man from absolute biblical morality, and opens the way for him to live according to the lusts and desires of his flesh. Through the strength the Lord gives *believers endeavor to please God,* whereas humanists endeavor to *please themselves* in fulfilling the lusts of the flesh (Rom. 1:24-32).

11. ***"Put on all the armor of God that you may be able to stand against the methods of the devil"***

This verse begins to give us a word-picture of believers engaged in a spiritual battle against the onslaughts of the devil. It is very important to observe that *Divine provision*, "all the armor of God," is made available to all believers. The genitive case clearly indicates that this is armor which *belongs to* and is *owned* by God, and is freely placed at the disposal of believers. On the other hand, believers have the *responsibility* to "put on" (ενδυσασθε), *clothe, invest,* and *cover* themselves with armor. The imperative mode and middle voice emphasize that this is a command which they themselves are obligated to fulfill - they are to array themselves in the complete armor of God.

Even though his Christian armor may make believers appear to be spiritual, yet, its purpose is to *enable them to stand* against the subtle methods of the devil. The Greek phrase translated "that you may be able to stand" (προς το δυνασθαι υμας στηναι) means *to the end that you may have the strength, power,* and *ability* to stand. The Greek verb translated "stand" (στηναι) means that regardless of the assaults of the devil believers are to remain *set, placed, fixed,* and *firm*. This word suggests that believers are to *defensively hold their spiritual position.* They are not to allow the devil to encroach upon or deprive them of their spiritual ground.

That which believers are to stand against are "the methods of the devil." the Greek word translated "methods" (μεθοδιας) is only used twice in the New Testament (4:14). Our English word *methods* is a transliteration of it. The thought is that believers are to stand against the cunning *ways, rules,* and *devices* used by the devil to spiritually defeat them. Since these wily methods belong to the devil, as implied by the genitive case, it is logical that the defensive armor against them must be of the Lord. In Second Corinthians 10:4, Paul says, "for the armor of our warfare is not carnal, but powerful in God to the destroying of strongholds" (cf. Rom. 13:12). Granting that the devil is a superhuman power, which we are forced to do on the basis of the Scripture, our defense against him must be from the superb Superpower, Almighty God (1 John 4:4).

12. ***"because our struggle is not against blood and flesh, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the world-***

powers of this darkness, against the spiritual-forces of evil in the heavenly places."

The previous verse ordered believers to put on all the armor of God so that they would be able to stand against the sinister methods of the devil. This verse opens with the Greek conjunction "οτι" (because), setting forth the reason why believers must clothe themselves in all the God-provided armor. If our struggle was against blood and flesh, i.e., on a human man-to-man plane, then it could be fought with human armor; however, Paul specifically says that it is not on this level. Believers are not engaged in a "struggle" (παλη), *wrestling match,* or *contest* against blood and flesh, "but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the world-powers of this darkness." The strong adversative "αλλα," translated *but*, emphasizes that this struggle is in the superhuman spiritual sphere.

Now let us examine the meaning of the Greek word translated "rulers" (αρχας). This *plural noun* speaks of those who are in *first place, principle ones,* or *who occupy eminent positions.* It is used of rulers of countries in the classical Greek. Jesus uses this word in both the plural and singular of *earthly rulers* (Luke 12:11; 20:20). Paul uses this word several times in both the singular and plural, however only once *specifically* with reference to earthly rulers (Titus 3:1). In this verse and in chapter 3, verse 10, he uses it with reference to *rulers in the heavenly sphere* (cf. Col. 1:16). In other passages it is difficult to determine whether Paul has earthly or heavenly rulers in mind. Furthermore, granting that he is primarily referring to heavenly rulers in most of the contexts, we still have the problem of knowing how the heavenly rulers dominate the minds of the earthly rulers.

Second, let us consider the meaning of the Greek noun translated "authorities" (εξουσιας). The plural form of this word, as we have it here, refers to those who have the *right to govern, the power to act,* hence, the best English equivalent is *authorities*. It is used in the classical Greek to depict government magistrates and officials. This noun is commonly used in the Synoptic Gospels regarding those who had authority (Matt. 28:18; Luke 12:5; 23:7). Paul uses it to depict civil government authorities (Rom. 13:1-3; Titus 3:1). Paul himself was endued with authority from the Lord (2 Cor. 13:10). He

apparently uses it to depict Satan as the authority of the air (Eph. 2:2; cf. Col. 1:13). Twice Paul uses this word with reference to *heavenly authorities* (3:10; 6:12; cf. 1 Peter 3:22). This noun, like the above noun for "rulers" (αρχας), is often used in contexts where it may refer to either earthly or heavenly rulers, or possibly to both (1 Cor. 15:24; Eph. 1:21; Col. 1:16).

Third, now let us turn our attention to the fact that believers are engaged in a struggle "against the world-powers of this darkness." The Greek word rendered "world-powers" (κοσμοκρατορας) comes from combining the words "κοσμος" and "κρατεω" and literally means *world forces, world-dominions,* and *world-mighty-ones.* An Egyptian inscription ascribes this title to an emperor. This is the only time it is used in the New Testament; therefore, we must establish its meaning on the basis of the two words which constitute it.

We might conclude that Paul is referring to human worldpowers who dominate the nations, but his statement "of this darkness" adds a spiritual dimension. The phrase "the authority of darkness," which appears in Luke 22:53 and Colossians 1:13, clearly refers to the devil's domain. Since the word "darkness" (σκοτους) is closely tied to the devil, and since he is the god of this age (2 Cor. 4:4), it follows that these world-powers are *of him, belong to him,* and are *possessed by him.* They are undoubtedly his henchmen in this world which lies in the evil one (1 John 5:19).

Fourth, Paul affirms that believers are locked in battle with the "spiritual-forces of evil in the heavenly places." The phrase translated "the spiritual-forces of evil" (τα πνευματικα της πονηριας) may very literally be rendered *the spirituals of evil,* which obviously means the *spiritual beings, hosts,* and *forces* that belong to evil. John inextricably links sin and evil with the devil (1 John 3:8). The sphere in which these spiritual-powers operate is "in heavenly places" (εν τοις επουρανιοις), very literally *upon the heavens*, a heavenly or air (αηρ) location instead of on the earth (Eph. 2:2). Paul's main emphasis in this verse is that the real behind-the-scene enemy of believers is the devil and his cohorts. This is the reason we must put on the *armor of the supreme God* for we are engaged in conflict with a superhuman being, the devil.

13. ***"On account of this take up all the armor of God, that you may be able to stand against in the evil day, and having accomplished all things to stand."***

This verse opens with the Greek preposition "δια" used with the accusative case, which we have translated "on account of." The thought is that *on account of the fact* that our struggle is against "spiritual-forces of evil in the heavenly places"; therefore, we need to take up all the armor of God. Our battle is against a spiritual enemy; therefore, it is imperative that we fight it with *spiritual armor*, that which God provides for us. The Greek verb translated "take up" (αναλαβετε) is derived from "ανα" and "λαμβανω" and literally means *to take or receive up*. We have a verbal picture of believers *picking up* or *receiving* from God their spiritual armor. The Greek noun rendered "all the armor" (πανοπλιαν) means the *complete, total,* and *full armor* which God has provided for waging this spiritual battle (cf. Luke 11:22).

Why is Paul instructing his readers to take up all the armor of God? The purpose is clear, "that you may be able to stand against in the evil day." The use of the conjunction "ινα" with the verb translated "you may be able" (δυνηθητε) clearly expresses the idea of *purpose* and may also be rendered *in order that you may be able, that you may have the ability,* or *that you may have the strength* to stand against in the evil day. The Greek infinitive translated "to stand against" (αντιοτηναι) comes from the preposition "αντι" and the verb "ιστημι" and most literally means *to stand against, to oppose*, or *to resist* in the evil day. Since this is the only time Paul uses the phrase "the evil day" (τη ημερα τη πονηρα) we cannot affirm that he is speaking of a specific future time such as the day of wrath (Rom. 2:5). In view of the entire context surrounding this phrase it is feasible to identify "the evil day" with "the present evil age" (Gal. 1:4; Eph. 5:16).

Having observed that the armor Paul speaks of here *belongs to God,* it is that which He has provided for believers, and having observed that this armor is able to *enable believers to stand against* the foe in

the evil day, we conclude that this armor has been *Divinely designed to adequately equip believers to be victorious.*

Now that Paul has stated the reason believers are to take up all the armor of God, namely, that they may be able to triumphantly resist the Satanic evil forces, he adds, "and having accomplished all things, to stand." The Greek participle rendered "accomplished" (κατεργασαμενου) is derived from the preposition "κατα" and the verb "εργαζομαι" and very literally means *to work down*, hence, in actual usage in the aorist tense commonly means *having produced, having effected,* or *having done.* A viable interpretation would be that having taken up and completely put on God's armor, as already instructed, they are to stand. The infinitive translated "to stand" (στηναι) is the same infinitive as used in verse 11, where Paul says, "that you may be able *to stand* against the methods of the devil." If God's specially designed spiritual armor is fully utilized, as He intends that it should be, believers will *thwart and prevail against* all their enemies. Having done this they are to *remain fixed, set,* and *firm* in their victorious position (cf. Col. 4:12).

14. ***"Stand therefore, having girded your loins with truth, and having put on the breastplate of righteousness,"***

This is the fourth and final time, in this context, that Paul emphasizes the need for believers *to stand firm*. In the first three instances he uses the infinitive form to express the need to remain steadfast. In this verse he uses the imperative mode, *commanding them to stand firm and immoveable.* The Greek particle translated "therefore" (ουν) implies that in view of what he has already said about God's provision of adequate armor, *they are ordered to stand*. Regardless of how fierce the enemy may be, there are no alternatives: they are to unflinchingly stand (2 Cor. 1:24).

Paul now begins to describe the various parts of this spiritual armor; then he proceeds to figuratively place it on the bodies of believers. It is far more important to observe *what the armor is* than where it is placed. The first piece of armor he refers to is "truth" (αληθεια). As those who have their loins girded *with truth,* or *in the sphere of truth,* they are to stand. It can be said without fear of contradiction that

Paul's general use of the word *truth* (αληθεια) refers to the *truth revealed to him for the Church* (Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9). This truth, which is primarily found in his epistles, is what believers are to be girded with. If we construe the Greek phrase "εν αληθεια " as being in the locative case, then Paul is affirming that believers should be girded *in the sphere of this Body Truth*, i.e., be encircled with it.

The second piece of spiritual armor which believers are to put on is "righteousness" (δικαιοσυνης). The aorist participle indicates that believers are to be those who "have put on the breastplate of righteousness." Paul most commonly uses this word with reference to a *righteousness apart from the Law* (Rom. 3:21), *a righteousness apart from works* (Rom. 4:6), *a righteousness out of faith* (Rom. 9:30), and *a righteousness out of God* (Phil. 3:9). This is a righteousness which God freely gives to His elect on the basis of faith in Christ (2 Cor. 5:21; Eph. 2:8). Clothed in the perfect righteousness of Christ, which figuratively speaking represents a defensive breastplate, believers are commanded to stand fast. In First Thessalonians 5:8, the substance of the breastplate is faith and love. This difference suggests that we should be careful not to overemphasize the significance of the figures of speech used in this context.

15. ***"having shod the feet with the preparation of the gospel of peace."***

The third piece of spiritual armor believers are to put on is the "gospel of peace" (του υαγγελιου της ειρηνης). The aorist participle translated "having shod" (υποδησαμενοι) means that they are *to have bound under their feet, to have put on as sandals* the "preparation" (ετοιμασια), the *preparedness*, and *readiness* which belongs to the gospel of peace. The thought here is that the feet should be *ready to move* to aggressively carry forth the gospel. A part of the armor which enables believers to unswervingly stand is active engagement in proclaiming the truth of the gospel to both the lost and the saved.

As Paul uses the phrase "the gospel of peace" (του ευαγγελιου της ειρηνης) he is obviously referring to the gospel which he preached, the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24). This gospel has the power to save sinners and establish them in a

peace relationship with God (Rom. 1:16; 5:1). It also has the power to break down partitions between men and bring harmony and peace between them (Eph. 2:14-16).

16. ***"in all having taken up the shield of faith, by which you will be able to quench all the flaming darts of the evil one."***

The phrase "in all" (εν πασιν) implies that in the midst of putting on all the other pieces of armor they are not to forget to take up the shield of faith. It is interesting to observe that all the other parts of the armor were attached to the body except the sword and shield. The physical shield, to which Paul alludes, was a large oblong shield used to protect the body. The aorist participle translated "having taken up" (αναλαβοντες) is derived from the Greek preposition "ανα" prefixed to the verb "λαμβανω" and literally means that one is not ready to engage in spiritual battle until he *has taken up* or received in his hand the shield of faith.

The Greek noun translated "faith" (πιστεως), as used in this verse with the article preceding it, could refer to *the faith* as a body of truth. On the other hand, the context of this verse strongly favors the meaning of *belief, trust,* and *confidence*. This faith is not subjectively self-generated, *it is not something from within*, but armor which is objectively given to be taken up and received. The shield, which represents *faith*, is a *gift* from God. The exercise of this gift is essential for both salvation and a walk pleasing to God (2:8; 2 Cor. 5:7). God is the one who instills in the minds of sinners the faith to believe in Jesus Christ as Savior, and who subsequently provides the faith-armor which is imperative for Christian victory.

As Paul writes to them he affirms, "you will be able to quench all the flaming darts of the evil one" by utilizing the faith made available to you. The Greek verb translated "you will be able" (δυνησεσθε) is in the future tense and indicative mode, and as such, positively declares that they (believers) will have the *ability, strength,* and *power* to thwart all future onslaughts of the devil. The emphasis is not on their personal ability to foil the enemy, but on the *perfect defence* which their God-given faith-shields provide. Their faith serves as a shield

which intercepts the flaming darts of their spiritual foe (Heb. 11:33; 1 Peter 1:5; 5:8-9).

Now let us examine the statement, "to quench all the flaming darts of the evil one." The Greek infinitive translated "to quench" (σβεσαι) means to *extinguish, put out*, hence, *to quench as a fire* (Mark 9:48; Heb. 11:34). The noun rendered "darts" (βελη) denotes a *missile weapon, an arrow, shaft*, or anything that is hurled at an enemy. We have translated the Greek participle which describes these darts by the English word "flaming" (πεπυρωμενα). In as much as this participle is in the perfect tense and passive voice it gives us a picture of missiles or arrows *which have been set on fire, which are burning,* being hurled or shot at the Lord's people.

The one who is aggressively waging this war against believers in designated as "the evil one" (του πονηρου). The darts, arrows, and missiles belong to him, they bear his trademark. Observe that the Greek *article* precedes the noun for "evil" (πονηρου), and this grammatical construction as used in the New Testament favors the interpretation, *the evil one* (Matt. 13:19, 38; 2 Thess. 3:3; 1 John 3:12; 5:18-19). Furthermore, verse 11, a part of this same context, identifies the evil one as the devil (cf. 4:27; 1 Tim. 3:6-7; James 4:7; 1 Peter 5:8).

Summarizing, the protection against the onslaughts of the devil, which Paul speaks about in this verse, is available to all believers, but is limited to those who have actually taken up God's Divine-faith-shield. It is a wonderful thing to have the shield of faith available, to have the dynamic-spiritual-armor which can perfectly defend us, but it is also a tragedy to fail to take it up, and as a result, go down in spiritual defeat.

17. ***"And receive the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the Word of God."***

The Greek verb translated "receive" (δεξασθε) is in the aorist tense and imperative mode. Paul uses this verb some 15 times in his epistles. In all contexts in which it is used the intended meaning is most accurately expressed by the English verb *receive*. Other

possible translations are to *take or accept*. We have already emphasized that He has freely provided complete sets of armor for every believer. This armor consists of six pieces, namely, truth, righteousness, the gospel of peace, faith, salvation, and the Word of God. Aorist participles are used in conjunction with the first four implying that they have been properly arranged to provide maximum bodily protection.

When it comes to the last two parts of the armor Paul takes nothing for granted, but *commands* and orders them to receive the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit (the Word of God). It is difficult to ascertain why Paul used aorist participles in placing the first four pieces of armor and an aorist imperative verb in relation to the last two. The imperative mode certainly tends to emphasize the *responsibility* believers have to *receive* the salvation helmet and the Word of God, but we are not justified in claiming that these are more important than the foregoing. Possibly Paul's grammatical variations may be alterations merely for the sake of literary variety.

In examining the phrase "the helmet of salvation" we observe that the Greek noun for "helmet" (περικεφαλαιαν) comes from the preposition "περι" prefixed to the noun "κεφαλη" and literally refers to *that which is around or encircles the head,* hence, in military terminology *protection for the head, a helmet.* Paul uses it figuratively here to refer to a *helmet of salvation, which belongs to salvation*, or *the essence of which is salvation.* The Greek word for "salvation" (σωτηριου) is used against a background of sin. It involves being rescued, delivered, and saved from sin. It may refer to salvation from original sin (Eph. 2:8), or to salvation from a sinful lifestyle (2 Cor. 2:15; 2 Tim. 4:18). Since the aorist participles used above imply that these believers were already armored in truth, righteousness, proclaiming the gospel of peace, and faith, they obviously possess salvation from original sin and are daily being saved from sin in their lifestyle. Since the helmet is in itself salvation, defensive armor, it protects them from the devil, the initiator and promulgator of all sin (John 8:44; 1 John 3:8).

Now let us look at the ramifications of the statement, "the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God." Figuratively speaking, the sword of the Spirit is the sword *which belongs to the Spirit, the sword which*

the Spirit wields. This sword is defined as the Word of God. Since the main thrust of this context is defensive, resisting the devil, we see the Spirit primarily using the Word to defend believers from the assaults of the devil. As noted above, Paul *commands* believers to *receive* the sword, the Word of God, which in itself is "sharper than any two-edged sword . . . judging the intents and thoughts of the heart" (Heb. 4:12). Looking back in this context the main emphasis is on defense. Looking ahead, identifying ourselves with Paul, the main thrust is *offensive*, aggressively making known the Word of God for today, the Mystery (v. 19).

18. ***"Through all prayer and supplication praying all the time in the Spirit, and unto this end watching in all perseverance and supplication for all the saints,"***

Having instructed believers to take up the six pieces of armor which God has provided for them, that they may be able to stand against the devil in the evil day, Paul adds the perfect seventh, prayer. He says that "through all prayer and supplication" they are to be "praying all the time in the Spirit." The Greek preposition "δια" used with the genitive case may be translated: *through the agency of every prayer and supplication.* This indicates that their continuous praying, as implied by the present participle "προσευχομενοι," encompassed many single prayers and supplications (δεησεως) i.e., needs and petitions.

The phrase translated "praying all the time" (κροσευχομενοι εν παντι καιρω) may also be rendered *continuously praying in every season.* The nominative present participle literally suggests that they are to be always-praying-ones. The Greek noun translated "time" (καιρω) is used by Paul to refer to the *present time* (Rom. 3:26), *proper time* (Rom. 5:6), *future time* (1 Thess. 2:7), *latter time* (1 Tim. 4:1), *hard times* (2 Tim. 3:1), and *time as an opportunity* (Gal. 6:10). Regardless of when the time might be and the circumstances, believers are to maintain a prayer relationship with God.

It is important to recognize that this praying all the time is to be "in the Spirit" (εν πνευματι). If we interpret this phrase as being in the

locative case the thought is that believers are to continuously pray *in the sphere of the Spirit*. On the other hand, if we interpret this phrase as being in the instrumental case the thought is that believers are to continuously pray *by means of the Holy Spirit*. The best commentary on this phrase is found in Romans 8:26-27, where Paul says, "And likewise also the Spirit helps in our weakness; for what it is necessary for us to pray for we do not know, but the Spirit himself intercedes with unspeakable groanings; and the one interpreting the hearts knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because he intercedes on behalf of the saints according to God." This passage suggests that there are two reasons why believers need the help of the Spirit in praying: (1) because they do not know what to pray for; and (2) because they need the Spirit to conform their praying to the will of God. Jude also admonishes those to whom he is writing to be continuously "praying in the Holy Spirit" (προσευχομενοι; Jude 20; cf. 1 Cor. 14:15; Col. 1:9).

Now let us examine the meaning of the last part of this verse, Paul's statement, "unto this end watching in all perseverance and supplication for all the saints." The phrase "unto this end" (εις αυτο) is our translation of the United Bible Societies Greek text. This phrase has an additional word in the Majority Text, which is accurately translated "unto this very end" (εις αυτο τουτο). The latter translation is supported by Paul's use of it in four of his epistles (6:22; Rom. 9:17; 13:6; 2 Cor. 5:5; Col. 4:8). In view of this evidence we definitely prefer the Majority Text reading, namely, "unto this very end watching in all perseverance." The end or object which Paul has in mind for believers is that they might perseveringly watch and petition God on behalf of all the saints. The Greek participle translated "watching" (αγρυπνουντες) means they are to be *awake, alert,* and *attentive*. The Greek word for "perseverance" (προσκαρτερησει) indicates that they are to *steadfastly persist*. Summarizing, Paul's end and goal for believers is to steadfastly persist with an alert mind in praying and petitioning for all the saints.

19. ***"and on my behalf that a message may be given to me in opening my mouth, with boldness to make known the mystery of the gospel"***

Having emphasized the need for believers to pray for all the saints, Paul adds, "and on my behalf" (και υπερ εμου). Following the Greek word order, we would translate this *and on behalf of me* or *and for me.* Paul never asks prayer for his own personal aggrandizement or for selfish, subjective reasons, but only that the objective will of God may be accomplished through him (Col. 4:3; 2 Thess. 3:1; Heb. 13:18-19).

The purpose for which Paul asked for prayer was "that a message may be given to me in opening my mouth." The noun translated "message" (λογος), as used by Paul in his epistles, is predominantly used to depict *that which is spoken*, hence, *a word* or *a message*. He requested believers to pray for him in order that a word, many of which constitute a message, may be given unto him. The verb translated "may be given" (δοθη) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that he wanted the Lord *to give, grant*, and *bestow upon* him a Divine message. The use of the passive voice excludes Paul as the originator of his message; it was given to him by One outside of himself (1 Cor. 2:10; Gal. 1:12; 1 Thess. 2:13).

Having observed that Paul wanted a message given to him, now let us consider his desire "in opening" his mouth to communicate it to others. The emphasis in this verse is on effective verbal communication of the message. Colossians 4:4 throws additional light on this verse, for speaking of the mystery of Christ, Paul says, "that I might manifest it as it is necessary for me to speak." Paul had the dispensation of the grace of God entrusted to him (1 Cor. 9:17; Eph. 3:2); therefore, the imperative to make all men see its truth rested heavily upon him (3:9).

Paul desires prayer so as "in boldness to make known the mystery of the gospel." The Greek word translated "boldness" (παρρησια) conveys the idea of *plain speaking, frankness, and openness*. Paul frequently uses this word in describing his uninhibited, free, frank ministry (2 Cor. 3:12; Phil. 1:20; Philemon 8). We do not know the exact circumstances which prompted Paul to ask for prayer, but whatever they were, he apparently felt the need to more openly and freely share the gospel with those around him. When we consider that boldly speaking the mystery was what always got him in trouble,

resulting in his imprisonment, we should not be surprised if his human body and mind were beginning to cringe and shrink back from further suffering. We do not actually see this in his epistles; however, he may have been waging an internal spiritual struggle against diffidence and reticence in speaking the mystery.

The reason Paul wanted believers to pray for him was to the end that in the sphere of boldness, freedom of speaking, and courageousness he might "make known the mystery of the gospel." The Greek infinitive translated "make known" (λνωρισαι) is consistently used by Paul with the thought of *opening up, revealing, openly declaring* and *making known truth* (Rom. 16:26; Gal. 1:11; Eph. 1:9; 3:3; Col. 1:27).

The reason why Paul wanted to speak boldly was because he had a *very important* message to make known - THE MYSTERY OF THE GOSPEL. This literally means *the mystery which belongs to the gospel.* Paul is speaking here about *a particular gospel*, one which is *constituted of mystery truth*. In chapter three we defined the mystery as the *truth revealed for the Church,* the dispensation of the grace of God. The truth of the mystery was the *essence of the gospel* which Paul was eager to make known.

20. ***"on behalf of which I serve as an ambassador in a chain, that in it I may speak boldly as it is necessary for me to speak."***

This verse is an integral part of the preceding verse with no intervening punctuation. The subject at hand is "the mystery of the gospel," regarding which Paul says, "on behalf of which I serve as an ambassador in a chain." This verse begins with the Greek preposition "υπερ" which may be translated *in behalf of, for the sake of*, *for the defense of,* or by the single word *for*. Both the reason Paul was in prison and *what he was doing* in prison depend upon this preposition to take us back to "the mystery of the gospel." He was there in behalf of, for the sake of, and for the defense of the Mystery Gospel, the good news of the Mystery.

The Greek word translated "I serve as an ambassador" (πρεσβευω) is used only here and in Second Corinthians 5:20 in the New Testament. This word is a *verb* and an accurate English translation should reflect this fact. Paul is not talking about his status or position

as an ambassador, but rather *about what he is doing* as an ambassador. On behalf of the mystery truth which was once hidden but now revealed, he is *doing the work* of an ambassador. The important thing to Paul *was not status per se*, but to *fully utilize* the ability the Lord had given to him in making known the mystery of the gospel (Acts 19:9-10; 1 Cor. 2:6-7; Eph. 3:8-9; Col. 1:24-2:3).

As Paul did the work of an ambassador he was "in a chain" (εν αλυσει). The Greek noun for chain is in the *singular* and should be translated as such (2 Tim. 1:16). In Acts 21:33, Luke says that Paul was bound with two chains; however, this is the only time the word *bound* is used in connection with his chains - never in connection with his one chain. In Rome, when Paul met with the chief Jews, he said to them, "for on account of the hope of Israel *this chain* lies around" (Acts 28:20). The Greek verb rendered "lies around" (περικειμαι) suggests that a chain circumscribed some part of his body to demarcate him as a prisoner (cf. 2 Tim. 1:16). There is no reason to think that this chain restricted his physical movements. It was merely around a part of his body to signify that he was a prisoner of Rome (Acts 28:16, 30-31).

Now let us look at Paul's statement, "that in it I may speak boldly as it is necessary for me to speak." The phrase "in it" (εν αυτω) may be open to two possible interpretations: (1) as a locative case - that I might speak boldly *in the sphere of* the Mystery Gospel; and (2) as a dative of reference - that I might speak boldly with reference to the Mystery Gospel. The Greek verb translated "I may speak boldly" (παρρησιασωμαι) is in the subjunctive mode and may also be rendered, *that I may speak plainly, straightforwardly, freely,* and *openly.* We must keep in mind that the Truth of the Mystery was Divinely revealed to Paul by the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 2:10), and he in turn desired to *clearly tell it as it is* with no deleting or embellishing (1 Cor. 4:6; cf. Rev. 22:18-19).

An imperative rested upon Paul to plainly and forcefully speak the mystery of the gospel, for he affirms, "as it is necessary for me to speak." The Greek word translated "it is necessary" (δει), as used in this context, may also be rendered as it is *binding, required*, and *essential*. Our best commentary on this verse is found in Colossians

4:4, where dealing with the same subject, Paul says, "that I might manifest it as it is necessary for me to speak." In writing to the Corinthians he echoes this same thought, for he says, "For necessity rests upon me; for woe is to me if I do not preach the gospel" (1 Cor. 9:16; cf. vv. 17-23). May God help each of us to increasingly identify with Paul's imperative to make known the Gospel of the Mystery (See 2 Tim. 2:2).

Having examined Paul's prayer request that the Lord might give him a *message*, that he might have *freedom to boldly make known* the mystery of the gospel, and that he might effectively *do the work of an ambassador* while in prison, we raise the question: did God honor the prayers of those early believers and grant his requests?

The answer is in the last epistle Paul wrote during his first Roman imprisonment, Philippians; and the answer is a resounding YES! During this period of time God gave him *the fulness of the message of the mystery* which he obviously both spoke and wrote in his prison epistles. According to what Paul says in Philippians 1:12-14, his imprisonment resulted in a great *advancement of the gospel*. News about him and the gospel *reached into the praetorian guard* (πραιτωριω), i.e., the palace of the Roman Emperor. Furthermore, Paul's *confident demeanor* and *bold sharing* of the gospel of the mystery instilled *greater boldness in other believers* to fearlessly speak the Word of God.

21. ***"And that also you may know the things pertaining to me, what I do, Tychicus the beloved brother and faithful minister in the Lord, shall make known all things to you."***

Apart from his imprisonment and request that believers include him in their prayers, Paul has said little or nothing about his personal affairs in this epistle. One reason for this would be its *encyclical nature;* many of the readers were not personally acquainted with him. More important, however, is *Paul's object* in writing this epistle. It was not written to solicit personal attention or sympathy, but to systematically set forth the pertinent truths essential for establishing members of the Body of Christ, the Church.

The Greek phrase translated "things pertaining to me" (τα κατ εμε) consists of the preposition "κατα" used with the accusative case which has a *distributive meaning*. It has the basic idea of *things according to me, details relating to me, things happening to me, or what is taking place in my life day by day.* In order to more accurately understand what is behind the statement *the things pertaining to me* we must try to piece together the available data relating to Paul's incarceration in Rome.

In Acts 28:16, Luke says, "And when we had entered into Rome, permission was given to Paul to stay by himself [privately] with the soldier guarding him." In the 23rd verse, we read concerning the chief Jews in Rome, "And having arranged with him (Paul] a day, many came to him entering the lodging." Finally, Luke says of Paul in the 30th verse, "And he stayed in his own rented dwelling for two whole years, and he was receiving all those coming in to him." Verse 31 indicates that he was carrying on an *unhindered* (ακωλυτως), noninterfered-with ministry in his rented quarters. Summarizing, Paul was given permission to live in his own rented house, it had an adequate meeting room to accommodate many, and those who wanted to see him were free to do so. This arrangement existed for two entire years, possibly more, but less than three. It was a time when *minimal* standards of confinement were in effect for Paul as he awaited his trial. As already implied, his chain was merely an insignia that he was a prisoner of the Roman Government.

As Tychicus delivered this epistle to the first church to receive it, possibly Ephesus its custodian, he would share with them details about Paul's ministry, etc. Paul refers to Tychicus as "the beloved brother and faithful minister in the Lord." In Colossians 4:7, he uses the same words to describe him, adding only that he is a "fellowslave." According to Acts 20:4, he was an Asian. In Second Timothy 4:12, Paul says that he had sent him unto Ephesus, which may have been his home city (cf. Acts 20:5-6). He was capable of replacing Titus on the Island of Crete (Titus 3:12). Summarizing, available evidence suggests that Tychicus was a faithful minister with Paul for *over eight years*. Unlike most of the Asians (2 Tim. 1:15), he remained faithful to Paul and the mystery message until the end.

22. ***"whom I sent to you for this very purpose, that you may know the things regarding us, and that he may encourage your hearts."***

In stating his purpose for sending Tychicus to them, Paul says, "that you may know the things regarding us." In the preceding verse, speaking with reference to the information Tychicus has for them, Paul says, "that also you may know the things pertaining *to me*, what I do." The use of the pronoun "me" (εμε) suggests that he is limiting what he says to *himself*. On the other hand, his use of the pronoun "us" (ημων) in this verse implies that he is including all those associated with him in Rome, possibly even his fellow-workers scattered abroad. It is logical that Paul would want them to know about all those engaged with him in the furtherance of the gospel (Col. 1:6; 1 Thess. 1:7-8).

In addition to keeping the Asian churches up on what was happening at Rome, Paul says I sent Tychicus to you "that he may encourage your hearts." The Greek verb translated "encourage" (παρακαλεση) is derived from the preposition "παρα" and the verb "καλεω" and literally means *to call beside or alongside*. It has been commonly translated with the meaning of *exhort* or *comfort*. In view of both the *etymological* and *usage meaning* of this compound verb in the New Testament, we have concluded that it is often best translated by our English word *encourage*, i.e., *to inspire believers on, to strengthen their resolve.*

Another significant aspect of this word is that when it has the meaning of comfort or encourage these are *based on exhortation* from the Word, God is the source. The only way we can adequately encourage and comfort others is through the literal teaching of the Truth given to the Church, the Body of Christ. Smooth-tongued emotionalism, empathetic loquaciousness, and superficial human love may bring temporary balm to an aching heart and a troubled mind but only that which God speaks through His Word can *truly assuage the broken heart and bring peace to the troubled mind* (2 Cor. 1:3-7; 7:6; Col. 2:1-2; 1 Thess. 4:18; 5:11).

The fact that Paul sent Tychicus to encourage and comfort their hearts through an exhorting ministry suggests that he was a competent teacher of the Word, the Truth which Paul had given to Him (Phil. 4:9; 2 Tim. 2:2; Titus 2:15). This is also implied by a like ministry at Colossae (Col. 4:7-8) and his ability as a possible replacement of Titus (Titus 3:12).

23. ***"Peace to the brethren, and love with faith, from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ."***

First, observe those to whom Paul is addressing these final greetings, namely, "the brethren" (τοις αδελφοις). Of course, *the brethren* includes all men and women who are members of the Family of God, the Body of Christ (2:19; 1 Cor. 12:27). This impersonal *general greeting* is additional evidence favoring our view that this is an encyclical epistle, primarily intended for but not limited to the Asian churches.

Second, Paul's desire for all those to whom he is writing is *peace, love,* and *faith*. This peace, love, and faith he is proffering to them is *from* God the Father and Jesus Christ. According to Galatians 5:22, these are *fruit* implanted into the lives of believers by the Holy Spirit. Their origin is in God the Father and Son. They are *gifts* which are transmitted to and infused into believers by the Spirit.

Now let us examine the specific meanings of these three gifts for a greater appreciation of Paul's desire for all believers. Peace (πειρηνη) from God is a *frictionless, synchronous, harmonious*, and *tranquil relation* between believers and God and believers with believers (John 14:27; Rom. 1:7; 5:1; 2 Cor. 13:11; Eph. 2:14). Love (αγαπη) is a *concern* for the spiritual and physical welfare of others to the point of and including death for them (John 15:13; Rom. 5:8). In First Corinthians 13:4-6, we have a superb definition of love, which abbreviated is *longsuffering, kind, free from jealousy, void of pride, unselfish, not irritable, bears and endures all things, and rejoices in the truth* (cf. Eph. 2:4; 3:18-19; Col. 2:2; 2 Thess. 3:5).

Faith (πιστεως), the last gift mentioned here, is confidence that *something is* apart from verification by the five senses. According to

Hebrews 11:1, "Faith is the substance of things hoped for, it is the proof of things not seen." This means that faith gives *substance and essence* to things in the sphere of hope. It *persuades, convinces, is proof* of the reality of that which is unseen. The natural man's world is limited to what he can acquire through his five senses. He does not have the capability in himself to project into or enter the heavenly sphere where God exists, i.e., he is *incapable of initiating* a human-Divine relation. If he was able, *in himself*, to originate a relationship with God; then it follows, he would be saved by his own works and not by grace (contrast: Eph. 2:4-9; cf. Rom. 3:24; 5:1-2; Gal. 2:16; 3:26). Since the only way a man can relate to God is through faith, and he is unable to generate this faith within himself, it follows that the faith by which he relates to God *must be from God*, a gift from God, as this verse teaches (cf. 2:8; 1 Tim. 1:14).

24. ***"Grace be with all those loving our Lord Jesus Christ in an incorruptible manner."***

In this verse Paul is extending the Grace of God to a *specific group*, "all those loving our Lord Jesus Christ." This is a *general* greeting, not to a given church, but directed toward believers who genuinely love Jesus Christ. The language in the Greek text does not extend this grace-greeting to all who *profess* to love Jesus Christ, but rather to those who love Him *in an incorruptible sphere* (αφθαρσια). This is a very literal rendering, but for the sake of clarity I have preferred to translate it *in an incorruptible manner*, i.e., to *purely* and *sincerely* love Him. Paul may well have been aware of empty professors in some of the churches; therefore, he draws a distinct line between those who sincerely love Christ and those who have a phony love (1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23; 1 John 3:17).

The central expression of grace is God the Father *giving up His Son* to die on Calvary's Cross for sinners. What was accomplished on the Cross is comprehensive enough to save all men, but only those chosen before the creation of the world, those who are the recipients of Divine faith, are interested in exercising faith in the Saviour. We have the responsibility of proclaiming the Gospel of the Grace of God to *all men,* being confident that those chosen of God will respond to the Gospel (cf. John 6:44).